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Zoroaster in History

by
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of Iran and Central Asia
University of Rome



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Dedicated to the memory of

WALTER BRUNO HENNING
1908–1967

fifty years after his masterly
Zoroaster



About the Author

Professor Gherardo Gnoli was born in Rome in 1937 and studied Classics and Oriental languages there at the Faculty of Letters and Philosophy. He was Professor of Iranian Philology at the Oriental Institute of Naples (1965–93) and, since 1993, has taught at the University of Rome as Professor of the Religious History of Iran and Central Asia.

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Professor Gnoli has taken part in many excavations and scientific and cultural missions and written extensively on historical and philological subjects relating to Iran and the Middle East. His publications include *Ricerche storiche sul Sistan antico* (1967); *Zoroaster’s Time and Homeland* (1980); *De Zoroastre à Mani* (1985); and *The Idea of Iran. An Essay on its Origin* (1989).



Zoroaster in History

Zoroaster, the prophet of ancient Iran and the founder of a religion which is still alive and practiced today, was an extraordinary figure with a wide sphere of influence both in the Iranian world and in the philosophical and religious thought of the West, from Hellenism to the Renaissance and the Enlightenment.

The historical dating of Zoroaster has been a matter of much debate and dispute. Different theses, including those in support of an early chronology, and those that place him in a remote and nebulous past, as well as an alleged unhistoricity of Zoroaster, are here discussed in great depth while an attempt is made to demonstrate the validity of the thesis which situates him in historical times. Zoroaster is thus placed in the period between the last two decades of the seventh to the middle of the sixth century B.C., when the Medes and Persians became the protagonists in ancient history.



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Preface

The four seminar lectures which make up the present volume were read in April 1997 in the Department of Near Eastern Languages and Cultures, at the invitation of the committee for the Ehsan Yarshater Lectures at UCLA. They were preceded by a public lecture, with a summary in Persian, and the partly modified text of this lecture is given here in the Introduction.

No substantial changes have been made to the text of the four lectures, translated into English by Mrs Barbara Goss Gandolfo in December 1996. I have devoted some Addenda at the end to several points that I thought it necessary to bring up to date as a result of studies that I have become acquainted with since April 1997. The whole text in its final form has been read through by Dr Andrea Piras, and I am grateful to him for his kindness.

I take pleasure in thanking the members of the committee for their kind invitation. It was a great honour for me to deliver the second in the series of lectures which take their name from one of the greatest scholars in Iranian studies of our time. My warmest and most heartfelt thanks are due to Amin Banani, as Chairman, to Antonio Loprieno, also in his capacity as Chairman of the Department, and to Hossein Ziai: it is due to their attentive and friendly hospitality that I, and my wife, will always cherish wonderful memories of the days we spent in Los Angeles.

Gherardo Gnoli
October 1999



Abbreviations

For abbreviations occurring after an author's name see under that name in the Select Bibliography.

<i>AAASH</i>	<i>Acta Antiqua Academiae Scientiarum Hungaricae</i>
<i>ActIr</i>	<i>Acta Iranica</i>
<i>ADMG</i>	Abhandlungen für die Kunde des Morgenlandes herausgegeben von der Deutschen morgenländischen Gesellschaft
<i>AIUN</i>	<i>Annali dell'Istituto Universitario Orientale di Napoli</i>
<i>Air. Wb.</i>	see Bibliography under Bartholomae
<i>AJA</i>	<i>American Journal of Archaeology</i>
<i>AM</i>	<i>Asia Major</i>
<i>AMI</i>	<i>Archäologische Mitteilungen aus Iran</i>
<i>ANRW</i>	Aufstieg und Niedergang der römischen Welt, ed. H. Temporini and W. Haase, Berlin - New York
<i>ArOr</i>	<i>Archiv orientální</i>
<i>ARW</i>	<i>Archiv für Religionswissenschaft</i>
<i>ASNP</i>	<i>Annali della Scuola Normale Superiore di Pisa</i>
<i>Av.</i>	<i>Avestan</i>
<i>BAI</i>	<i>Bulletin of the Asia Institute</i>
<i>BCH</i>	<i>Bulletin de correspondance hellénique</i>
<i>BEO</i>	<i>Bulletin d'études orientales</i>

BGA	Bibliotheca Geographorum Arabicorum, ed. M.J. de Goeje, 8 vols, Leiden, 1870-1894
BSO(A)S	<i>Bulletin of the School of Oriental (and African) Studies</i>
CHIr.	<i>The Cambridge History of Iran</i>
CHJ	<i>The Cambridge History of Judaism</i>
CII	Corpus Inscriptionum Iranicarum
CRAI	<i>Comptes rendus de l'Académie des Inscriptions & Belles-Lettres</i>
CSCO	Corpus Scriptorum Christianorum Orientalium
DkM	<i>Dēnkard</i> , ed. D.M. Madan, Bombay, 1911
DH	Bonyād-e Fāhrang-e Irān (Iranian Culture Foundation), <i>The Codex DH, Being a Facsimile Edition of Bondahesh, Zand-e Vohuman Yasht, and parts of Denkard</i> , Tehran, n. d. [1349Š./1970]
EP ²	<i>The Encyclopaedia of Islam</i> , 2nd ed., London–Leiden
Elr.	<i>Encyclopædia Iranica</i> , ed. E. Yarshater
EW	<i>East and West</i>
FGrHist	see Bibliography under Jacoby
GBd. – BTA	<i>Zand-Ākāsīh. Iranian or Greater Bundahišn</i> , transl. by B.T. Anklesaria, Bombay, 1956
GBd. – TDA	<i>The Bundahišn</i> , ed. T.D. Anklesaria (see TD 2)
GlrPh	<i>Grundriss der iranischen Philologie</i> , ed. W. Geiger and E. Kuhn, 2 vols, Strassburg, 1895-1904
HdO	Handbuch der Orientalistik
HR	<i>History of Religions</i>
HUCA	<i>Hebrew Union College Annual</i>
IF	<i>Indogermanische Forschungen</i>
IJJ	<i>Indo-Iranian Journal</i>
IndBd.	<i>Indian Bundahišn</i> , transl. E.W. West, <i>Pahlavi Texts</i> , I (SBE 5), Oxford, 1880, pp. xxii-xxlv, 1-151
IrAnt	<i>Iranica Antiqua</i>
JA	<i>Journal asiatique</i>
JAH	<i>Journal of Asian History</i>

JAOS	<i>Journal of the American Oriental Society</i>
JCOI	<i>Journal of the K.R. Cama Oriental Institute</i>
JHS	<i>Journal of Hellenic Studies</i>
JNES	<i>Journal of Near Eastern Studies</i>
JRAS	<i>Journal of the Royal Asiatic Society</i>
KKZ	Inscription of Kerdīr, Ka'be-ye Zardošt
MANL	<i>Memorie dell'Accademia Nazionale dei Lincei, Classe di Scienze morali, storiche e filologiche</i>
Mojmal	<i>Mojmal al-tawārik wa'l-qeṣaṣ</i> , ed. M.T. Bahār, Tehran, 1318Š./1939
OInd.	Old Indian
OIr.	Old Iranian
OPers.	Old Persian
Oss.	Ossetic
Pahl.	Pahlavi
<i>Persia e mondo greco-romano</i>	<i>Atti del Convegno sul tema: la Persia e il mondo greco-romano (Roma, 11-14 aprile 1965) (Accademia Nazionale dei Lincei – Problemi attuali di scienza e di cultura, 76), Roma, 1966</i>
<i>Persia nel Medioevo</i>	<i>Atti del Convegno sul tema: la Persia nel Medioevo (Roma, 31 marzo-5 aprile 1970) (Accademia Nazionale dei Lincei – Problemi attuali di scienza e di cultura, 160), Roma, 1971.</i>
P.G.	see Bibliography under Migne
<i>Pahl. Rev. Dd.</i>	<i>The Pahlavi Revāyat accompanying the Dādestān ī Dēnīg</i>
RANL	<i>Rendiconti dell'Accademia Nazionale dei Lincei, Classe di Scienze morali, storiche e filologiche</i>
RE	<i>Paulys Real-Encyclopädie der classischen Altertumswissenschaft, Neue Bearbeitung von G. Wissowa</i>
REA	<i>Revue des études anciennes</i>
REJ	<i>Revue des études juives</i>
RhMus	<i>Rheinisches Museum für Philologie</i>

<i>RHR</i>	<i>Revue de l'histoire des religions</i>
<i>RSO</i>	<i>Rivista degli studi orientali</i>
<i>SBE</i>	Sacred Books of the East, ed. Max Müller
<i>Sogd.</i>	Sogdian
<i>SOR</i>	Serie Orientale Roma, Istituto italiano per il Medio ed Estremo Oriente (since 1996: Istituto italiano per l'Africa e l'Oriente)
<i>StIr.</i>	<i>Studia Iranica</i>
<i>Studia Grammatica Iranica</i>	<i>Studia Grammatica Iranica. Festschrift für Helmut Humbach</i> , ed. R. Schmitt and P.O. Skjærvø, München, 1986
<i>TD 1</i>	Bonyād-e Fahrang-e Irān (Iranian Culture Foundation), <i>The Bondahesh, Being a Facsimile Edition of the Manuscript TD 1 (prepared by P.K. Anklesaria)</i> , Tehran, n. d. [1349Š./1970]
<i>TD 2</i>	T.D. Anklesaria, <i>The Bundahishn, Being a Facsimile of the TD Manuscript No. 2 brought from Persia by Dastur Tîrandâz and now preserved in the late Ervad Tahmuras' library</i> , Bombay, 1908
<i>Vd.</i>	<i>Vendidad</i> or <i>Widēwdād</i>
<i>VDI</i>	<i>Vestnik drevnei istorii</i>
<i>WZKM</i>	<i>Wiener Zeitschrift für die Kunde des Morgenlandes</i>
<i>XPh</i>	Inscription of Xerxes, Persepolis, <i>h</i>
<i>Y.</i>	<i>Yasna</i>
<i>Yt.</i>	<i>Yašt</i>
<i>ZA</i>	<i>Zeitschrift für Assyriologie</i>
<i>ZDMG</i>	<i>Zeitschrift der Deutschen morgenländischen Gesellschaft</i>
<i>ZII</i>	<i>Zeitschrift für Indologie und Iranistik</i>
<i>ZPE</i>	<i>Zeitschrift für Papyrologie und Epigraphik</i>



Introduction

THE ORIGINALITY AND STRENGTH OF ZOROASTER'S TEACHING consist in its own peculiar answer to the problem of evil, namely in the radical dualism of the two opposite spiritual Powers, with which he showed man a way of salvation, obliging him to side with the benevolent power by his own free choice. No compromise is possible; only the acceptance of Truth can bring salvation; only good thoughts, good words and good deeds can guarantee the Best Existence. Zoroaster's teaching exalts the dignity in Man, making him the real protagonist of the work of salvation. There is a memorable page written by Walter Bruno Henning in 1949, dictated by a profound, clear-headed capacity for reflection, in which he grasps the essence of that teaching with masterly insight:

It seems to me that a dualism of this kind can have been built only on a pre-existing monotheism, on the belief that one God, a good God, was responsible for the world. For this reason I would claim that the religion in which Zoroaster grew up was purely monotheistic. Zoroaster's religion (as are most dualistic movements) is best understood as a *protest against monotheism*. Wherever a monotheistic religion establishes itself, this protest is voiced — if there is a man with a brain in his head. Any claim that the world was created by a good and benevolent god must provoke the question why the world, in the outcome, is so very far from good. Zoroaster's answer, that the world had been created by a good god *and* an evil

spirit, of equal power, who set out to spoil the good work, is a complete answer: it is a logical answer, more satisfying to the thinking mind than the one given by the author of the Book of Job, who withdrew to the claim that it did not behove man to inquire into the ways of Omnipotence¹.

Having reached this point, we shall quote Henning once more, as the following passage is the best possible introduction to our effort to place Zoroaster in history:

To us such problems may seem matters of past history; but to appreciate Zoroaster, we should see him against the background of his time. If we do that, we cannot help paying tribute to him as an original thinker; for he was the first to put forward this protest, based on reasoning, against monotheism; and he was the first, in drawing the consequence from his dualism to give his lofty conception of the position of Man. This is a great achievement. It seems all the greater when we consider that in material culture he was not far advanced; far less advanced than the peoples of the Near East, whom he nevertheless surpassed in thought².

I think that these words of Henning's fully answer the question that crops up repeatedly in our studies: "Who was Zoroaster?". This question has been put from different points of view: from the viewpoint of history or the phenomenology of religions by one such as C. Jouco Bleeker³ or from the more precisely Iranistic viewpoint of, for instance, Jean Kellens⁴.

The dualistic nature of Zoroaster's teaching did not escape the Greeks, who saw Zoroaster and the Magi as the champions of dualism. This was the view of Eudoxus of Cnidus, Theopompus, Aristotle, Eudemus of Rhodes, Hermippus, Diodorus Siculus, Plutarch, Diogenes Laertius, Hippolytus of Rome, Damascius and others, about whom we know very little as regards their standpoint concerning our subject, for example, Pythagoras or Plato⁵, or perhaps Empedocles, the philosopher of the four elements and of Love and Strife, himself a dualist, who exerted a profound influence on religious, philosophical and scientific thought from Classical Antiquity to Hellenism, from Late Antiquity to the Middle Ages, and not only in Europe; significantly enough, he was considered by his fellow countrymen as a disciple of the Persian Magi⁶.

Religious and philosophical thought in the 6th century and, more generally, in the period of the Persian empire of the Achae-menians (6th-4th century B.C.), were marked by the progressive spreading of new tendencies with a highly ethical content, which gave the individual a centrality he had never had in the old religious systems: in Israel the persistence of prophetism and post-exilic Judaism; in Greece the pre-Socratics; in India, Buddha and Mahavira; in China Confucius and the Taoist school. We know very little about the beginning of Zoroastrianism, but we can glean something of its spreading at that particular time, since it is reflected in a way both in the spirit and in the letter of the inscriptions of Darius I or Xerxes. Soteriology and eschatology ended up by being prevalent in the typical *Weltanschauung* of that time, while the traditional religious cults gradually began to lose their hold both in Greece and in the East.

Alongside Judaic monotheism and Zoroastrian dualism — two answers to the problem of evil, which was becoming more and more keenly felt — a new religiosity, with syncretistic tendencies, began to develop in western Asia and the eastern Mediterranean, that placed increasing emphasis on the individual as being directly responsible for his moral and intellectual choices. In this great historical development, Israel and Iran were two of the three main protagonists: the other one was Greece between Classicism and Hellenism.

Cyrus's empire, which embraced several nations, as did Alexander's two centuries later, favoured the separation between religion and state and encouraged a tendency towards a universalistic religiosity. One who fully realized this was Wilhelm Bousset in his *Die Religion des Judentums im späthellenistischen Zeitalter*: it was a general process towards an inner, personal religiosity, which separated the religious from the political sphere and widened the gap between the individual and the official cults of state and city. A more secular, ethical mentality came to the fore, which was less restricted than formerly by the influence of the traditional clergy⁷.

Placing Zoroaster just before or at the beginning of this process could mean restoring him to the 'axial age' which in a way was evoked, in the context of this same problem, by Louis Charles Casartelli, more than forty years before Karl Jaspers' *Vom Ursprung und Ziel der Geschichte* appeared in 1949. Casartelli's brief contribution to the *Spiegel Memorial Volume* was certainly not an argument in favour of the theories put forward by Edward W. West and A.V. Williams Jackson (see pp. 20, 67 f.), which had been questioned by Christian Bartholomae⁸ but "a sidelight, so to speak, an *a priori* historical consideration, which, if it cannot precisely be called an argument, at least indicates a certain harmony in the philosophical evolution of human thought, which appears to me not without its value"⁹. Indeed, the *Achsenzeit* would be seriously lacking without Zoroaster¹⁰. In the history of Iran between the 6th and the 4th century the Achaemenian monarchy was not everything. Together with it — as the Greeks were well aware — there flourished an intellectual and spiritual world that greatly influenced the historical development of Iranism and of the whole of antiquity. As well as Cyrus, Darius, Xerxes, or the three Artaxerxes etc., we must also name Zoroaster, Ostanes, Hystaspes (the 'Hellenized' Magi of Joseph Bidez and Franz Cumont) and other members of the *clarissima et utilissima* school of the Magi, in the opinion of Eudoxus of Cnidus and Aristotle apud Pliny, *Naturalis Historia* XXX, 3, about whom we know nothing but their names, and then only thanks to the Greeks.

I trust that nobody, then, would want to consider as superfluous this study whose results I shall be presenting in this second cycle of the Ehsan Yarshater Lectures, which the University of California, Los Angeles, has done me the honour of entrusting to me. It is not an abstruse exercise on a marginal problem of the religious history of ancient Iran, but an attempt — which I hope will be a convincing one — to solve a problem that is crucial not only for our understanding of Zoroastrianism, but also, considering the importance, the originality and the interest that Zoroaster's message aroused even beyond the vast territories where Iranian civili-

zation flourished, for the reconstruction of the intellectual and spiritual history of the ancient world, in a wider sense than the one which is usually limited by an essentially Classicist viewpoint, or at the most a Mediterranean or Near-Eastern one. In fact, the influence of Zoroastrian dualism and eschatology spread from Greece and Israel as far as India and Central Asia, as is shown by some characteristic trends in Great Vehicle Buddhism. Even before the Renaissance, when Zoroaster was revived in the transfigured form that had been handed down by the Platonic Academy, even before the tradition of western Hermetism and the culture of Illuminism,¹¹ the figure of Zoroaster, as one of the foremost exponents of that Wisdom which has been considered 'alien' to the Greeks and the Greek-Latin-Hebrew *collegium trilingue*,¹² was conspicuous for his enormous uniqueness in history, according to Friedrich Nietzsche's well-chosen expression in his *Ecce Homo*, in his appraisal of the contribution made by Zoroaster.¹³ There can be no doubt that Zoroaster's thought is the greatest treasure that ancient Iranian civilization has bequeathed to man, tormented as he is by evil and by his desire to fathom its inmost nature and its terrible power.

As I state more aptly in lecture one, if we are to understand what role a person or an event had in history, it is absolutely necessary to know when that person lived or when the event took place. Now, the date of Zoroaster has always been one of the major problems in Iranian studies, so much so that it has been said, with inappropriate irony, that the study of it has always been the favourite pastime of scholars.¹⁴ Up till the sixties the most authoritative scholarly opinions, with few exceptions, were divided in favour of one or the other extreme of a time-span that was fairly long, but fell substantially within the first half of the first millennium, i.e. between the 11th-9th centuries and the 7th-6th centuries B.C. However, from the seventies onward, in particular with Mary Boyce's research (see p. 21 ff.), these opinions covered a much wider range of time. Thus we were to learn from Max Mallowan that "It was perhaps in or about 586 B.C. that Zoroaster

at the age of 42 made a notable convert in king Vištāspa",¹⁵ but also, in reading the Columbia Lectures on Iranian Studies delivered by Boyce in 1988, and published in 1992, that the prophet must have lived between c.1500 and c.1200 B.C. (with some preference for the later date: see p. 22).¹⁶ And we must remark that, although this latter date is in itself an early one, in Boyce's opinion it is a comparatively late date in Zoroastrian chronology. As a matter of fact, in her *Zoroastrians. Their religious beliefs and practices*, she had proposed a span of time that could go back a further three, four or five centuries before 1200, that is to say, between 1700 and 1500 B.C.¹⁷ In a review of this last work, the renowned scholar for whom these lectures are named, Professor Ehsan Yarshater, did not fail to point out that such a date in remote antiquity also raises problems that are certainly not easy to solve.¹⁸

So, up till the seventies, in our studies the date of Zoroaster ranged between the beginning and the middle of the first millennium, though not without some exceptions. A fairly exhaustive account of the state of these studies, which covers the situation up till the beginning of the sixties, can be found in Kurt Rudolph's article of 1961, republished by Bernfried Schlerath in 1970,¹⁹ whereas for a more up-to-date situation my *Zoroaster's Time and Homeland* and my *The Idea of Iran* can be consulted, or else Boyce's aforementioned Columbia Lectures, or a recent article by I.V. P'yankov, as well, of course, as the relevant information given during our seminar lectures.²⁰ The most notable exception is certainly the view expressed by James Darmesteter, who assumed a somewhat extreme position, re-echoed in part by Marijan Molé²¹ and now by Kellens as well (see p. 17),²² that goes so far as to deny the historicity of Zoroaster. From the seventies onwards the tendency to give an earlier date for Zoroaster or for the Gāthās has become more marked, as can be seen from the studies of such scholars as, for instance, Christian Rempis,²³ Thomas Burrow,²⁴ A. Shapur Shahbazi,²⁵ as well as Helmut Humbach,²⁶ M. Boyce, the present author, J. Kellens, and very recently Jahanshah Derakhshani.²⁷ Kellens' standpoint received a sympathetic hearing from

Prods Oktor Skjærvø in a recent useful article on the Avesta as a source for the early history of the Iranians.²⁸ In 1995 there also appeared in the periodical *Iran* an important contribution which Ilya Gershevitch made, at the end of 1993, to an International Colloquium on “New Approaches to the Interpretation of the Gathas”, held in Croydon under the auspices of the World Zoroastrian Organisation.²⁹ On this occasion Gershevitch resolutely repropounded Henning’s thesis in favour of dating Zoroaster between the 7th and the 6th century B.C. and made a penetrating critical examination of my previous position, together with those held by Boyce, Humbach, Kellens, Shahbazi and Peter Kingsley who, in one of his recent articles, having taken an early chronology for granted, puts forward the idea, as original as it is unlikely, of there having been a Greek origin for the traditional date of Zoroaster³⁰ (see p. 106 f.). Even more recently there has appeared the aforementioned article by P’yankov in *Vestnik drevnei istorii* 1996, in which the author proposes a date for Zoroaster between the second half of the seventh and the first half of the sixth century.³¹

What was the cause of this division between scholars? In substance, the importance that is to be attached to the traditional date of the prophet, as it has been handed down by the Zoroastrian and Muslim sources, which is the subject of our seminar lecture number four. This traditional date places Zoroaster between the end of the 7th and the first half of the 6th century B.C. and dates his life, which according to tradition lasted seventy-seven years, 258 years before Alexander. The historical reliability of this chronology was presumed to be little or none by those who believed in the great antiquity of the Gāthās, on the grounds of a comparison with Vedic literature, or who were misled by the Greeks’ dating in terms of five millennia before the fall of Troy or six millennia before the death of Plato (see lecture number two), and they felt free, in the face of these mythical calculations, to take the chronology of the prophet back by several centuries at least. Or there are others who, for sound reasons, did not believe in the argument of those who accept the traditional date but go even further and identify the

Vīštāspa whom Zoroaster converted with Darius I's father of the same name.³²

Now, in spite of the fact that the present author, in an article of 1971, and then in *Zoroaster's Time and Homeland*, 1980, and in *De Zoroastre à Mani. Quatre leçons au Collège de France* (delivered in 1983 and published in 1985), assumed a critical attitude towards the theses based on the traditional date, with particular reference to the arguments set forth by the scholar to whose memory this cycle of lectures is dedicated,³³ he is now obliged to admit that in actual fact, from the forties onwards, the historical reliability of the traditional date of Zoroaster has been proved once and for all by the discovery made by an American scholar, Hildegard Lewy, fifty-five years ago³⁴ and backed up by the arguments of the leading expert in the chronology and chronography of ancient Iran, Sayyed Hasan Taqizadeh,³⁵ that were summed up by Henning in the third of his Ratanbai Katrak Lectures, given in Oxford in 1949 and published in 1951:³⁶ the mistake according to which, under the first Sassanian kings, only 266 years were assigned to the Arsacid dynasty was only the natural consequence of the identification, that had then come into use, of the years of the Seleucid era with the corresponding years of the tenth millennium of the world-year, since the duration of the Arsacid period could only be calculated on the basis of a certainty, consisting in the 258 years between Zoroaster and Alexander, which thus turned out to be an 'immutable quantity' (Henning: see p. 144) that was anchored to a tradition of unquestionable importance.

The four seminar lectures deal with the whole matter, and particularly with the studies that have come after 1980, when my *Zoroaster's Time and Homeland* was published.

The first lecture is devoted to the reasons that persuaded me to change my mind about the thesis according to which Zoroaster lived between the end of the second and the beginning of the first millennium B.C., or in the tenth century. It includes a review of the positions of Kellens and Boyce, which also takes into consideration Gershevitch's refutation of them.

The second lecture is mainly concerned with the interpretation of the Classical sources that date Zoroaster in remote antiquity and shows how these were conditioned by a misunderstanding that had already arisen amongst the Greeks in the mid 5th century B.C. over the information concerning the Iranian doctrine of the world-year of 12000 years (my arguments differ not only from the ones used by Humbach but also from those used by Gershevitch concerning the evidence given by Xanthus of Lydia).

The third lecture takes into account another Greek tradition about the date of Zoroaster that is implicit in the Pythagoras-Zoroaster synchronism and is the subject of a stimulating but misleading article by Kingsley. It also considers the *interpretatio Judaica* Ezekiel-Zoroaster, attested by Clement of Alexandria, which was the subject of my contribution to the third European Conference of Iranian Studies, held in Cambridge in September 1995.³⁷

The fourth and last lecture is concerned entirely with the dating of Zoroaster in Zoroastrian sources and in others that derive from them, and with the attempt to demonstrate the historicity of the traditional date of 258 years before Alexander. It also deals once again with the problem of Zoroaster's date according to the Manichaeans, which was the subject of a recent article of mine in *East and West*³⁸ and it proposes as the historical date of the prophet the one which Henning gave as a third possible alternative: 618-541 B.C.³⁹

The results obtained in the four lectures all point to a date for Zoroaster between the end of the 7th and the middle of the 6th century B.C. and I hope, if no new evidence to the contrary turns up, that this problem, which is crucial to the studies on ancient Iranian civilization, can be taken as substantially resolved, in the very way that Henning proposed fifty years ago.

If this were to be so we should also acquire, implicitly, another no less important piece of evidence, that would do away with the prejudice that the ancient Iranians had absolutely no sense of history. In religious circles, at least, the memory of an epoch-making event, the revelation of the Good Religion or the Coming of Zoro-

aster, would have been kept alive for as long as two and a half centuries, thanks to a continuous counting of the years, before the Seleucid era was established. This was fully realized by Gershevitch.⁴⁰ The ancient Iranians did not lack a sense of history, independently of the indubitable breach in the tradition that was caused by Alexander's invasion and the consequent impoverishment in their knowledge about the Achaemenian period,⁴¹ as has been investigated with great insight by Professor Yarshater in a well known lecture that he read in Rome in 1970.⁴² Arnaldo Momigliano has also drawn attention to this matter in some of his studies,⁴³ and I, too, have attempted to go into it more thoroughly in my recent research.⁴⁴ This, however, is a matter which goes beyond the target I set myself in these Ehsan Yarshater Lectures. Suffice it to mention here that a sense of history and a sense of national identity were two aspects of the one historical process which began in Iran in the first half of the first millennium B.C., when Iranian civilization flourished, not only with the world empire founded by Cyrus, but also with the ethical and philosophical message of the great prophet of dualism.

Notes to Introduction

1. Henning, *Zoroaster*, 46. F. Spiegel expressed himself in partly similar terms in order to explain the essence of dualism in its different forms: *Erânische Alterthumskunde*, II: *Religion, Geschichte bis zum Tode Alexanders der Grossen*, Leipzig, 1873, p. VI. The analogy between Henning's and Spiegel's interpretations was noted by Duchesne-Guillemin, *Western Response*, 1-2; *RIA*, p. 392 n. 3; "Variations sur Zoroastre", in *Au carrefour des religions. Mélanges offerts à Philippe Gignoux* (Res Orientales, 7), Bures-sur-Yvette, 1995, 39-48, at p. 43.

2. Henning, *Zoroaster*, 46-47.

3. Bleeker, "Wer war Zarathustra?", *Persica*, 7, 1975-1978, 25-41.

4. Kellens, *Qui était Zarathustra?* (Faculté de Philosophie et Lettres – Conférences, débats, dossiers), Liège, 1993.

5. On the evidence in Classical authors see Clemen, *Fontes* and *Nachrichten*; Fox and Pemberton, *Passages*; Bidez and Cumont, *MH* I and II. See also the specific studies on the subject by Windischmann, *Studien*, 260-313; Benveniste, *PR*; Messina, *Ursprung*.

6. Empedocles is the subject of an important book by P. Kingsley, that has just been published by the Oxford University Press: *Ancient Philosophy, Mystery, and Magic. Empedocles and Pythagorean tradition*, Oxford, 1995.

7. See, amongst others, Duchesne-Guillemin, *RIA*, 258-59, and, with particular reference to post-exilic Judaism, W. Bousset, *Die Religion des Judentums im späthellenistischen Zeitalter* (Handbuch zum Neuen Testament, 21), 3rd ed. by H. Gressmann, Tübingen, 1926, 53-86, 481-82.

8. Bartholomae, *Air. Wb.*, 1675-76.

9. Casartelli, "A note on the Probable Date of Zarathustra", in *Spiegel Memorial Volume*, ed. J.J. Modi, Bombay, 1908, 130-32, at p. 130. I am grateful to Antonio Panaino, who is well acquainted with Casartelli's work (see Panaino, "Casartelli, Louis Charles", *Elr.* V, 1992, 24-25) for having drawn my attention to this short but significant note.

10. The good fortune that was enjoyed by Jaspers' idea (*Vom Ursprung und Ziel der Geschichte*, Zürich, 1949), or at any rate the interest it aroused, was remarkable indeed. Recent references to the 'axial age' can be found in works that differ greatly in subject, approach and leaning, as for instance in

Momigliano, *Alien Wisdom*, 9-10, or in M. Liverani, *Antico Oriente. Storia, società, economia*, Roma-Bari, 1988, 938-42. An interesting book is the one edited by S.N. Eisenstadt, *The Origins & Diversity of Axial Age Civilizations*, Albany, N.Y., 1986, about the origins of the 'axial age civilizations' and their differences, though unfortunately Iran is practically, and unexpectedly, not dealt with.

11. O.-H. Bonnerot, "La légende de Zoroastre au Siècle des Lumières", in *Études sur le XVIII^e siècle*, Strasbourg, 1982, 323-56. The figure of Zoroaster in Western culture is dealt with in a lecture that I gave at the University of Urbino on 26th March 1996: "Zoroastro nella nostra cultura", *Studi Urbinati B*, 68, 1997-1998, 205-19.

12. Momigliano, "The fault of the Greeks", in *Essays*, 9-23, at p. 21.

13. Cf. Duchesne-Guillemin, *Western Response*, p. 22 n. 1.

14. Daffinà, "Senso del tempo", 25.

15. M. Mallowan, "Cyrus the Great (558-529 B.C.)", in *CHIr*: II, 1985, 392-419, at p. 416.

16. Boyce, *Zoroastrianism*, 45.

17. Boyce, *Zoroastrians*, 18.

18. Yarshater, *JAH*, 14, 1980, 152-55, at p. 154.

19. Rudolph, "Zarathustra – Priester und Prophet", *Numen*, 8, 1961, 81-116, at pp. 82-88 (= *Zarathustra*, ed. B. Schlerath, Darmstadt, 1970, 270-311, at p. 271-78).

20. Gnoli, *ZTH*, 158-59; *Idea of Iran*, 64-65; Boyce, *Zoroastrianism*, 27-51; P'yankov, "Zoroastr."

21. Molé, *CMC*, 530-32.

22. Kellens, *ZAA*, 67. We must bear in mind, however, that the theories of Darmesteter, Molé and Kellens concerning the problem of the historicity of Zoroaster all have rather different starting points.

23. Rempis, "Die Zeit Zarathustras", *Die Welt des Orients*, 6, 1970-1971, 234-39.

24. Burrow, "The Proto-Indoaryans", *JRAS*, 1973, 123-40.

25. Shahbazi, "Date of Z."

26. Humbach, "Western approach", 2-15; *Gāthās I*, pp. 24-30.

27. Derakhshani, *Geschichte und Kultur des Alten Ostiran*, I, 1: *Die Zeit Zarathustras. Rekonstruktion der altiranischen Chronologie*, Tehran, 1995, 89-127.

28. Skjærvø, "The Avesta as source for the early history of the Iranians", in *The Indo-Aryans of Ancient South-Asia. Language, material culture and ethnicity*, ed. G. Erdosy, Berlin – New York, 1995, 155-76, at p. 160-62.

29. Gershevitch, "Approaches".

30. Kingsley, "Greek origin".
31. P'yankov, "Zoroastr".
32. Cf. Gnoli, *ZTH*, 2-3.
33. Gnoli, "Sassanidi", 233-38; *ZTH*, 166-74; *De Z. à M.*, 36-39.
34. H. Lewy, "Faulty Pers. chron."
35. Taqizadeh, "Era of Z."
36. Henning, *Zoroaster*, 37-41.
37. Gnoli, "Further considerations on a Manichaean dating of Zoroaster", in *Proceedings of the Third European Conference of Iranian Studies held in Cambridge, 11th to 15th September 1995*, Part 1: *Old and Middle Iranian Studies*, ed. N. Sims-Williams, Wiesbaden, 1998, 13-20.
38. Gnoli, "Once more Zoroaster's time: a Manichaean dating", *EW*, 45, 1995, 313-19.
39. Henning, *Zoroaster*, 41. Gershevitch, "Approaches", 15, also gets the same result: see below, p. 85 n. 61.
40. Gershevitch, "Approaches", 8-9.
41. Cf. Gnoli, *Idea of Iran*, 121-24, with the necessary bibliographical references.
42. Yarshater, "Were the Sasanians heirs to the Achaemenids?", in *Persia nel Medioevo*, 517-31. On this argument see also: Gnoli, *Idea of Iran*, 118 ff.; "L'inscription de Šābuhr à la Ka'be-ye Zardošt et la propagande sassanide", in *Histoire et cultes de l'Asie Centrale préislamique. Sources écrites et documents archéologiques* (Actes du Colloque international du CNRS, Paris, 22-28 novembre 1988, sous la direction de P. Bernard et F. Grenet), Paris, 1993, 57-63; T. Daryaee, "National history or Keyanid history: the nature of Sasanid Zoroastrian historiography", *Iranian Studies*, 28, 1995, 129-41.
43. Momigliano, "Eastern elements in post-exilic Jewish, and Greek, historiography", in *Essays*, 25-35; "Persian historiography, Greek historiography, and Jewish historiography", in *The Classical Foundations of Modern Historiography* (Sather Classical Lectures, 54), Berkeley – Los Angeles – Oxford, 1990, 5-28.
44. Gnoli, "Iranic identity as a historical problem: the beginnings of a national awareness under the Achaemenians", in *The East and the Meaning of History – International Conference (23-27 November 1992)* (Studi Orientali, 13), Rome, 1994, 147-67.

New hypotheses on the date of Zoroaster

AT THE PRESENT STAGE OF MY STUDY I am greatly indebted to Ilya Gershevitch. Ever since I published my book on Zoroaster's time and homeland in 1980, I can say that he has never failed to point out to me, every time I have had the good fortune of speaking to him, that my criticism of Henning's position concerning the date of Zoroaster was wrong because it was based on a flaw in my judgement of what that giant of Iranian studies had written in his Ratanbai Katrak Lectures.¹ As a matter of fact, my own shortcomings had led me to make an erroneous analysis of that excellent resumé and it was only with the passing of time that it became clear and convincing to me.

I am therefore grateful to Gershevitch for having persuaded me to reconsider my position on a subject which is fundamental to our knowledge of the history and religion of ancient Iran. We cannot but agree with the opinion expressed by Henning:

It is obviously impossible to understand anything of anyone without knowing, at least approximately, the time in which he lived, without apprehending, by such knowledge, his environment, the conditions of life, the cultural situation in which he found himself. To say that the date is irrelevant shows abysmal lack of feeling for all history. The date must be settled one way or the other; without it all discussion on Zoroaster will remain futile.²

And since I realize, after more than twenty years of research, that Gershevitch was right when he wrote of his master that "the chances of his taking a false step in the solution of whatever problem he decided to tackle were reduced to the minimum compatible with human fallibility"³, I have decided to present here the results of a critical revision of my earlier opinions, dedicating them to the memory of Henning fifty years after his lectures, together with a different proposal for solving the problem of the date of Zoroaster.

It was not only, to tell the truth, the incentive provided by Gershevitch's criticism, nor what he has recently written, in an article that we shall come back to several times,⁴ that convinced to undertake this critical revision of my work. There was another reason, too. The abandonment of Henning's proposed date coincided with a sort of disintegration of Zoroastrian studies which is apparent to everyone. Whereas once there was a fairly general agreement over a date at the turning point between the 2nd and the 1st millennium B.C.,⁵ before Henning's third Ratanbai Katrak lecture, now the situation has changed radically. If anyone wishes to find out when we ought to date the leading figure in ancient Iranian religious and philosophical thought, who made such a strong impression upon the mind and imagination of the Greeks and then came down in various forms to Western culture, from Humanism to the Enlightenment and down to our time, will come across a great number of conflicting ideas that cover a time-span of more than a thousand years. And so it is not surprising that, as well as the bewildering vagueness of the time, the very person who was supposed to have lived in that time seems to vanish: some think that Zoroaster was only a name and not a real historical figure at all. Thus we have a whole range of theories going from the founder of a prehistoric and even, in a sense, 'pre-Iranian' religion to an emblematic name standing for a social group that was distinguished by its liturgy (see p. 22).

At the two extremes of this range we have the theories of Mary Boyce and of Jean Kellens. These theories have been elaborated

in a series of studies on Zoroastrianism and on Avestan respectively. The very authority of their authors obliges us to pay due attention to them. As well as in a great number of minor studies, Boyce has expounded her theories in what will be, when it is finished, the greatest history of Zoroastrianism ever written.⁶ As for Kellens, he has gradually enucleated them, as it were, from his studies on the language of the Avesta and especially of the Gāthās.⁷ Just as Boyce has drawn away from the ideas that her teacher, Henning, had about Zoroaster and the historical development of Zoroastrianism, Kellens has gradually increased the gap between his ideas and the teachings of Jacques Duchesne-Guillemin, who had first guided him in Iranian studies with a specific interest in religion, and, as well as abandoning the theory of the tripartite ideology with regard to Iran,⁸ he has rehabilitated some aspects of Marijan Molé's arguments, namely the ones where — we might say — structure and cult definitely prevail over history.⁹

Before we turn our attention to the conclusions reached by Boyce and Kellens, I think I ought to explain the reasons that led me to reject the idea that Zoroaster lived between the end of the 2nd and the beginning of the 1st millennium B.C., as I wrote in my book *Zoroaster's Time and Homeland*. In recent years I have only briefly mentioned some changes of mind without giving a full explanation of the reasons behind them.

After my attempts to prove that the tradition that would have Zoroaster living 258 years before Alexander is historically unreliable and that the beginnings of Zoroastrianism must go back to a time between the end of the 2nd and the middle of the 1st millennium B.C.,¹⁰ I have come back to the subject on several occasions, though assuming positions of greater uncertainty which do not necessarily rule out the possibility of a date between the 7th and the 6th century B.C.¹¹

I can sum up as follows the reasons that led me to change my mind about my previous viewpoint, that was in favour of what we can define from now on as the early chronology of Zoroaster (about the 10th century B.C.; consequently, we shall define the 7th-6th

century date as the late chronology).

There were three arguments that I used to back up the thesis that I presented in its most complete form in 1980. First, the differences in the social and economical environment of western Iran in the Achaemenian period, with the development of urbanization and the formation of a new concept of royalty, as compared with the Iranian society that is revealed by the Avesta, with its archaic social structures and its economy based on pasturage, stock-raising and elementary forms of agriculture.¹² Secondly, the negative opinion about the historical value of the traditional date of 258 years before Alexander. Thirdly, the apparently imaginary date for Zoroaster that was frequent amongst the Greeks, suggesting a remote and mythical antiquity that could hardly be explained if he had lived at the time of Cyrus, but would be feasible if we were to suppose that Zoroastrianism had arisen several centuries earlier than the formation of the Persian empire.

The first argument seemed to me to entail the passing of a period of time between Zoroaster and the great world empire that was long enough to allow for the aforesaid social, economic and political changes that came about amongst the Medes and the Persians. I had calculated this period as being approximately four centuries — the same length of time as Kellens had supposed in 1985 (see p. 35 n. 7), though on completely different grounds — and this accorded with the opinion of many renowned scholars who had come before me.

Closer consideration of the Gāthās and the *Yasna Haptaḡhāiti*, which was prompted by the research done in the eighties and nineties — I refer in particular to the works by Johanna Narten and Martin Schwartz in 1986, Jean Kellens and Eric Pirart in 1988, Helmut Humbach in 1991¹³ — convinced me, though, that it is no use comparing Achaemenian reality with that of the Avesta taken as a whole. It is true that the Avestan horizon does not include western Iran, Media and Persia, and that the social and political order of the Avestan people, as far as we can reconstruct it, is very different from that of Achaemenian Persia, but this does not

mean that we must necessarily conceive of the evolution of the Aryans, who had settled in the western region of the Plateau, towards a new social and political order as being a historical process that lasted for several centuries.

In actual fact the western Aryans, the Medes and the Persians, must have been strongly influenced by factors such as the particular environmental conditions, the contact with other cultures and societies of long-settled peoples and also political and military requirements, and all these factors would have brought about radical and, in particular, rapid changes, of which we find significant echoes in the Classical sources.¹⁴ At the same time we have no elements of certainty to help us reconstruct the exact relationship between, for example, the *Yašts* and the *Gāthās*, or the relationship between either of them and the *Yasna Haptaṅhāiti*,¹⁵ etc. In these cases the problems of absolute and relative chronology are just as intricate, except when we have evidence in the *Yašts* of some passages in a hymn depending directly on passages from another hymn. On these subjects we can benefit from reading the outline of Old Iranian literature that Gershevitch published in 1968.¹⁶

In any case my reasoning was supported by evidence that turned out to be misleading: it is true that the *Gāthās* do not mention the Medes and the Persians, but it is equally true that western Iran is unknown to the 'Young Avesta' even in the parts that we may reasonably suppose to belong to Achaemenian or post-Achaemenian times. This incontrovertible fact undermines one of the main points upon which my earlier thesis was built. In order to explain the silence of the *Gāthās* and of the whole of the Avesta with regard to the Medes and Persians, we must find reasons other than a chronological gap: in this instance, too, the explanations given by Gershevitch in the aforementioned work can be enlightening.

As for my negative opinion about the historical value of the traditional date that places Zoroaster 258 years before Alexander, I have already admitted that it is unlikely that this number "may be the simple result of a Sassanian calculation, as I thought in

1971 and in 1980" and that "Henning was probably right in this".¹⁷ The reason for my change of mind is due to the fact that in all likelihood the dates with 258 years and 300 years are not variations of the one reckoning. It is therefore not possible to take the two numbers as being connected with one another, according to the explanation which I agreed with,¹⁸ that would have the first date as being the one when Zoroaster, at the age of forty-two, converted Vīštāspa and the second date as the year when he was born. Both the 258 years and the 300 years between Zoroaster and Alexander start with the same event, namely with the coming of the religion and its first propagation, when Zoroaster was thirty years old, and not forty-two, and when Vīštāspa had already been reigning for thirty years (see p. 156). All this was made clear a century ago by E.W. West and by A. V. Williams Jackson.¹⁹ Carlo G. Cereti has proved convincingly that the acceptance of the religion, which is spoken of in the *Greater Bundahišn*, does not refer to the conversion of Vīštāspa but to the revelation which Zoroaster had at the age of thirty, that is to say, to the coming of the religion.²⁰ And so the second argument of my earlier thesis is also demolished: the number 258 is not the result of the subtraction of 42 years (the age of Zoroaster when he converted Vīštāspa) from the round figure of 300, which is supposed to have been the number of years that elapsed between Zoroaster and Alexander. In actual fact these numbers are the result of different chronological reckonings that are also calculated from two different viewpoints: in one Alexander is the starting-point from which to count back to Zoroaster; in the other he represents the end of a period in which the new religion flourished, pure and uncontaminated by doubts according to *Ardā Wīrāz Nāmag* I, and undisturbed, side by side with royalty, according to *Wizīdagīhā ī Zādspram* XXV. The only thing these two calculations have in common is the reference to the cursed Macedonian as being the point of greatest crisis in the religious tradition.

The third argument is the one that turned out to be the weakest of all three. The dating of Zoroaster to six millennia before the

5th-4th century B.C. or five millennia before the Trojan War is by no means proof of the prophet's having lived in very remote times,²¹ but only goes to show that the Greeks of the Classical period had come to hear of the millenarian doctrine. In this doctrine, as Jackson pointed out,²² the formation of Zoroaster's *fravaši* was made to date back to "several thousands" of years before his birth. The Greeks were probably misled, most likely because they took a sort of spiritual birth of Zoroaster to be his appearance in the material world. Not all of them, however: some dated Zoroaster in the 6th century, making him Pythagoras' teacher.

In a recent article I have therefore tried to show that the disagreement between a date going back some thousands of years and the 6th-century date is actually only apparent or, at any rate, it was real only for the Greeks and not for their sources of information, which were more or less misunderstood.²³ This does away with one of the most frequently occurring arguments that have brought into disrepute the traditional date of Zoroaster as being 258 years before Alexander, as E.W. West had already pointed out.²⁴

The Greek sources can therefore be added to the Iranian ones as being in favour of a late chronology for Zoroaster: not only the sources that tell of a meeting between Pythagoras and Zoroaster — which Peter Kingsley thought lay behind the Persians' sixth-century dating of Zoroaster²⁵ — but also the sources that date the prophet six thousand years before Xerxes or Plato or five thousand years before the Trojan War. Furthermore, in two recent articles,²⁶ I have attempted to show that there is concrete evidence to affirm that the Manichaeans also dated Zoroaster to the 6th century, probably because they were influenced by a Jewish or Judaeo-Christian tradition that was most likely independent of the Greek tradition (see p. 111 ff.), as well as by the evidence to that effect that must have come from the Magi priesthood.

We shall now turn our attention to the arguments that have been put forward by Boyce and Kellens concerning the date of Zoroastrian origins. These arguments could be called extreme, as one tends toward a very remote antiquity for the prophet while

the other even tends to dissolve the very figure of Zoroaster in a sort of 'cercle gâthique'. We must remark straight away that a large part of the considerations I have just made in revising my earlier views are equally valid as a criticism of the reconstruction proposed by Boyce and so it is not necessary to re-state my arguments. We only need to specify that over the last twenty years Boyce has proposed an approximate date for Zoroaster to be included in a time-span that goes from 1700 B.C.²⁷ to 1200 B.C.²⁸, though she declares that she is inclined to opt for 1200, so as to avoid "too huge a temporal gap between the Old and the Young Avesta".

According to Boyce, Zoroaster was a "trained priest, steeped from a very early age in the professional study of religion"²⁹ and a prophet who was the author not only of the Gāthās but of all the "Old Avestan texts". He would have lived, then, before his people emigrated from the steppes of Inner Asia towards the sites they occupied in historical times, that is to say, in the Iranian Heroic Age, when they would still have had a bipartite social structure composed of warrior-herdsmen and priests.

It is not possible to go over all the arguments that Boyce has used on many occasions³⁰ to support her theories, from the first volume of her *History of Zoroastrianism* in 1975 to the publication of her Columbia Lectures in 1992. There is, however, one feature that is constant. They are based on a number of hypotheses that are all linked to one another and are in several cases based on premises that are taken as certain, whereas in actual fact this is not so. For example, there is the theory that draws its inspiration from an article written by Thomas Burrow in 1973,³¹ according to which a period of some 100-150 years can be reconstructed for the generations that went from Saēna son of Ahūm.stūt down to Utayūti son of Viṭkavi in the *Farvardīn Yašt*, or a period of 150-200 years that lapsed between the Gāthās and the great Yašts. In actual fact, we have no proof that these Yašts "slowly acquired more or less their existing forms during the ninth-eighth centuries, becoming essentially fixed by the end of that period" as

Boyce wrote.³² Burrow's reasoning can be refuted by the remarks made above about the fact that there is no mention of western Iran in the whole Avesta. It is therefore quite clear that if these texts were to date to the height of the Achaemenian period (which is not only possible but probable), then those calculations of generations could confirm a date for Zoroaster between the 7th and the 6th century B.C.

Actually Boyce has now given up the idea of a Zoroaster who "flourished when the Stone Age was giving way for the Iranians to the Bronze Age, possibly, that is, between about 1700 and 1500 B.C."³³ Even so, with her inclination towards a date around 1200, she cannot avoid an excessive chronological vagueness that, on account of the weakness and too conjectural nature of her arguments, is destined to oscillate in a temporal gap — a gap which the archaeological discoveries, however interesting, have not managed to fill so far, at least with regard to our problem.³⁴ As for the particular expressions of the language of the Gāthās, in their use of metaphors and pastoral imagery, which in Boyce's opinion are proof of a greater antiquity of the parts of the Avesta that should be attributed to Zoroaster, the same objection must be made as for the linguistic argument in general. Although Boyce is not averse to this latter argument, it is more typical of Kellens' thesis and this gives us reason to proceed with our critical review.

Kellens has based his thesis on linguistic arguments. As he is one of those scholars who uses the definitions 'Old Avestan' and 'Young Avestan' to distinguish the language of the various parts of the Avesta, he maintains that the language of the Gāthās, the *Yasna Haptaŋhāiti*, the *Yaθā ahū vairyō* and the *Ā airyāmā išyō* (though not the *Ašəm vohū* and the *Yeŋhē hātqm*)³⁵ and likewise the language of other 'Old Avestan' fragments, such as *Y. 27,7* and *Y. 56,1*, marks them as a monolithic corpus, in verse and prose, of which no part "signale le moindre décalage chronologique entre la partie en vers et la partie en prose".³⁶ We shall come back to this last point later on. For the time being we must merely point out that it is not possible to give a diachronic meaning to the defi-

nitions 'Old Avestan' and 'Young Avestan' and therefore, in order to avoid misunderstanding, it would be better to substitute them with 'Gathic' or 'Gathic Avestan' (used by Christian Bartholomae) and 'Standard Avestan', as Gershevitch suggests very appropriately.³⁷

The definition 'Young Avestan', although Bartholomae uses it, is a tricky one and also misleading, as it can suggest a distinction in terms of absolute chronology. The unsoundness of this was demonstrated by Antoine Meillet in his famous article "Observations critiques sur le texte de l'Avesta".³⁸ This means that we cannot accept what is proposed in this connection by Karl Hoffmann and Johanna Narten, Humbach, Boyce, Kellens,³⁹ as all of them maintain that the 'Old Avestan' texts are chronologically earlier than the 'Young Avestan' ones.

It is easy to refute the theory according to which a language that is on the whole richer in archaic features is also older than *another* language which does not possess these features to the same extent, unless this theory is founded on historical or extra-linguistic evidence as well. We have already seen how weak these arguments are in the reconstruction that Boyce proposes and we can rightly say that Kellens does not introduce any further extra-linguistic arguments to back up his theory, except for the one which derives, in substance, from his recent utilization⁴⁰ of Burrow's theory on the Proto-Indoaryans and the Iranian **daiyā-* (see p. 28). Indeed, quite paradoxically he reverses the terms of the question: since it would not be possible to accept as extra-linguistic evidence the date of 258 years before Alexander, because in his opinion it is dubious and in any case its authenticity cannot be proved, then the only grounds are the "évident décalage d'évolution entre le vieil-avestique et l'avestique récent"⁴¹.

Thus Kellens thinks that the irregularity in the linguistic development is not in itself valid evidence and that it could be overlooked if there are no reliable historical data to contradict it. That is to say, it would be justifiable to take the degree of development of two different languages and use it as the basis for a chronologi-

cal reconstruction. In this particular case it would be justified on three different grounds: the comparison of the accusative and the dative-genitive of the enclitic pronouns of the first and second person plural in 'Old Avestan', which distinguishes them, and in 'Young Avestan', which does not; the conjugation which is based entirely on the present root in 'Young Avestan' and in Old Persian, and on the present and aorist roots in 'Old Avestan'; the presence in the Gāthās of the Indo-European laryngeals in the form of a hiatus in an intervocalic position — a feature which reveals the remarkably archaic nature of 'Old Avestan'.⁴²

According to Kellens there has been such progress in Iranian linguistics since the studies of Meillet⁴³ and Henning — who made a decided stand against the linguistic argument "of such extraordinary feebleness that one is amazed at finding it seriously discussed at all"⁴⁴ — up till the end of the fifties that the irregularity of the linguistic evolution cannot be used by the opponents of the early chronology "avec la même innocence qu'en 1925 ou en 1951".⁴⁵ In his view this is shown by the importance of the three aforesaid arguments, for each of which he refers respectively to Hoffmann,⁴⁶ Humbach⁴⁷ and Kuiper.⁴⁸ But it is here, to my mind, that he commits an error. It is not true, as he would have it, that those who are against an early chronology still use the irregularity of the linguistic evolution as their main argument. According to Henning, for instance, the traditional date is the real argument while the linguistic evidence is simply a non-argument for any sort of solution to the chronological problem. Let us read his own words on the subject:

The linguistic argument is this: in comparison with the language of the Old Persian inscriptions the language of the Gāthās is far less developed, far closer to hypothetical Old Iranian; therefore, the Gāthās should be older than the oldest Old Persian inscriptions by more than a few decades. This argument would hold good only if the language of the Gāthās were the same dialect, at an earlier stage, as Old Persian; but that is not the case and has never been claimed. It is notorious that the various dialects of one and the same language group develop at different speeds and in different directions, so that the comparison

of two dialects can never lead to a relative date. Moreover, in Iranian the Eastern and Western dialects developed not merely in different but in opposite directions; thus while the word endings disappeared in the West, they were well maintained in the East. From the point of view of comparative linguistics the Gāthās could have been composed at a date far later than 600 B.C.⁴⁹

As for Meillet, he had written a quarter of a century earlier:

L'état de langue que présentent les gāthā ne permet pas de préciser la date où cette langue se serait fixée. Car la rapidité avec laquelle évoluent les langues varie d'un cas à l'autre. En second lieu, une langue littéraire une fois fixée se maintient sans grand changement visible: le latin dans lequel sont rédigés les textes médiévaux ne donne aucune idée de l'italien, de l'espagnol, du français que parlaient les gens du XIII^e siècle ap. J.-C. Enfin, on n'a pas de point de repère pour le dialecte auquel appartient la langue avestique.⁵⁰

In Kellens' opinion, however, the lesser archaism of the 'Young Avesta' is proof in itself, even in the absence of extra-linguistic evidence, of the greater antiquity of the Gāthās compared, for example, with the Yašt. Furthermore, he is also convinced that the comparatively equal extent of development reached by Old Persian and 'Young Avestan'⁵¹ could be taken, if not as proof of actual linguistic synchronism, at least as a "point de repère commode, dont j'ai toujours eu un peu honte, mais dont je me sers parce que je ne crois pas qu'il puisse être radicalement faux".⁵² But in actual fact, as far as he is concerned, the irregularity in the linguistic development — an argument that of course he admits is legitimate in principle — is a mere sophism if used against the early chronology to solve the problem of the date of Zoroaster. He even goes so far as to maintain that the similar degree of development between 'Young Avestan' and Old Persian should suggest dating the Young Avesta in roughly the same period as the Achaemenian inscriptions. It is my belief that, if there is a sophism amongst people who all have a scientific approach to linguistics, then each one should be able to judge just where it is.

In the review I wrote of Humbach's *The Gāthās of Zarathushtra and the Other Old Avestan Texts* I stated that, in my opinion, nei-

ther Meillet nor Henning would now change their minds in view of the three aforementioned arguments concerning the archaic nature of 'Old Avestan' compared with 'Young Avestan'. Their sole intent was to show the utter inadequacy of using linguistic proof alone to reconstruct the date of Zoroaster.⁵³ Now I can confirm that opinion, which also gains support from the stand made recently by Gershevitch, who has stressed the point that the Gāthās "can be dated only by the date of their author".⁵⁴ He illustrates this point with a parable about present-day English and German, imagining what would happen if Humbach's German and English translations of the Gāthās were to be compared, as the only surviving remains of these two languages, in the year A.D. 4000 by the future Kellens and Pirart. He refuses to define the language of the Gāthās and the *Yasna Haptanhāiti* as 'Old Avestan' and the language of the Yašts etc. as 'Young Avestan' as they do not represent two phases in the same development of the one language, but are two kindred languages that have "descended *pari passu*, though each in its own way, from one single prehistoric Avestan mother", like Iron and Digoron in present-day Ossetia.⁵⁵

At this point we could leave our criticism of Kellens' theories if he had not added recently some further, historical arguments to his linguistic proof,⁵⁶ perhaps prompted by the awareness of theoretical and methodological shortcomings in a purely linguistic approach to the chronological problem posed by the 'Old Avestan' texts. As we have already seen above, Kellens makes no mystery of his embarrassment when he refers to the linguistic synchronism of Old Persian and 'Young Avestan' as being a rather approximate idea to say the least, one that is not well-grounded but could still be used as a convenient point of reference, though insufficient in itself — and this admission is something new in his way of tackling the problem — unless we also take into account that the development of religious concepts "fait argument et preuve en la matière".⁵⁷

The historical arguments that Kellens introduces to back up his thesis are prompted to some extent by some remarks made by

Gérard Fussman, concerning the problem of the Āryas of Mitanni,⁵⁸ and also by the well-known article that Burrow devoted to the 'Proto-Indoaryans'⁵⁹ and that has already been mentioned here above in the criticism of Boyce's theories as expressed in the Columbia Lectures published in 1992.⁶⁰

In connection with Fussman's remarks, I must admit that I cannot understand why, having identified the Āryas of Mitanni as the 'Proto-Indoaryans', one should then deduce not only that the splitting up of the Indo-Iranian community should have been before their arrival in Mesopotamia, that is to say, in the 18th century B.C., but also, as a result, that the main part of the reform attributed to Zoroaster (the repudiation of the Indo-Iranian or Indian gods) would have been acquired in the 18th century B.C. and undoubtedly still earlier, and therefore Zoroaster's originality would have consisted solely in his preaching of monotheism.⁶¹ All this does not seem to me to be a logical consequence of the theories advanced by Paul Thieme,⁶² and Burrow, in spite of the opinions expressed by Fussman and by Kellens, who states: "Fussman a incontestablement raison: si les Āryas du Mitanni sont des Indo-Aryens, le sens négatif accordé à **daiyā*- remonte loin dans la préhistoire iranienne et le monothéisme est la seule innovation zoroastrienne possible".⁶³ In actual fact Kellens tends — almost instinctively, I should say — to accept that consequence because in his view it contains an important argument in favour of his theory on the **daiyā*- in Iran, Old Iranian demons or Proto-Indoaryan gods. But, if we consider the matter closely, the identification of the Āryas of Mitanni as the Proto-Indoaryans does not imply as a result that the *daivas* were only Indo-Iranian gods, as Burrow thought (though he held that they had been regarded as evil by Zoroaster and not because of "just some natural impersonal development"),⁶⁴ nor that they were demons of a pan-Iranian religious expression, as Kellens thinks.⁶⁵ Nor does it imply that the difference in language between 'Young Avestan' and Gathic Avestan proves that "a considerable lapse of time, which is not likely to be less than 200 years", had passed between them. This,

in fact, is only an opinion which Burrow himself expressed,⁶⁶ of which we perhaps find an echo in the inaugural lecture read by Kellens at the Collège de France: "Un intervalle de deux siècles entre l'Avesta ancien et l'Avesta récent est certes nécessaire, mais il est aussi suffisant, de telle sorte que l'Avesta ancien pourrait en principe ne pas remonter au-delà du VIII^e siècle. C'est l'archaïsme sans cesse confirmé du vieil-avestique qui incite à remonter le plus près possible de la date de composition postulée pour le Rigveda".⁶⁷ This would be the period 1500-1200 B.C. in his opinion, which is a fairly widely-shared one, but it is, incidentally, far from meeting with the general approval of scholars, as we can also judge from Paolo Daffinà's recent precise and keen-sighted study, at least as far as the compilation of the Vedic hymns in their traditional order is concerned.⁶⁸

Since the problem of the condemnation of the Old Iranian *daivas* is directly linked to the problem of Zoroaster's time in the minds of those who, like myself, think that their condemnation was the work of the prophet, it is a good idea to dwell upon it a little longer. If, like Burrow, we were to think that it goes back to the second half of the second millennium B.C., then that would have to be the date of Zoroaster too. This is not the attitude of Kellens, who mainly agrees with what Marijan Molé wrote in his *Culte, mythe et cosmologie dans l'Iran ancien*.⁶⁹ Molé is for the pan-Iranian nature of their condemnation, precisely because he thinks that it was not the work of the prophet but a constitutive element of Iranian religious thought. As far as we are concerned, then, we must prove the inconsistency both of the theory that would have the demonization occurring several centuries before the Achaemenian period, and of the theory that it was a pan-Iranian phenomenon and therefore prior to Zoroaster and the so-called Old Avesta. As we think the demonization was the result of the condemnation pronounced by Zoroaster, we should not have to look for clues that make us go back too far in time.

Now, in my opinion, the idea that Herman Lommel put forward on the demonization of the *daivas* is still a valid one.⁷⁰ Not

only is it borne out by Theodor Nöldeke's remarks on the 'White Dēv' of Māzandarān⁷¹ and on the proper names *Δēwōdād* and *Δēwōdāšt*, of some princes of Ustrūšana,⁷² but also by Émile Benveniste's study on the syntagma 'gods (*daēva*) and men (*mašya*)'.⁷³ This had already been noted by Jacques Duchesne-Guillemin⁷⁴ and by the late Professor Geo Widengren⁷⁵ (who also mentioned the Pahlavi locution *dēwān ud mardōmān*).⁷⁶ Further support is given by Xerxes' inscription against the *daivas*⁷⁷ and by Sogdian onomastics, not only in the documents of mount Mugh, as Henning pointed out,⁷⁸ but also in other sources, as in the cases studied by Yutaka Yoshida (Sogdian names in Chinese script)⁷⁹ and by Nicholas Sims-Williams (Sogdian inscriptions of the Upper Indus),⁸⁰ though these are not taken into consideration by Kellens.⁸¹ All in all, this evidence does not fit in very well with the explanation given by Molé,⁸² who thought there were 'Buddhist' influences on the proper names *Δēwōdād*, *Δēwōdāšt* and *Δēwōdāštīč* (*δῶωδῆστῑτς*), so that the criticism made of Lommel's theory by Kellens, who agrees with Molé's explanation, is of too speculative and conjectural a nature to be convincing. The same can be said for Burrow's article. Although it was written in 1973, Burrow was evidently not aware of what Henning had written in 1965 and Benveniste in 1967: as a matter of fact, there is a significant lack of reference in his article to these two fundamental contributions. I think we may rightly say that, if he had been acquainted with them, he would probably not have maintained that OIr. **daiua-* is a Proto-Indoaryan loanword.

I had acknowledged that Burrow's theory on the condemnation of the *daivas* could perhaps have been accepted in part, namely in the cases of Indra, Saurva and Nāṇhaiṭya, in which could be discerned ancient Proto-Indoaryan gods with their names adapted to Iranian phonology, that correspond to the Vedic gods' names Indra, Śarva and Nāsatya.⁸³ This would not mean, though, that **daiua-* was a Proto-Indoaryan loanword in Iranian, but only that these three gods of foreign origin had been condemned in so far as they were false gods, deceptive rivals of Ahura Mazdā. Even less so would it prove an absurdity, which did not escape Kellens'

attention: namely, in the case that OIr. **daiya-* meant 'demons' and not 'gods', Zoroaster would simply have been condemning some demons. In order to avoid such an absurdity, Kellens is compelled to pose once again the problem of 'Old Avestan' monotheism.⁸⁴

On the whole, then, Burrow's thesis must be rejected because it is not possible to reduce to an ethnic clash between Iranians and Proto-Indoaryans the condemnation of the gods, which is typical of the Gāthās, and their demonization in the entire Zoroastrian tradition. An article by Gershevitch has been and still is an enlightening point of reference for me: since it was published, in 1975, I have gone back to it on several occasions.⁸⁵

Now I should like to add just one more argument to the ones I gave in my *Zoroaster's Time and Homeland*,⁸⁶ in order to show that there were not only foreign gods or demons of the ancient Iranian religion amongst the Avestan *daēvas* but some of the most typical deities of the religious tradition of ancient Iran. It seems to me that one of the cornerstones of Kellens' arguments to the contrary does not stand up to an objective criticism.

In the article **Daiva*, which was written for the *Encyclopædia Iranica* together with Clarisse Herrenschildt,⁸⁷ and then especially in his recent book *Le panthéon de l'Avesta ancien*, Kellens connects the *daivas* in Xerxes' inscription at Persepolis with the *daēvas* in *Yt.* 5, 94 because, in his opinion, a similar use is made of both: their worshippers, the *daēvayasnās*, would have been the necessary reference of every act of religious censure and the *daēvas* no more than victims of the ritual choice that is characteristic of the dualistic conflict.⁸⁸ The *daēvas* would not have been real gods and the *daēva*-worshippers not real, true worshippers.

In actual fact I think it is precisely *Yt.* 5, 94 which makes it very clear that we must include amongst the *daēvas* one of the most important female deities of ancient Iran, Anāhitā. The evidence for this goddess, which is gained from the most disparate sources of different periods, persuaded Boyce to reconstruct a double identity: the Avestan Arədvī Sūrā Anāhitā, a popular Zo-

roastrian *yazatā* (in Middle Persian Ardwīsūr Anāhīd), and the goddess of the planet Venus, Anaitis, in the Greek rendering of her name, whose worship was largely influenced by the cult of the Mesopotamian Ištar.⁸⁹

The aforementioned passage from the *Ābān Yašt* (5, 94) says: “O Arədvī Sūrā Anāhitā, what becomes of the libations that the *daēva*-worshippers, owners-of-Falsehood, offer to you after sunset?”⁹⁰ It goes on with the *yazatā* replying that she does not accept those offerings. There can be no doubt, then, that for the *daēva*-worshippers Anāhitā was a *daēvī*. This was fully realized by Gershevitch,⁹¹ though Kellens makes no reference in this connection, but merely remarks that whoever performs a sacrifice at night-time, even to the great goddess of the Mazdean Yašts, is a *daēva*-worshipper.⁹² The twist in meaning is evident. Actually, the *daēva*-worshippers offer libations to Anāhitā for the very reason that they consider her to be a *daēvī*. Gershevitch went further still, stating quite rightly that “what is true of Anāhitā has a good chance of applying also to Mithra”. He backs up this deduction, which I, too, consider perfectly reasonable, by quoting the passage from *Yt.* 10, 108, in which “the god (Mithra) is said to distinguish between worshippers who consider it their duty to offer him ‘good sacrifice’ and those who see fit to revere him with ‘bad sacrifice’”. The latter — he goes on to say — are most probably the *daēva*-worshippers, whose sacrifice to Mithra Zoroastrians could only regard as an affront to the god”.⁹³

If this, as everything leads us to think, is the right interpretation of *Yt.* 5, 94, we may deduce that Anāhitā, and probably also Mithra on the grounds of *Yt.* 10, 108, besides being two *yazatas* for the authors of the Avestan Yašts and two *bagas* for Artaxerxes II, were also two *daēvas* for the disciples of a religion that was repudiated by the Zoroastrians. Similar conclusions from these two passages of the *Ābān Yašt* and the *Mihr Yašt* were also reached by Robert Charles Zaehner.⁹⁴

All this demolishes Kellens’ ingenious reconstruction of the ‘Old Avestan pantheon’. The *daēvas* were the gods of the Old

Iranian religion whose ranks were boosted, after Zoroaster's condemnation, by hosts of demons and perhaps foreign gods as well. Their worshippers were real persons, who could be described, in *Y.* 32, 4, as 'favourites of the gods', 'beloved of the gods', or 'approved of by the gods' — by the '(evil) gods' according to Kellens — *daēvō.zuštā*, a compound that was an "altes Sakralwort, das aber Zarathustra, wie das Wort *daēva*- selber, mit gegenteiliger Bewertung gebraucht", according to Lommel.⁹⁵ As far as Zoroaster was concerned, the meaning of *daēva*- remained the same: he condemned *all* of them (*daēvā vīspāñhō*) for the very reason that they were the *gods* of polytheism and not just because they were demons. As Gershevitch rightly points out, they existed as "*thoughts, conceived by erroneously thinking men*".⁹⁶ And so, in keeping with this premiss, the *daēvas* will never be defined as anything else but *mainyava*- in the Avesta, according to a doctrine that I have tried to explain in a recent study, a doctrine that has its roots in the Gāthās.⁹⁷

Therefore the semantic development of Iranian *daivas* from 'gods' to 'demons' still holds good. It gets its origin from Zoroaster's condemnation of all the gods, 'manifestation of evil thinking' (*Y.* 32, 3)⁹⁸ or 'Hirngespinnste', as Gershevitch writes. The condemnation of the *daivas* does not go back to the remote past and therefore does not affect the solution of the problem concerning the date of Zoroaster because it is not a main feature of Iranian religious expression but the consequence of the message of the Gāthās: in the eyes of the faithful Zoroastrians, the condemned gods became real demons, in the terms contemplated by Lommel⁹⁹ and further explained by Gershevitch in the aforementioned article. That will be enough on this subject for the moment.

So far I have spoken of the reasons that have persuaded me to change my mind radically about my previous thesis on the date of Zoroaster and of the reasons why, in my opinion, the theses put forward by Boyce and Kellens do not stand up to a close criticism. There are other scholars, however, who have dealt with this problem of ours since my book *Zoroaster's Time and Homeland*

was published. Apart from Gershevitch, with whose recent article I largely agree, I may also name Humbach and Kingsley of whom the former argues for an early chronology and the latter against the historical value of the date of 258 years before Alexander.¹⁰⁰ On account of the nature of their arguments, which are closely connected with the interpretation of the Greek sources, we shall pay more attention to them later on. Whereas we must say something straight away about the essay which H. E. Eduljee devoted to the date of Zoroaster in no. 48 of the *Journal of the K.R. Cama Oriental Institute* and which was published at the same time as my book.¹⁰¹ Eduljee agrees substantially with Boyce's proposals and, after examining the evidence in the Classical authors for the 7th millennium B.C. (see lecture two), is inclined towards the timespan 1700-1400 B.C. His main arguments will be fully discussed further on in this work, where we shall point out how his explanation for the dates given by the Greeks in terms of millennia and his confutation of the historical soundness of the date 258 years before Alexander are based on an erroneous interpretation of the available data, as we shall see in our discussion of the theses put forward by other authors as well.

Notes to Lecture One

1. Henning, *Zoroaster*, 35-41.
2. *Ib.*, p. 35.
3. Gershevitch, "W.B. Henning 1908-1967 *In memoriam*", in *W.B. Henning Memorial Volume*, ed. M. Boyce and I. Gershevitch, London, 1970, vii-xxiv, at p. vii.
4. Gershevitch, "Approaches".
5. For the bibliographical references see M.A. Dandamaev and V.G. Lukonin, *Kul'tura i ekonomika drevnego Irana*, Moskva, 1980, 304-308 (= *The Culture and Social Institutions of Ancient Iran*, English ed. by P.-L. Kohl with the assistance of D.J. Dadson, Cambridge, 1989, 320-23); Gnoli, *De Z. à M.*, 38.
6. See Boyce, *HZ* I, p. 190; II, p. 3, and also: Boyce, *A Persian Stronghold of Zoroastrianism*, Oxford, 1977, 17; *Zoroastrians*, 18; "The bipartite society of the ancient Irānians", in *Societies and Languages of the Ancient Near East. Studies in honour of I.M. Diakonoff*, Warminster, 1982, 33-37, at p. 36; "On the antiquity of Zoroastrian apocalyptic", *BSOAS*, 47, 1984, 57-75, at p. 75; *Textual Sources for the Study of Zoroastrianism*, Manchester, 1984, 11; "Priests, cattle and men", *BSOAS*, 50, 1987, 508-26, at p. 511; *Zoroastrianism: a shadowy but powerful presence in the Judaeo-Christian world* (Friends of Dr. William's Library, Forty-first lecture), London, 1987, 4; "Avestan people", *Elr.* III, 1989, 62-66, at p. 64; *Zoroastrianism*, 44-45.
7. Kellens, "Quatre siècles obscurs", in *Transition Periods in Iranian History. Actes du Symposium de Fribourg-en-Brisgau (22-24 Mai 1985)* (*StIr* Cahier 5), Paris, 1987, 135-39; "Characters of ancient Mazdaism", *History and Anthropology*, 3, 1987, 239-62, at p. 240; "Avesta", *Elr.* III, 1989, 35-44, at p. 35; "Avestique", in *Compendium Linguarum Iranicarum*, ed. R. Schmitt, Wiesbaden, 1989, 32-55, at p. 38; *ZAA*, 14-25; "Questions préalables", in *La religion iranienne à l'époque achéménide. Actes du Colloque de Liège, 11 décembre 1987*, ed. J. Kellens (*IrAnt* Supplément V), Gent, 1991, 81-86, at p. 81; *Qui était Zarathustra?*, o. c. (see p. 11 n. 4), 6-7; *Leçon inaugurale faite le Mercredi 6 avril 1994* (Collège de France, Chaire des Langues et religions indo-iraniennes), Paris, 1994, 22; "Formules d'exécration et mimes de combat dans le rituel mazdéen ancien", in *Le Temple, lieu de conflit*, Genève, 1994, 89-94, at p. 90; "L'eschatologie mazdéenne ancienne", in *Irano-Judaica* III, ed. S. Shaked and A. Netzer, Jerusalem,

1994, 49-53, at pp. 49-50. See also: Kellens and Pirart, *TVA* I, pp. 12-13; C. Herrenschmidt and Kellens, "La question du rituel dans le mazdéisme ancien et achéménide", *Archives des Sciences sociales des Religions*, 85, 1994, 45-67, at p. 47.

8. See, in this connection: Kellens, "Yima, magicien entre les dieux et les hommes", in *Orientalia J. Duchesne-Guillemin emerito oblata* (ActIr 23), Leiden, 1984, 267-81; "Les Fravaši", in *Anges et démons. Actes du Colloque de Liège et de Louvain-la-Neuve, 25-26 novembre 1987*, Louvain-la-Neuve, 1989, 99-114.

9. It should be noted that Kellens, *Qui était Zarathustra?* (o.c. in n. 7), p. 12, describes Molé as "le savant le plus proche de nous", who expressed his disagreement with the traditional idea about the historical development of early Zoroastrianism. On this subject Kellens holds a similar position to Herrenschmidt, "Once upon a time, Zoroaster", *History and Anthropology*, 3, 1987, 209-37. Cf. Gnoli, "Tendenze attuali negli studi zoroastriani", in *The Notion of 'Religion' in Comparative Research. Selected proceedings of the XVI IAHR Congress*, ed. U. Bianchi, Rome, 1994, 55-62, at p. 59.

10. See in particular: Gnoli, "Sassanidi", 233-39; *ZTH*, 159-79; *De Z. à M.*, 31-52.

11. Gnoli, *Idea of Iran*, p. 64 n. 53 and p. 66; *EW*, 42, 1992, 519-26 (review of Humbach, *Gāthās*), at p. 520; art. cit. (see p. 13 n. 38), pp. 313-14; "Data di Z.", 193-95; art. cit. (see p. 13, n. 37), p. 20.

12. Gnoli, *ZTH*, 175-79; *De Z. à M.*, 31-52. On the formation of the Achaemenian concept of royalty see in particular Gnoli, "Politica religiosa e concezione della regalità sotto gli Achemenidi", in *Gururājamañjarikā. Studi in onore di Giuseppe Tucci* (Istituto Universitario Orientale – Seminario di Studi Asiatici, Series Minor [I]), Napoli, 1974, 24-88 (= "Politique religieuse et conception de la royauté sous les Achéménides", French transl. by J. Duchesne-Guillemin, in *Hommage Universel à l'Iran. Commémoration Cyrus*, II [ActIr 2], Téhéran-Liège, 1974, 117-90).

13. Narten, *Der Yasna Haptaṅhāiti*, Wiesbaden, 1986; M. Schwartz, "Coded sound patterns, acrostics, and anagrams in Zoroaster's oral poetry", in *Studia Grammatica Iranica*, 327-92; Kellens and Pirart, *TVA*, I; Humbach, *Gāthās*.

14. Gnoli, art. cit. (see n. 12), p. 25 with nn. 13-15.

15. For an attempt to reconstruct the place occupied by the *Yasna Haptaṅhāiti* in the very early history of Mazdaism see Gnoli, "The *Yasna Haptaṅhāiti* and the early history of Mazdaism", to be published in the proceedings of the Conference organised by the World Zoroastrian Organisation on the literature of the Zoroastrian tradition (London, 16th to 17th November 1996).

16. Gershevitch, "Old Iranian literature", in *Iranistik-Literatur*, HdO, Leiden – Köln, 1968, 1-30, at pp. 23-24, 28.

17. Gnoli, *Idea of Iran*, p. 64 n. 53.

18. For the bibliographical references see n. 10.

19. E.W. West, *Pahlavi Texts*, I: *The Bundahis-Bahman Yast, and Shāyast lā-shāyast* (SBE 5), Oxford, 1880, p. 219 n. 1; *Pahlavi Texts*, V: *Marvels of Zoroastrianism* (SBE 47), Oxford, 1897, p. xxvii; Jackson, *Zoroaster*, 159.

20. Cereti, "Padīrīftan ī dēn and the turn of the millennium", *EW*, 45, 1995, 321-27.

21. As I still thought in 1985: *De Z. à M.*, 41.

22. Jackson, "Date of Z.", 3 (= *Zoroaster*, 152). See below, p. 67.

23. Gnoli, "Data di Z."

24. E.W. West, *Pahlavi Texts*, V (o.c. in n. 19), p. xlii.

25. Kingsley, "Greek origin".

26. For the bibliographical references see n. 11.

27. Between 1700 and 1500 B.C.: Boyce, *Zoroastrians*, 2, 18.

28. Between 1500 and 1200 B.C.: Boyce, *Zoroastrianism*, 45.

29. *Ib.*, p. 64.

30. For the bibliographical references see n. 6.

31. Burrow, art. cit. (see p. 12 n. 24). To this article I too referred: *ZTH*, 161.

32. Boyce, *Zoroastrianism*, 29.

33. Boyce, *Zoroastrians*, 2; and see *Zoroastrianism*, p. 123 n. 45, with reference to *HZ I*. When she was not opposed to the historicity of the traditional date, she proposed, on the basis of calendrical observances, 665-588 B.C. for the prophet's lifetime: Boyce, "On the calendar of Zoroastrian feasts", *BSOAS*, 33, 1970, 513-39, at p. 538. See below, p. 178 n. 130.

34. So far the attempts to make use of the results of some archaeological investigations to help solve the problems concerning the date and homeland of Zoroaster have not been convincing, either in the case of Boyce in chapter II of her *Columbia Lectures* or in the case of the archaeologist V.I. Sarianidi and his important discoveries in the oasis of Merv: Sarianidi, "Le complexe culturel de Togolok 21 en Margiane", *Arts Asiatiques*, 41, 1986, 5-21; "South-West Asia: migrations, the Aryans and Zoroastrians", *Information Bulletin* (International Association of the Study of the Cultures of Central Asia – Unesco, Moscow), 13, 1987, 44-56; "Zoroastriiskaya problema v svete noveishikh arkhologicheskikh otkrytii", *VDI*, 1989/2, 178-81; *I zdes' govoril Zaratushtra*, n. p., 1992; *Margiana and Protozoroastrianism*, Athens, 1998, esp. pp. 167-75. For Sarianidi's position see, amongst others, V.A. Livshits and I.M. Steblin-Kamenskii, "Protozoroastrizm?", *VDI*, 1989/1, 174-76; Gnoli, "Arkheologiya i problema proiskhozhdeniya zoroastrizma: novye perspektivy", *VDI*, 1989/2, 175-78.

35. There is no general agreement that the four so-called 'sacred formulas' (Y. 27, 13-15 and 54, 1) belong to authentic 'Old Avestan' literature: cf. Kellens, "L'avestique de 1972 à 1990", *Kratylos*, 36, 1991, 1-31, at p. 5. Humbach (*Gāthās* I, p. 7; II, p. 14) takes *Yeǰhē hātqm*, defined as 'pseudo-altavestisch' by K. Hoffmann and J. Narten (*Der Sasanidische Archetypus*, Wiesbaden, 1989, 89; cf. Narten, *Die Aməša Spəntas im Avesta*, Wiesbaden, 1982, 80-94), to be more recent than the other three. Hoffmann and Narten are also uncertain about the authentically Old Avestan character of *Yaθā ahū vairyō* and *Ašəm vohū*. Kellens and Pirart (*TVA* I, p. 3; Kellens, art. cit., p. 5) consider *Yaθā ahū vairyō* and *Ā airyāmā išyō* to be 'Old Avestan' on account of their metric structure, identifying them as the first strophe of Y. 28-34 and the last strophe of Y. 53 respectively. In particular, Pirart ("Deux notes indo-iraniennes", *AIUON*, 47, 1987, 209-13, at pp. 212-13) is in favour of omitting *Ašəm vohū* from the 'Old Avestan' corpus, but Humbach (*Gāthās* II, pp. 8-13) does not cite him. On the four traditional prayers see also Boyce, *Zoroastrianism*, 65, 96, 136. For the first three *fragards* of the *Bag nask*, which contain a commentary on the three prayers that precede the *Gāthās* (and which are extant as *Yasna* 19-21), see Skjærvø, "Bag nask", *Elr.* III, 1989, 400-401.

36. Kellens, *Leçon inaugurale* ..., (o. c. in n. 7), p. 22.

37. Gershevitch, "Approaches", 3.

38. Published in *JA*, XI^e s., 10, 1917, 183-214.

39. Hoffmann and Narten, o. c. (see n. 35), p. 88; Humbach, *Gāthās* I, p. 7; Boyce, *Zoroastrianism*, 29; Kellens and Pirart, *TVA* I, p. 16.

40. Kellens, *Panthéon*, 32-34.

41. Kellens, *ZAA*, 15.

42. *Ib.*, pp. 15-16, and cf. Kellens, "Avestique" (art. cit. in n. 7), p. 36.

43. Meillet, art. cit. (see n. 38); *Trois conférences sur les Gāthā de l'Avesta faites à l'Université d'Upsal pour la Fondation Olaus Petri* (Annales du Musée Guimet – Bibliothèque de vulgarisation, 44), Paris, 1925, 27-32.

44. Henning, *Zoroaster*, 36.

45. Kellens, loc. cit. in n. 41.

46. Hoffmann, "Altiranisch", in *Iranistik-Linguistik*, HdO, Leiden – Köln, 1958, 1-19 at pp. 15-16.

47. Humbach, *Die Gathas des Zarathustra*, I-II, Heidelberg, 1959; Cf. Kellens, *Le verbe avestique*, Wiesbaden, 1984, 2; Kellens and Pirart, *TVA* II, pp. 65-98.

48. F.B.J. Kuiper, "Avestan *mazdā-*", *IJJ*, I, 1957, 86-95. This is the first of Kuiper's studies to be cited by Kellens (*Panthéon*, p. 16 n. 17) in connection with the problem of the laryngeals in the metrical text of the *Gāthās*. See also M.C. Monna, *The Gathas of Zarathustra. A reconstruction of the*

- text, Amsterdam, 1978, 97, 104; Kellens, art. cit. (see n. 35), pp. 15-16.
49. Henning, loc. cit. in n. 44.
 50. Meillet, o. c. (see n. 43), p. 27.
 51. Kellens, "Avestique" (art. cit. in n. 7), p. 36; ZAA, 14.
 52. Kellens, *Leçon inaugurale ...* (o. c. in n. 7), p. 23.
 53. Gnoli, *EW*, 42, 519-27 (see n. 11), at p. 525 n. 4.
 54. Gershevitch, "Approaches", 2.
 55. *Ib.*, p. 3.
 56. Kellens, *Panthéon*, 32-34.
 57. Kellens, loc. cit. in n. 52.
 58. Fussman, "Histoire du monde indien", *Annuaire du Collège de France – Résumé des cours et travaux*, Paris, 1988-1989, 507-32.
 59. Burrow, art. cit. (see p. 12 n. 24).
 60. Cf. above, pp. 22-23.
 61. Fussman, art. cit. (see n. 58), p. 519.
 62. P. Thieme, "The 'Aryan' gods of the Mitanni treaties", *JAOS*, 80, 1960, 301-17. This article should be read together with G. Dumézil, "Les 'trois fonctions' dans le Rgveda et les dieux indiens de Mitani", *Académie Royale de Belgique, Bulletin de la Classe des Lettres et des Sciences Morales et Politiques*, 5^e série, 47, 1961, 265-98. Cf. Gnoli, *ZTH*, p. 72 n. 61.
 63. Kellens, *Panthéon*, 27.
 64. Burrow, art. cit. (see p. 12 n. 24), p. 133.
 65. Kellens, *Panthéon*, pp. 27, 33-34.
 66. Burrow, art. cit., pp. 137-38.
 67. Kellens, *Leçon inaugurale ...* (o. c. in n. 7), p. 22.
 68. Daffinà, "Sull'uso della scrittura nell'India antica", *RSO*, 65, 1991, 13-39. The author bases his argument on the comparatively late use of writing in ancient India, with appropriate reference to the theories of Otto Böhtlingk, Rudolph von Roth, Willibald Kirfel and others, for which the reader is referred to the bibliography given by him.
 69. Molé, *CMC*, 6-7, 14-25. Cf. Kellens, *Panthéon*, 134-40.
 70. Lommel, *RZ*, 90-92.
 71. Nöldeke, "Der Weiße Dēv von Māzandarān", *ARW*, 18, 1915, 597-600.
 72. Nöldeke, "Dēva", *ZII*, 2, 1923, 318.
 73. Benveniste, "Hommes et dieux dans l'Avesta", in *Festschrift für Wilhelm Eilers*, ed. G. Wiessner, Wiesbaden, 1967, 144-47.
 74. Duchesne-Guillemin, *OA*, p. 27 n. 1; *RIA*, 189. Cf. Gnoli, *ZTH*, p. 76 n. 107; Duchesne-Guillemin, "La contribution d'É. Benveniste aux études avestiques", in *É. Benveniste aujourd'hui. Actes du Colloque international du C.N.R.S., Tours, 28-30 septembre 1983*, ed. J. Taillardat, G. Lazard and G. Serbat, Paris, 1984, 197-206, at p. 205 n. 11; Kellens, *Panthéon*, p. 84 n. 30.

75. Widengren, *Stand und Aufgaben der iranischen Religionsgeschichte*, Leiden, 1955, p. 15 with n. 55; *RI*, 20.

76. In *Pahl. Rev. Dd. XVIII*: see Nyberg, "La légende de Keresāspa", in *Oriental Studies in honour of Cursetji Erachji Pavry*, ed. Jal Dastur Cursetji Pavry, London, 1933, 336-52, at p. 342; Widengren, *Hochgottglaube im alten Iran*, Uppsala-Leipzig, 1938, 225; A.V. Williams, *The Pahlavi Rivāyat Accompanying the Dādestān ī Dēnīg*, Copenhagen, 1990, I, p. 106 f.; II, p. 41.

77. *XPh* 35-41. See in particular A. Christensen, *Essai sur la démonologie iranienne*, København, 1941, 39-46; Gnoli, *ZTH*, pp. 78-79 with n. 120 for bibliographical references, and also Id., "L'Arachosia e l'Avesta", in *Kunst, Kultur und Geschichte der Achämenidenzeit und ihr Fortleben* (AMl Ergänzungsband 10), ed. H. Koch and D.N. MacKenzie, Berlin, 1983, 121-33, at p. 125 with nn. 30, 31; *De Z. à M.*, 71; *Idea of Iran*, pp. 91-93 with n. 28. For Kellens' position on *XPh*: Kellens, *Panthéon*, 125.

78. Henning, "A Sogdian god", *BSOAS*, 28, 1965, 242-54, at p. 253 f.

79. Yoshida, "Sogdian miscellany [I]", *StIr*, 13, 1984, 145-49, at p. 149.

80. Sims-Williams, "The Sogdian inscriptions of the Upper Indus: a preliminary report", in *Antiquities of Northern Pakistan, 1: Rock inscriptions in the Indus Valley*, ed. K. Jettmar, D. König and W. Thewalt, Mainz, 1989, 131-37, at p. 136; *Sogdian and Other Iranian Inscriptions of the Upper Indus II*, (CII, Part II, Vol. III), London, 1992, 51.

81. To which we could add Oss. *ævdīw/ævdew*, which Kellens, *Panthéon*, 16, dismisses too hastily. See in particular V.I. Abaev, *Istoriko-etimologičeskii slovar' osetinskogo yazyka*, Moskva-Leningrad, 1958, I, pp. 199-200, who proposes the etymological meaning 'seven gods' (<**hafta daiva*). For Sogd. *šyw'štyc* see now A. Tafazzolī, "Iranian proper nouns in the *Kitāb al-Qand fi ḍikr 'Ulamā' Samarqand*, 1: Sogdian proper nouns", *Nāme-ye Farhangestān*, 1/3, 1374 Š./1995, 4-12, at p. 6.

82. Molé, *CMC*, p. 7 n. 1.

83. Gnoli, *ZTH*, 73, 79.

84. Kellens, *Panthéon*, 34.

85. Gershevitch, "Die Sonne das Beste", in *Mithraic Studies*, ed. J.R. Hinnells, Manchester, 1975, I, pp. 68-89.

86. Gnoli, *ZTH*, 73-83.

87. Herrenschildt and Kellens, "*Daiva", *Elr*, VI, 1993, 599-602.

88. Kellens, *Panthéon*, 86.

89. Boyce, "Anāhīd-i: Ardwīsūr Anāhīd", *Elr*, I, 1985, 1003-1005; "Anāhīd-ii: Anaitis", ib., 1005-1006.

90. Cf. Gershevitch, *AHM*, 200.

91. Ib., p. 63.

92. Kellens, loc. cit. in n. 88.

93. Gershevitch, *AHM*, 63, with reference to *Yt.* 10, 108. With regard to the position held by Mithra in the various phases of Zoroastrianism (on which see the important, though in some ways not very convincing, article by Boyce, "On Mithra's part in Zoroastrianism", *BSOAS*, 32, 1969, 10-34), from the 'Old Avestan' to the 'Younger Avestan' system (according to Kellens, *Panthéon*, 32), the rehabilitation of the god cannot be explained by his presumed earlier status in an ancient religion of the *ahuras* opposed to the *daēvas*. For Av. *ahura*- cf. Gnoli, "Le religioni dell'Iran antico e Zoroastro", in *Storia delle religioni*, 1: *Le religioni antiche*, ed. G. Filoramo, Roma-Bari, 1994, 455-98, at pp. 463-64, with some bibliographical references.

94. Zaehner, *The Dawn and Twilight of Zoroastrianism*, London, 1961, 100.

95. Lommel, *Die Gathas des Zarathustra*, ed. B. Schlerath, Basel-Stuttgart, 1971, 63. On *daēvō.zušta*- (the Av. plural in *Y.* 32, 4 is rendered in Pahlavi as *kē gōwēnd ān ī dēwān dōšīd*: *Air.Wb.*, 672), see Gershevitch, art. cit. (see n. 85), p. 80. The remarks made by Kellens, *Panthéon*, p. 85 n. 32, in no way affect the restoration of the original meaning, which is vouched for by OInd. *devājušta*-.

96. Gershevitch, ib.

97. Gnoli, "Einige Bemerkungen zum altiranischen Dualismus", in *Proceedings of the Second European Conference of Iranian Studies held in Bamberg, 30th September to 4th October 1991*, ed. B.G. Fragner et alii (SOR 73), Roma, 1995, 213-31, at pp. 226-27.

98. There is a fairly general agreement over the interpretation of *akāṭ managhō stā čīθrām* (*Y.* 32, 3), if we bear in mind the different shades of meaning that *čīθra*- can have and its construction with the ablative: see Gershevitch, *AHM*, p. 213 n.; and also Kellens and Pirart, *TVA II*, pp. 39, 242. This is true for the old translations, before Bartholomae's (*Die Gathas des Awesta. Zarathushtra's Verspredigten*, Strassburg, 1905, 27), and for the ones that come after it (see e.g. S. Insler, *The Gāthās of Zarathustra* [ActIr 8], Téhéran - Liège, 1975, 45, 198). For further evidence cf. B. Schlerath, *Awesta-Wörterbuch. Vorarbeiten*, I: *Index locorum zur Sekundärliteratur des Awesta*, Wiesbaden, 1968, 45, to which can be added, amongst many others, Christensen, o. c. (see n. 77), p. 7, as well as Boyce, *HZ I*, p. 201; Gershevitch, art. cit. (see n. 85), p. 79 n. 4; Gnoli, loc. cit. in n. 97.

99. Lommel, loc. cit. in n. 70.

100. A different case is the article by Winfried Corduan, "The date of Zoroaster: some apologetic considerations", *Presbyterion*, 23, 1997, 25-42, in which the author speaks in favour of the traditional date basing his argument on the grounds of Henning's thesis. His main concern however — i.e.

the problem of “the influence of ancient Iranian ideas on Jewish and Christian thought” (ib., p. 25), that he solves negatively, in conflict with Boyce’s theses — lies largely outside the subject matter of our lectures.

101. Eduljee, “Date of Z.”

Zoroaster 6000 years before Xerxes or Plato

IN *ZOROASTER'S TIME AND HOMELAND* I underestimated the importance of the Classical sources in reconstructing the date of Zoroaster. I rejected the millenarian date — 6000 years before the death of Plato or, if the *lectio* ἑξακισχίλια in Diogenes Laertius' Proem is correct, before Xerxes' Greek expedition — as being mythical, without going into it in further detail.¹ I confined the association of Zoroaster with Ninus and Semiramis to the realm of legend, and rightly so.² Lastly, I overlooked the connection between Zoroaster and Pythagoras, to which Kingsley paid particular attention, providing Gershevitch with new arguments for his recent article "Approaches to Zoroaster's Gathas".³

Now, on the grounds of further enquiries which followed upon the lectures I gave at the Collège de France in 1983,⁴ I think that the millenarian date for Zoroaster and also the Zoroaster-Pythagoras synchronism can be of great use to us in working out in what historical period Zoroaster lived. The same cannot be said for the association of the prophet with Ninus and Semiramis: this association, with Zoroaster being transformed into a king of Bactria, stems from a confusion of names due to a corruption in a passage from Ctesias apud Diodorus II, 6, 2 concerning Ninus' expedition against Oxyartes, king of the Bactrians.⁵ The error by which Zoro-

aster was confused with Oxyartes (in some manuscripts 'Exaortes', 'Xaortes', 'Zaortes') soon took root in various Hellenistic, Late-Antique and Mediaeval authors, such as Cephalion, Theon, Justin, Arnobius, Eusebius, Paulus Orosius, Augustine, Isidorus, Hugo de St. Victore, and contributed, as in Ammianus Marcellinus, towards making Zoroaster into a Bactrian.⁶

Regarding the information that I have managed to glean from the data concerning the 6000 years before Plato or Xerxes, the following remarks can be made. The dating of Zoroaster in a remote past that went back several thousand years was one of the reasons that, as I have already said, made me inclined to take that information as completely groundless and more likely to be proof of the fact that the Greeks, who had come into direct contact with the Persians from the 6th century B.C. onwards, reflected their informers' lack of an exact historical memory. This would be quite unaccountable if Zoroaster had lived more or less at the time of Cyrus, but could easily be explained if he had lived several centuries earlier than that, as I have maintained on several occasions and as others have not failed to point out.⁷

Although I have changed my mind about my previous theory on the date of Zoroaster, there are still some aspects on which my ideas have remained the same as in 1980. One, in particular, is the choice of the *lectio* ἑξακισχίλια in Diogenes Laertius' Proem to his *Vitae philosophorum*, where he tells about Xanthus of Lydia. However, as this argument has been the subject of recent studies, I shall dwell upon it now before going any further. Indeed, it is important to begin by deciding which is the earliest mention we have of the chiliadic doctrine, which is characteristic of the theories of the Magi and of the whole Zoroastrian tradition. I am convinced that the testimonies we have of it did not come from a mere invention of the Greeks that took shape in Platonic Academy circles, but rather, as we shall see more clearly later on, from the misunderstanding of an Iranian doctrine. This has been maintained by some scholars, though it has not always been backed up by convincing arguments.⁸

The authenticity of Xanthus of Lydia's Μαγικά⁹ (either a separate work or part of a larger work in four books known as Λυδικά-κά) should not be taken as dubious, as is proved by an exhaustive state of the art for which we are indebted to Hans Herter.¹⁰ As far as our problem is concerned, however, the evidence given by Xanthus of Lydia in Diogenes Laertius I, 2 is still a matter of dispute: there is still some general doubt about whether it is right to attribute the information on the date of Zoroaster to the historian from Lydia, though without any convincing reasons having been put forward for this doubt. The main problem is the one about the two *lectiones* ἐξακισχίλια and ἐξακόσια. If we accept the first reading, this raises a doubt as to whether the information dates back to Xanthus, as it seems unlikely that the Iranian doctrine of cosmic millennia had already taken shape in the first half of the 5th century B.C. Accordingly, Boyce, taking up some remarks made by Carl Clemen,¹¹ wrote that the dating of Zoroaster to 6000 years before Xerxes' invasion "was wrongly attributed to Xanthos, since there is no reason to suppose that the magi were already making chronological calculations according to millenary schemes in the early fifth century B.C."¹² She neglects, however, to give her reasons to the contrary. Clemen, for his part, had defined as most unlikely the theory that Xanthus, who lived a century before Theopompus (of whom Plutarch hands down the first testimony of the chiliadic doctrine), had come to hear of the Magian doctrine about the spiritual existence of Zoroaster several thousand years before his historical birth (see p. 74), though he gives no clear proof to support such a statement and refers to the doubt that Nathan Söderblom expressed on this point in his article "Ages of the World" (an excellent article, too) in the *Encyclopædia of Religion and Ethics* edited by James Hastings.¹³

In this way the problem ends up in a vicious circle. Some think that it is not the *lectio* ἐξακισχίλια which is debatable, but whether or not the relevant information actually dates back to Xanthus, as Diogenes says. Others think that the attribution to Xanthus is correct, but that the *lectio* ἐξακόσια is preferable.

Others again would prefer to read ἑξακισχίλια but think that the original source, i.e. Xanthus, must have had the figure ἐξήκοντα, of which there is of course no evidence in the manuscript tradition. Lastly, there are those who think that we should simply acknowledge the fact that in Xanthus, who was writing in about the mid-fifth century, we have the first, indirect, reference to the doctrine of the Magi about the division of cosmic history into millenary cycles and, at the same time, a dating of Zoroaster to 6000 years before 480 B.C. There can be no doubt that this evidence gives rise to various issues, as can be seen from the history of the studies in this field, but it is a question of throwing more light than has been done so far on the origin of this chronology, whether in Xanthus or in any other Classical sources that, in attributing a historical epoch to the founder of the Magian school of thought (the Magi were older than the Egyptians, according to Aristotle),¹⁴ used the calculation of 6000 or 5000 years. The idea that the evidence is spurious is to be rejected. There is no argument that can be used against the reliability of Xanthus' information, not even his supposed anachronism, on account of the fact that it is followed by the διαδοχή of the Magi which concludes with the destruction of the Persian empire at the hand of Alexander. There is no proof that the διαδοχή was included in the information given by Xanthus (as a matter of fact, it is not very likely that it was), nor is there, of course, any proof that it included the names 'Οστάνας, 'Αστραμψύχους, Γωβρύας and Παζάτας,¹⁵ and ended before the phrase "μέχρι τῆς τῶν Περσῶν ὑπ' 'Αλεξάνδρου καταλύσεως".¹⁶ The recent discussion on Diogenes Laertius' information about the date of Zoroaster according to Xanthus is mainly due to two contributions by Humbach, in 1984 and in 1991,¹⁷ and to one by Gershevitch, in 1995, the conclusion of which he had already anticipated in 1986.¹⁸ Humbach thinks that, in the text of the Proem, which is given here below, we ought to restore the exact number of the years which lapsed between Zoroaster and Xerxes' passage of the Hellespont as 'six hundred' instead of 'six thousand':

Ἀπὸ δὲ τῶν Μάγων, ὧν ἄρξαι Ζωροάστρην τὸν Πέρσην, Ἑρμόδωρος μὲν ὁ Πλατωνικὸς ἐν τῷ Περὶ μαθημάτων φησὶν εἰς τὴν Τροίαν ἄλωσιν ἔτη γεγονέναι πεντακισχίλια· Ξάνθος δὲ ὁ Λυδὸς εἰς τὴν Ξέρξου διάβασιν ἀπὸ τοῦ Ζωροάστρου ἑξακισχίλια φησι, καὶ μετ' αὐτὸν γεγονέναι πολλοὺς τινὰς Μάγους κατὰ διαδοχὴν, Ὀστάνας καὶ Ἀστραμψύχους καὶ Γωβρύας καὶ Παζάτας, μέχρι τῆς τῶν Περσῶν ὑπ' Ἀλεξάνδρου καταλύσεως.

The date of the Magians, beginning with Zoroaster the Persian, was 5000 years before the fall of Troy, as given by Hermodorus the Platonist in his work on mathematics; but Xanthus the Lydian reckons 6000 years from Zoroaster to the expedition of Xerxes, and after that event he places a long line of Magians in succession, bearing the names of Ostanas, Astrampsycho, Gobryas, and Pazatas, down to the conquest of Persia by Alexander. (Translation by R.D. Hicks, Loeb Classical Library)

According to Felix Jacoby¹⁹ and also to Bidez and Cumont,²⁰ the quotation from Xanthus should begin with his name and end with “ἑξακισχίλιά φησι”, and that is my opinion too. As we have already said, the most authoritative manuscripts give two *lectiones* of the number given by Xanthus. Amongst the *codices antiquiores* there is the *Parisinus gr.* 1759 (13th cent.) that gives ἑξακισχίλια and the *Laurentianus Florentinus* 69.13 (13th cent.) that gives χ' (600) in figures, to which corresponds the *Seragliensis Constantinopolitanus* that gives ἑξακόσια. We do not know the reading given in the *Neapolitanus Bourbonicus gr.* III B 29 (12th cent.), as it has been lost with the lacuna at the beginning of the manuscript (the first folio begins after the epitaph of Linus). As far as the relationship between these three codices is concerned, there is a general inclination to take the last-named codex as the pre-eminent one²¹. The *Parisinus* is the nearest to it, whereas the *Laurentianus* has recently been described by Denis Knoepfler, as being a “manuscrit plus fantasque, dont la valeur a été appréciée de façons très contradictoires”.²²

The editors of Diogenes Laertius²³ are inclined to choose the *lectio* ἑξακισχίλια, whereas some specialists in Iranian studies²⁴ tend to prefer the reading ἑξακόσια, as it fits in better with a

historical reconstruction and is therefore thought to be more useful in the attempt to find a historical date for Zoroaster, given the supposed shortage of elements of certainty. In fact, Giuseppe Messina²⁵, on the grounds of some remarks made by Joseph Markwart, reconsidered the reading ἑξακόσια and proposed a date around 1080 B.C. This reconsideration was rightly rejected by Bidez and Cumont,²⁶ and this helped to swell the ranks of the scholars who had not accepted that calculation, some of whom preferred to follow the traditional date. In spite of all this, Shahbazi²⁷ still based his arguments on the reading ἑξακόσια (see p. 50), and likewise Humbach,²⁸ who states: "Xanthus dates Zoroaster 600 before Xerxes' crossing, i.e. in 1080 B.C.",²⁹ convinced that the problem of the date of Zoroaster could be solved in this way.

In actual fact, the *lectio* ἑξακισχίλια is backed up by other Classical sources that give the figures of Zoroaster's date as five or six thousand years before a more or less distant or recent event. These are what Jackson called "Allusions placing Zoroaster at 6000 B.C."³⁰ They are Hermodorus the Platonist — apud Diogenes Laertius I, 2 — who, in his *Περὶ μαθημάτων*³¹, placed Zoroaster 5000 years before the fall of Troy; Eudoxus of Cnidus — apud Pliny, *Nat. Hist.* XXX, 3 — who, in his *Γῆς περίοδος*, as the comparison with another passage in Diogenes (I, 8) would seem to indicate, placed him *sex milibus annorum ante Platonis mortem*, or, as Eduard Fraenkel suggested, simply "before Plato";³² Aristotle — in the same passage in Pliny: *Eudoxus ... sic et Aristoteles* — who, in his *Περὶ φιλοσοφίας* gives the same testimony as Eudoxus;³³ Hermippus — also apud Pliny (*Nat. Hist.*, XXX, 4) — who, in the *Περὶ Μάγων*, places him *quinque milibus annorum ante Troianum bellum*;³⁴ Plutarch who, in the *De Iside et Osiride*, probably with reference to Theopompus and Eudoxus of Cnidus,³⁵ said that Zoroaster was five thousand years before the beginning of the Trojan 'era': Ζωροάστρης ὁ Μάγος, ὃν πεντακισχίλοις ἔτεσιν τῶν Τρωϊκῶν γεγονέναι πρεσβύτερον ἱστοροῦσιν; the Scholiast to *Alcibiades* I (122 A) who placed him six thousand years before Plato: Ζωροάστρης ἀρχαιότερος ἑξακισχίλοις

ἔτεσιν εἶναι λέγεται Πλάτωνος.³⁶

Leaving aside Xanthus for the moment, in Hermodorus, Hermippus and Plutarch the calculation of five thousand years before the Trojan war, which should also be restored in Suidas on Zoroaster Περσομῆδος σοφός (see p. 52), is evidently no more than another formulation of the calculation of six thousand years before Plato in Eudoxus, Aristotle and the Scholiast to *Alcibiades* I. For quite some time the date of the Trojan war, which was normally calculated in relation to the first Olympiad (776 B.C.), oscillated, according to the Greeks, in a time-span that stretched from the beginning of the 13th century to the first half of the 12th century B.C., between 1290 and 1171 B.C.³⁷ The 'Trojan' calculation, at any rate, must have reflected an adaptation of the millenarian date to a chronological system that, however vague and dubious, was certainly popular amongst the Greeks, as is witnessed by Thucydides.³⁸ In other words, our millenarian calculations do not contradict each other, but they should be traced back to the one tradition that in the 4th century — and also in the 5th century, if we take Xanthus into account — placed Zoroaster '6000 years before' (their time) or, with a fair degree of approximation, '5000 years before the fall of Troy'. Although Xanthus' testimony as reported by Diogenes is therefore different in its *terminus ante quem* as it refers to 480 B.C. and not to the life or death of Plato, it is quite understandable that the reading ἑξακισχίλια has been preferred to ἑξακόσια. Bidez and Cumont argued against Messina's idea that the most reliable manuscripts of the *Vitae philosophorum* confirmed ἑξακόσια, and rightly remarked that "le chiffre (6000) attribué par P[arisinus] à Xanthos peut chronologiquement se concilier avec la donnée tirée d'Hermodore";³⁹ and we have also seen above that the study of the manuscript tradition of Diogenes Laertius seems to attest to the particular relation of the *Parisinus* with the most authoritative of the *codices antiquiores*, the *Neapolitanus Bourbonicus*, that unfortunately has a lacuna in the first part of the Proem. And this is not all: the codex that gives the figure '600', i.e. the *Laurentianus*, seems to be the most ex-

travagant of the *antiquiores* and not constant in its reliability (see p. 47).

The *lectio* ἑξακόσια vanished from the scene since ἑξακισχίλια had met with fairly widespread approval. All the same, it continued to have supporters, as we have seen. One of them was Walter Spoerri,⁴⁰ who repropounded it in the context of his confutation of Werner Jaeger's theory, to which we shall refer later on (see p. 57 f.). In the final analysis, what this confutation set out to do was to demonstrate the groundlessness of any theory that presented Plato as being in some way dependent on, or simply attracted by, Oriental thought. However, as we have seen, the reading ἑξακόσια has come back into vogue with some scholars, who have not gone to the trouble of going closely into the complex debate about Diogenes Laertius' text, its manuscript tradition and the implication that Xanthus' testimony has in the wider framework of the problems concerning the Greeks' knowledge of Oriental thought in the 5th and 4th centuries B.C.

Thus the theory that Messina had elaborated has been repropounded in a summary and over-hasty fashion. The *lectio* ἑξακόσια has been revived by Shahbazi because, in his opinion, it supports a reconstruction of the chronology of Zoroaster, based on an unlikely interpretation of some information given by Biruni⁴¹ about the origins of the local history of Khwarezm, which he considers as 'the cradle of Zoroastrianism':⁴² the supposed 600 years before 480 B.C. in Xanthus would coincide perfectly with the calculation that, according to him, is implicit in Biruni and is proof of the fact that Zoroaster lived in about 1080 B.C. Not even Humbach, who also held that Xanthus actually dated the prophet to 1080 B.C., has accepted Shahbazi's arguments,⁴³ on account of this intrinsic weakness that I had already pointed out.⁴⁴

For his part, Humbach has remarked, wrongly, that "Classicists have disregarded the following facts: Only three of the extant codices of Diogenes are of critical value ..." ⁴⁵ But this is contradicted both by the apparatus criticus and by Bidez and Cumont's commentary to B 1a.⁴⁶ Furthermore, on the sole ground of a purely

formal comparison between the numbers given by Hermodorus (πεντακισχίλια in the *Parisinus* and in the *Seragliensis* and '5000' in the *Laurentianus*) and by Xanthus, he has concluded rather too simply that "in accordance with the accepted rules of textual criticism, though contrary to the editors' practice here, the reading '600' [...] is a *lectio difficilior* and so must be left in the text",⁴⁷ evidently because in his opinion the *lectio faciliior* consists in a number that is nearer to the one in Hermodorus.⁴⁸ On the sole basis of this argument, Humbach has then automatically and mechanically applied the so-called 'rule' of the *lectio difficilior*, without taking into account any criterion of intrinsic probability or, what is more, of the greater reliability of the *Parisinus gr.* 1759 compared with the *Laurentianus Florentinus* 69.13. In this way he got to the date of 1080 B.C., probably unaware of the sensible judgement expressed by A. Berriedale Keith who wrote, more than seventy years ago: "Xanthos [...] attests the belief which was always held in Greece, that Zoroaster was a very ancient sage, and, if we take the date 600 before the expedition of Xerxes, we obtain a date of 1080 B.C. which is not itself implausible, although to give it credence on its own merits alone would be obviously impossible".⁴⁹

Another argument, which is superfluous and misleading, was introduced against the reading ἑξακόσια by Bidez and Cumont and I incautiously agreed with it in my review of Professor Humbach's book *The Gāthās of Zarathushtra and the Other Old Avestan Texts*.⁵⁰ According to this argument the δέ after Ξανθός would not be enough to express such a drastic contradiction between the two dates given by Hermodorus and by Xanthus. The authors of the *Mages hellénisés* state, in fact, that "si l'on s'en tenait au nombre ἑξακόσια [...], il y aurait entre les deux données successives (5000 puis 600) une opposition irréductible, et il serait surprenant que Diogène ne l'eut pas marquée par une particule plus expressive qu'un simple δέ".⁵¹ There is no reason to resort to such a weak argument⁵² to confirm the validity of the reading ἑξακισχίλια.

This reading is consistent with all the other Classical sources, which make the time in which Zoroaster lived go back five or six thousand years, according to the chronological reference-point they start from. This was effectively asserted by Arthur D. Nock, when he wrote: "The variant reading 600 for 6000 may be disregarded; the context is fatal to it".⁵³ The '600' (χ') in the *Laurentianus Florentinus* stands for the 'six thousand' in the *Parisinus* and, in all likelihood, it is the outcome of a simple error that has not been recognized as such, especially by those who have been searching for a historical date for Zoroaster in the Greek sources. We can see a very similar error to this one in the *Suidas Lexicon*, that places Zoroaster '500' (φ') years before the Trojan war: Ζωροάστρης· Περσομήδους, σοφός[...] ἐγένετο δὲ πρὸ τῶν Τρωϊκῶν ἔτεσι φ'.⁵⁴ No-one could doubt that the 500 years given by the tradition of *Suidas* are anything but the 5000 years that, according to *Hermodorus*, *Hermippus* and *Plutarch*, come between the Iranian prophet and the Trojan war.

We have already mentioned the fact that someone has proposed rejecting both the readings ἑξακισχίλια and ἑξακόσια (the only ones attested in the manuscript tradition), suggesting that we reconstruct ἐξήκοντα in the original testimony given by *Xanthus*. This proposal has been made by *Gershevitch*, in the article that I have mentioned several times. In order to reconcile the '5000 down to Troy' with the '6000 down to Plato', he thinks it would be tolerable to round off the figure 850 (the years between the death of *Plato* and the Trojan war) to 1000, but he is not of a like mind concerning the 720 years that supposedly elapsed between the Trojan war and *Xerxes'* expedition. Moreover, as regards the reading ἑξακισχίλια, he declares:

One must not overlook that the estimate by ancient Greeks of Zoroaster's date in terms of millennia has received a generally accepted explanation valid only from the fourth century onward, being inapplicable to the fifth century by definition. The explanation lies, to use the words by which *Gnoli*, 1980, 165, sums up *W. Jaeger's* incisive investigation, in "the desire among Greeks to connect *Plato* with Zoroaster through two cycles of 3000 years". As *Xanthus* lived

at a time when such a desire could not even have crossed his mind, a time when on the other hand in his youth plenty of men were in circulation whose fathers had born witness direct or indirect to Zoroaster's funeral, it seems obvious that until about the end of the fourth century the manuscripts of Xanthus's own, original work lost to us, will have carried the number of years correctly as 60.⁵⁵

This is what he thinks must have happened. There was a gradual passage from the original figure of 60 years before Xerxes' expedition to the figure 6000, that derives from a later and independent tradition, two-three centuries after Xanthus, fostered by a suspicion in some compiler's or copyist's mind with the result that gradually the 60 disappeared from view. The reading 600 "poses a challenge to the narrowly text-critical assumption that it be due merely to careless copying". And he adds:

Xanthus, since he took 480 B.C. for the year from which he counted back, could for correct number have given only a number that lay between 60 (Zoroaster's death) and 138 (his birth).⁵⁶ This rules out both 6000 and 600 from having been his figure. That his figure was the lowest, sc. 60, is a possibility, but in its favour it would be good to have a little more than the inference which we drew above from its being from Plato's death, that later Greeks counted back to Zoroaster. This little more can very well be the figure 600 itself, if with Humbach one assumes that it goes back to Diogenes or one of his sources. For then, since the 6000 of codex P must also go back to Diogenes or to one of his sources, what is helpful is that of the two figures certainly not given by Xanthus, only 6000 is explicable, the only explanation on offer, however, being that it derives from a tradition independent of whatever figure between 60 and 138 Xanthus may have given. By contrast, 600 would be a figure wholly devoid of rhyme or reason, unless it arose by way of compromise between the explicable, independent 6000, and the figure between 60 and 138 given by Xanthus. There is only one figure included in the latter range, between which and 6000 the sexagesimal 600 would make sense, as a compromise devised in deference to the 'respectability' in Greek eyes of 6000. This is why I mooted *60, as a *ballon d'essai*, already in 1986, pp. 94-8.⁵⁷

And in § 55 of his article Gershevitch argues that a slip in Humbach's text — ἐξήκοντα for ἐξακόσια — which I had pointed out in the review of *The Gāthās of Zarathushtra and the Other*

Old Avestan Texts,⁵⁸ is proof of the impact which it has made on him by the asterisked figure *60, that he would not have been able to find elsewhere than in the article which Gershevitch contributed to the miscellany in his honour.⁵⁹

We can sum up Gershevitch's proposal as follows: since the dating of Zoroaster in terms of millennia can only be explained by the Greeks' attempt to connect Zoroaster and Plato, it could not have been found in the original text by Xanthus, as he had lived more than a century before Plato, and therefore it would be found in Diogenes, a Greek compiler datable to the third century A.D., because a figure in the thousands is given also by other Greek writers counting from Zoroaster, apart from the fact that it would hardly be plausible for the above-mentioned reason either, namely because the rounding off of 720 to 1000 years (the lapse of time between 480 B.C., the year of Xerxes' expedition, and 1200 B.C., a date for the fall of Troy) "looks questionable". Consequently, we must suppose that the date given originally by Xanthus would have been "60 years before Xerxes' crossing" and moreover it would have referred to the death of Zoroaster, just like the date of 6000 years before the death of Plato:

That for 'date' of Zoroaster the Greek logographer would to fifth-century Greeks specify the year of his death rather than, say, of his birth, would be a supposition of mine inspired by its being down to Plato's death, and not birth, that to Greeks of the late fourth century the number of years that had lapsed since Zoroaster was specified as 6000 by such authors as believed in it.⁶⁰

With these arguments Gershevitch has attempted to demonstrate that the date of Zoroaster that was originally present in Xanthus' text, i.e. 540 B.C. (480 + 60) according to his reconstruction, coincides with the traditional date of 258 years before Alexander.⁶¹

In actual fact, Gershevitch's proposal does not stand up to criticism because, as we shall see more clearly later on, the date of 6000 years could well have been present in Xanthus' text, even though the Platonists' adoption of it probably had the ideological

implications that have been illustrated by Jaeger. The Academy may have given it a new meaning, but it was probably already known to the Greeks. On the other hand, this was Jaeger's own view-point;⁶² he did not refute the authenticity of the 6000 years before Xerxes' crossing in Xanthus' text. What Gershevitch asserts, namely that the millenarian date is "inapplicable to the fifth century by definition",⁶³ because it would be attested more than a century before Plato, is not necessarily true.

Even if we do accept the date of 6000 years in Xanthus' text, this does not mean that we obtain any proof against the unreliability of the traditional date that placed Zoroaster between the 7th and the 6th century B.C. In fact, this date can only be explained by the misinterpretation of an Iranian source that, as we shall see, considered the historical Zoroaster as having lived at a time that was not too far removed from the beginning of the 5th century. In other words, Gershevitch's ingenious proposal, that eliminates the 6000, a figure that was due to a tradition introduced later on through the influence of the Platonists, and 600, a figure that arose by way of compromise between the explicable 6000 and the figure between 60 and 138 (see p. 53) given by Xanthus, and replaces them with *60, which, besides being not very convincing, could not appear in the manuscript tradition, is not even necessary to prove the theory that Zoroaster actually had lived between the 7th and 6th century B.C. It is — as he is well aware — only a 'possibility',⁶⁴ that is just as theoretical and remote as it is impossible to prove. However, it is not to be disposed of as Kingsley does,⁶⁵ in his reference to Gershevitch's contribution to the *Festschrift für H. Humbach*,⁶⁶ because it is not really an emendment to Diogenes Laertius' text, as Gershevitch himself explained afterwards.

That Zoroaster's date was given by means of a millenary calculation in Xanthus' testimony as well is therefore quite probable, and has always been acknowledged by the great majority of scholars, though not unanimously as Gershevitch states.⁶⁷ In fact, there never has been such unanimity, not even before Humbach put forward his theory. This date has a special significance be-

cause it differs from the other millenary dates that occur in the Classical sources on one important point: it calculates the period starting from an event that was meaningful only for a Greek and only for its outcome, namely Xerxes' expedition to Europe. In this connection, the conjectures made by Bidez and Cumont are not very likely.⁶⁸ They maintained that "un prêtre mazdéen aurait bien pu révéler à Xanthos que le désastre de l'armée perse présageait la fin d'une période qui avait commencée par la révélation d'Ahoura-Mazda à Zoroastre" — an idea which was already present in Cumont.⁶⁹ Other improbable theories are the one expressed by Reitzenstein,⁷⁰ who imagined that the Magus Ostanēs, who took part in the Persian venture according to Pliny, *Nat. Hist.* XXX, 8, saw the end of an epoch drawing nigh on account of the failure of the expedition and the revolt that broke out in Asia, and also the theory advanced by Altheim and Stiehl, which is substantially the same⁷¹. These are mere conjectures which do not take into account either that Xanthus refers explicitly to the διάβασις of the Persian army — and therefore to 480 B.C. and not to the battles of Salamis and Plataea — or that a Persian would not be very likely to think of the defeat that had been suffered outside the boundaries of the empire as being a disaster of cosmic proportions.⁷² What we can say is that all the attestations of six thousand and five thousand years are substantially similar, because they are not considering a precise chronological calculation, reckoned in centuries, decades or years. Xanthus' testimony is the earliest one — we know nothing of the Περσικά of Dionysius of Miletus and Charon of Lampsacus, that also had to do with the Magi⁷³ — and perhaps lay behind the others, some of which take the Trojan war as their reference-point while others establish in some way a connection between Zoroaster and Plato. As for the evidence of the Platonists, though, we must bear in mind the possibility that the great antiquity attributed to Zoroaster by the Academy had been vouched for by the 'Chaldaean' who was a disciple, according to a papyrus from Herculaneum,⁷⁴ probably late in Plato's time, as has opportunely been remarked, for instance, by Jaeger and

Nyberg.⁷⁵ Kingsley has made the fitting remark that a 'Magian system of dating' must be seen in the millenarian date given to Zoroaster by the Greeks.⁷⁶ There would not even be any need to suppose that Eudoxus, who was certainly an authority on Xanthus as Hans Herter has proved,⁷⁷ was responsible for the diffusion of the date 6000 years before Plato in Academy circles. As Kingsley writes, "Eudoxus or Aristotle might have reported it, and even understood its significance, but neither of them would have invented it in the first place".⁷⁸ The presence of Magi in the Academy, towards the end of Plato's life and at his death, is clearly attested by the author of the anonymous life of Plato⁷⁹ and by Seneca's statement (*Epist.* 58, 31), according to which there were some Magi present in Athens when Plato was dying.⁸⁰ In his recent article "Meetings with Magi", Kingsley refers to the whole problem of Oriental influence on Greek thought — a theme which now occurs frequently in his stimulating studies and on which he thinks differently from A.-J. Festugière or Arnaldo Momigliano⁸¹ — and in particular on Plato's Academy. He also deals with the role played by the Magi in handing down Babylonian ideas and with the confusion between 'Magi' and 'Chaldaeans' that is frequent in Greek literature, proof of which would be the etymology of the name Zoroaster as ὀστροθύτης in Dinon and also in Hermodorus:⁸² on this point see also the recent remarks made by Margherita Isnardi Parente.⁸³ The significance and importance of Plato's Chaldaean visitor is thus placed in a broader historical context, which also includes the portrait-statue of Plato erected by Mithradates the Persian.⁸⁴ A significant hypothesis, in this connection, is the one put forward by Konrad Gaiser, according to which the 'Chaldaean' at the Academy and the Persian Mithradates were one and the same person.⁸⁵

As everybody knows, Jaeger has stressed the importance of these testimonies on the date of Zoroaster that can be traced back to Plato's Academy:

The date given by Aristotle and Eudoxus, as reported by Pliny, differs from the other traditional dates in its peculiar point of reference. When

we compare '6,000 years before Plato's death' with figures reckoned from the fall of Troy or from the expedition of Xerxes (which later gave way to that of Alexander), it becomes obvious that this manner of statement is due not to chronological convenience but to the desire to connect Zarathustra and Plato as two essentially similar historical phenomena. The point of the comparison, and of Aristotle's interest in the round thousands of the interval, is clearly the view put forward in *On Philosophy* that all human truths have their natural and necessary cycles.⁸⁶

After referring to Jackson, Cumont and Friedrich Gisinger⁸⁷ and after speaking of Iranian dualism and of an enthusiasm for Zoroaster at the Academy that "amounted to intoxication, like the rediscovery of Indian philosophy through Schopenhauer"⁸⁸, Jaeger added that "Zarathustra and Plato are obviously two important stages in the world's journey towards its goal, the triumph of the good"⁸⁹; a triumph that was to have come about according to the times of the great cosmic aeon of the Iranian religion and the vicissitudes of the dramatic fight between Ahura Mazdā and Angra Mainyu.

Cumont and Nyberg, had followed Jaeger in the German edition of the *Aristoteles* (1923), and so had Richard Reitzenstein.⁹⁰ Nyberg, in particular, also referred to Émile Benveniste,⁹¹ with whom he agreed for a time on the idea that the first attestation of Zoroaster's name amongst the Greeks went back to the Platonists, without any mention of the testimony of Xanthus. It was only later on that he corrected these ideas, but he preferred the reading ἐξακόσια in Diogenes Laertius: "Das früheste Zeugnis für die Zeit Zarathustras, das wir besitzen, stammt von Xanthos dem Lyder, einem älteren Zeitgenossen des Herodot: Zoroaster lebte 600 Jahre vor Xerxes' Feldzug nach Griechenland".⁹² Jaeger had found support for his thesis in the doctrine attested in Theopompus, who had probably got it from Eudoxus of Cnidus, and handed down by Plutarch in his *De Iside et Osiride* 47, in which an eschatological drama is marked into three periods of three thousand years each. It is also well known that Jaeger discerned in the learned Alexandrian Sotion and in his Διαδοχή the source from which Diogenes

got Xanthus' testimony, and that he distinguished between Sotion, as being the source for the spurious *Μαγικός* and the *Περὶ μαθημάτων* by Hermodorus, and Hermippus, on whom Pliny drew as a source for Aristotle's *Περὶ φιλοσοφίας* and Eudoxus' *Γῆς περίοδος*. Lastly, Jaeger upheld that it was Aristotle, "led by his doctrine of the periodical return of all human knowledge", and not Eudoxus, who linked the number of six thousand years with the return of dualism, thus making a connection with Plato "in a setting that corresponded to his profound reverence for him". Pliny, who quotes Eudoxus, Aristotle and Hermippus, attributes the actual reference to Plato's death to Aristotle, since Eudoxus had died — or so he thought at first — before Plato.⁹³ Jaeger's theory, as we all know, met with success,⁹⁴ though there were still some who criticized it. Benveniste also obtained similar results in his *The Persian Religion According to the Chief Greek Texts*.⁹⁵

In order to understand the origin of the millenarian date given by Xanthus we certainly cannot use the explanation for the date that, more than a century later, was commonly accepted in Academy circles, unless we can make it clear that this explanation was the fruit of a Greek interpretation of Persian evidence, of such a type than it can satisfactorily explain the date given by Xanthus, as well as the one given by Eudoxus, Aristotle and the Scholiast to *Alcibiades* I. And this is exactly what we must try to do.

It is more than likely that the date that was in current use at the Academy was meant to connect Plato with Zoroaster, although the explanations that have been given for it by Jaeger and Benveniste are not, in my opinion, satisfactory as far as the relevant Iranian ideological background is concerned. We can certainly admit that Xanthus reported information that was consistent with an Iranian conception of the world-year, just as the Platonists did, either because they depended on Xanthus or because they were in close contact with, for example, their fellow-disciple the Chaldaean (see p. 57), whom Nyberg sees as the voluntary inspirer of the parallelism between Zoroaster and Plato.⁹⁶ All things considered, there is no reason why we should share Boyce's scepticism on the

authenticity of the information that Diogenes attributes to Xanthus, as we have already noted (see p. 45), because there is no need to think that such a conception in the 5th century B.C. should coincide entirely with the "fully evolved world chronology as this reaches us through the Pahlavi books", as she has written, or that the Magi were not "already making chronological calculations according to millenary schemes in the early fifth century B.C."⁹⁷ We only have to acknowledge that, apart from its complex astrological implications as they are set out in the *Bundahišn*,⁹⁸ the idea that established the total period of those millenary schemes as twelve thousand years had already been conceived by the Magi in the first half of the 5th century. Zoroaster will have been placed in a certain millennium and we have no definite reason to deny that he had already been placed at the beginning of the 10th millennium, in accordance with the doctrine that is widely attested in the Zoroastrian tradition.

We come now to the explanations given by Jaeger and Benveniste for the millenarian date of Zoroaster, with particular reference to Plato's Academy. As we shall see, they have given rise to considerable confusion which has prevented us from seeing that the Greek dates for Zoroaster, six thousand years before Xerxes or Plato, are quite compatible with Iranian cosmology.

Jaeger was probably right in saying that the Academy was willing to accept the idea that the Platonic doctrine of Good being a divine and universal principle "had been revealed to eastern humanity by an Oriental prophet thousands of years before", but in the English edition of his work he deliberately gave up the idea of trying to make the Greek and Persian traditions fit in with one another, as he had attempted to do in the German edition, "since for my purpose the only important thing is to establish *the fact that* shortly after his death, and even while he was still living, Plato was brought into connexion with Zarathustra and with Iranian teaching about the struggle between the good principle and the bad".⁹⁹

Benveniste went still further, independently of Jaeger, as he

himself says. In fact, quite some time after he had delivered his Ratanbai Katrak Lectures, given at the Sorbonne in 1926 and published in 1929, Benveniste discovered that Jaeger “in his admirable *Aristoteles* [he refers to the German edition of 1923] had already raised the same question in a similar manner, but with a far wider outlook on the connexion between Iranian and Greek ideas and with more copious comparisons”. He maintained that the great cycle of twelve thousand years was to be taken as being divided “into two periods of six thousand years, the first of which is marked by the appearance of Zoroaster” and the second by Platonic dualism, since Plato was “a representative of the same ideas” as Zoroaster. And he concluded: “Everything happens as if the disciples of Plato, urged by a desire to find an origin for themselves as far back as possible, had obscurely made Zoroaster a precursor of Plato, or Plato a reincarnation of Zoroaster”.¹⁰⁰

We have already mentioned Reitzenstein (see pp. 56, 58). He took over Jaeger’s theory, though he did not agree with the idea that it had been Aristotle who saw Plato as Zoroaster’s successor — Reitzenstein attributed it to Eudoxus — and he conjectured that Xanthus’ source of information had been Ostanès, a Magus in Xerxes’ retinue, who, according to Pliny (*Nat. Hist.* XXX, 8), was the author of a work on Zoroaster’s doctrine. According to him, Ostanès had calculated six thousand years from the First Man to his own time, but this had been misunderstood by Xanthus who attributed to Zoroaster the mythical age of the First Man.¹⁰¹ Subsequently Eudoxus “probably chose ‘6000 years before Plato’ as a substitute for the ‘6000 years before Ostanès’ of Xanthus, and his choice — as Nock wrote, though he did not believe in a similarity of doctrine between Plato and Zoroaster — is easily explained by the admiration which he felt for both Plato and Zoroaster”.¹⁰² We have also seen how Jaeger’s theory was accepted by Cumont, who wrote:

Les mages avec lesquels les Grecs ont été en contact, ont probablement cru dès l’époque des Achéménides à une période cosmique de 6.000 ans, dont la fin serait marquée par des calamités inouïes, suivies

de l'apparition du sauveur dont les livres sacrés prédisaient la venue. Du moins, c'est ainsi que s'explique, semble-t-il, la singulière tradition suivant laquelle Zoroastre aurait vécu six mille ans avant l'expédition de Xerxès ou avant la mort de Platon. Pour les uns, le désastre qui avait atteint l'armée perse présageait la fin de l'âge qui avait commencé avec le «millénaire de Zoroastre»; pour les autres, l'activité de Platon était celle du sage inspiré qui devait, quand les temps seraient accomplis, compléter l'œuvre du fondateur du mazdéisme. Ses disciples faisaient ainsi du grand idéaliste une sorte de messie.¹⁰³

Cumont represented these ideas, with Bidez, in *Les Mages hellénisés*, and Bidez expressed them in *Éos ou Platon et l'Orient*.¹⁰⁴ For his part, Nyberg stated, at the same time as Cumont, that "La spéculation académique suppose une prophétologie zoroastrienne qui fait apparaître Zoroastre à un moment très important de l'Aion présent. Il est bien probable que ce moment était le milieu du cours de l'Aion, qui comprend donc 12000 ans, divisés en deux périodes de chacune 6000 ans".¹⁰⁵ In *Die Religionen des alten Iran* he confirmed this point of view with some slight changes (see p. 58).¹⁰⁶ The date of 6000 years that was current in Academy circles (in his view we should read 600 in Xanthus apud Diogenes), is seen by him as an argument in favour of the idea that the Iranian prophétology which was known to the Platonists must have been the Zurvanite one, "car 12000 ans, c'est le chiffre zervanite de préférence",¹⁰⁷ in spite of Benveniste's opinion.¹⁰⁸

And so the Zoroaster-Plato connection, as far as millenarian dates are concerned, has met with great success. It has resisted the firm opposition put up by Walter Spoerri, due to an analysis which Mario Untersteiner rightly defined as hypercritical.¹⁰⁹ Thus we come across it in recent works, such as those by Boyce, Kingsley and Gershevitch, although with different implications and with totally different contexts.¹¹⁰ Jaeger and Benveniste, however, did not manage to find out the Iranian background — that had formerly been assumed by Alfred von Gutschmid¹¹¹ — of the doctrine that placed Zoroaster 6000 years before Xerxes' expedition or Plato's death, nor did Reitzenstein have any success.

It has mostly been thought that this was a Magian conception of a cosmic aeon lasting 6000 or 12000 years, which was divided

into two equal periods. This is a mere conjecture that seems to be proved wrong by everything we know about Iranian cosmology. Nock's reservations and Spoerri's criticisms are right in this respect,¹¹² and the careful considerations that Jaeger made in the English edition of his work (see p. 60) are also justified. Herzfeld's explanation of Eudoxus' testimony on the 6000 years before Plato is quite unfounded. According to him, it would 'somehow' have reflected the Iranian chiliadic doctrine, combining two ideas: "Zoroaster shall reappear after 6,000 years" and "Plato is an incarnation of Zoroaster". Herzfeld added:

Eudoxus may have heard this from his Chaldean fellow-student in the following form: "The Persians say, 6,000 years after Zoroaster a new Zoroaster shall appear, he has already appeared in Plato". The rationalistic Greek students calculated therefrom: Zoroaster lived 6,000 years before Plato. It was the time when the Greeks first heard of the high oriental antiquity and believed in astronomical figures. This explanation which implies the Zoroastrian doctrine of the messianic return is the only acceptable explanation of the number.¹¹³

But the fact is that, in the system of aeons in which he was placed in Iranian cosmology, Zoroaster was never considered as the inaugurator of the 4th millennium, and what is more, there is no trace in that cosmology of his return after 6000 years, as Herzfeld concluded.¹¹⁴

Not even the explanation that Kingsley has recently given of the number 6000 in Xanthus' testimony, which he rightly takes to be authentic, is any more convincing than the ones given so far, that he justly finds unsatisfactory. Kingsley does not doubt that there was an Iranian background behind them, but he is mistaken in continuing to believe that it only belonged to the "realms of mythological history",¹¹⁵ without considering that it could be the outcome of a misunderstanding (see p. 73 ff.). Although we can agree with him that simply to refer it to the "cosmic periods of either nine or twelve thousand years" is to make "an almost equally fundamental mistake", we cannot accept that the number 6000 was a "chronological stakepost", as in Eratosthenes — who was supposed to have been influenced by Xanthus, as we are told by Strabo

I, 3, 4.¹¹⁶ Nor can we accept that its origin was to some extent similar to what Cumont imagined, together with Bidez as well (see p. 62), namely that the disaster of the Persian expedition fulfilled a Magian prediction on the end of an epoch that had begun with Ahura Mazdā's revelation to Zoroaster. What Kingsley thinks, in actual fact, is that we should interpret "Xanthus's six-thousand year interval between Zoroaster and Xerxes as related to the idea of an apocalyptic battle", which "harmonizes well with the other evidence available, both earlier and later". He then goes on to say:

the linking of Zoroaster with Xerxes's crossing must have been *before* the event: the attempted invasion was, of course, to prove a major failure. In other words, it must originally have been a prophecy of success [...] On the Iranian side there can be no real doubt that the Magian dating of Zoroaster in specific relation to Xerxes's critical crossing of the Hellespont was one more, very powerful, attempt to predict and confirm the outcome of the fighting.¹¹⁷

The number 6000 would have been, in Kingsley's opinion, typical of one of the possible versions of the Magian concepts concerning the cosmic period, because "most important of all is the fact that a basic figure of six thousand years for the acting out of events" would have been "the original period from which the others were for various reasons subsequently derived". This would, in his opinion, be confirmed by the fact that "this same period of six thousand years for the duration of the world continues to appear in Christian, Mandaean, and Armenian sources down to and beyond the Middle Ages",¹¹⁸ and it would be confirmed by the presumed variety of conceptions that the Magi had of the duration of the world-year, that Boyce has reconstructed.¹¹⁹ But, upon closer consideration, this variety is only due to a wrong estimate because we have no objective evidence for thinking that some of the Magi in the 5th century B.C. had conceived of an aeon that was limited to six thousand years. The evidence given in the *Book of Six Thousand* (*Vec' Hazareak*) and other Armenian texts, for instance, can easily be explained by the aeon of twelve thousand years, since

the entire Zoroastrian tradition fixes the period of the world-year as six thousand years starting from the attack (*ēbgatīh*) of Ahreman upon the material world, and, of course, also by the Christian speculations on the figure 6000, on account of which each millennium reflects one day of the six of Creation in *Genesis*. On this subject we can see the pages that James R. Russell has devoted to it¹²⁰ to which Kingsley also refers. The fact is that both Russell and Kingsley appeal to the authority of Boyce,¹²¹ though she upholds the idea that there existed amongst the Magi an original period of six thousand years precisely on the grounds of the evidence given by the Greeks about the date of Zoroaster before Plato. In this way, as anyone can see, we get into a vicious circle, using as proof the very thing we set out to prove. And so Kingsley's explanation falls through.

On the other hand, the apocalyptic explanation for the date of six thousand years is in any case unlikely. In fact, it assumes that "Xerxes's crossing was meant to represent a single vast unit of time, or world period" and that "Placing Zoroaster at a start of this world period presents no problem", because "it is not a dating to be factually analyzed, but is to be understood as reflecting the *perception* of Zoroaster and his religion as the determining reality behind the world in which we live".¹²² The references to the remarks made by Henry Corbin and Andrew R. Burn¹²³ add nothing, and neither do the references to the conceptions of the six or seven thousand years dominated by the planets, on which Cumont dwelt at length.¹²⁴ In actual fact we have no evidence that enables us to reconstruct a Magian idea of the world-year which placed Zoroaster at the beginning of a single aeon, whose conclusion would have involved *six thousand years after* an "enormous, armed confrontation in which the Zoroastrian forces of good would once and for all conquer the forces of evil".¹²⁵ On this point the references to *Y.* 31, 16-18 and to *Yt.* 19, 88-96 are misleading, and so are those to some pages by Samuel K. Eddy and by Boyce.¹²⁶ There were also those who, like V.V. Struve, chose to see Xerxes as the Saošyant, though this must be relegated to the realm of pure fantasy.¹²⁷

We therefore need to find another explanation for the origin of the six-thousand years date that the Greeks must certainly have got from the Persians. It does not concern us here, as regards the *interpretatio Graeca*, to take sides in favour of Jaeger's and Benveniste's theories. What must concern us now is not so much that interpretation and not even the much-debated problem of the Oriental influence on Platonic thought, on which it will be useful to read the pages that Momigliano devoted to the topic in *Alien Wisdom*, with the fitting remarks made by Kingsley.¹²⁸ Rather we should try to understand how it came about that the news of that date in terms of six thousand years reached the Greeks, that is to say, what its Iranian background was. Gershevitch, for instance, did not consider the question and for this reason he thought that the reading ἑξακισχίλια did not belong to Xanthus' original text, since he was of the opinion that this figure could only be explicable in connection with the Academy.¹²⁹ In this fashion, however, he mistook the consequences for the cause of the impact that the relevant Iranian doctrine had on the Platonists. We shall see, on the contrary, that it is possible to find a convincing explanation for that figure that can be applied equally to Xanthus' testimony and to those of Eudoxus, Aristotle and the Scholiast to *Alcibiades I*. And this is not all. We shall also see that this explanation had already been given a century ago.

In actual fact, research on the Platonic interpretation has prevailed over research into the origin. Attention has been concentrated mostly on Jaeger's theory, naturally to criticize it as well, and on the very strong interest in the Orient of which the Academy was said to be the centre, particularly on the role that would have been played by one such as Eudoxus, Aristotle or Hermodorus, and on the idea of a bad world-soul that opposes the good one in the *Laws* of Plato as "a tribute to Zarathustra" — as Jaeger wrote¹³⁰ — as well as on Aristotle's interest in the Magi in the dialogue *On Philosophy* and in one of the oldest parts of the *Metaphysics*, where, in talking about Platonic dualism, there is a reference to Pherecydes in Greece and to the Magi in Asia as forerunners of this view.¹³¹

As for the Iranian background to the six-thousand years date, the only reference that has been made is to a generic 'Weltalterlehre', without any attempt to reconstruct, or without managing to identify, the Iranian doctrine that lay behind it. This is probably the reason why its exact identification, although it had been glimpsed as early as 1896, faded into the background.

At the end of the last century Jackson, in his 1896 article that was reprinted in his *Zoroaster*, suggested that the extraordinary figures in terms of millennia given for the date of the prophet of ancient Iran in the Classical texts were

presumably due to the Greeks' having misunderstood the statements of the Persians, who place Zoroaster's millennium amid a great world-period of 12,000 years, which they divided into cycles of 3000 years,¹³² and in accordance with which belief Zoroaster's *fravashi* had in fact existed several thousands of years.¹³³

This gives us in a nutshell the identification of the Iranian background to that extraordinary date. We know, in fact, that Zoroaster's spiritual ego, his *fravaši*, was formed at the beginning of the second cycle of three thousand years, *six thousand years before his material birth*, which was placed at the end of the third millenary cycle.

The classic place in which this doctrine is expounded is the *Dēnkard* VII, 2, 16. The reader is referred to Molé's edition, edited by Jean de Menasce in 1967. Here it says that, at the end of the third millennium (of the cycle of twelve thousand years), in the 3000 years of *mēnōg* existence that was not devastated by the assault of the evil powers (after the creation had been in the *mēnōg* existence and before the advent of the Druz) the Amahraspandān created the *frawahr* of Zarduxšt.¹³⁴ This doctrine is consistently attested in the Pahlavi books.¹³⁵ In *Wizīrgard ī Dēnīg* — a late text, though one which is full of Avestan citations¹³⁶ — there is a distinct confirmation of it: after 3000 years of *mēnōg* existence and after a further 3000 years of *gētīg* existence that was marked by a mixture of truth and falsehood, the *frawahr* of Zoroaster came into the material world.¹³⁷ This means that, according to this doc-

trine, the spiritual ego of Zoroaster was formed at the end of the third millennium and that *Zoroaster was born six thousand years after*, at the end of the ninth millennium.

We cannot dwell at length here on the typical Iranian conception of the *fravašis*,¹³⁸ but whoever is acquainted with the cosmology, anthropology and soteriology of Mazdaism will easily understand the importance of this evidence with regard to our problem, just as it was understood by Jackson and, immediately after him, by E. W. West in his lucid, well-balanced introduction to book 47 of the *Sacred Books of the East*. He rightly says:

It seems, therefore, that the ancient statements, regarding the date of Zarātūst, reported by Pliny and corroborated by a few other classical writers, can be fully explained from the traditional system of chronology used in Pahlavi texts, by identifying the classical Zoroaster of the seventh millennium B.C.¹³⁹ with the traditional Zarātūst in his ante-natal spiritual state, after he had ceased to be a mere Fravashi, or primary idea, and had become an intelligent, moving, and personal existence, but still a spirit [...]

It will be noticed that this explanation depends entirely upon the peculiarly artificial system of the traditional chronology, in which the whole of time is assumed to consist of twelve millennia devoted to different purposes [...] The only reasonable conclusion seems to be that the chronology based upon the twelve millennia was in use in the fifth century B.C., about which time the earliest quoted statement seems to have been made.¹⁴⁰

The idea of the pre-existence of Zoroaster — the subject of a penetrating study by Molé, who made use of Kaj Barr's 1952 article on the Iranian prophet as τέλειος ἄνθρωπος¹⁴¹ — is an essential feature of Zoroastrian prophetology, and there is no available evidence to make us think it is a late one.

The pre-existence of the prophet involves the idea of a double birth, on two different levels of existence that are closely linked with each other. On the other hand, the close connection that the *fravašis* in their turn had with birth is well known. This connection even led James H. Moulton to think that, as 'ancestor-spirits' (following in the tracks of Söderblom's interpretation), they were, first and foremost, beings that were responsible for the pregnancy

of women and the continuation of the race.¹⁴²

This is surely an exaggeration, though Moulton had some grounds for thinking it. Boyce did not fail to stress this aspect of the characteristic Iranian conception,¹⁴³ confirmed by such evidence as that in *Yt.* 13, 15.

Zoroaster's first birth, if we think in terms of the specific ontology of Zoroastrianism, came about on a level that was no less real than his second birth. It is therefore quite probable that the formation of the prophet's *fravaši* ended up by being mistaken for his birth into life on earth. In the case of a Magus giving this information to a Greek, in the 5th century B.C., there could have been some natural element of ambiguity. It is not for nothing that we can perhaps catch sight of a similar ambiguity in a passage from the *Farvardīn Yašt* regarding the praise and veneration of Zoroaster's *fravaši*. It ends with the exclamation: "According to (our) wish a priest is born to us, Zarathuštra the Spitamid!", *ušta.nō zātō āθrava yō Spitāmō Zarahuštrō* (*Yt.* 13, 94).¹⁴⁴ Eight whole stanzas of this *yašt* are devoted to the prophet's *fravaši* (87-94), which is mentioned in the first stanza straight after the one devoted to *Gaya.marətan*, the primeval man. Afterwards there comes a long list with the names of the *fravašis* of the other heroes of the faith and the national tradition that takes up almost all the rest of the hymn (95-157). Zoroaster appears again in it (152) as a being who is worthy of devotion, according to a usage that was soon to become constant in the liturgy (see, for example, the passages in *Y.* 3, 21; 7, 21; 16, 1-2), for the very reason — we must suppose — that the prophet is endowed with a venerable and holy *fravaši*. And so Zoroaster is defined in the Pahlavi texts as *yašt frawahr* 'whose *fravaši* is venerable' or else *ahlaw frawahr* 'whose *fravaši* is righteous'. And, as a matter of fact, Zoroaster's *fravaši* occupies a very important position in the religion, in connection with *Hōm*, *Srōš* and fire. Here the reader is referred to the recent work by Dastur Firoze M. Kotwal and James W. Boyd.¹⁴⁵

Now, it is very likely, and generally accepted, that the conception of the *fravašis*, which is attested both in the so-called Young

Avesta and in the *Yasna Haptaṅhāiti*,¹⁴⁶ but does not appear in the Gāthās, belongs to the prehistory of Zoroastrianism. Being so deeply rooted in the religious conscience of the Iranians, it was assimilated by Zoroastrianism, especially because of its relation with the cult of the dead and the belief in immortality, and also on account of its presence in the more important traditional festivities.¹⁴⁷ We can say that the conception of the *fravašis*, and therefore of the Avestan *ašaonqm fravašayō*, is not of Zoroastrian origin in so far as we have no trace of it in the Gāthās. But we cannot deny that it is widely represented in the whole Zoroastrian tradition and that it is therefore an integral part of the priestly elaboration of ancient Zarathuštricism.¹⁴⁸

In any event, there can be no doubt that the cult of the *fravašis* was already practised at the beginning of the 5th century B.C. Herodotus (VII, 43) tells how Xerxes, having reached the banks of the Scamander with his army, went up into Priam's Pergamum and offered a huge sacrifice to the Athena of Ilium, while the Magi made libations to the heroes, *χοὰς δὲ οἱ μάγοι τοῖσι ἥρωσι ἐχέαντο*. These ἥρωες could be no other than the *artāvans* of the Persians — who were themselves called ἄρταῖοι, as Herodotus reports further on (VII, 61) — and the cult mentioned must have been the worship of their *fravašis*. The ἄρταῖοι were the ἥρωες παρὰ Πέρσαις according to Hesychius and a whole lot of correspondences, that can be explained by the Iranian notion of OPers. *artāvan-*, Av. *ašāvan-*, Pahl. *ahlaw* and, consequently, by the reverence that was paid to the *fravašis* of those who were worthy of such definitions.¹⁴⁹ In this regard, there is a page of Herzfeld's *Zoroaster and His World* that is noteworthy.¹⁵⁰

Therefore, in the background of the episode that Herodotus recounts we must see the Persians' veneration for their heroes, of which there is plenty of parallel evidence in the Avesta where it speaks of the worship of the *fravašis* of the *ašavans*, not only in *Yt.* 13, but also in *Y.* 26. We have no reason to believe that the libations of the Magi in Xerxes' retinue were only made to the "spirits of brave men of another race", and of them only, as Boyce

argued.¹⁵¹ It is not impossible that, on that occasion, the Magi paid tribute to the heroes of ancient Troy, but it is certainly possible that they worshipped, together with the other *fravašis*, Zoroaster's as well, which had been formed, according to the cosmological doctrine of the twelve millennia, six thousand years before.

We could go still further — but it is a mere conjecture — and suppose that the Hellenized version of the alternative dating of Zoroaster in terms of millennia, namely five thousand years before the fall of Troy in Hermodorus, Hermippus and Plutarch, was the outcome of a Graeco-Persian adaptation that came about in the context of the episode reported by Herodotus, where Xerxes went up ἐς τὸ Πριάμου Πέργαμον and, having contemplated the place and had everything explained to him, θεησάμενος δὲ καὶ πυθόμενος ἐκείνων ἑκάστα, he took it upon himself to avenge Priam. This should not amaze us if we think of the Persian explanation of the Trojan war as in Herodotus I, 4-5. We can note that the information given by Herodotus is inserted right in the detailed account of Xerxes' διάβασις, which is the chronological point of reference from which Xanthus calculated Zoroaster's date. This event, the crossing of the Hellespont, was certainly important for the Persians and the Greeks, although it has not the apocalyptic significance that Cumont (see p. 62) and now Kingsley (see p. 64) have attributed to it. The first dates that the Greeks gave for Zoroaster would therefore have been the one given by Xanthus — 6000 years before Xerxes' crossing and 5000 years before the fall of Troy, two versions of the same date that had gained credit during the crossing of the Hellespont by Xerxes' army. Who could have handed on this information better than the Lydian writer?

One thing, though, is not conjecture but a logical consequence of everything we have said so far, and that is the fact that the dates for Zoroaster calculated as five millennia, all with reference to the Trojan war, are proof of the fact that, as early as the 4th century B.C., at the time of Hermodorus, the reading ἐξακισχίλια could well have been considered authentic in Xanthus' original text.

Xanthus, a Hellenized Lydian who experienced a famine during the reign of Artaxerxes I (465-425 B.C.),¹⁵² is a source that should be taken into due account, as can be seen by the great importance that it has for the history of Lydia.¹⁵³ We know that he was probably active around 450 B.C., as Herter has reasonably concluded¹⁵⁴ (according to Ephorus,¹⁵⁵ before Herodotus; according to Jacoby, dubitatively, after 425 B.C.),¹⁵⁶ or “some time either in the late fifties or in the forties of the fifth century B.C.”, according to Kingsley,¹⁵⁷ but not if his *Μαγικά* were a separate work, in the opinion of Cumont,¹⁵⁸ because the remarks on the Magi could have been part of book IV of the *Λυδιακά* according to von Gutschmid, Clemen, or Nock, although this last hypothesis seems to be the most plausible one, as Kingsley points out.¹⁵⁹ We can be certain, however, that the Lydian writer had every possibility of coming into direct contact with the Persians and getting first-hand information from them. On the other hand, his interest in the Magi is evident in other fragments of his work, both in the *Μαγικά* fragment apud Clement of Alexandria *Strom.* 3, 11, 1,¹⁶⁰ where Xanthus gives the perfectly reliable information about the Magian practice of marriage between blood-relations, and in the only fragment of his account of Empedocles, apud Diogenes Laertius VIII, 63,¹⁶¹ which, as Kingsley remarks, “appears to have presented him [sc. Empedocles] in the context of a discussion of the Persian Magi”.¹⁶² It is no wonder, then, that Xanthus is also the first source on the Iranian cosmological doctrine in terms of millennia. Significantly enough, Santo Mazzarino, discerned a link between the Empedoclean doctrines on metempsychosis and their cycles of three thousand years and the ‘cyclic period’ of six thousand years that in his opinion is attested in the date that Xanthus, an admirer of Empedocles, gives for Zoroaster.¹⁶³ In any case, Mazzarino also thinks that the right reading is *ἑξακισχίλια*, as it would be justified by the widespread diffusion of the doctrines concerning millenary cycles, of Oriental origin, in the Greek world of that time, quite apart from the Empedoclean doctrines on metempsychosis.

In actual fact the Iranian cosmological doctrine of the twelve millennia gives us a plausible explanation — the only one that accounts for all the evidence at our disposal — of the date of Zoroaster in terms of millennia that is attested in a large part of the Classical sources. The Magi will have declared that their prophet belonged to a very remote past, considering the importance that the conception of the *fravašis*, especially Zoroaster's, had for them in their cosmology, prophetology and eschatology. This is where the misunderstanding about the historical Zoroaster stems from. Xanthus reported that date, and likewise Hermodorus, Hermippus and Plutarch. In the Academy circles it was most likely interpreted in such a way as to form a close association between Plato and Zoroaster, who were divided by a period of six millennia and united by a similar dualistic idea. Eudoxus and Aristotle were of this same mind because, as Jaeger wrote, they were "aware of the great cycle in Iranian religion, and of the world-wide drama of the struggle between Ormuzd and Ahriman",¹⁶⁴ of which Theopompus apud Plutarch gives an accurate description. Aristotle, in the first book of his *On Philosophy*, thought that the Magi were older than the Egyptians, as Diogenes Laertius I, 8 reports.

It is hard to say whether the misunderstanding between the spiritual ego of Zoroaster and his material birth is entirely due to the Greeks. Duchesne-Guillemin wrote: "il n'est pas nécessaire de supposer ici, comme le fait ce savant [sc. Jackson], une erreur des Grecs. Les milieux d'où provenaient leurs informations pouvaient fort bien considérer la création «spirituelle» du prophète comme sa véritable naissance". He added that the Magi "avaient d'ailleurs intérêt à vieillir la religion qu'ils professaient, pour masquer le fait qu'elle n'était pas née parmi eux",¹⁶⁵ but perhaps we might also suppose that the real reason for the information that they gave in terms of millennia lay especially in their belief in the immortality that was to follow the resurrection — an idea that was known to Theopompus and Eudemus of Rhodes, as Diogenes Laertius I, 8-9 says¹⁶⁶ — that is to say, in a deathless existence that, as is clearly witnessed by the conception of the *fravašis*, comes both

before and after physical existence. It is not for nothing that the future 'saviours', the *saošyants*,¹⁶⁷ already exist in an immaterial state, with their *fravašis* to whom reverence can be paid (*Yt.* 13, 128-129). In fact, they are waiting to become flesh by their own free will, in accordance with a doctrine that is fully explained in the third chapter of the *Greater Bundahišn*.¹⁶⁸

Thus Duchesne-Guillemain adopted Jackson's explanation for the 6000 years, which, as we have noted, had met straight away with E. W. West's approval.¹⁶⁹ He included Xanthus amongst the Classical authors who have handed down this date, altering somewhat the idea of Jackson, who was referring mainly to the ancient Academy. More recently, Professor Martin L. West, in *Early Greek Philosophy and the Orient*, has also accepted this explanation, stating that Xanthus dated Zoroaster to six thousand years before Xerxes, probably because he misunderstood the doctrine according to which Zoroaster's soul had been created six thousand years before his birth. Therefore, he remarks, we could hold that the idea of the twelve thousand years, divided into four periods of three thousand years each, would have been common knowledge to the Greeks not only in the 4th century, as we know from Theopompus apud Plutarch, but already in the 5th century B.C.¹⁷⁰ All things considered, there is nothing against such a logical conclusion: the reservations expressed by Söderblom or by Clemen are not based on any concrete evidence. In fact, Söderblom and Clemen confined themselves to defining Jackson's explanation as 'not very probable'¹⁷¹ and 'sehr unwahrscheinlich'¹⁷² respectively, without giving any precise arguments,¹⁷³ except for the one that, in their opinion, the idea of the formation of Zoroaster's *fravaši* at the beginning of the 4th millennium of the world-year could not have been known to the Greeks as early as the 5th century B.C., evidently not even with regard to its implication concerning the epoch in which the prophet's birth should be placed. It will be useful to give some thought to the pages that Martin L. West has devoted to Heraclitus and to the links that there could have been between his idea of the αἰών and the Iranian conception of a time

conceived of as a single period of twelve thousand years. This is an extremely complex and controversial argument,¹⁷⁴ but it will be enough for the moment to remark that, apart from the hypothesis of Greek-Iranian contact on a subject similar to ours, the chiliadic speculation had already run its course before Xanthus' time. P'yankov, too, agrees with the solution proposed by Jackson, but without dealing with the textual and exegetical problems that constitute the main argument of the present lecture.¹⁷⁵

Humbach came very near the solution to our problem in his essay "A Western approach to Zarathushtra". In fact, he proposed explaining, albeit dubitatively, that the origin of the dating of Zoroaster in Pliny, that is, in Eudoxus and Aristotle (6000 years before Plato's death), and in Hermippus (5000 years before the Trojan war),¹⁷⁶ may have been the confusion arising out of the formation of the *fravaši* and the material birth of the prophet:

It is true that these figures please those who would like to date back the prophet to a period as remote as possible, but more probably they are fanciful adaptations of half-understood Iranian ideas, among them perhaps the idea of the pre-existence of Zarathushtra's Fravashi.¹⁷⁷

Humbach did not go any further into this hypothesis and did not reach the right solution (the same both for Xanthus and for the Greek philosophers) because he was convinced that the *lectio* ἑξακισχίλια for Xanthus should be given up in favour of ἑξακόσια (see pp. 48, 50 f.): "If '6000' is the correct reading then the statement of Xanthus is as fantastic as that of the Greek philosophers, but if it is '600' then it has an undeniable historical interest", as he wrote seven years later.¹⁷⁸ In other words, he took Jackson's explanation as holding good, hypothetically, only for the philosophers — and as a matter of fact it had originally been given with reference to them (see p. 74) — and not for Xanthus, who he thought would have established Zoroaster's date as 'six hundred before Xerxes' crossing' as a result of information that he had probably got from the Magi. This would also be the historical date of the prophet: 1080 B.C. (= 480 + 600).

Humbach did not realize, then, that Jackson's explanation could be the most reasonable solution to the various problems issuing from the Classical sources with regard to Zoroaster's date. In fact, it explains both the testimony of Xanthus and also those of the Academy circles: namely, Zoroaster lived six thousand years before (their time, evidently), because the advent of his *fravaši* went back to the beginning of the fourth millennium, when the first 3000 years of the world-year of 12000 years had already passed.

The information about the spiritual 'birth' of the prophet could just as well have been given to a Greek by a Persian either in 450 (with reference to 480) or in 347 B.C. and it could well have given rise to a misunderstanding, either voluntary or involuntary, by the Greek or the Persian, as to the actual time of his physical birth.

The *lectio* ἑξακισχίλια in Xanthus' testimony should certainly be preferred to ἑξακόσια for the reasons concerning text and content that have been given so far, and there is no reason to believe that it was attributed to the Lydian writer "by Greeks two-three centuries *after* Xanthus",¹⁷⁹ who wished to solve the presumed conflict between a hypothetical original report about '60 years before Xerxes' crossing' and one about '6000 years before Plato's death', on the grounds of the conjecture that at "the end of the second century B.C. the number of 'authorities' who Platonically gave the number as 6000 would be sufficiently impressive to engender in the mind of some compiler or other, or some copyist, the suspicion that 60 had somehow resulted from a misunderstanding or from confusion", as Gershevitch ingeniously supposed.¹⁸⁰

Now it is important to have established that the correct reading in Diogenes is ἑξακισχίλια as it is a faithful reflection of the information given by Xanthus, not only because it solves at least one of the problems posed by the passage from the Lydian historian in *Vitae philosophorum* — the subject of a lengthy debate¹⁸¹ — but also because on the one hand it gets rid of a presumed Greek testimony on a historical date for Zoroaster in the 11th century B.C. and on the other because it allows us to consider Xanthus' testimony as being definitely one of the earliest Classical ones on

the chiliadic doctrine of the Magi, in spite of Clemen's doubts that led him to consider 6000 "vielmehr als eine runde Zahl", though with the honest admission: "ohne einen solchen Gebrauch der Zahl freilich sonst bei den Persen nachweisen zu können".¹⁸² It follows that this doctrine must already have been formed in the first half of the 5th century B.C., that is to say, a century before Theopompus' testimony as handed to us by Plutarch, *De Iside et Osiride* 47.¹⁸³ Therefore we should not share the reservations of those who think, without any sound arguments, that the Magi had not begun to devote themselves to chronological calculations according to millenary schemes until a much later date, as Boyce would have it,¹⁸⁴ or Eduljee, who reached the unlikely conclusion, to some extent similar to Clemen's, that the figures 600 and 6000 (he is not sure about which of the two readings) were due to the "use of stock or conventional numbers to represent something numerous" and, as a result, they "may only mean: a long time (a very long time) before Plato/Xerxes/Troy".¹⁸⁵ We may remark, on the one hand, that there are already traces in the Avesta of a chiliadic conception, in the archaic myth of Yima (*Yt.* 9, 8-10) that we shall come back to later on (see p. 157 f.), and that, on the other hand, Irano-Mesopotamian syncretism, which was probably not alien to the Magian idea of the world-year, had already begun to bear fruit at the end of the 6th century B.C., as can be seen, for instance, from the calendrical innovations that were introduced during the reign of Darius I.¹⁸⁶ A different matter is the particular form that was given to the doctrine of the world-year of 12000 years, with one millennium under the chiliadic power (*chronokratoria*) of each zodiacal sign, which is set out in chapter VB of the *Greater Bundahišn*. Even if the Babylonian astronomers established the zodiac of twelve times thirty degrees and the relative movements of the sun, the moon and the planets after about 500 B.C., as Boyce reminded us, referring back to Otto Neugebauer, as well as to B. L. van der Waerden's article on the Great Year and the eternal return,¹⁸⁷ the process of attributing a strictly astrological meaning to the doctrine of the twelve millennia, as it

appears in the Pahlavi texts, may well be of a much later date.¹⁸⁸

Another consequence of the reading ἐξακισχίλια is of particular importance in finding a solution to the problem of Zoroaster's historical date amongst the Greeks. It attests implicitly that the Magi of the 5th century B.C. believed that they were living in the millennium that had been inaugurated by the revelation of the Good Religion, because when they said that Zoroaster's *fravaši* was six millennia earlier, it meant that the physical birth of the prophet had come about in their millennium. This also means that the clash between this and the other Greek dating for Zoroaster — the one that, by making him Pythagoras' teacher, placed him in the 6th century B.C. (see p. 102 ff.) — was felt to be such only by those Greeks who were involuntarily misled over the formation of Zoroaster's spiritual ego and his material birth, perhaps because of the ambiguity of the information they were given (see p. 73 f.). It is certainly plausible that this misunderstanding gained a footing in the Academy for the ideological reason that Jaeger gives, just as it is plausible that Aristoxenus the musician had taken sides against the date for Zoroaster that was in vogue in Academy circles, as Kingsley has perspicaciously pointed out.¹⁸⁹ We shall see this more clearly later on.

The important thing, however, is to have made it clear for the time being that the dates of 6000 years before Xerxes' crossing (or the equivalent one of 5000 years before the fall of Troy) or before Plato's death are paradoxically based on the Magi's conviction that they were living in the very same millennium that had been inaugurated by Zoroaster. They do not tell us much more than this, but at any rate they do not clash with the so-called 'traditional date', which placed the prophet 258 years before Alexander, and they do not allow us to deduce that, according to the Magi, he was immersed in a mythical and legendary antiquity. And it is also legitimate to think that, if a Magus declared in the 5th century B.C. that Zoroaster's *fravaši* had been formed six millennia before, he thought of himself as living at the beginning,

and not at the end, of his millennium — the tenth of the twelve millennia — otherwise he would most likely have spoken of seven millennia and not of six. Therefore we must suppose that he considered Zoroaster to be quite near in time and that he also knew how many years there were between him and Zoroaster. Although this is only a conjecture at the moment (we shall come back to this subject later on), we can agree with the substance of Gershevitch's reasoning in § 44 of the article that we have already mentioned several times: namely, the Zoroastrian Magi may well have known how many years had passed of what we might call the Zoroastrian era (see p. 144). On the contrary, they knew nothing at all about an 'aeonic dating' for the prophet, in spite of what Altheim and Stiehl have written about two datings for Zoroaster, an 'aeonic' one and a 'historical' one.¹⁹⁰ We shall come back to the historical one later on, but as far as the aeonic one is concerned, we can now assert that it is quite arbitrary, because the date of six thousand years could only be a reflection, amongst the Greeks, of a Magian tradition that did not refer to Zoroaster's birth but to the formation of his spiritual ego.

Notes to lecture two

1. Gnoli, *ZTH*, 163; *De Z. à M.*, 41.
2. Gnoli, *ZTH*, p. 92 with n. 6; *De Z. à M.*, 42.
3. Gershevitch, "Approaches", 14-15.
4. Gnoli, *De Z. à M.*, 31-52.

5. See Jackson, "Date of Z.", 4-6 (= *Zoroaster*, 154-57). See also: *FGrHist*, 688 F 1, p. 426; Clemen, *Nachrichten*, 21-23; Bidez and Cumont, *MH* I, pp. 8-10; F.W. König, *Die Persika des Ktesias von Knidos* (Archiv für Orientforschung, 18), Graz, 1972, p. 128 n. 5; Gnoli, *ZTH*, p. 92 n. 6; Boyce, *HZ* III, p. 155 n. 12. For the various explanations of the name 'Οξυάρτης or 'Εξυάρτης see, amongst others: Darmesteter, *ZA* II, p. 584 n. 266; Jackson, loc. cit.; Bartholomae, "Arica X", *IF*, 9, 1898, 252-83, at p. 266 n. 1, who were inclined towards *Uxšyaf.ərata-* as was also Messina, *Magi a Betlemme*, 50. Justi, *NB*, 232-33, related it to the name 'Οξάρτης, as did Hinz, *Altiranisches Sprachgut der Nebenüberlieferungen*, Wiesbaden, 1975, 123, and Mayrhofer, *IPNB* I, 1, p. 102 (*Huxšaθra-*). Marquart, *UGE* II, p. 26 n. 2, proposed **Waxšu-warta* "von Wachšubeschützt", which is probably the best explanation, as Boyce, *HZ* III, p. 155 n. 12, p. 180 n. 18, suggests. Boyce is sceptical about the proposal made by Grenet ("L'Onomastique iranienne à Aï Khanoum", *BCH* 107-I, 1983, 373-81, at p. 378), who sees it as a *dvandva*: *Vaxšu-Rta* or *Vaxšu-Rti*, containing the name of the god Oxus that had already been perceived by Markwart. W. Nagel (*Ninus und Semiramis in Sage und Geschichte. Iranische Staaten und Reiternomaden vor Darius*, Berlin, 1982, 80) suggests reconstructing a form **'Yoxšārτης*, "eine Parallelumschrift zu Κυαξάρτης". Thomas Hyde (*Veterum Persarum et Parthorum et Medorum religionis historia*, 2nd ed., Oxford, 1760, 525) had already pointed out that the name Oxyartes should be restored in the place of Zoroaster.

6. For the relevant testimonies see Jackson, *Zoroaster*, 186-88. On this subject see also Windischmann, *Studien*, 303-305. As we know, the story of Zoroaster and Semiramis is also found in Moses of Chorene: R.W. Thomson, *Moses Khorenats'i, History of the Armenians*, Cambridge, Mass., 1978, 101-102; A. and J.-P. Mahé, *Histoire de l'Arménie par Moïse de Khorène*, Paris, 1993, 134-35.

7. Gnoli, "La religione persiana", in *Storia delle religioni*, ed. G. Castellani, Torino 1971, vol. II, 235-92, at p. 254; "Problems and prospects of the studies on Persian religion", in *Problems and Methods of the History of Religions* (Supplements to Numen, 19), ed. U. Bianchi, C.J. Bleeker and A. Bausani, Leiden, 1972, 67-101, at p. 90; *ZTH*, 163-65; *De Z. à M.*, 41; "Zarathushtra", in *The Encyclopedia of Religion*, ed. M. Eliade, New York, 1987, vol. XV, 556-59, and see, e.g., Boyce, *HZ* II, p. 261.

8. P'yankov, "Zoroastr", 19, for instance, takes for granted such an interpretation of the date of Zoroaster in terms of six millennia before Xerxes or Plato or five millennia before the fall of Troy, on the basis of Jackson (see p. 67 ff.). He does not stop to consider the textual problems in Diogenes Laertius or the various interpretations that scholars have given, whereas particular – and necessary – attention has been paid to these matters here. Eduljee, "Date of Z.", 111-12, on the contrary, does not ignore Jackson's interpretation, but he dismisses it hastily.

9. *FGrHist* 765 F 31 and *32. Cf. Gnoli, "Data di Z.", 180-81.

10. Herter, "Xanthos der Lyder", *RE* IX A, 1967, 1353-74, at cols 1371-72. With regard to Xanthus' testimony on the date of Zoroaster apud Diogenes Laertius, the authenticity of the passage has been questioned more than once (cf. amongst others J. Hertel, *Die Methode der arischen Forschung*, Leipzig, 1926, 43-45), though without any sound arguments. See in particular A. von Gutschmid, *Kleine Schriften*, IV: *Schriften zur griechischen Geschichte und Literatur*, ed. F. Rühl, Leipzig, 1893, 307-15; Clemen, *Nachrichten*, 23; Herter, "Von Xanthos dem Lyder zu Aineias aus Gaza: Tylon und andere Auferweckte", *RhMus*, 108, 1965, 189-212, at p. 204 n. 81.

11. Clemen, *Nachrichten*, 26-27.

12. Boyce, *HZ* II, p. 261.

13. Söderblom, "Ages of the World (Zoroastrian)", in *Encyclopædia of Religion and Ethics*, ed. J. Hastings, Edinburgh, 1908, vol. I, 205-10, at p. 208.

14. Diogenes Laertius I, 8.

15. On the names of the Magi: Windischmann, *Studien*, 286; Marquart, *UGE* II, pp. 211-12; Moulton, *EZ*, 410-11; Messina, *Ursprung*, p. 29 n. 1; Altheim and Stiehl, *GMA*, 32.

16. Altheim and Stiehl, *ib.*

17. Humbach, "Western approach", 4-9; *Gāthās* I, pp. 25-27.

18. Gershevitch, "*mazdāšcā ahurāghō*", in *Studia Grammatica Iranica*, 83-101, at pp. 96-97; "Approaches", 10-12.

19. Jacoby, *FGrHist* III, C, p. 758, in the apparatus: "Ξάνθος – φησι 'parenthese' Gutschmid; eher zusatz des Diogenes als citat Hermodors".

20. Bidez and Cumont, *MH* II, p. 7 and p. 9 n. 5: "Il faut, dans l'extrait de Diogène Laërce, mettre pour ainsi dire entre parenthèses et détacher de la suite du texte la ligne où l'opinion divergente de Xanthos est mentionnée dans une remarque incidente par le consciencieux compilateur".

21. F. Nietzsche, *Beiträge zur Quellenkunde und Kritik des Laertius Diogenes* (*Gratulationsschrift des Paedagogiums zu Basel*), Basel, 1870, § 6 (= Nietzsche, *Werke, Kritische Gesamtausgabe*, by G. Colli and M. Montinari, 2. Abt., 1. Bd., ed. F. Bornmann and M. Carpitella: *Philologische Schriften* (1867-1873), Berlin, 1982, 216-18).

22. Knoepfler, *La vie de Ménédème d'Érétrie de Diogène Laërce. Contribution à l'histoire et à la critique du texte des 'Vies des philosophes'*, Basel, 1991, 21; and cf. Gnoli, "Data di Z.", 182.

23. See, for instance: C.G. Cobet, *Diogenis Laertii de clarorum philosophorum vitis, dogmatibus et apothegmatibus libri decem*, Parisiis, 1850, 1; R.D. Hicks, *Diogenis Laertius, Lives of eminent philosophers*, London - New York, 1925, vol. I, p. 4; H.S. Long, *Diogenis Laertii Vitae philosophorum*, Oxford, 1964, vol. I, p. 1. See also Clemen, *Fontes*, 74; Fox and Pemberton, *Passages*, 80; Bidez and Cumont, *MH* II, p. 8 n. 4; Jacoby, *FGrHist* III, C (765 F *32), p. 758. However, there is no lack of Classical scholars, who like W. Spoerri ("Encore Platon et l'Orient", *Revue de philologie, de littérature et d'histoire anciennes*, 31, 1957, 209-33, at p. 215 and p. 230 n. 93; *Späthellenistische Berichte über Welt, Kultur und Götter*, Basel, 1959, 67-68), have declared themselves in favour of a *lectio* ἐξακόσια. In any case, for a state of the matter see Herter, art. cit. (see n. 10), pp. 203-204 n. 81, with an ample bibliography. In disagreement with Spoerri's position is also O. Gigon, "Das Proemium des Diogenes Laertios: Struktur und Probleme", in *Horizonte der Humanitas. Eine Freundesgabe für Professor Dr. Walter Wili zu seinem 60. Geburtstag*, ed. G. Luck, Bern, 1960, 37-64, at p. 49. We can say that the *lectio* ἐξακισχίλια is now generally accepted by Classical scholars.

24. M. Haug, *Essays on the Sacred Language, Writings and Religion of the Parsis*, London, 1878, 298; C. de Harlez, *Avesta, livre sacré du Zoroastrisme*, 2nd ed., Paris, 1881, p. XXI; Darmesteter, *ZA*, III, p. LXXVI, where the διαδοχή of the Magi is also spoken of. Windischmann, *Studien*, 285, was also inclined towards the 600 years, whereas Moulton, *EZ*, 410, 412, was uncertain. See also Messina, Shahbazi, Humbach (cf. below notes 25, 27, 28, 29).

25. Messina, *Ursprung*, p. 41 n. 1; *Magi a Betlemme*, 52-55.

26. Bidez and Cumont, *MH* II, p. 8 n. 4.

27. Shahbazi, "Date of Z.", p. 35 with n. 75, who revives the old idea of A. Rapp ("Die Religion und Sitte der Perser und übrigen Iranier nach den

griechischen und römischen Quellen”, *ZDMG*, 19, 1865, 1-89, at pp. 22 and 26) that the correct reading is ἑξακόσια, while “6000 Jahre scheinen nur der aristotelischen Nachricht gleich gemacht zu sein”. According to Rapp formerly and to Shahbazi or Humbach now, Xanthus “rechnet von Zoroaster bis auf den Feldzug des Xerxes 600 Jahre, so dass also Zoroaster um 1080 lebte”.

28. Humbach, “Western approach”, 6-7; *Gāthās* I, pp. 24-27.

29. Humbach, *Gāthās* I, p. 26.

30. Jackson, “Date of Z.”, 4 (= *Zoroaster*, 152).

31. A work used by Sotion in his *Διαδοχή*: Jaeger, *Aristotle*, p. 132 n. 4 and p. 134; Bidez and Cumont, *MH* II, p. 8 n. 2. As M. Gigante (*Diogene Laerzio, Vite dei filosofi*, Roma-Bari, 1976, II, p. 457 n. 1) recapitulates, Diogenes Laertius relies on Sotion for the quotations from the pseudo-Aristotelian *Μαγικός* and from Hermodorus, and on Hermippus (see p. 48) for the quotations from Aristotle’s *Περὶ φιλοσοφίας* and Eudoxus’ *Γῆς περίοδος*. As for the problem posed by Diogenes’ Proem with reference to the position of Greek science and philosophy in relation to earlier Oriental learning and speculation, see R. Mondolfo, in E. Zeller and R. Mondolfo, *La filosofia dei Greci nel suo sviluppo storico*, Firenze, 1951, Part I, vol. 1, 3rd ed., pp. 73-74.

32. Cf. Jaeger, *Aristotle*, p. 136 n. 2. Jaeger first pointed out that the reference to Plato’s death could not be found in Eudoxus, as he was believed to have died before Plato, and that the attempt to shift the time of Eudoxus’ death on the grounds of this passage from Pliny should be rejected. This idea had been expressed by F. Gisinger, *Die Erdbeschreibung des Eudoxos von Knidos* (Στοιχεία, Heft VI), Leipzig-Berlin, 1921, p. 5 n. 1. On this argument – and on Jaeger’s reasoning – see also Reitzenstein, *Studien*, 4; Bidez and Cumont, *MH* II, p. 11 n. 5; Untersteiner, *AF*, 89; Momigliano, *Alien Wisdom*, 143. See, though, F. Lasserre, *Die Fragmente des Eudoxos von Knidos*, Berlin, 1966, 137-39, 254-55, and most recently Kingsley, “Meetings”, p. 183 n. 64, pp. 195-96, and below, p. 192 n. 22.

33. For Pliny’s testimony see Jaeger, *Aristotle*, 135-36, who explains that it comes from Hermippus; Reitzenstein, *Studien*, 3; Messina, *Ursprung*, 26-30; Bidez and Cumont, *MH* I, p. 11 n. 2; Untersteiner, *AF*, 86-90.

34. The point of reference for this calculation is actually Agonaces or Azonaces (on this name: Reitzenstein, *Studien*, p. 3 n. 1; Messina, *Ursprung*, 39; Bidez and Cumont, *MH* II, p. 12 n. 6), Zoroaster’s teacher. As well as Jaeger, *Aristotle*, 131-36, and Bidez and Cumont, *MH* I, 85-88, see Windischmann, *Studien*, 288-93; Clemen, *Nachrichten*, 51-53; Messina, *Ursprung*, 30-33.

35. Bidez and Cumont, *MH* II, p. 72 n. 1. For the evidence in Plutarch see also Moulton, *EZ*, 399-407; Benveniste, *PR*, 69-117.

36. Bidez and Cumont, *MH* II, pp. 23-24 with n. 1.

37. See now Daffinà, "Senso del tempo", 16.

38. On the chronology of Thucydides see W.K. Pritchett, "Thucydides' statement on his cronology", *ZPE*, 62, 1986, 205-11, and also the remarks made by Mazzarino, *PSC* II, 2, p. 427.

39. Bidez and Cumont, *MH* II, p. 8 n. 4.

40. See above n. 23.

41. Biruni, *Ālār*, 35; transl. Sachau, *Chronology*, 40-41.

42. Shahbazi, "Date of Z.", 34. This statement refers to a controversial problem which is still open: cf. Gnoli, "More on the Khwarezmian hypothesis", in *Corolla Iranica. Papers in honour of Prof. Dr. D.N. MacKenzie on the occasion of his 65th birthday on April 8th, 1991*, ed. R.E. Emmerick and D. Weber, Frankfurt am Main, 1991, 74-78, and more recently P'yankov, "Zoroastr", 5.

43. Humbach, "Western approach", 6-7; *Gāthās* I, p. 27 n. 4.

44. Gnoli, *ZTH*, 162, 164.

45. Humbach, *Gāthās* I, p. 26.

46. Bidez and Cumont, *MH* II, pp. 7-8 with nn. 1 and 4. See also Long, o.c. (see n. 23), I, p. 1, in the apparatus: "ἐξακισχ.] ἐξακόσια dett.". As for Humbach's remark, it seems less correct than the one he made to me seven years earlier: Humbach, "Western approach", 7.

47. Humbach, loc. cit. in n. 45.

48. Humbach, "Western approach", 7: "the reading Hexakiskhilia '6000' of the Parisinus is the lectio faciliior as it is very similar to the preceding Pentakiskhilia '5000'".

49. A. Berriedale Keith, "The date of Zoroaster and the R̥gveda", *The Indian Historical Quarterly*, 1, 1925, 3-17, at p. 8.

50. Gnoli, *EW*, 42, p. 520 (see p. 36 n. 11).

51. Bidez and Cumont, loc. cit. in n. 39.

52. I am grateful to my colleague Prof. Albio C. Cassio of the University of Rome "La Sapienza", who kindly pointed out to me the incorrectness of this argument.

53. Nock, "The problem of Zoroaster", *AJA*, 53, 1949, 272-85, at p. 276 (= *Essays*, II, p. 688).

54. Jackson, "Date of Z.", 4 (= *Zoroaster*, 154); Clemen, *Fontes*, 109; Bidez and Cumont, *MH* II, p. 140.

55. Gershevitch, "Approaches", 10.

56. This is explained by the 77 years that are traditionally attributed to Zoroaster (see p. 156).

57. Gershevitch, "Approaches", 11.
58. Gnoli, *EW*, 42, p. 526 (see p. 36 n. 11).
59. Gershevitch, "Approaches", 11-12.
60. *Ib.*, p. 10.
61. Gershevitch, *ib.*, p. 15 (and see below, p. 157) proposes taking 588 B.C. (330 + 258 as the thirtieth year of Zoroaster's life) so that he would have been born in 618 B.C., while 541/0 B.C. (618-77) would have been the year of his death.
62. Jaeger, *Aristotle*, 133.
63. Gershevitch, "Approaches", 10.
64. *Ib.*, p. 11.
65. Kingsley, "Meetings", p. 183 n. 64.
66. Gershevitch, *art. cit.* (see n. 18), pp. 97-98.
67. Gershevitch, "Approaches", 10.
68. Bidez and Cumont, *MH* I, p. 7.
69. Cumont, "Fin du monde", 58.
70. Reitzenstein, *Studien*, p. 5 n. 1.
71. Altheim and Stiehl, *GMA*, 31, 37.
72. On this see, amongst others, M.A. Dandamaev, *Politicheskaya istoriya Akhemenidskoï derzhavy*, Moskva, 1985, 170 (= *A Political History of the Achaemenid Empire*, English transl. by W.J. Vogelsang, Leiden - New York - København - Köln, 1989, 225-26); P. Briant, *Histoire de l'Empire perse. De Cyrus à Alexandre*, Paris, 1996, 558-89.
73. On Dionysius of Miletus: E. Schwartz, "Dionysius von Milet", *RE* V, 1, 1903, 933-34; Pearson, *EIH*, 110, 137; J.B. Bury, *The Ancient Greek Historians*, 2nd ed., New York, 1958, 22-24, 67-68; K. von Fritz, *Die griechische Geschichtsschreibung*, I: *Von den Anfängen bis Thukydides*, Berlin, 1967, 102-103; M. Moggi, "Autori greci di Persikà, I: Dionisio di Mileto", *ASNP*, s. III, 2.2, 1972, 433-68, with an ample bibliography at p. 435 n. 1. On Charon of Lampsacus: Jacoby, "Charon von Lampsakos", *Studi italiani di Filologia Classica*, n.s. 15, 1938, 207-42 (= *Abhandlungen zur griechischen Geschichtsschreibung*, ed. H. Bloch, Leiden, 1956, 178-206); Pearson, *o.c.*, pp. 139-51; L. Piccirilli, "Carone di Lampsaco ed Erodoto", *ASNP*, s. III, 5, 1975, 1239-54; Moggi, "Autori greci di Persikà, II: Carone di Lampsaco", *ASNP*, s. III, 7.1, 1977, 1-26.
74. S. Mekler, *Academicorum philosophorum Index Herculanensis*, Berlin, 1902, 13; U. von Wilamowitz-Moellendorf, *Platon*, I, 2nd ed., Berlin, 1919, 709. In addition to Untersteiner, *AF*, 82, and the bibliographical references given there, see now: K. Gaiser, *Philodems Academica. Die Berichte über Platon und die Alte Akademie in zwei herkulanensischen Papyri* (Supplementum Platonicum, Bd. 1), Stuttgart - Bad Canstatt, 1988, 176-80;

Dörrie, *Platonismus*, 478-79; T. Dorandi, *Filodemo, Storia dei filosofi. Platone e l'Accademia*, Napoli, 1991, 37-38, 133-34, 187, 219-22; W. Burkert, *Platon in Nahaufnahme. Ein Buch aus Herculanum*, Stuttgart – Leipzig, 1993, 34-35; Kingsley, “Meetings”, p. 199 with n. 167. In this recent article Kingsley deals with the whole subject of the encounter with the Magi and the close connection between Magi and Chaldaeans in Greek culture. He comes to conclusions that I largely agree with on the main points (except, of course, for his theory about Zoroaster’s dating: see Kingsley, *ib.*, p. 182 etc.).

75. Jaeger, *Aristotle*, 132; Nyberg, *RAI*, 27.

76. Kingsley, “Meetings”, 196.

77. Herter, art. cit. (see n. 10: *RE IX A*), col. 1372.

78. Kingsley, loc. cit. in n. 76.

79. *Prolégomènes à la philosophie de Platon*, ed. G.L. Westerink and transl. J. Trouillard, Paris 1990, p. 10 with n. 78, and p. 57.

80. P. Boyancé, *Le culte des Muses chez les philosophes grecs*, 2nd ed., Paris, 1972, p. 225 n. 3; Dörrie, loc. cit. in n. 74.

81. A.-J. Festugière, *La révélation d'Hermès Trismégiste, I: L'astrologie et les sciences occultes*, 2nd ed., Paris, 1950, 19-44; Momigliano, *Alien Wisdom*.

82. According to Diogenes Laertius I, 8. Cf. Bidez and Cumont, *MH II*, p. 67, and I, p. 6 n. 5.

83. Isnardi Parente, *Supplementum Academicum (MANL IX. VI, 2)*, Roma, 1995, 249-309, at pp. 272-73. The testimony on Zaratas by Aristoxenus (see p. 102) is not, then, the first evidence of this confusion, as Momigliano, *Alien Wisdom*, 143, would have it: Kingsley, “Meetings”, 201.

84. Diogenes Laertius III, 25: E. Mensching, *Favorin von Arelate*, Berlin, 1963, 71-73. See Gaiser, o.c. (see n. 74), pp. 367-77, 435-36; Dörrie, loc. cit. in n. 74; Kingsley, “Meetings”, 197-98.

85. Gaiser, *ib.*, pp. 434-35.

86. Jaeger, *Aristotle*, 133.

87. *ib.*, p. 134 n. 1.

88. *ib.*, p. 134.

89. *ib.*, pp. 134-35.

90. Cumont, “Fin du monde”, 58; Nyberg, “Questions de cosmogonie et de cosmologie mazdéennes”, *JA*, 219, 1931, 1-134, at pp. 18-19; Reitzenstein, *Studien*, 3-5.

91. Benveniste, *PR*, 15-16.

92. Nyberg, *RAI*, 27.

93. Jaeger, *Aristotle*, p. 136 n. 2, but see above n. 32 as well.

94. See, amongst others, E. Meyer, *Ursprung und Anfänge des Christentums*, Stuttgart – Berlin, 1923, III, p. 651; Reitzenstein, *Studien*, 3-6; Messina,

Ursprung, 40; Nyberg, art. cit. (see n. 90), 104-105; E. Bignone, *L'Aristotele perduto e la formazione filosofica di Epicuro*, Firenze, 1936, II, pp. 84-85, 341-42; Bidez and Cumont, *MH* I, pp. 13-14; Bidez, *Éos ou Platon et l'Orient*, Bruxelles, 1945, 35-37; Herzfeld, *Zoroaster*, 22; S. Pétrement, *Le dualisme chez Platon, les gnostiques et les manichéens*, Paris, 1947, 19-21; Untersteiner, *AF*, 86-89; Boyce, *HZ* II, pp. 260-61. But see also J. Kerschens- steiner, *Platon und der Orient*, Stuttgart, 1945; and Spoerri, art. cit. in n. 23, with other bibliographical references, as well as O.G. von Wesendonk, *Platon und der Orient*, Berlin, 1926, 10-11; *Das Weltbild der Iranier*, München, 1933, 161, 170-72. For a state of the matter: Duchesne-Guillem- in, *Western Response*, 70-72.

95. Benveniste, *PR*, 16-21.

96. Nyberg, *RAI*, 27, 30-31.

97. Boyce, loc. cit. in n. 94.

98. In particular in chapter VB of the *Bundahišn*, translated and anno- tated by MacKenzie, "Zoroastrian astrology in the *Bundahišn*", *BSOAS*, 27, 1964, 511-29 especially pp. 520-21. In general on astrology in Sassanian Iran see C.J. Brunner, "Astrology and astronomy in Iran, ii: Astronomy and astrology in the Sasanian period", *Elr*, II, 1987, 862-68. On the origin of the 12000 year cycle see A. Panaino, "La diffusione dell'astronomia e dell'astro- logia mesopotamica in India attraverso la mediazione iranica", in *L'astrologia e la sua influenza nella filosofia, nella letteratura e nell'arte dall'età classica al Rinascimento*, Milano, 1992, 9-50, at p. 26; *Tessere il cielo. Considerazioni sulle tavole astronomiche, gli oroscopi e la dottrina dei legamenti tra Induismo, Zoroastrismo, Manicheismo e Mandeismo* (SOR 79), Roma, 1998, 163-65 (I am very grateful to Prof. Panaino for his willingness to discuss this matter with me on several occasions).

99. Jaeger, *Aristotle*, p. 134 with n. 2.

100. Benveniste, *PR*, p. 20 with n. 3, and p. 21.

101. Reitzenstein, *Studien*, 4-5. Kingsley, "Meetings", p. 193 n. 128, notes, in this connection, that "Reitzenstein's attempted analysis of the material [...] is so devious – and assumes such a fundamental misunder- standing on the part of Xanthus – that it ultimately explains nothing". See also Spoerri, art. cit. (see in n. 23), p. 229 n. 87 on the subject.

102. Nock, *JHS*, 49, 1929, 111-16 (review of Reitzenstein, *Studien*), at pp. 111-12 (= *Essays* I, pp. 195-201, at pp. 195-96), though he admits that: "At the same time, it is quite thinkable that Plato was in his later years influenced by Iranian thought, and the impulse which Jaeger and Reitzenstein have given to study in this direction deserves to be followed up".

103. Cumont, loc. cit. in n. 90.

104. Bidez and Cumont, *MH* I, p. 7; Bidez, loc. cit. in n. 94, and cf. Pétrement, loc. cit. (ib.).

105. Nyberg, art. cit. (see n. 90), p. 105.

106. Nyberg, *RAI*, 27-30.

107. This theory met with agreement of Zaehner, *Zurvan*, 96-100, or M. Eliade (*Le mythe de l'éternel retour. Archétypes et répétition*, new ed., Paris, 1969, 147-48). Molé ("Le problème zurvanite", *JA*, 247, 1959, 431-69, at pp. 445-8; cf. Gnoli, "Osservazioni sulla dottrina mazdaica della creazione", *AIUON*, n.s. 13, 1963, 163-93, at pp. 178-79) went still further, maintaining that the 12000 year cycle was as much 'Zurvanite' as 'orthodox'. Herzfeld, *Zoroaster*, 1-7, and A. Hultgård ("Mythe et histoire dans l'Iran ancien: cosmogonie et l'histoire du monde", in *Recurrent Patterns in Iranian Religions. From Mazdaism to Sufism* [*StIr* Cahier 11], Paris 1992, 27-56, at pp. 49-50) consider the 9000 year cycle as the original one. On the cosmic period see also H. Junker, *Über iranische Quellen der hellenistischen Aion-Vorstellung* (Vorträge der Bibliothek Warburg 1921-1922), Leipzig, 1923.

108. Benveniste, *PR*, 106-11.

109. Untersteiner, *AF*, 89.

110. Boyce, *HZ* II, pp. 259-60; Kingsley, "Meetings", 191; Gershevitch, "Approaches", 10.

111. Gutschmid, o.c. (see n. 10), p. 315.

112. Nock, loc. cit. in n. 102; Spierri, art. cit. (see n. 23), pp. 219 and 233 n. 148.

113. Herzfeld, *Zoroaster*, 3.

114. *Ib.*, p. 22: "The date known to Plato's Academy, 'Zoroaster 6,000 years before Plato', shows that already about 400 B.C. Zoroaster had his place as inaugurator of the 4th millennium in that system, and that his return was expected after 6,000 years".

115. Kingsley, "Meetings", 191.

116. *FGrHist* 765 F 12; Pearson, *EIH*, pp. 116-17, 123 with n. 1. Cf. Kingsley, "Meetings", p. 190 n. 114 and p. 191.

117. *Ib.*, p. 194 and p. 193.

118. *Ib.*, p. 192.

119. Boyce, *HZ* I, p. 286; *Zoroastrians*, 74-75. Cf. Kingsley, "Meetings", p. 192 n. 123.

120. Russell, *Zoroastrianism in Armenia*, Cambridge, Mass., 1987, 167-69, 184 n. 96.

121. Boyce, *HZ* I, p. 286 with n. 38.

122. Kingsley, "Meetings", 192, who substantially draws somewhat extreme conclusions from the word **mazdēac'i* in Armenian, attested as a *hapax legomenon* in the abl. plur. (*mazdēac'woc'*) in a manuscript contain-

ing a “preamble tracing the transmission of the *Vec’ Hazareak*”. See Russell, o. c. (see n. 120), p. 169.

123. Corbin, *Cyclical Time and Ismaili Gnosis*, London, 1983, 191 (= *Temps cyclique et gnose ismaélienne*, Paris, 1982, 206); Burn, *Persia and the Greeks. The defence of the West 546-478 B.C.*, 2nd ed., London, 1984, 69. Cf. Kingsley, “Meetings”, p. 192 n. 127. According to Burn, loc. cit., who refers to Clemen, *Fontes*, 41 ff., 74 f., we must prefer *ἐξ᾽ ἀκόσια* in the testimony of Xanthus.

124. Cumont, “Fin du monde”; Bidez and Cumont, *MH* I, pp. 218-20; II, pp. 365-66.

125. Kingsley, “Meetings”, 193.

126. Eddy, *The King is Dead. Studies in the Near Eastern resistance to Hellenism*, Lincoln, Nebraska, 1961, 30-32; Boyce, “On the antiquity of Zoroastrian apocalyptic”, *BSOAS*, 47, 1984, 57-75, at p. 59.

127. Strouvé, “The religion of the Achaemenids and Zoroastrianism”, *Cahiers d'histoire mondiale*, 5, 1960, 529-45, at p. 529. Cf. Dandamaev, *Persien unter den ersten Achämeniden (6. Jahrhundert v. Chr.)*, transl. from the Russian by H.-D. Pohl, Wiesbaden, 1976, 229. Humbach, “Western approach”, 9, comes to a similar conclusion, though he maintains, unlike Struve, that the date in Xanthus was ‘600 years before Xerxes’ crossing’. Against Struve’s idea see Eduljee, “Date of Z.”, 113-14.

128. Momigliano, *Alien Wisdom*, 146-47, 169; “The fault of the Greeks”, in *Essays*, 9-23, at pp. 18-19; and see Kingsley, “Meetings”, 207.

129. Gershevitch, “Approaches”, 10.

130. Jaeger, *Aristotle*, 132.

131. Bidez and Cumont, *MH* I, p. 102. But on the interpretation of the passage of book XIV of Aristotle’s *Metaphysics* (N 4, 1091b, 8 ff.) and the problem of Oriental influence in the Platonic dualism of the *Laws* see the state of the matter in Isnardi Parente, in E. Zeller and R. Mondolfo, o. c. in n. 31, Firenze, 1974, Part II, vol. 3/2, 1st. ed., pp. 846-54, though with an inclination that is substantially to opposite of Jaeger’s.

132. Jackson, “Date of Z.”, p. 3 n. 2 (= *Zoroaster*, 152) quoted *Bundahišn* 34 (= XXXVI: cf. MacKenzie, “Bundahišn”, *EIr*. IV, 1990, 547-51), with reference to the translation by E.W. West in *SBE* 5, o. c. (see p. 37 n. 19), 149-51. See also Windischmann, *Studien*, 147-65; Spiegel, *Erânische Alterthumskunde*, I: *Geographie, Ethnographie, älteste Geschichte*, Leipzig, 1871, 500-508; and chapter 47 of Plutarch’s *De Iside et Osiride*.

133. Jackson, “Date of Z.”, 3 (= *Zoroaster*, 152); “Zoroaster”, in *Harper’s Dictionary of Classical Literature and Antiquities*, New York, 1897, II, pp. 1685-87. Jackson was thinking mainly of the ancient Academy. According to him the reading 6000 for Xanthus was evidently dubious (cf. Jackson,

Zoroaster, pp. 9 and 154, and also E.W. West in SBE 47, o. c. [see p. 37 n. 19], p. xl). It is not surprising, then, that J. Ries, in a course of lectures on the history of the religions of the ancient East, declared himself in favour of Jackson's explanation for the 6000 years, although he himself reads 600 years in Xanthus' testimony: *La religion de Zarathustra et le mazdéisme depuis les origines jusqu'à l'avènement des Achéménides*, Louvain-la-Neuve, 1983, 44.

134. Molé, *Légende*, 16 and 17 (Pahlavi text and translation).

135. Cf. *Bundahišn* XXXIII, 12 (*GBd.* – TDA, p. 214. 1-2; *GBd.* – BTA, p. 275). Eduljee, "Date of Z.", 111-12, is mistaken when he states that "An earlier chapter of the Iranian Bundahishn compresses the whole of time into six millennia only, in which Zoroaster appears at the beginning of the fourth millennium": it is not a matter of 'the whole of time' but of the time of the 'mixed state' (*gumēzišn*). On the 12000 year cycle see above the notes 98 and 107.

136. Cf. E.W. West, "Pahlavi literature", in *GIrPh* II, 75-129, at pp. 89-90; J.C. Tavadia, *Die mittelpersische Sprache und Literatur der Zarathustrier*, Leipzig, 1956, 114-15; Molé, *Légende*, 8*-9*; Boyce, "Middle Persian literature", in *Iranistik-Literatur* (o. c.: see p. 37 n. 16), p. 46 n. 4; Cereti, "Studi preliminari sull'ottavo libro del *Dēnkard*", *RANL*, IX. VIII, 1, 1997, 95-117, at p. 97 n. 23.

137. Molé, *Légende*, 122 and 123 (Pahlavi text and translation).

138. See, amongst others: Söderblom, "Les Fravashis: Étude sur les traces dans le mazdéisme d'une ancienne conception sur la survivance des morts", *RHR*, 39, 1899, 229-60 and 373-418; Moulton, *EZ*, 254-85; Wesendonk, *Urmensch und Seele in der iranischen Überlieferung. Ein Beitrag zur Religionsgeschichte des Hellenismus*, Hannover, 1924, 191-202; L.H. Gray, *The Foundations of the Iranian Religions* (*JCOI*, 15), Bombay, 1929, 75-79; Lommel, *RZ*, 159-63; Nyberg, *RAI*, 62-64; Bailey, *ZP*, 107-109; Herzfeld, *Zoroaster*, 495-515; K. Barr, "Irans profet som τέλειος ἄνθρωπος", in *Festskrift til L.L. Hammerich*, København, 1952, 25-36; Dumézil, "Vīšnu et les Marūt à travers la réforme zoroastrienne", *JA*, 241, 1953, 1-25; Duchesne-Guillemin, "L'homme dans la religion iranienne", in *Anthropologie religieuse. L'homme et sa destinée à la lumière de l'histoire des religions* (Supplements to *Numen*, 2), Leiden, 1955, 93-107, at pp. 96-97; Widengren, *RI*, 21-23; W.W. Malandra, *The 'Fravaši Yašt'. Introduction, text, translation and commentary*, Diss., Ann Arbor, Michigan, 1971, 8-65; Boyce, *HZ* I, pp. 117-29; Gnoli, "Le fravaši e l'immortalità", in *La mort, les morts dans les sociétés anciennes*, ed. G. Gnoli and J.-P. Vernant, Cambridge – Paris, 1982, 339-47; Kellens, "Les Fravaši" (art. cit.: p. 36 n. 8).

139. See the chronological table, based on the Religion (B.R. = 'before the religion'; A.R. = *anno religionis*), which E.W. West in SBE 47, o. c. (see p. 37 n. 19), gives on pp. xxviii-xxxi.

140. *Ib.*, pp. xl-xli.

141. See above n. 138, and Molé, *CMC*, 284-91.

142. Moulton, *EZ*, 270.

143. Boyce, *HZ* I, pp. 118 and 125.

144. On this passage: K. Geldner, *Über die Metrik des jüngeren Avesta nebst Übersetzung ausgewählter Abschnitte*, Tübingen, 1877, 100; Darmesteter, *ZA* II, p. 529; F. Wolff, *Avesta. Die heiligen Bücher der Parsen übersetzt auf der Grundlage von Chr. Bartholomae's Altiranischem Wörterbuch*, Strassburg, 1910, 243; Lommel, *Die Yäšt's des Avesta übersetzt und eingeleitet*, Göttingen – Leipzig, 1927, 94; Gershevitch, *AHM*, 27; Malandra, o. c. (see n. 138), pp. 87 and 131.

145. Kotwal and Boyd, *A Persian Offering. The Yasna: A Zoroastrian High Liturgy* (*Stlr Cahier* 8), Paris, 1991, pp. 88, 94 n. 89, 95, 98.

146. *Y.* 37, 3: Narten, o. c. (see p. 36 n. 13), pp. 42 and 180-81; Kellens and Pirart, *TVA* I, p. 136; II, p. 269; III, p. 141; Humbach, *Gāthās* I, p. 146.

147. Cf. Boyce, "Iranian festivals", in *CHIr.* III, 1983, 792-815, at pp. 806-11.

148. For the meaning of 'Zarathuštricism' see Gershevitch, "Zoroaster's own contribution", *JNES*, 23, 1964, 12-38, at p. 12.

149. Gnoli, "Ašavan. Contributo allo studio del libro di Ardā Wirāz", in *Iranica*, ed. G. Gnoli and A.V. Rossi (Istituto Universitario Orientale – Seminario di Studi Asiatici, *Series Minor*, 10), Napoli, 1979, 387-452, at pp. 397-98, with n. 53 for the bibliographical references as well; in addition see also Gnoli, "Antico-persiano *anušya-* e gli Immortali di Erodoto", in *Monumentum Georg Morgenstierne*, I (*ActIr* 21), Leiden, 266-80; "Ašavan", *Elr.* II, 1987, 705-706.

150. Herzfeld, *Zoroaster*, 515.

151. Boyce, *HZ* II, p. 166.

152. Strabo I, 3, 4 = *FGrHist* 765 F 12. On Xanthus see Pearson, *EIH*, 109-38; P. Tozzi, "Xanto di Lidia", *Rendiconti dell'Istituto Lombardo*, 99, 1965, 157-84; Herter, art. cit. (see n. 10: *RE* IX A); Momigliano, *The Development of Greek Biography*, Cambridge, Mass., 1971, 30-32, 33, 38, 44; and now Kingsley, "Meetings", with bibliographical references that bring Herter's up to date.

153. Dionysius of Halicarnassus, *Roman Antiquities* I, 28, 2 = *FGrHist* 765 F 16.

154. Herter, art. cit., col. 1354.

155. Athenaeus XII, 11 = *FGrHist* 70 F 180 = 765 T 5.

156. Jacoby, *FGrHist* III C, p. 750.13.
157. Kingsley, "Meetings", 176.
158. Cumont, *Textes et monuments figurés relatifs aux mystères de Mithra*, Bruxelles, 1899, I, p. 22.
159. Gutschmid, o. c. (see n. 10), p. 315; Clemen, *Nachrichten*, 23; Nock, art. cit. (see n. 53), p. 277; Kingsley, "Meetings", 183.
160. *FGrHist* 765 F 31.
161. *FGrHist* 765 F 33.
162. Kingsley, o. c. (see p. 11 n. 6), p. 227 with n. 36; "Meetings", 185-87.
163. Mazzarino, *PSC* I, pp. 209-10.
164. Jaeger, *Aristotle*, 134.
165. Duchesne-Guillemin, *OA*, 8-9, and *RIA*, 135.
166. For Theopompus see also the testimony of Aeneas of Gaza: Bidez and Cumont, *MH* II, pp. 70, 256 n. 1.
167. Kellens, "Saošiiant", *StIr*, 3, 1974, 187-209, and also Boyce, *HZ* II, pp. 242-43.
168. Cf. Nyberg, "Questions de cosmogonie et de cosmologie mazdéennes", *JA*, 214, 1929, 193-310, at pp. 236 and 237; Zaehner, *Zurvan*, 324 and 336.
169. See above n. 133.
170. M.L. West, *Early Greek Philosophy and the Orient*, Oxford, 1971, 32-33.
171. Söderblom, art. cit. (see n. 13), p. 208.
172. Clemen, *Nachrichten*, 26.
173. Clemen's 'runde Zahl' (just like the stock or conventional numbers of Eduljee, "Date of Z.", 116) is evidently an expedient rather than a real argument.
174. An excellent study has been devoted to this subject by M.L. West, o. c. (see n. 170), 165-202. See also Duchesne-Guillemin, "Heraclitus and Iran", *HR*, 3, 1963, 34-49; Boyce, *HZ* II, pp. 158-61; M. Papatheophanes, "Heraclitus of Ephesus, the Magi, and the Achaemenids", *IrAnt*, 20, 1985, 101-61.
175. P'yankov, "Zoroastr", 19. P'yankov's article, which has been known to me for only a short time (it appeared in the July - August - September issue of *VDI* 1996), calls for still further study.
176. See above p. 48.
177. Humbach, "Western approach", 5.
178. Humbach, *Gāthās* I, p. 25.
179. Gershevitch, "Approaches", 11.
180. *Ib.*, p. 10.

181. See above pp. 47 ff., and Gnoli, "Data di Z.", p. 193 n. 86, where reference is also made to F. Creuzer, C. Müller, F.G. Welker and A. Rapp.

182. Clemen, *Nachrichten*, 27.

183. On the world-year, in studies that approach the subject from the viewpoint of the history of science, see E.S. Kennedy and B.L. van der Waerden, "The World-Year of the Persians", *JAOS*, 83, 1963, 315-27; D. Pingree, "Astronomy and astrology in India and Iran", *Isis*, 54, 1963, 229-46; Kennedy, "Ramifications of the world-year concept in Islamic astrology", in *Proceedings of the Tenth International Congress of the History of Sciences (Ithaca 26/VIII - 2/IX 1962)*, Paris, 1964, 23-43; Pingree, *The Thousands of Abū Ma'shar* (Studies of the Warburg Institute, 30), London, 1968; Kennedy and Pingree, *The Astrological History of Māshā'allāh*, Cambridge, Mass., 1971; Brunner, art. cit. (see n. 98), p. 864, as well as the works by Panaino cited in the same note.

184. Boyce, *HZ* II, p. 261 with n. 198, where she maintains, with a bit of exaggeration and citing only Clemen as an example, that the attribution to Xanthus of the passage about the 6000 years before Xerxes' invasion "has been generally regarded with suspicion".

185. Eduljee, "Date of Z.", 115-16, and see above n. 173.

186. W. Hartner, "The Young Avestan and Babylonian calendars and the antecedents of precession", *Journal of the History of Astronomy*, 10, 1979, 1-22; "Old Iranian calendars", *CHIr.* II, 1985, 714-92; Panaino, "Calendars (Pre-Islamic calendars)", *Elr.* IV, 1990, 658-68, at pp. 659, 662; art. cit. (see n. 98), pp. 26-28. See also B.I. Marshak, "The historico-cultural significance of the Sogdian calendar", *Iran*, 30, 1992, 145-54, who proposes, as the conclusion of a complex and problematical study, the theory that "the year was lengthened by five days at the time of the Achaemenians in the first half of the fifth century before our era" and that "It is most likely that the 'Pīshdādī' calendar was introduced not less than 240 years before the Achaemenian reform" (p. 151). Although it is not possible for me to go into this matter here, I feel I must express my scepticism about this proposal. Lastly, it should be noted that F. de Blois, "The Persian calendar", *Iran*, 34, 1996, 39-54, in spite of his criticism of various earlier reconstructions, places the Zoroastrian calendar without intercalations in the Achaemenian period, which is a reappraisal of Boyce's theory (art. cit.: see p. 37 n. 33), according to which "no intercalations were carried out during the Sasanian period" (de Blois, *ib.*, p. 51 n. 6).

187. Neugebauer, *The Exact Sciences in Antiquity*, 2nd ed., Providence, 1957, 103; van der Waerden, "Das Grosse Jahr und die ewige Wiederkehr", *Hermes*, 80, 1952, 129-55. Cf. Boyce, *HZ* II, p. 234 with nn. 109-10.

188. For an in-depth treatment of this subject, see Panaino, *Tessere il cielo* (o. c.: see n. 98), where a chapter (pp. 161-79) is devoted to the Great world-year, with a distinction between the 'nuda struttura del ciclo', which could even go back as far as the 5th century B.C., and the doctrines of the zodiacal chronocratories, on which the single millennia of the 12000 year cycle were made to depend.

189. Kingsley, "Greek origin", 262.

190. Altheim and Stiehl, *SA*, 44; *GMA*, 29-33.

★ LECTURE THREE ★

*Zoroaster – Pythagoras
and Zoroaster – Ezekiel*

THE MISUNDERSTANDING OVER ZOROASTER'S DATE in terms of millennia seems to have been a common and recurrent one, from the Ionian logographers — as we can call Xanthus together with Lionel Pearson, although he was Lydian¹ — to the early Academy. Even Aristotle was, in a sense, a victim to it, together with Eudoxus of Cnidus, according to Pliny's report (see p. 48). It is true that, in speaking about dualism — in spite of Spoerri's opinion on the matter² — as a doctrine that identifies the beginning of the generation as the supreme good (which, by the way, is typical of the whole Zoroastrian tradition, from the Gāthās to Pahlavi literature),³ Aristotle in book XIV of the *Metaphysics*, that is, according to Jaeger, in one of the oldest parts of that work,⁴ juxtaposed the Magi to Pherecydes as well as to Empedocles and Anaxagoras, therefore to Greek philosophers of the 6th and 5th centuries. But it is also true that this juxtaposition has no visible meaning in terms of absolute or relative chronology. On the other hand Aristotle, in complete harmony with Pliny's aforementioned testimony, stated in book I of *On Philosophy* that the Magi were older than the Egyptians, as Diogenes Laertius attests in his Proem (I, 8).⁵ We do not know whether Aristotle kept to this same opinion about the time of Zoroaster and the origin of the Magi, but we do know

that not all the Greeks were victims of that misunderstanding. Apart from those who made yet another mistake through mixing up the names Zoroastres and Oxyartes (see p. 43 f.), there were also the ones who linked Pythagoras to Zoroaster, as disciple and teacher. It is interesting to note that it was in the Peripatos, and not in the Academy, that this link was made, due to the assertions of Aristoxenus of Tarentum, known as 'the musician', whose position in the Peripatetic school was nevertheless a strictly personal one and distinctly marked by his past as a Pythagorean. Besides Fritz Wehrli's work,⁶ we can also benefit from reading about him in the pages that Momigliano devoted to the first Peripatetic biographer, the author of biographies of Pythagoras, Archytas, Socrates and Plato, in *The Development of Greek Biography*,⁷ and also, with specific reference to our subject, the aforementioned article by Kingsley, published in 1990.⁸

Now this is very important for us because Aristoxenus, as Kingsley reminds us in 1990, "did the greatest part of his writing in the 320s and the following two decades",⁹ that is to say, after Alexander's conquest of the Persian empire. Aristoxenus was one of the authors who wrote after Alexander's extraordinary exploit had opened up to the Greeks a far greater knowledge of the East than they had had hitherto, therefore even greater than the Academy had had in earlier times. After 300 B.C. streams of information flowed towards Greece, not only from Babylonia, as Kingsley points out,¹⁰ but also from Persia and other regions of the vast Persian dominions. If Dinon and Hermodorus, according to a passage in Diogenes Laertius (I, 8) that has now been further studied by Margherita Isnardi Parente,¹¹ etymologized the name Ζωροάστρης as meaning ἀστροθύτης, with an obvious reference to the Babylonian cult of the stars, the distinction between Magi and Chaldaeans, which has been the subject of some enlightening pages by Bidez and Cumont,¹² must already have been extremely slight to the Greeks in the first half of the 4th century, as Kingsley has most aptly stressed.¹³ On this point Kingsley¹⁴ has rightly criticized Momigliano, who thought that Aristoxenus was the earliest

surviving evidence for the confusion of Chaldaeans and Magi.¹⁵ There can be no doubt, then, that towards the end of that century the figure of the founder of the Magian school and expert in Chaldaean sciences gained new aspects and new meanings, even though Magi and Chaldaeans were not always confused. Messina, who mentions attestations covering an enormous time-span, from Dinon apud Diogenes Laertius (I, 8) to Dio Chrysostomus (*Oratio* XXXVI, 40) and Porphyry (*De abstinentia* IV, 4, 16), exaggerates in his reconstruction of an initial distinction between the Magi, as followers of Zoroaster who were devoted solely to the divine cult, and the Chaldaeans, as astrologers, sorcerers, magicians and soothsayers;¹⁶ a distinction which was to diminish with the passing of time until it faded away almost completely. This sort of simplification, which was substantially agreed with by Molé,¹⁷ does not do justice to the complex nature of the problem: it is not such a simple matter as this. Elias J. Bickerman and Hayim Tadmor are not altogether without grounds when they state that the Magi in Achaemenian Iran were both priests and soothsayers in Media and only wizards in Persia, and they “functioned just as the Etruscan haruspices worked in Rome”.¹⁸ In actual fact the problem is much too complex to be dealt with here, as it would take us too far off our main subject. Without overlooking what Boyce¹⁹ and Miltiades Papatheophanes have written about them,²⁰ we shall refer to the judicial remarks made by Gershevitch,²¹ and for the moment say no more than that the Magi were essentially experts in things sacred amongst the Medes and Persians; they were not distinguished by specific or univocal theological doctrines and they were not yet organized in a Church. Their following of Zoroaster’s teaching cannot have been compact or uniform, while there are evident traces of an inclination toward eclecticism and syncretism,²² which probably found a particularly fertile ground in Babylonia. They were doubtless the main mediators of Irano-Mesopotamian syncretism amongst the Greeks, as has been made clear by Kingsley in a recent study which we have already mentioned.²³ The ‘Hellenized’ Magi were preceded by the ‘Chaldaeized’ Magi. Some of the

latter were not lacking in a certain amount of opportunism if, as Curtius Rufus V, 1, 22 reports, they joined in the procession of the Macedonian conqueror in Babylon. Even if the demonization of Alexander must go back much further than Sassanian times,²⁴ it was not a matter that involved all the Persians, amongst whom could be numbered quite a few 'collaborationists', nor all the Magi.

It was after Alexander, at all events, that the other form of the name Zoroaster, Ζαράτας,²⁵ began to appear in the Classical sources, where it is present in the aforementioned testimony of Aristoxenus and linked to the Mesopotamian environment. In *The Exact Sciences in Antiquity*, Otto Neugebauer has written that within a few years, after Alexander's conquest of Babylon, a lot of scientific knowledge poured into Athens from what had been Achaemenian Mesopotamia.²⁶ The Persian empire had already been, for two centuries, a natural mediator between East and West, between India and Greece, as David Pingree's various studies have pointed out most clearly of all.²⁷

We can grasp the importance of the new cultural situation that had been brought about by Alexander's conquests in the field of ideas and religious beliefs as well. For example, we have the testimony of Eudemus of Rhodes in the 'Απορίαι καὶ λύσεις περὶ τῶν πρώτων ἀρχῶν of Damascius (125bis) and the one in Diodorus Siculus I, 94, 2, from an unidentified source which must, however, surely be identified as an author who wrote about Persian things — or at least also about them — after 330 B.C.²⁸ These testimonies have one thing in common: they prove the higher level of knowledge that the Greeks had acquired in that field after that date. We must be careful about making over-simplified and clear-cut judgements, like Momigliano, who thought that Alexander's exploits had as a consequence a change of interest in Greek intellectuals towards the Persians, these being the only ones that, compared with the other protagonists of Hellenistic history (Romans, Jews, Celts), the Greeks had known and appreciated before then. In this change, according to Momigliano's theory in *Alien Wisdom*, the Greeks replaced King Cyrus with the prophet Zoroaster

as the most representative Iranian figure, but paradoxically without bothering to find out who he really was and what he had really said.²⁹ Although there is some truth in this statement, it is too extreme because it does not take into account the fact that, after 330 B.C., the Greeks gained, in any case, new information and new knowledge on Persia and the Iranian world in general and on Zoroaster and the Magi in particular.

We shall not dwell at length on Eudemus of Rhodes, because Kingsley has already written about him in a very similar context³⁰ and because I, too, have written about his aforesaid testimony fairly recently, with the aim of confirming its authenticity — that had been questioned by J. Scheftelowitz and by Otto G. von Wesendonk³¹ — and analysing the expression Μάγοι δὲ καὶ πᾶν τὸ Ἀρειον γένος. There can be no doubt that Eudemus has given us a valuable description of Iranian dualism, which fully agrees with what we know about its historical development.³²

As regards Diodorus' source, it is worthwhile spending more time, in order to make a digression which I think will turn out to be useful to our subject. The passage from the *Urgeschichte* of the *Library of History* is the well-known one about the legislators who gave their people the laws that they said they had received from divine beings (I, 94, 1-2): thus Menes (Μνεύης) in Egypt by order of Hermes, i.e. Thoth; Minos on Crete by order of Zeus; Lycurgus to the Lacedaemonians by order of Apollo; Zoroaster (Ζαθραύστης) to the Aryans (Ἀριανοί) by order of the Good Spirit (ἀγαθὸς δαίμων); Zalmoxis to the Getae by order of Hestia; and lastly, Moses (Μωυσῆς) to the Jews by order of Yahwe (Ἰαώ). The sentence that concerns us mostly is: παρὰ μὲν γὰρ τοῖς Ἀριανοῖς Ζαθραύστην ἱστοροῦσι τὸν ἀγαθὸν δαίμονα προσποιήσασθαι τοὺς νόμους αὐτῷ διδόναι;³³ "they report that amongst the Aryans (= Iranians)³⁴ Zoroaster claimed that the Good Spirit had given him the laws".³⁵

This testimony is valuable from many points of view: if we examine it carefully we can appreciate it for its historical value. > The information reported by Diodorus is undoubtedly independ-

ent of all the other information about Zoroaster that circulated amongst the Greeks and it is therefore a source of the utmost importance. This is shown in the first place by the name Ζαθραύστης which, by the metathesis of the voiceless dental fricative and the loss of the final 'r' or, according to Markwart and Messina "mit dissimilatorischer Ausstossung der Silbe *ra*", we come much nearer to the Avestan name *Zarathuštra*- than with Ζωροάστρης,³⁷ that is, the form that was by far the most widespread amongst the Greeks from the 5th century onwards, now the subject of a keen-sighted and enlightening study by Gershevitch.³⁸ The only forms that also have this same peculiarity are Ζαραθρούστης and Ζωροθρύστης. They are attested in Cosmas of Jerusalem (mid 8th century).³⁹ Messina suggests that his source goes as far back as Hellenistic Babylon.⁴⁰

The mention of the Ἀπιανοί is also important because it, too, takes us back to a time when, after the conquest of the Achaemenian empire as far as India, the Greeks had come into direct acquaintance with the eastern Iranian world, and therefore of Ἀπιανή, whose boundaries Strabo (XV, 2, 1-8), basing his information on Eratosthenes, gives as corresponding roughly with those of the *airya*-lands and peoples in the Avesta.⁴¹

As for the Zoroastrian content of Diodorus' information, we must say that the ἀγαθὸς δαίμων reflects an Avestan idea and entity: *Vohu Manah*.⁴² The connections with the Avesta are evident: the theme of the law, *dāta*-, that was revealed to Zoroaster by Ahura Mazdā (for example in *Yasna* 46, 15 and 51, 19) is faithfully translated into a Greek version.⁴³ The concept of a law established by Ahura Mazdā, on which Antonino Pagliaro has made some useful remarks,⁴⁴ also occurs in Xerxes' inscription against the *daivas* at Persepolis (*XPh* 49-53).⁴⁵

As for the source that Diodorus drew on for this passage, Eduard Schwartz, in two successive studies on Hecataeus and on Diodorus, thought it to be a different one from the source of the whole first book of the *Library of History*, namely Hecataeus of Abdera, in accordance with the theory proposed by G. J. Schneider.⁴⁶ The

debate is still open, even after the commentary to book I of Diodorus that Anne Burton made in 1972, in which she overlooked a previous study of mine on the matter.⁴⁷ The problem is a complex one. Bidez and Cumont,⁴⁸ who take up Jacoby's arguments as well as an article by K. Reinhardt on Hecataeus of Abdera's dependence on Democritus,⁴⁹ had no doubt that the author of the Αἰγυπτιακά was the author of our passage. But the doubts persist: even Jacoby's position wavered.⁵⁰ H. Volkmann attributed the passage to Hecataeus;⁵¹ Spoerri refuted the connection with Democritus and supposed a first-century B.C. source;⁵² G. Pfligersdorffer proposed Posidonius of Apamea for no sound reasons;⁵³ Burton seems to have accepted the doubts that Jacoby expressed over Schwartz's theory about chapters 94-95, though she admits that 95, 5-6, on account of its anti-Alexander content, "must rather be taken to reflect later native [sc. Egyptian] nationalism, or perhaps the attitude of Diodorus himself",⁵⁴ her reference for this being an article by Oswyn Murray on Hecataeus of Abdera and the Pharaonic kingdom.⁵⁵

In reality, as Markwart pointed out,⁵⁶ the source for Diodorus I, 94, 1-2 may be Megasthenes, who lived between 350 and 290 B.C. A point in favour of this hypothesis is the fact that the other passage in which Diodorus speaks of Ἀπριανοί (II, 37, 6) could go back to Seleucus Nicator's representative at the court of Candragupta Maurya, the author of the Ἰνδικά, of which Arrian made a great deal of use and of which quite a few fragments have survived.⁵⁷ We cannot rule out entirely, though, that it might have been precisely the Αἰγυπτιακά by Hecataeus of Abdera or, as Frantz Grenet suggests,⁵⁸ Clearchus of Soli — also a disciple of Aristotle — mentioned by Diogenes Laertius (I, 8) in connection with what he wrote in his *On Education* about the Gymnosophists, descendants of the Magi. As we know, the French excavations at Ai Khanum in Afghanistan have brought him to the attention of scholars in eastern Hellenism, in particular Louis Robert.⁵⁹ What we can be sure of, however, is that it was an author who wrote after 330 B.C. The Zaratas that Aristoxenus of Tarentum gives as

Pythagoras' teacher, the information that Eudemus of Rhodes gives about the doctrine of the Magi, and the information about Zathraustes the lawgiver of the Aryans that is handed down by Diodorus Siculus are three significant pieces of evidence on the new course that Greek knowledge of Zoroaster and the Magi took after Alexander the Great. Some of this knowledge certainly derives from what we might call the 'Chaldaeized Magi', and some from a more direct encounter with the Zoroastrian tradition that came about in the easternmost regions of the Persian empire, and probably also on the Iranian plateau. Simplifying the matter, we could probably attribute the form *Zaratas* to the first-named contact and the form *Zathraustes*, which has been handed down by Diodorus' *Urgeschichte*, to the second.

Let us return to Aristoxenus,⁶⁰ the prolific author of 453 different works, some of them have to do with the science of music, which earned him the epithet 'the musician',⁶¹ and others of a philosophical and biographical nature, such as the collection of the Πυθαγορικά ἀποφάσεις or the biographies of Pythagoras and Archytas of Tarentum, of Socrates and Plato. As we all know, the information about the philosopher from Samos being the disciple of Zoroaster comes from him, handed down by Hippolytus of Rome in his *Refutation of all Heresies* I, 2, 12:

Διόδωρος δὲ ὁ Ἐρετριεὺς καὶ Ἀριστόξενος ὁ μουσικὸς φασὶ πρὸς Ζαράταν τὸν Χαλδαῖον ἐληλυθέναι Πυθαγόραν, τὸν δὲ ἐκθέσθαι αὐτῷ δύο εἶναι ἀπ' ἀρχῆς τοῖς οὖσιν αἴτια, πατέρα καὶ μητέρα· καὶ πατέρα μὲν φῶς, μητέρα δὲ σκότος· τοῦ δὲ φωτὸς μέρη θερμόν, ξηρόν, κοῦφον, ταχύ, τοῦ δὲ σκότους ψυχρόν, ὑγρόν, βαρὺ, βραδύ. Ἐκ δὲ τούτων πάντα τὸν κόσμον συνεστάναι, ἐκ θηλείας καὶ ἄρρενος. εἶναι δὲ τὸν κόσμον φησὶν καὶ μουσικὴν ἁρμονίαν, διὸ καὶ τὸν ἥλιον ποιεῖσθαι τὴν περίοδον ἐναρμόνιον.⁶²

Diodorus the Eretrian and Aristoxenus the musician say that Pythagoras went to Zaratas the Chaldaean, who taught him that everything derives from two primal causes, father and mother. And the father is light; the mother is darkness. The parts of the light are hot, dry, light and swift. The parts of the darkness are cold, wet, heavy

and slow. Of these the whole cosmos is made, that is, of female and male. And he [sc. Pythagoras] says⁶³ that the cosmos is also a musical harmony, and that is why the sun performs its period according to the laws of harmony.

The evidence on Pythagoras' meeting with Zoroaster in Hippolytus' *Philosophumena* has two sources: Diodorus of Eretria and Aristoxenus the musician. Unfortunately, however, we can only make use of the latter because we know nothing at all about when the former lived, what his intellectual inclinations were and what connections he may have had with other authors, including Aristoxenus. In it we can see reflected the Magian environment that we called 'Chaldaeized'. This is proved by the epithet 'Chaldaean' given to Zaratas and also by the comparison with other references in the Classical sources concerning Pythagoras' meeting with the Iranian sage, in which Zaratas or Zaratus or Zoroaster⁶⁴ is from time to time called 'Chaldaean', 'Persian' or 'Assyrian'.⁶⁵ One such example is in a historian of the 1st century B.C., Alexander Polyhistor (see p. 113) apud Clement of Alexandria (*Strom.* I, 15. 70),⁶⁶ who states that Pythagoras was a keen student of Zoroaster, the Persian Magus, of whom the disciples of Prodicus boasted that they owned the apocryphal books, and then he goes on to say: 'Ἀλέξανδρος δὲ ἐν τῷ Περὶ Πυθαγορικῶν συμβόλων Ζαράτω τῷ Ἀσσυρίῳ μαθητεῦσαι ἱστορεῖ τὸν Πυθαγόραν; "Alexander in his work on Pythagorean symbols relates that Pythagoras became a pupil of Zaratas the Assyrian". On the interchangeable usage of the terms 'Chaldaean', 'Assyrian' and 'Babylonian' in the Classical sources we can consult the illuminating pages by Wilhelm Bousset, in his *Hauptprobleme der Gnosis*,⁶⁷ who also definitely demolished the idea, formerly expressed by Friedrich Windischmann, of it being possible to reconstruct two distinct persons by the names of Zoroaster and Zaratas. Rather than giving credence to Pliny, *Nat. Hist.* XXX, 5, who seems to believe in this, we should prefer on this point — as Bidez and Cumont have made clear⁶⁸ — the version of the Byzantine historian to whom Averil Cameron has devoted some fundamental research,⁶⁹ viz.

Agathias, *Περὶ τῆς Ἰουστινιανοῦ βασιλείας*, II, 24: οὗτος δὲ ὁ Ζωρόαστρος, ἧτοι Ζαράδης (διττὴ γὰρ ἐπ' αὐτῷ ἢ ἐπωνυμία) ...: "this Zoroaster or Zarades (for he is called by two names) ..." ⁷⁰ Aristoxenus' testimony, which has naturally gained a place in the more general debate about the connection between Pythagoras and the Orient, ⁷¹ has given rise to a complex discussion, ⁷² to which Kingsley has contributed with a penetrating study. ⁷³ The reader is referred to it with regard to the information on Zaratas and the importance of Aristoxenus' testimony concerning the idea of the cosmos as a musical harmony, in spite of the views expressed by Eduard Zeller and Walter Spoerri. In fact, I do not think there can be any doubts about the author of the *Elements of Harmonics* being the source for these points. On the other hand, doubts of this kind are justified as far as the next passage in Hippolytus' text is concerned, where he speaks of the two δαίμονες, one celestial and the other terrestrial, and the nature of these elements, on which we can see the influence of Stoicism. We cannot be quite sure, though, that the name used by Aristoxenus actually was Zaratas. We cannot exclude that the Zaratas in Hippolytus' text was due to a later writer "when copying or adapting Aristoxenus's account", as Kingsley has honestly admitted, although he reasonably thinks it plausible that Aristoxenus "took special pride" in writing *Zaratas* instead of *Zoroastres*. ⁷⁴ On the other hand, we can be fairly sure of the fact that Aristoxenus reported the information about Pythagoras' meeting with Zoroaster and this is what we are mostly interested in now. Heinrich Dörrie, in his *Der hellenistische Rahmen des kaiserzeitlichen Platonismus* also acknowledges that Aristoxenus is Hippolytus' source of information and, like Kingsley, he stresses its importance as far as the dualism of the two opposite principles is concerned. ⁷⁵

The testimony of Aristoxenus and Diodorus of Eretria as reported by Hippolytus thus places Zoroaster in the 6th century, since it speaks of him as a contemporary of Pythagoras, perhaps a generation older, as would be fitting for a teacher. Several others before Kingsley have devoted their attention to this testimony, fully

aware of its chronological implications — if it can be taken as reliable — in attempting to solve the problem of Zoroaster's date. We may recall, to name a few, the different opinions of Windischmann, Clemen, Bidez and Cumont, Duchesne-Guillemin, Altheim and Stiehl.⁷⁶ In particular, I think that what Duchesne-Guillemin has written on this subject is important. He starts out with the premiss that the Magi, in taking over the teaching of Zoroaster, tried to pass him off as one of themselves and, “pour mieux y réussir”, from the time of Eudoxus and perhaps also of Xanthus (he was not sure about the authenticity of Diogenes' attribution), they dated him to a distant past. They did not succeed, however, in wiping out the memory of the traditional date of 258 years before Alexander, which had reached the ears of the Greeks, as we can see from the actual testimony of Aristoxenus:

Ce souvenir était parvenu jusqu'aux Grecs. En effet, selon Aristoxène, élève d'Aristote, et Diodore d'Érétrie, cités tous deux par Hippolyte, *Refut. Haeres.*, I. 2. 12, Pythagore avait fait le voyage de Babylonie pour s'y instruire auprès de Zoroastre. Les deux sages étaient donc, selon cette vue, contemporains. Or Pythagore passait pour être né en 572: Aristoxène lui-même le faisait émigrer en Italie à l'âge de 40 ans, à cause de la tyrannie de Polycrate, laquelle débuta en 532. Aristoxène et Diodore se trouvent ainsi confirmer la tradition iranienne qui plaçait Zarathustra “deux cent cinquante-huit ans avant Alexandre”.⁷⁷

Altheim and Stiehl, for their part, have come back to the subject several times, regarding the testimony given by Aristoxenus and Diodorus of Eretria, and they have concluded that “Diese Überlieferung, die in vielfacher Brechung vorliegt, führt von vornherein ins 6. Jahrhundert”.⁷⁸ On the other hand, there is so great a contrast between it and the date of Zoroaster six millennia before Xerxes or Plato or five millennia before the fall of Troy, that it has been seen as a conscious polemical reaction to the unlikeliness of the chronology in vogue in the early Academy. This was the view of Bidez and Cumont and it has recently been expressed by Dörrie and Kingsley.⁷⁹

Now, it is my view that Duchesne-Guillemin had fully realized in 1953 that the Pythagoras-Zoroaster synchronism confirmed the validity of the traditional date that, a short time before, Henning had once again brought into favour. In fact, at the time when *Ormazd et Ahriman* appeared, Duchesne-Guillemin agreed with this idea, but later on he voiced a somewhat different opinion, after Otakar Klíma's attempt to date the prophet to the mid-8th century,⁸⁰ on the grounds of the indemonstrable assumption that Mani had appeared as the Ušēdar of the Zoroastrian tradition — an idea that rightly provoked his scepticism in *La religion de l'Iran ancien*⁸¹ — and at any rate after the debate that developed over the traditional date — he was referring in particular to Kaj Barr⁸² —, as can be seen by his cautious remarks in a successive article.⁸³ And indeed, the observations he made in 1953 appear to us today to be perfectly logical and coherent.

On the contrary, Kingsley has, so to speak, reversed the terms of the question and has gone so far as to declare that the aforesaid synchronism should be explained the other way round. According to him, in fact, Aristoxenus' testimony is not the effect but the cause: that is to say, the Pythagoras-Zoroaster connection was the starting point from which the traditional date of 258 years before Alexander grew up in Iran, and consequently it had a Greek origin. The unlikelihood and artificiality of this conclusion have rightly been pointed out by Gershevitch in his recent article "Approaches to Zoroaster's Gathas".⁸⁴ However, it is worthwhile devoting a little more time to this subject.

Kingsley reached this conclusion on the grounds of a mistaken assumption, for which the present writer is also responsible (see p. 17 ff.). Taking it for granted that the historical date for Zoroaster must be fixed "a great deal earlier than the sixth century B.C. — probably some time in the second millennium",⁸⁵ Kingsley, who is a classicist of repute, has incautiously joined in a debate which is still an open question for Iranian scholars, in spite of Boyce's view that

by now it is agreed by almost all scholars actively working in the field that this date [sc. the traditional date that places Zoroaster in the 6th century] is in fact fictitious, calculated piously but quite erroneously by Persian magi, perhaps early in the Christian era, in order to place Zoroaster in a historical setting and so make him equal in this respect with Jesus and the gnostic prophets of that time.⁸⁶

Kingsley referred to results obtained by Professor Boyce in the first and second volumes of her *A History of Zoroastrianism*, by Shahbazi, and by the present author.⁸⁷ He also maintained that "In antiquity there were Magi who denied it any validity",⁸⁸ on the grounds of evidence given by Sven S. Hartman,⁸⁹ which, as we shall see more clearly later on, must be interpreted differently (see p. 162 f.), and on the basis of the fact that "The resultant diversity of Magian teaching is often and correctly emphasized",⁹⁰ in keeping with the remarks made by Bidez and Cumont, by Nock, and by Martin L. West.⁹¹ (These remarks, by the way, have nothing to do with what the Magi thought of the historical period of Zoroaster, except of course for what Nock observes on the 6000 years in Xanthus).

Starting from these premises, Kingsley observes that there is an agreement between the dating that is implicit in Aristoxenus' account and the traditional date and deduces that the latter was derived from the former, though he neglects to explain the reasons why the Magi should have been inspired by the tradition invented by Aristoxenus rather than the one that is reflected in the evidence provided by Xanthus and the early Academy. Neither does he make it clear how and when they would have chosen to do this, nor in what way they would have become acquainted with it. On the other hand, I think Gershevitch is right about Aristoxenus' presumed invention when he writes:

Even supposing that the teacher-pupil [sc. Zoroaster-Pythagoras] relationship referred to by Aristoxenus is a piece of wishful thinking on his part, it stands to reason that he would not have indulged in it had the reports which he gathered from Greek interrogators of Zoroastrians not included an indication that Zoroaster was still alive at the time known to Aristoxenus when Pythagoras travelled in Asia.⁹²

While we cannot give credit to Kingsley for having explained the origin of the 6th-century date for Zoroaster (and the present author certainly cannot blame him for this, having been amongst those who misled him), his is the merit, of no little importance, of having involuntarily shown by his painstaking analysis of the passage in Hippolytus that the echo of that date was still to be heard amongst the Greeks in the 4th century B.C. This, in turn, agrees with the aforesaid interpretation of Zoroaster's date attested by other Greek sources in terms of six or five millennia, respectively, before the fifth and fourth century B.C. or before the Trojan war. As we have seen, these various Greek traditions assume that a sixth-century dating for Zoroaster was current amongst the Magi or the Persians of the Achaemenian period, and we have no reason to believe that it was not of Iranian origin. The coincidence of the two chronological calculations giving 570 B.C. is therefore deceptive as they are really quite independent of one another. One is the result of applying the Apollodoran system of dating to reconstruct the date of Zoroaster, starting from the ἀκμὴ of Pythagoras in the 62nd Olympiad (532-529 B.C.) or from his birth in 570 B.C. (forty years before)⁹³ and thus getting to Zoroaster's ἀκμὴ in that same year; the other was based on the addition of the traditional date, 258 years before Alexander, to the epoch of the Seleucid era, i.e. 312 B.C. ($258 + 312 = 570$). This synchronism, which Kingsley was thinking of,⁹⁴ is based on an arbitrary assumption: that the expression 'before Alexander', in the traditional date of Zoroaster, referred to 312 B.C. and not, as is far more likely, to 330 B.C. (see p. 138 ff.). We should not allow ourselves to be misled, then, by the fact that Apollodorus of Athens (2nd century B.C.) may have depended on Aristoxenus with regard to the date of Pythagoras in 570 B.C.,⁹⁵ nor by the fact that the ἀκμὴ of Anaximander had been calculated as the same year.⁹⁶ The only thing we can be sure of is that Aristoxenus thought it natural that Pythagoras should have learnt from Zoroaster because evidently, in talking about their meeting, he was not aware of any chronological obstacle to it.

Bidez and Cumont and J.D.P. Bolton,⁹⁷ thought it possible that it had been Heraclides of Pontus (390-310 B.C. circa), the author of a dialogue named after Zoroaster but otherwise unknown to us, who had suggested to Aristoxenus the information about Pythagoras' meeting with Zoroaster. Kingsley re-examined the question in such terms that it is very difficult indeed either to agree with him or to reject his arguments.⁹⁸ The stand taken by H.B. Gottschalk against the thesis of Bidez and Cumont and of Bolton is perhaps too extreme.⁹⁹ What Plutarch tells us¹⁰⁰ about the independent attitudes that this author of various works of romantic fiction took pleasure in assuming, although he was one of Plato's pupils, thus contradicting the ideas that were current in the early Academy, could lead us to think that he had deliberately chosen, in the case of Zoroaster too, the method "of using dramatic art to bring figures from the distant past into the immediate present", as Kingsley supposed.¹⁰¹ This, though, is no more than a mere conjecture. The fact remains that Aristoxenus, who was well acquainted with Heraclides' work, did not agree with much of it, as Walter Burkert and Gottschalk¹⁰² have not failed to point out, and perhaps it is not enough to remark, in this connection, that "it is worth remembering that criticism is a good indicator of those to whom we are most indebted".¹⁰³ But what we must especially turn our minds to is the fact that the Greeks, particularly after 330 B.C., were gaining more and more knowledge about the history and culture of the former subjects of the defeated empire. If it ever did come about that one such as Heraclides made Zoroaster out to be a contemporary of Pythagoras, as Aristoxenus had certainly done, then we must acknowledge that the reason for this in the first place was the new intellectual resources to which they had access, thanks to their profounder and more direct knowledge of the Asiatic world. This is how we must explain the partial fading away of the misunderstanding about Zoroaster having lived six millennia before Plato. This seems to be a much sounder reason for confuting a chronology of this type, rather than the one imagined by Kingsley, who thought that Aristoxenus' anti-Platonism was the motive that

led the meticulous and reliable writer from Tarentum to 'invent' a date for Zoroaster in the 6th century by making him Pythagoras' teacher.

In his valuable analysis of Hippolytus' account of the evidence given by Diodorus of Eretria and Aristoxenus on Pythagoras and Zoroaster, Kingsley did not deal with a particular aspect of this connection that was so clearly attested in the Classical sources. This aspect is the Pythagoras-Cambyses connection that exists in some of these sources: in an excerpt from *Theologumena arithmeticae* (Aristoxenus fr. 12 Wehrli); in a passage from Apuleius, *Florida* 15;¹⁰⁴ in the *Chronicon Romanum*;¹⁰⁵ in the *Chronographia* by Georgius Syncellus;¹⁰⁶ in the *Vita Pythagorica* of Iamblichus.¹⁰⁷ According to these sources Pythagoras was taken prisoner by Cambyses in Egypt and this gave him the chance of going to Babylon where he met some learned Chaldaeans and Magi. The passage in Apuleius proves that Pythagoras' meeting with the 'Chaldaean' Zoroaster must be considered in this context too: *Sunt qui Pythagoran aiant eo temporis inter captivos Cambysae regis, Aegyptum cum adveheretur, doctores habuisse Persarum Magos ac praecipue Zoroastren, omnis divini arcani antistitem*.¹⁰⁸

The Pythagoras-Cambyses connection is not without problems and contradictions, that were already noted some time ago, for instance, by Wehrli or Burkert,¹⁰⁹ and have been recently emphasized once again by two recent editors of the Pythagorean way of life of Iamblichus, John Dillon and Jackson Hershbell.¹¹⁰ Furthermore, it bears a strange likeness to the information given in the Armenian version of Eusebius of Caesarea's *Chronica*, which is clearly anachronistic as Windischmann, for instance, pointed out.¹¹¹ In this account Pythagoras is a soldier of the Assyrian king Esarhaddon (680-669 B.C.), who conquered Egypt a century and a half before Cambyses. An attempt was made by Paul Schnabel, in his *Berosus und die babylonisch-hellenistische Literatur*,¹¹² to explain this account by reconstructing an erroneous identification of the sovereign's name by Alexander Polyhistor (Ἀσπαρίδης in the Ptolemaic Canon; *Ἀζαπαδᾶς "oder ganz ähnlich" in

Berossus-Polyhistor; *Axerdis* – Ἀζέρδης in Abydenus, who was Eusebius' and Moses of Chorene's source for Berossus, thanks to the excerpts he made of Polyhistor's work).¹¹³ That is to say, the error was due to an interpolation by the Milesian historian in Berossus's Βαβυλωνιακά, as Stanley Mayer Burstein still maintained.¹¹⁴ Whatever may have been the origin of the story about Pythagoras and the Assyrian king who conquered Egypt, all we know is that, from the 4th century onwards, there was a tradition amongst the Greeks linking the Samian philosopher to Cambyses (530-522). Actually, we can conjecture, with a fair degree of probability, that Pythagoras' link with Cambyses and Egypt provided the background for a mistaken anachronistic connection between Pythagoras and Esarhaddon, a sovereign who was also renowned, like Cambyses, for his victorious Egyptian campaign.

It will be worthwhile noting that some Christian sources, such as Eutychius, Makin-b. 'Amid and Bar Hebraeus, seem to attest the presence of another synchronism based on Cambyses, namely Cambyses (and Smerdis)-Zoroaster. We shall see later that this is a broader synchronism, with Zoroaster being a contemporary of the first Achaemenians, and that it probably combines the awareness of the traditional date 258 years before Alexander with the memory of the Cambyses-Pythagoras connection (see p. 159 ff.).

Pythagoras figures in another synchronism, this time with Ezekiel. This is particularly interesting for us, too, as it brings us into another, Jewish, environment, because of the prophet of the Exile being identified with Zoroaster.

The *interpretatio Judaica* of Zoroaster as Ezekiel is attested by Clement of Alexandria, *Strom.* I, 15, 70,¹¹⁵ in a passage which has been closely analysed by Jacoby and Kingsley:¹¹⁶

Ἀλέξανδρος δὲ ἐν τῷ Περὶ Πυθαγορικῶν συμβόλων Ζαράτω τῷ Ἀσσυρίῳ μαθητεῦσαι ἱστορεῖ τὸν Πυθαγόραν. Ἰεζεκιήλ τοῦτον ἡγούνται τινες· οὐκ ἔστι δέ, ὥς ἔπειτα δηλωθήσεται.

Alexander [Polyhistor] relates in his work on Pythagorean symbols that Pythagoras became a pupil of Zaratas the Assyrian. There are certain people who reckon this man is none other than Ezekiel, but that is not correct, as will become apparent later.¹¹⁷

To appreciate the interest this passage aroused in Jacoby and his interpretation of it, we need only consider what Kingsley had to say on the matter. Kingsley was in fact probably quite right in defending the authenticity of the report Hippolytus gives in his *Refutation of all Heresies*, where he states that, according to Diodorus of Eretria and Aristoxenus the musician, Pythagoras went to Zaratas the Chaldaean (see p. 102). Thus the tradition that has Pythagoras travelling to meet Zoroaster dates back to the 4th century B.C. and cannot therefore have been invented by Alexander Polyhistor (1st century B.C.) as Jacoby had it: “wenn es Aristoxenos war, der zuerst die linie Magier-Pythagoras zog, so wird man die möglichkeit offen lassen, dass er überhaupt keinen namen nannte und vielleicht, wie Aristot. Metaph. N 4, von ‘den Magiern’ sprach”.¹¹⁸ While Kingsley was probably right to contest Jacoby — and, as we have seen, Zeller and Spoerri — claiming the antiquity of the story of the meeting between Pythagoras and Zoroaster, he certainly exaggerated and was quite probably wrong when he argued that the tradition of identifying Zoroaster with Ezekiel must necessarily date back to “near or exact contemporaries” of Clement, in an Alexandria that was “a focal point, in the centuries after Christ, for the most elaborate integration of Zoroaster into a Jewish context”.¹¹⁹

As a matter of fact, there are no guarantees at all that the Zoroaster-Ezekiel identification did not date back earlier than Clement, or even than Alexander Polyhistor himself. In fact, it has all the requisites for a dating prior to this period. It is not mere chance that the identification of Ezekiel with Zoroaster is put into the story about Pythagoras. It shows an obvious desire to make Pythagoras a disciple of the Jewish prophet, evidently on the grounds of a pre-existent identification of the latter with the Iranian prophet. What is more, we can see no reason why the Jews should have confined to the Greeks their tendency to Judaize other people’s sages. Not without reason Artapanus, a Jewish novelist in Egypt at the end of the 2nd century B.C., presented Moses as Hermes-Thoth,¹²⁰ and it is not very likely that the Jews would have

identified Zoroaster as Ezekiel only because they had to make the latter out to be Pythagoras' teacher. What is even less likely is that this identification was not due to them, but to someone else: it fits in too well with the Jewish dogma, according to which Pythagoras was indebted to the Jews for his knowledge, as Josephus, *Contra Apionem* I, 162-5 and II, 168 and Origen, *Contra Celsum* I, 15, remind us.¹²¹

The connection between Pythagoras and Judaism dates back at least as far as the late 3rd century B.C., since — as Kingsley himself aptly pointed out although he did not draw the necessary conclusions — it was attested as early as Hermippus who was writing around 200 B.C. Pythagoras, like Plato for that matter, got his ideas from Moses through an alleged translation of the Torah predating the Septuagint, which Eusebius of Caesarea mentions in his *Praeparatio evangelica* XIII, 12, 1.¹²² Alexander Polyhistor, a historian of the 1st century B.C. from Miletus, who in Momigliano's opinion was reliable and objective,¹²³ though with pro-Jewish leanings according to Emilio Gabba,¹²⁴ was not averse to recording the claims the Jews made in various fields of science and civil life for the purpose of asserting the greater antiquity of Israel's tradition compared with other traditions. There were predecessors for Polyhistor, however, dating back to the 3rd century B.C., including the Jewish historian or exegete Demetrius, a chronographer who was writing at the time of Ptolemy IV Philopator (221-205/4 B.C.).¹²⁵ The same can be said for Hermippus, who, as Dionysius of Halicarnassus (*De Isaeo* 1, 1) tells us, was very careful to indicate school affiliations: he "accepted what must have been a suggestion from an earlier (Peripatetic or Jewish?) scholar that Pythagoras had imported Jewish thought into Greece", according to Momigliano.¹²⁶

After Jacoby had noted that Ezekiel was preaching in Babylonia from 593 to 571 B.C., Kingsley went on to demonstrate that the identification of the prophet of the Exile with Zoroaster should not constitute "an obvious explanation for Zoroaster's dating" in the 6th century,¹²⁷ although all that Jacoby had in fact pointed out

was that “hier könnte die gleichung mit Ezechiel (...) wichtig werden, dessen babylonischer aufenthalt 593/71 zeitliche verbindung mit Pythagoras und annectierung sowohl des persischen wie des griechischen religionsstifters ermöglichte”.¹²⁸

Nevertheless, absorbed in his own argument, Kingsley asserted that “Jacoby drew attention to another possible source of the figure [i.e. 258 years before Alexander]: Judaism”, and went on to remark that, although this seemed a more solid approach than those based on “what we know or can reasonably guess about the extent to which Zoroastrians were indebted to Babylonian methods of dating”,¹²⁹ it had

one major limitation: it does not allow us to tell whether Zoroaster’s identification with Ezekiel was the *cause* of his being given a date in the sixth century B.C., or whether he was equated with Ezekiel because he had already been given a date around that time. Certainly the parallels between Zoroaster and Ezekiel — note for example Ezekiel’s emphasis on fire and his reference to physical resurrection — are obvious and striking for anyone prepared to look for them.¹³⁰ But Zoroaster was also equated with Seth, Nimrod, Balaam and Baruch, as well as being considered a pupil of Abraham, without any of these identifications giving rise to a serious tradition about his dating.¹³¹

In the light of the considerations made so far, Kingsley’s observations are clearly unconvincing. Whether the Ezekiel-Zoroaster identification depends or not on the Pythagoras-Ezekiel connection, the fact remains that it was by all appearances very long-standing and of such a nature as to imply, in any case, that whoever invented it must have been convinced that Zoroaster was a contemporary of Ezekiel. Moreover, the identifications of Zoroaster with Baruch and Jeremiah (see p. 116) take us back to about the same historical period, just as the late definition of him as a ‘second Balaam’¹³² would seem to place him in a later period than the one given for the prophet in chapters 22-24 of *Numbers*.

I do not think that we can take the passage in Clement of Alexandria to argue, as Jacoby did, that the Pythagoras-Zoroaster connection was subsequent to the Ezekiel-Zoroaster identification,

nor do I agree with Kingsley when he argues that the latter was necessarily second. In fact, we have every good reason to argue that, apart from the Greek tradition placing Zoroaster in the 6th century, there was also an independent Jewish tradition that, at the height of the Hellenistic period, associated the Iranian prophet with the Judaeo-Babylonian culture of the same century. Without going into the doctrinal problems that the identification of Ezekiel with Zoroaster may raise,¹³³ I hope I have shown that there is really no reason — whether based on textual evidence or purely logical — to suppose that the Ezekiel-Zoroaster identification could only have come about with Greek mediation.

This seems to me to be an important point in explaining the Iranian origin of the sixth-century dating of Zoroaster. It would have to exist as a starting-point for the two independent traditions, one Greek and one Jewish, to develop, either making Zoroaster Pythagoras' teacher or seeing him as a sort of Iranian version of the prophet of the Exile.

The encounter between Iranian and Jewish culture began in 6th-century Babylonia.¹³⁴ It is to this encounter that we may trace back certain identifications of Zoroaster with figures in the history of Israel — identifications that deserve more attention than they have so far received from scholars, for example Bidez and Cumont,¹³⁵ or more recently Kingsley (see p. 114). The fact that they quite obviously contain totally arbitrary elements — which are, after all, an intrinsic feature of such evidence — should not lead us to reject them all out of hand, as if they did not contain any useful information for a historical reconstruction. They should, in fact, be analysed with the same care we give to the study of Classical sources, whether they date Zoroaster by a millenary calculation, or make him out to be a contemporary of Ninus and Semiramis, or refer to him as the teacher whom Pythagoras met on his journey to the East.

A good approach, then, is to sort out these identifications and we shall see that they are of various types and origins. Some are based on astrology and on Zoroaster as a leading figure amongst

the Magi and the Chaldaeans,¹³⁶ and here we find the identification with Nimrod (and with Chus, his father, Cham, his grandfather, and Misraim, his uncle), who wielded his power upon the earth, the mighty “hunter in the sight of Yahweh” in *Genesis* X, 8-9. As for this identification, Wilhelm Bousset’s masterly contribution is still valid,¹³⁷ while Bidez and Cumont point out that it may have been influenced by the legend in which Zoroaster was conceived of as the creator of Babylonian culture and as an ancient Chaldaean king,¹³⁸ this being supported by an account in the extremely garbled text of Panodorus apud Syncellus concerning the dynasties after the Flood according to Berossus.¹³⁹ It may also have been influenced by his association with Ninus and Semiramis, as well as by Nimrod’s connection with the cult of fire and the stars, as Pieter W. van der Horst has aptly shown.¹⁴⁰ There seems to have been a certain resemblance in the Haggadic tradition, which would have Zoroaster as a disciple of Abraham, the inventor of astrology,¹⁴¹ while there is a more complex situation consisting of a sort of rivalry or correspondence between Zoroaster and Seth, the scribe and the astrologer, as they emerge from the comparison of various works, mostly Christian ones — which has also been the subject of a careful study by Bousset,¹⁴² though it has only partly been made use of by A.F.J. Klijn in his monography on Seth.¹⁴³

Other identifications of Zoroaster seem to spring from different roots, particularly eschatology and the work of salvation. We may mention the identification with Balaam¹⁴⁴ and Baruch,¹⁴⁵ the association with Jeremiah,¹⁴⁶ and the aforementioned identification with Ezekiel. The first three of these connections, that are recorded in late Syriac and Arabic sources, may be more Christian than Jewish, at least as they have survived to this day, although we should not overlook what David Winston has written on the whole problem, and in particular on the possibility that the identifications with Jeremiah and Baruch already existed before the epoch of Christ.¹⁴⁷ The fourth of these identifications, at any rate, was certainly pre-Christian and most probably, as we have

seen, even a lot older than Alexander Polyhistor.

Now the point is that some of these identifications are manifestly chimerical, fitting in with the ideological trends of Judaism in the Hellenistic period that sought to involve all the sages of antiquity.¹⁴⁸ This, for example, is the explanation for the identification of Moses with Museus or Hermes that is given by a historian who was one of Polyhistor's sources, namely Eupolemus,¹⁴⁹ probably one of the envoys sent to Rome by Judas Maccabeus in 161 B.C.¹⁵⁰ But the main concern of the other identifications seems to have been to account for similarities and analogies between the doctrinal contents of messianic and soteriological trends in Iran and Israel, as well as in the Christian tradition, with particular reference to the story of *Matthew 2*, 1 ff.

Therefore, it is highly likely that a sixth-century dating for Zoroaster was attested amongst the Jews as it was amongst the Greeks, at least in the Hellenistic period. The Greek or Jewish synchronisms — with Pythagoras or e.g. Ezekiel — gained a footing precisely because they did not clash with the date that placed Zoroaster in that epoch. In the final analysis, they were not necessarily dependent on one another — although we cannot a priori rule out reciprocal influence — but on a common source of information, that must be sought not in Greece or in Israel, but much more reasonably in Iran or in the Jewish Diaspora in Babylonia, probably from the Achaemenian period onwards.

In fact, from a methodological viewpoint, we cannot rule out the possibility of the eastern Diaspora, in the Iranian-Mesopotamian environment, having followed similar trends to those of the Alexandrian Jews, who were more directly exposed to the influence of Greek culture and were naturally aware of it and interested in it. A similar tendency to Judaize the more prominent figures of foreign cultural traditions may well have been present amongst the Babylonian and Iranian Jews — and there are several traces of this having been so, that call for more thorough investigation. As far as contact between Iran and Israel is concerned,¹⁵¹ it should be noted in particular that an inverse process can also be

reconstructed, whose main centre of mediation was probably Babylon. We may take as an example the figure of Kay Lohrāsp in the fifth book of the *Dēnkard*¹⁵² and in the *Dādestān ī Mēnōg ī Xrad* XXVII, 64-67, where it says that his was the merit of destroying Jerusalem and dispersing the Jews. Thus the predecessor of the sovereign who was Zoroaster's protector takes the place of Nebuchadnezzar, who is demoted to the rank of a *spāhbed*.¹⁵³ This is evidently a negative example on account of its conflicting nature, but it is quite a meaningful one for the reconstruction of a complex historical contact that is marked by a mutual tendency toward a sort of cultural interpretation. It is hard not to agree with the opinion expressed by J. Horowitz on this matter, namely "that some of the Hebrew-Iranian synchronisms go back into pre-Islamic times",¹⁵⁴ and it will be just as hard to think that they were the result of Greek influence. The Jews of the eastern Diaspora worked out a system of identification between the main characters of their sacred history and those of the Iranian cultural heritage, paving the way for further identifications which became acceptable to the Iranian conscience when Islam diffused the meaning and values of a new tradition, in which the most venerable figures were the prophets of the Bible.¹⁵⁵

We shall see further on that there is a probable trace, not only in Christian authors but also amongst the Manichaeans, (see p. 161 ff.), of a sixth-century dating for Zoroaster in pre-Islamic times having existed among the Jews: the Manichaeans combined the direct knowledge that they probably had of the traditional date 258 years before Alexander with evidence gained from a different historiographical tradition, probably Jewish or Judaeo-Christian. But we shall come back to this matter — which is the subject of two articles that I have drawn on a lot in these last few pages¹⁵⁶ — in the following lecture.

Notes to lecture three

1. Pearson, *ElH*, 20.
2. Spoerri, art. cit. (see p. 82 n. 23), pp. 218-19. See however Bidez and Cumont, *MH* I, p. 132; Untersteiner, *AF*, 82-84, as well as the cautious remarks made by Isnardi Parenti in Zeller and Mondolfo, o. c. (see p. 89 n. 131), pp. 852-53.
3. On the subject see Gnoli, art. cit. (see p. 41 n. 97), where the relevant bibliography is also given.
4. Jaeger, *Aristotle*, 133, 167-69, and see above p. 66.
5. Bidez and Cumont, *MH* II, p. 67; Untersteiner, *AF*, 82.
6. Wehrli, *Die Schule des Aristoteles*, II: *Aristoxenos*, 2nd ed., Basel, 1967; "Aristoxenos", *RE*, Suppl. II, 1968, 336-43; "Aristoxenos von Tarent", in *Grundriss der Geschichte der Philosophie. Die Philosophie der Antike*, Basel-Stuttgart, 1983, 540-46. See also K. Ziegler, "Aristoxenos", *Der kleine Pauly*, I, Stuttgart, 1964, 591-92; A. Visconti, "Aristosseno di Taranto ed il nome del padre", *RANL*, IX. VII, 2, 1996, 425-44 (for other bibliographical references).
7. Momigliano, o. c. (see p. 91 n. 152), pp. 78-89, 103.
8. Kingsley, "Greek origin". Kingsley has come back to the subject of Aristoxenus in connection with the Pythagorean school of Tarentum and other problems of Pythagoreanism: Kingsley, o. c. (see p. 11 n. 6), pp. 143-46, 323-24; "Meetings", 201.
9. Kingsley, "Greek origin", 254-55.
10. Kingsley, "Meetings", 205.
11. Isnardi Parente, loc. cit. at p. 86 n. 83.
12. Bidez and Cumont, *MH* I, pp. 34-38.
13. Kingsley, "Meetings", 201.
14. Kingsley, "Greek origin", p. 254 n. 58.
15. Momigliano, *Alien Wisdom*, 143.
16. Messina, *Ursprung*, 17-21; *Magi a Betlemme*, 14-17.
17. Molé, *CMC*, 78-81.
18. E.J. Bickerman and H. Tadmor, "Darius I, Pseudo-Smerdis and the Magi", *Athenaeum*, 56, 1978, 239-61, at p. 260. See also Kingsley, "Greeks, Shamans and Magi", *StIr*, 23, 1994, 187-98, at pp. 192-93.
19. Boyce, *HZ* II, pp. 19-21, 46-47; *HZ* II, pp. 58-60, 386-87 etc.
20. Papatheophanes, art. cit. (see p. 92 n. 174), pp. 116-31.

21. Gershevitch, art. cit. (see p. 91 n. 148), pp. 24-26.
22. Gnoli, art. cit. (see p. 36 n. 12), pp. 43-53.
23. Kingsley, "Meetings", 198-202.
24. As Kingsley, "Meetings", pp. 194-95 with n. 142, has rightly stated, with reference to Curtius Rufus IV, 13, 12-14 and to Eddy's commentary (o. c. at p. 89 n. 126, pp. 30-31), and also to Boyce's remarks, *Zoroastrianism*, 12-3; *HZ* III, pp. 12-13, 371-75. In his criticism of the position held by A. Abel ("La figure d'Alexandre en Iran", in *Persia e mondo greco-romano*, 119-34) and myself, he does not take into account, in my case, the fact that, in *De Z. à M.*, 86-87, I was speaking of the demonization of Alexander as being one of the essential and characteristic themes of an official ideology, as I later explained in *Idea of Iran*, p. 194 n. 27. The fact remains that, as such, it is not clearly attested in the Parthian period, though it most likely goes back that far. Philippe Gignoux, on the contrary, seems convinced of the fact that was limited to the Sassanians: Gignoux, "Sur la réalité d'une Sibylle persane", in S. Shaked and A. Netzer, *Irano-Judaica III*, Jerusalem, 1994, 54-62, at pp. 59-60.
25. This form has some variants, Ζάρατος, Ζαράδης, etc., on which see Bousset, *Hauptprobleme*, 374-77; Clemen, *Nachrichten*, 20; "Μάγοι", *RE* XIV, 1, 1928, 509-18, at col. 509; Bidez and Cumont, *MH* I, pp. 37-38; R. Beck, "Thus spake not Zarathuštra: Zoroastrian pseudepigrapha of the Greco-Roman world", in Boyce and Grenet, *HZ* III, pp. 491-565, at pp. 523-24 n. 83. The idea that Ζωροάστρης and Ζαράτας refer to different persons is quite unthinkable: in fact, Bousset has proved that Windischmann's theory (*Studien*, 261-65) is groundless.
26. Neugebauer, o. c. (see p. 93 n. 187), p. 151.
27. Cf. Panaino, art. cit. (see p. 87 n. 98), pp. 47-48, and also for bibliographical references.
28. Gnoli, *Sistān*, 58; *De Z. à M.*, 43-44; *Idea of Iran*, 11-12; "Zoroastro nelle fonti classiche", *Studi Urbinati B*, 67, 1995-1996, 281-95, at p. 290. Some possibilities are: Megasthenes (Markwart, *Das erste Kapitel der Gāthā uštavati*, ed. G. Messina, Roma, 1930, 23), Hecataeus of Abdera (Bidez and Cumont, *MH* I, p. 20; II, p. 30), Clearchus of Soli (Grenet, *HZ* III, p. 158 n. 26), about whom see L. Robert, "De Delphes à l'Oxus. Inscriptions grecques nouvelles de la Bactriane", *CRAI*, 1968, 416-57, at pp. 421-23; C. Rapin and P. Hadot, "Les textes littéraires grecs d'Ai Khanoum", *BCH*, 111, 1987, 225-66, at p. 225 f. Others, such as E. Wilhelm, ("L'expédition de Ninus et des Assyriens contre un roi de la Bactrie", *Le Muséon*, 10, 1891, 556-74, at p. 571) and Justi (*NB*, 384), had wrongly thought of Ctesias or, like Herzfeld (*Zoroaster*, 699-700), of an author before the time of Alexander's conquests,

in the Achaemenian period.

29. Momigliano, *Alien Wisdom*, 2 and 147-48.

30. Kingsley, "Greek origin", p. 255 with n. 63.

31. Scheftelowitz, "Neues Material über die manichäische Urseele und die Entstehung des Zervanismus", *ZII*, 4, 1926, 317-44, at p. 343; Wesendonk, *Das Wesen der Lehre Zarathuštrōs*, Leipzig, 1927, 14.

32. Gnoli, "A note on the Magi and Eudemus of Rhodes", in *A Green Leaf. Papers in honour of Professor Jes P. Asmussen* (ActIr 28), ed. W. Sundermann, J. Duchesne-Guillemain and F. Vahman, Leiden, 1988, 283-88; *Idea of Iran*, p. 3 with n. 1.

33. Clemen, *Fontes*, 28; Bidez and Cumont, *MH* II, pp. 30-31 (fr. B 19). Cf. Jacoby, *FGrHist* III A, Kommentar, pp. 42, 297.

34. Gnoli, *Idea of Iran*, 109-12, for the bibliographical references as well.

35. On the passage from Diodorus see too Gnoli, *Sīstān*, 23-62; A. Burton, *Diodorus Siculus, Book I. A Commentary* (Études préliminaires aux religions orientales dans l'Empire Romain, 29), Leiden, 1972, 4-5, 272-73.

36. Markwart, o. c. (see n. 28), pp. 23-24; Messina, *Ursprung*, 51.

37. See Mayrhofer, IPNB I, 1, pp. 105-106; *Zum Namengut des Awesta* (Österreichische Akademie der Wissenschaften, philos.-hist. Kl., Sitzungsberichte 308, 5), Wien, 1977, 43-53; "Zarathustra und kein Ende?", *AAASH*, 25, 1977, 85-90.

38. Gershevitch, "Approaches", 19-24, with the essential bibliography.

39. Cf. Bidez and Cumont, *MH* I, pp. 175-77; II, pp. 18-19, 271-75.

40. Messina, *Ursprung*, 51.

41. W. Tomaschek, "Ariane", *RE* II, 1, 1895, 813-14, and, for Strabo's testimony, H. Berger, *Die geographischen Fragmente des Eratosthenes*, Leipzig, 1880, 238. I have come back to it on several occasions: "Airyō.šayana", *RSO*, 41, 1966, 67-75; "Ἀριωνή. Postilla ad Airyō.šayana", *ib.*, pp. 329-34; *Sīstān*, 85; *ZTH*, 140-42; "Le dieu des Arya", *StIr*, 12, 1983, 7-22, at pp. 19-21; *De Z. à M.*, 68; "Βασιλεὺς βασιλέων Ἀριωνῶν", in *Orientalia Iosephi Tucci memoriae dicata*, ed. G. Gnoli and L. Lanciotti, II (SOR 56, 2), Roma, 1987, 509-32, at pp. 515-17; *Idea of Iran*, 77-78. The reader is referred to these works for the state of the matter and the bibliography.

42. Cf. Gnoli, *ZTH*, p. 145 n. 129, with reference to the remarks made by W. Hinz, *ZDMG*, 119, 1970, 374-75 (review of my *Sīstān*), at p. 375.

43. Gnoli, *Sīstān*, 62.

44. See A. Pagliaro and A. Bausani, *Storia della letteratura persiana*, Milano, 1960, 31-32.

45. As well as in the Avesta, of course: Gnoli, *ZTH*, p. 145 with n. 128.

46. Schneider, *De Diodori fontibus*, Berlin, 1880; E. Schwartz, "Hekataios

von Theos", *RhMus*, 60, 1885, 223-62; "Diodoros (von Agyrion)", *RE* V, 1, 1903, 663-704 (= *Griechische Geschichtsschreiber*, Leipzig, 1957, 35-97).

47. Burton, o. c. in n. 35, and Gnoli, *Sīstān*, 53-63.

48. Bidez and Cumont, *MH* I, pp. 7, 20, 24, 29; II, p. 30.

49. Jacoby, "Hekataios (aus Abdera)", *RE* VII, 2, 1912, 2750-69, at col. 2760; Reinhardt, "Hekataios von Abdera und Demokrit", *Hermes*, 47, 1912, 492-513.

50. Jacoby, *FGrHist* II C, Kommentar, p. 198; III A, Kommentar, p. 42. Cf. Gnoli, *Sīstān*, 54.

51. Volkmann, "Die indirekte Erzählung bei Diodor", *RhMus*, 98, 1955, 354-67, at pp. 363-64.

52. Spoerri, o. c. (see p. 82 n. 23), p. 6.

53. Pfligersdorffer, *Studien zu Poseidonios*, Wien, 1959, 145; but see Spoerri, "Zu Diodor von Sizilien I, 7/8", *Museum Helveticum*, 18, 1961, 63-82.

54. Burton, o. c. (see n. 35), pp. 31 and 5.

55. Murray, "Hecataeus of Abdera and Pharaonic kingship", *Journal of Aegyptian Archaeology*, 56, 1970, 141-71.

56. Markwart, o. c. (see n. 28), pp. 23-24.

57. For the fragments of Megasthenes see *FGrHist* 715 F 1-34 (= III C, pp. 603-39). Cf. A. Zambrini, "Gli Indiká di Megastene", *ASNP*, s. III, 12, 1982, 71-149; 15, 1985, 781-853; Daffinà, *Le relazioni tra Roma e l'India alla luce delle più recenti indagini* (Conferenze IsMEO, 7), Roma 1995, 11-12.

58. See above n. 28.

59. Ib., and see also Isnardi Parente, "Il papiro filosofico di Aī Khanoum", in *Studi su codici e papiri filosofici. Platone, Aristotele, Ierocle* (Accademia Toscana di Scienze e Lettere 'La Colombaria' – Studi, CXXIX), Firenze, 1992, 169-88, at p. 177.

60. See above nn. 6-8.

61. On Aristoxenus as a musician see A. Bélis, *Aristoxène de Tarente et Aristote. Le traité d'harmonique*, Paris, 1986; M.L. West, *Ancient Greek Music*, Oxford, 1992, 4-5, 225 ff. etc. For Aristoxenus' rhythmic theory see, in particular, L. Pearson, *Aristoxenus. Elementa Rhythmica. The fragment of Book II and the additional evidence for Aristoxenean rhythmic theory*, Oxford, 1990.

62. H. Diels, *Doxographi Graeci*, Berlin, 1879, 557; P. Wendland, *Hippolytus Werke*, III: *Refutatio omnium haeresium*, Leipzig, 1916, 7; Clemen, *Fontes*, 76; Bidez and Cumont, *MH* II, p. 63; Spoerri, "À propos d'un texte d'Hippolyte", *REA*, 57, 1955, 267-90, at p. 267; Zaehner, *Zurvan*, 447-48; U. Bianchi, *Zamān i Ōhrmazd. Lo Zoroastrismo nelle sue origini e nella sua essenza*, Torino, 1958, 170; Dörrie, *Platonismus*, 179 (translated

text), 459 (commentary). For the restoration of the text in the last sentence (in particular for φησὶν καὶ μουσικὴν instead of φύσιν καὶ μουσικὴν or φησὶν κατὰ μουσικὴν) see Spoerri, art. cit., p. 271 n. 1, and Kingsley, "Greek origin", p. 249 n. 1.

63. Fox and Pemberton, *Passages*, 82, are wrong in translating the verb in the plural, because the unexpressed subject cannot be anyone but Pythagoras, to whom chapter II of the first book of the *Refutatio* is entirely devoted, as Spoerri, art. cit., pp. 270, 271 n. 1, does well to point out, bearing in mind the critics' agreement over this point.

64. For the sources: Jackson, *Zoroaster*, p. 7 n. 5; Bidez and Cumont, *MH* I, pp. 33-38, 103-106, 108; II, pp. 35-40 (B25a: Hippolytus; B25b: Plutarch; B26a: Clement of Alexandria; B26b: Cyril; B27: Porphyry; B28a and B28b: Apuleius; B29a: Suidas; B29b: Schol. Plato, *In Rempubl.*, etc.).

65. Bidez and Cumont, *MH* I, p. 37.

66. *FGrHist* 273 F 94; Clemen, *Fontes*, 68; Bidez and Cumont, *MH* II, p. 36 (B 26a); Dörrie, *Platonismus*, 179 (translated text), 460 (commentary); Kingsley, "Greek origin", p. 257 with n. 76.

67. Bousset, *Hauptprobleme*, 373-78. Cf. Kingsley, "Greek origin", p. 253 with n. 47.

68. Bidez and Cumont, *MH* I, pp. 37-38; II, p. 12 n. 9. On the other hand Dörrie, *Platonismus*, p. 459 n. 7, is mistaken in thinking it possible that Aristoxenus made a distinction between Zoroaster and Zaratas, taking the latter as a more recent disciple of the former.

69. See in particular Cameron, "AS".

70. *Ib.*, p. 81. As for the Magi-Chaldaean connection, which goes back to the early Academy, see now the decisive remarks made by Kingsley, that I have already mentioned (see above p. 96 f.).

71. On which see the positions held by W.K.C. Guthrie (*A History of Greek Philosophy*, I, Cambridge, 1962, 252-53) and W. Burkert (*Lore and Science in Ancient Pythagoreanism*, Cambridge, Mass., 1972, 112, 166-72, 360, 441-42), amongst others, and now Kingsley's as well ("Greek origin", 255-56).

72. See for instance the different opinions of Bousset, *Hauptprobleme*, 153-4; Zeller, *Die Philosophie der Griechen in ihrer geschichtlichen Entwicklung*, I, 1, 6th ed., Leipzig, 1919, p. 385 n. 1; Clemen, *Nachrichten*, 20-1; A. Delatte, *La vie de Pythagore*, Bruxelles, 1922, 160; I. Lévy, *Recherches sur les sources de la légende de Pythagore*, Paris, 1926, 82; Jacoby, *FGrHist* III A, Kommentar, p. 297; Spoerri, art. cit. (see n. 62), pp. 272-73.

73. Kingsley, "Greek origin", 249-56, with an exhaustive state of the matter and with conclusions which seem to me convincing. He rightly points

out that the passage from Hippolytus is interesting "because it very probably contains an underlying stratum of genuine Zoroastrian teaching", noting that scholars such as Bousset, *Hauptprobleme*, 153, Bidez, o. c. (see p. 87 n. 94), p. 16; Zaehner, *Zurvan*, 72-74, and M.L. West, o. c. (see p. 92 n. 170), p. 32, "all assume the passage is by Aristoxenus" (p. 248 with n. 17). Zaehner, however, mentions only Hippolytus.

74. Kingsley, *ib.*, p. 256.

75. Dörrie, *Platonismus*, 459.

76. Windischmann, *Studien*, 260-4; Clemen, *Nachrichten*, 20-22; Bidez and Cumont, *MH I*, pp. 33, 38, 103; Duchesne-Guillemin, *OA*, 8-9; Altheim, *Weltgeschichte Asiens im griechischen Zeitalter*, I, Halle (Saale), 1947, 107-108, 111; Altheim and Stiehl, *SA*, 41; *GMA*, 30.

77. Duchesne-Guillemin, *OA*, 9.

78. Altheim and Stiehl, *GMA*, 30, with the same words they used in *SA*, 41.

79. Bidez and Cumont, *MH I*, p. 17; Dörrie, *Platonismus*, p. 459 n. 7; Kingsley, "Greek origin", 262.

80. Klíma, "The date of Zoroaster", *ArOr*, 27, 1959, 556-64.

81. Duchesne-Guillemin, *RIA*, 137, note from the previous page.

82. Barr, *Avesta oversat og forklaret* (Verdensreligionernes Hovedværker), København, 1954, 39.

83. Duchesne-Guillemin, "La religion des Achéménides", in *Beiträge zur Achämenidengeschichte* (*Historia – Einzelschriften*, 18), ed. G. Walser, Wiesbaden, 1972, 59-82, at pp. 61-62.

84. Gershevitch, "Approaches", 14-15.

85. Kingsley, "Greek origin", 245.

86. Boyce, *Zoroastrianism: a shadowy but powerful presence ...* (see p. 35 n. 6), p. 4. Cf. Kingsley, *loc. cit.*, and the remarks made in this connection by Gershevitch, "Approaches", 15.

87. Boyce, *HZ I*, pp. 3-7, 190-91; *II*, pp. 1-3; Shahbazi, "Date of Z.", 31; Gnoli, *ZTH*, 159-79. Cf. Kingsley, "Greek origin", p. 245 n. 4.

88. *Ib.*, p. 245.

89. Hartman, *Gayōmart. Étude sur le syncrétisme dans l'ancien Iran*, Uppsala, 1953, p. 149 n. 6.

90. Kingsley, "Greek origin", p. 245 n. 2.

91. Bidez and Cumont, *MH I*, p. 63; Nock, *art. cit.* (see p. 84 n. 53), p. 277 (= *Essays II*, p. 689); M.L. West, o. c. (see p. 92 n. 170), p. 240.

92. Gershevitch, "Approaches", 15.

93. Jacoby, *Apollodors Chronik*, Berlin, 1902, 215-27, and see Kingsley, "Greek origin", p. 260 n. 90, with further bibliographical information.

94. Kingsley, *ib.*, pp. 257 and 260.

95. *Ib.*, p. 260 n. 94. In this regard Kingsley refers also to Porphyry's *Life of Pythagoras* (Aristoxenus fr. 16 Wehrli) and, on the relation between Aristoxenus and Apollodorus, to A.H. Mosshammer, *The Chronicle of Eusebius and Greek Chronographic Tradition*, Lewisburg, 1979, 119-20, 124, 278, 285. Useful reading is provided by Mosshammer's excursus: "The chronological method of Apollodorus" (pp. 113-27). On our subject see also J. Burnet, *Early Greek Philosophy*, 4th ed., London, 1930, p. 88 n. 1.

96. Cf. Kingsley, "Greek origin", p. 260 n. 92.

97. Bidez and Cumont, *MH* I, pp. 81-84; Bolton, *Aristeas of Proconnesus*, Oxford, 1962, p. 159 n. 25.

98. Kingsley, "Greek origin", 263-64.

99. Gottschalk, *Heraclides of Pontus*, Oxford, 1980, 111-12, 114-15.

100. *Moral.* 1115a (Heraclides fr. 68 Wehrli). Cf. Kingsley, "Greek origin", p. 263 with n. 114.

101. *Ib.*, p. 263.

102. Burkert, o. c. (see n. 71), p. 107; Gottschalk (see n. 99), p. 139 n. 41.

103. Kingsley, "Greek origin", p. 264 n. 121.

104. Bidez and Cumont, *MH* II, pp. 38-39.

105. *FGrHist* 252 B 7; 2 B, Kommentar, p. 829.

106. Mosshammer, *Georgii Syncelli ecloga chronographica*, Leipzig, 1984, 249.

107. J. Dillon and J. Hershbelle, *Iamblichus, On the Pythagorean Way of Life*, Atlanta, Georgia, 1991, 45.

108. Bidez and Cumont, loc. cit. in n. 104. There is no intrinsic need for Kingsley's deductions ("Greek origin", 263) on the meaning of *ac praecipue*.

109. Wehrli, o. c. (see n. 6), p. 50; Burkert, o. c. (see n. 71), p. 177 n. 8.

110. Dillon and Hershbelle, o. c. (see n. 107), p. 45 n. 2.

111. *FGrHist* 685 F 5. See Windischmann, *Studien*, 260.

112. Schnabel, *Berosus und die babylonisch-hellenistische Literatur*, Leipzig-Berlin, 1923, 143-47.

113. E. Schwartz, "Abydenos", *RE* I, 1, 1894, 129; Schnabel, o. c., pp. 164-66; S.M. Burstein, *The Babyloniaca of Berosus*, (Sources from the Ancient Near East, 1/5), Malibu, 1978, p. 6 with n. 11.

114. Burstein, *ib.*, p. 25 with n. 91, and p. 6 n. 10.

115. *FGrHist* 273 F 94; Clemen, *Fontes*, 68; Bidez and Cumont, *MH* II, p. 36.

116. Jacoby, *FGrHist* 3 A, Kommentar, pp. 294-98; Kingsley, "Greek origin", 257-59.

117. But unfortunately in Clement the "later" has no clear sequel. See, however, Kingsley, *ib.*, p. 257 for the translation and p. 258 n. 83.

118. Jacoby, *FGrHist* 3 A, Kommentar, p. 297.
119. Kingsley, "Greek origin", p. 258 n. 83 and p. 259.
120. M. Hengel, "The interpenetration of Judaism and Hellenism in the pre-Maccabean period", *CHJ* II, 1989, 167-228, at p. 200.
121. Cf. E. Schürer, *The History of the Jewish People in the Age of Jesus Christ*, revised English ed. by G. Vermes, F. Millar and M. Goodman, Edinburgh, 1986, III, 1, p. 696; Kingsley, "Greek origin", p. 258 n. 82.
122. Schürer, o. c., p. 582; Bidez and Cumont, *MH* I, p. 41; H. Hegermann, "The Diaspora in the Hellenistic age", *CHJ* II, 1989, 115-66, at p. 156; Hengel, art. cit., p. 201; E. Gabba, "The growth of anti-Judaism or the Greek attitude towards Jews", ib., 614-56, at p. 638. See also Momigliano, *Alien Wisdom*, 84, who does not find it incredible, in any case, that some parts of the Torah were translated before the Septuagint.
123. Momigliano, ib., pp. 121-22.
124. Gabba, art. cit., p. 652.
125. Schürer, o. c. (see n. 121), pp. 513-17; Hegermann, art. cit. (see n. 122), p. 137. Cf. A.-M. Denis, *Fragmenta Pseudepigraphorum quae supersunt Graeca una cum historicorum et auctorum Iudaeorum hellenistarum fragmentis* (Pseudepigrapha Veteris Testamenti Graece, 3b), Leiden, 1970, 175-79; Hengel, *Juden, Griechen und Barbaren. Aspekte der Hellenisierung des Judentums in vorchristlichen Zeit*, Stuttgart, 1976, 134-41.
126. Momigliano, o. c. (see p. 91 n. 152), pp. 79-80.
127. Kingsley, "Greek origin", 257.
128. Jacoby, *FGrHist* 3A, Kommentar, p. 298. On Ezekiel's vision of a throne near Babylon in 593 B.C., on the great canal that joined the Tigris to the Euphrates, see also Kingsley, "Ezekiel by the Grand Canal: between Jewish and Babylonian tradition", *JRAS*, 1992, 339-46.
129. Kingsley, loc. cit. in n. 127. Kingsley refers to Shahbazi, "Date of Z.", 31-32, and to Boyce, *Zoroastrians*, 92-93; *HZ* II, pp. 68-69, as well to Gnoli, *ZTH*, 166-75 (although the theory I proposed then was based on other arguments).
130. Kingsley, "Greek origin", p. 258 n. 78. Kingsley refers to *Ezekiel*, chapters 1, 8, 10 etc. with regard to fire, and chapter 37 with regard to resurrection. On this problem see also Boyce, *HZ* III, p. 439.
131. Kingsley, ib., pp. 257-58 with n. 79, with references to Bousset, *Hauptprobleme*, 369-82 ("Nimrod und Zoroaster", and "Zoroaster-Seth"); to Bidez and Cumont, *MH* I, pp. 41-50; and, "on the later period of the trend", to J. Horowitz, "Hebrew-Iranian synchronisms", in *Oriental Studies in honour of C.E. Pavry* (see p. 40 n. 76), 151-55.
132. According to Theodore bar Kōnay in his *Liber scholiorum*: Bidez

and Cumont, *MH* II, p. 129 with n. 2 (and cf. I, p. 49 n. 2). On this text see in particular Messina, *Magi a Betlemme*, 59-60.

133. Cf. Boyce, *HZ* III, pp. 439-40, and, for bibliographical references, E.M. Yamauchi, *Persia and the Bible*, Grand Rapids, Mich., 1990, 460-61.

134. Cf. Bickerman, "The Babylonian captivity", *CHJ* I, 1984, 326-400, at pp. 342-58; R. Zadok, *The Jews in Babylonia in the Chaldaean and Achaemenian Periods in the Light of Babylonian Sources*, Tel Aviv, 1976.

135. Bidez and Cumont, *MH* II, pp. 41-50.

136. Bidez and Cumont, *MH* I, p. 36, with source references. See also Messina, *Ursprung*, 60-66; Beck, o. c. (see n. 25), pp. 523-25.

137. Bousset, *Hauptprobleme*, 369-78.

138. Bidez and Cumont, *MH* I, p. 42.

139. *Ib.*, II, pp. 45-46 (B 37); *FGrHist* 680 F *5b. See also Burstein, o. c. (see n. 113), p. 33 with n. 13.

140. van der Horst, *Essays on the Jewish World of Early Christianity*, Freiburg Schweiz-Göttingen, 1990, 230.

141. D. Winston, "The Iranian component in the Bible, Apocrypha, and Qumran: a review of the evidence", *HR*, 5, 1966, 183-216, at pp. 184-85, with references. Cf. Bidez and Cumont, *MH* I, p. 41; II, pp. 43 and 48 (B 35a: Eusebius; B 41: Petrus Comestor). See also H. Windisch, *Die Orakel des Hystaspes* (Koninklijke Akademie van Wetenschappen), Amsterdam, 1929, 17-18. On Abraham as the inventor of astrology; A. Bouché-Leclercq, *L'astrologie grecque*, Paris, 1899, p. 578 n. 1. On Abraham and the Magi: Russell, "Our father Abraham and the Magi", *JCOI*, 54, 1987, 58-67.

142. Bousset, *Hauptprobleme*, 378-82 (excursus VI to Chapter III).

143. Klijn, *Seth in Jewish, Christian and Gnostic Literature* (Supplements to *Novum Testamentum*, 46), Leiden, 1977, 53-60.

144. Cf. Gottheil, "References", pp. 27, 30 n. 1; Jackson, "Date of Z.", 6 (= *Zoroaster*, 157); Messina, *Magi a Betlemme*, 59-61, 69-71, 84; Bidez and Cumont, *MH* I, pp. 49-50; Widengren, *Iranisch-semitische Kulturbegegnung in parthischer Zeit* (Arbeitsgemeinschaft für Forschung des Landes Nordrhein - Westfalen, 70), Köln - Opladen, 1960, 46; Winston, art. cit. (see n. 141), pp. 214-15; Hultgård, "Das Judentum in der hellenistisch-römischen Zeit und die iranische Religion - ein religionshistorisches Problem", in *Principat* (ANRW II, 19, 1), Berlin - New York, 1979, 512-90, at p. 578; Boyce, *HZ* III, p. 438.

145. Cf. Gottheil, "References", 28-29; Jackson, "Date of Z.", 13 (= *Zoroaster*, 165-66); *Zoroaster*, 30; Reitzenstein, *Das iranische Erlösungsmysterium. Religionsgeschichtliche Untersuchungen*, Bonn, 1921, 100-102; Messina, *Magi a Betlemme*, 61; Bidez and Cumont, *MH* I, pp. 49-50; Widen-

gren, loc. cit.; J. Teixidor, "Reflexiones sobre el Zoroastro siriano", *Orientalia Christiana Periodica*, 28, 1962, 181-85, at p. 185; Winston, loc. cit.; Hultgård, loc. cit.; Boyce, loc. cit.

146. Cf. Gottheil, "References", 36-37; Jackson, loc. cit.; Bidez and Cumont, *MH* I, p. 49 n. 4; Winston, loc. cit.; Boyce, loc. cit.

147. Winston, art. cit., pp. 216-17, with a discussion of the thesis of J. Neusner ("Note on Baruch ben Neriah and Zoroaster", *Numen*, 12, 1965, 66-69), according to which the identification of Zoroaster with Baruch was Christian and not Jewish.

148. Bidez and Cumont, *MH* I, p. 41; Winston, art. cit., pp. 183-84; Momigliano, *Alien Wisdom*, 93 and chapters, IV and V; Hultgård, art. cit. (see n. 144), p. 579; Boyce, *HZ* III, p. 436.

149. On Eupolemus as a source for Alexander Polyhistor see in particular B.Z. Wacholder, *Eupolemus. A study of Judaeo-Greek literature*, Cincinnati, 1974, 44-52. On Pseudo-Eupolemus, a Samaritan writer who was a typical representative of the tendency to Judaize figures belonging to other cultural traditions: Wacholder, "Pseudo-Eupolemus' two Greek fragments on the life of Abraham", *HUCA*, 34, 1963, 83-113; N. Walter, "Zu Pseudo-Eupolemos", *Klio*, 43-45, 1965, 282-90; Hengel, *Judentum und Hellenismus. Studien zu ihrer Begegnung unter besonderer Berücksichtigung Palästinas bis zur Mitte des 2. Jhs. v. Chr.*, 2nd ed., Tübingen, 1973, 162-64; Gabba, art. cit. (see n. 122), p. 639; J.D. Purvis, "The Samaritans", *CHJ* II, 1989, 591-613, at pp. 606-607; Walter, "Jewish-Greek literature of the Greek period", *ib.*, 385-408, at pp. 399-400. Useful references to other Jewish-Greek writers, such as Demetrius, Aristobulus, Artapanus, who showed substantially the same tendency to assert the primacy of Israel, can be found in other contributions to the second volume of the *Cambridge History of Judaism* (1989).

150. Hengel, art. cit. (see n. 120), pp. 217-18.

151. For the main bibliographical references see Gnoli, "Ebraismo e cultura iranica", in *Ebrei in Asia e Africa. Il contributo della Diaspora alle culture e allo sviluppo dell'Asia, dell'Africa e del Mondo Mediterraneo* (Orientalia Karalitana, Quaderni dell'Istituto di Studi Africani e Orientali, 3), Cagliari, 1998, 103-14, at pp. 112-14.

152. *DkM* 433. 9-13. Cf. J.-P. de Menasce, *Une encyclopédie mazdéenne. Le Dēnkart. Quatre conférences données à l'Université de Paris sous les auspices de la Fondation Ratanbai Katrak* (Bibliothèque de l'École des Hautes Études, Section des Sciences religieuses, 69), Paris, 1958, 30.

153. Jackson, "Date of Z.", 10 (= *Zoroaster*, 162-63); *Zoroaster*, 209; L.H. Gray, "Kai Luhrasp and Nebuchadrezzar", *WZKM*, 18, 1904, 291-98; Horowitz, art. cit. (see n. 131), 154-55; de Menasce, *o. c.*, pp. 29-31; Gnoli,

“A proposito di un aspetto della leggenda di Salomone in Iran”, *AIUON*, n. s. 18, 1968, 79-84, at p. 83 n. 1. Horowitz makes appropriate mention of the list of the kings of Iran preserved in the Mandaean *Ginzā* (cf. M. Lidzbarski, *Ginzā. Der Schatz oder das große Buch der Mandäer*, Göttingen, 1925, 477), on which see Gray, “The kings of early Irān according to the Sidrā Rabbā”, *ZA*, 19, 1906, 272-87, and cf. Widengren, o. c. (see n. 144), p. 49.

154. Horowitz, art. cit., p. 154. Darmesteter (“Textes pehlevi relatifs au Judaïsme”, *REJ*, 18-19, 1889, 1-15 and 41-56) thought of the Sassanian period, but it is not impossible, in some cases, to go further back.

155. Gnoli, art. cit. (see n. 153), p. 84. See also, more recently, S. Shaked, “Zoroastrian polemics against Jews in the Sasanian and early Islamic period”, in *Irano-Judaica II*, ed. S. Shaked and A. Netzer, Jerusalem, 1990, 85-104, at p. 90.

156. See p. 13 nn. 37 and 38.

Zoroaster 258 years before Alexander

HERODOTUS (IV, 98) TELLS HOW DARIUS I, upon reaching the Danube after his victory over the Getae, tied sixty knots in a strap and, having summoned the tyrants of the Ionians, told them to undo one of the knots every day, starting from the day of his departure for the Scythian expedition. For all this time they were to guard the bridge of boats that had been thrown across the river, while they waited for his return with the army.¹ We can see from this passage what we would naturally expect, that is to say, that the Persians were not indifferent to the calculation of time and that they were not without means, however rudimentary, to cope with this basic need.

Referring to Herodotus' report, Elias J. Bickerman displayed a not very high opinion of their capacity, in the 5th century B.C., to effect computations concerning calendrical problems,² but Willy Hartner has rightly pointed that this episode cannot be taken for proof of lack of mathematical insight on the part of the Persians, because "it proves nothing, for even a skilled mathematician may get confused without such a primitive aid to memory".³ What is important to us here is that, in any case, the Persians were certainly not heedless of the necessity to calculate time for practical needs as well. Therefore we cannot see any logical reason why

they should not be able to calculate lapses of time of even more than two months. This means that we have no sound reason for supposing that the first disciples of Zoroaster and the Magi were not capable of counting the years from Zoroaster onwards or, as we have said (see p. 79) and as we shall see still more clearly (see p. 165), from the date of the advent of the Good Religion, which according to tradition corresponded to the thirtieth year in the life of their prophet. Any scepticism over this matter is quite unjustified. It is not at all surprising that a religious tradition was not indifferent to a calculation of time connected to the life of its founder. Whatever confidence we may have, for example, in the 'dotted record' in reconstructing the historical date of the Nirvāṇa, we must at least admit that sooner or later the Buddhist tradition paid particular attention to the most important event in the life of Śākyamuni.⁴ We must not confuse calculations of this kind with the dating systems that mark the events in the civil and political history of a nation. We do not mean that the Persians of the Achaemenian period had elaborated the idea of an era in the true sense of the word, one that could be used for civil and essentially profane purposes. As we know, an achievement of this type goes back to Antiochus I, that is, not to the Achaemenians but to the Seleucids. Although they continued to date events by the regnal years of the reigning monarch, it was to be the Sassanians who identified a religious era of this type, the era of Zoroaster, with the Seleucid era, which was not a foreign era for them (see p. 143). The studies of H. Lewy, Taqizadeh and Henning have thrown light on this important historical and chronological problem, that Gershevitch has also taken up again recently.

In actual fact, in dealing with these arguments or with the subject of the connections between chronography and history, we must be careful of the common tendency to make generalizations, such as saying that the Persians had absolutely no sense of history, for which we would have to suppose, as Daffinà wrote, "a chronological axis with all the past marked off on it right down our time, by means of which any point of the past could be reached and so

become present”.⁵ On the Persians and history, I shall take the liberty of referring the reader to an article of mine that has already appeared, “Iranic identity as a historical problem”, and another one that is to be published shortly, in the proceedings of the conference on “Presentazione e scrittura della storia” that was held at the Certosa di Pontignano (Siena) in April 1996.⁶ In these articles, in discussing the theories of scholars such as Arnaldo Momigliano or John Van Seters,⁷ I have tried to throw light on the value of Persian historiography which, together with Jewish historiography, is considered as an end-point in the *Geschichtsschreibung* of the Ancient Near East.

As for the possible connection between a cyclic conception of time and a chronological calculation expressed as years of an Olympiad or a sovereign’s rule or magistrate’s office, on the one hand, and on the other, a linear conception of time and a continuous reckoning of the years in eras, I think we must agree that it is, in point of fact, far more problematical than it looks at first sight, if one has philosophical or theological or historico-religious interests,⁸ as Santo Mazzarino, for instance, has demonstrated in a long note in his *Pensiero storico classico*.⁹ These very same categories of cyclic time and linear time reveal an obvious weakness to whoever enquires into them from a strictly historical viewpoint, like Momigliano in his contribution “Time in ancient historiography”, that also took into consideration a study by Hermann Fränkel.¹⁰ I, too, think we can certainly say that, just as the Romans dated events by consular years but for religious purposes they also made a continuous calculation of the years by fixing the *clavus annalis* to a wall of the temple of Jupiter Optimus Maximus on the ides of September, as we know from Livy VII, 3, 5-7¹¹ (or else, out of mainly literary habit, they used the diastematic system *ab urbe condita*),¹² in the same way those Iranians who thought of themselves as successors or disciples of Zoroaster did not fail to calculate, with the means available to them, the amount of time that elapsed starting from an epoch-making event in the life of their prophet. On the other hand, there is distinct evidence for two

systems of dating in the Sassanian period, a continuous calculation of the years according to the era of Zoroaster (= Seleucid era) and a traditional calculation according to the regnal years of the sovereign.

I have already mentioned the reasons that made me change my negative attitude towards the historical value of the date that placed Zoroaster 258 years before Alexander (see p. 17 ff.). This date belonged to a different chronological calculation from the one that reckoned a duration of the Good Religion in a pure and uncontaminated state for 300 years before the cursed Alexander, according to what is said in the *Ardā Wirāz Nāmag* I and in *Wizīdagihā ī Zādspram* XXV (see p. 137). For this reason the first date cannot be explained as the result of the subtraction of 42 years (the age at which Zoroaster was said to have converted Vīštāspa) from the 300 years. What is more, the first was used in the calculation of the 538 years that separated the official beginning of Sassanian rule from the beginning of the Seleucid era, i.e. the Julian year 312/1 B.C.¹³ These 538 years consisted of a period of time that was divided into three parts: the 258 years, 14 years for the reign of Alexander and 266 years that were attributed to the Arsacid dynasty. H. Lewy and Taqizadeh have in fact shown that the Sassanians identified the beginning of the tenth millennium, the millennium of Zoroaster, with the epochal year of the Seleucid era.¹⁴ Therefore the two chronological calculations had nothing to do with each other, except for the reference to the arrival of the Macedonian conqueror as being the moment of greatest crisis in the religious tradition and — we might add — in the political history of Iran.

The sources for the traditional date are well known: the *Bundahišn* (*GBd.* XXXVI, 8-9; *IndBd.* XXXIV, 8-9); Mas'udi in his *Moruj al-ḡahab* IV, 107;¹⁵ Biruni in his *Ātār al-bāqia* III, 14; VI, 105; VIII, 213.¹⁶ To these can be added other sources such as the *Mojmal al-tawāriḡ wa'l-qeṣaṣ*,¹⁷ the tale about the cypress of Kašmar in the *Dabestān-e maḡāheb*,¹⁸ the *Tāriḡ-e Beyhaq*,¹⁹ or the evidence in Ṭabari²⁰ and in other sources of the Islamic period

which, by ascribing 266 years to the Arsacids, seem to fall into line with the calculation of the 538 years divided into $258 + 14 + 266$. This calculation was in all likelihood codified in the Sassanian *Xwādāy Nāmag*,²¹ whereas the information given by Theodore bar Kōnay in his *Book of Scholia*, which probably goes back as far as Theodore of Mopsuestia (beginning of the fifth century), should probably be explained in another way (see p. 158). The evidence given by these sources has been thoroughly investigated and so it is not necessary to spend any length of time on them or on their interpretation: the reader is referred to the aforementioned studies by H. Lewy and Taqizadeh and, of course, to the subsequent use made of them by Henning, whose validity has been confirmed once more by Gershevitch, with sound arguments.²²

Before going any further, it will be worth while observing that the figures 258 and 300 referring to the years before Alexander speak in favour of what we have called the late chronology, according to which Zoroaster should be dated to the 6th century B.C. Whatever its origin may have been (and we shall come back to this later), the second figure could hardly have gained a footing if there had not been the conviction that Zoroaster actually had lived between the end of the 7th and the first half of the 6th century B.C. If we were to succeed in proving that the first figure has the value of a perfectly plausible historical date, in confirmation of the results obtained by H. Lewy, Taqizadeh, Henning and Gershevitch, we could deduce that the second figure became generally accepted for the very reason that it did not drastically contradict the first one, but on the contrary corroborated it to some extent by placing the prophet roughly at the beginning of Medo-Persian rule.

We have said that the main point of reference for the chronological calculation on which the traditional date is based is the one represented by the name 'Alexander' and that it was also common to the tradition which placed Zoroaster 300 years before the great crisis that overwhelmed the monarchy and the religion of Iran. Now, the origin of a lot of uncertainty and of great confusion lies precisely in the meaning that is given to 'Alexander'.

Many have maintained, in fact, that the name of the Macedonian contained a distinct reference to the Seleucid era, on the ground of the fact that this could also be called 'era of Alexander' according to some late sources and an initial error made by Biruni (see below). This opinion has met with the agreement of Herzfeld, Altheim and Stiehl, Shahbazi and the present author,²³ though from different viewpoints and with different conclusions. It is, however, if we look at the matter closely, a mistaken opinion that is proved wrong by the available sources. There can be no doubt that, by 'Alexander', reference was made to 330 B.C.: the death of Darius III in the summer of that year was surely an epoch-making event for the Persians because it marked the end of the Persian empire.²⁴ There are numerous, unmistakable testimonies that bear witness to the importance given by the Magi to that event.

We must say, first of all, that the *Bundahišn* calculates 258 years up till the end of the reign of Dārā ī Dārāyān (Darius III). As for Biruni, it is true that he speaks of the time between Zoroaster and the era of Alexander (*ta'rik al-Eskandar*), meaning by this the Seleucid era, but it is equally true that he later corrected himself in his *Qānun al-Mas'udi* and in an apology for his mistake,²⁵ placing the prophet 276 before the 'era of Alexander': this has been pointed out by Taqizadeh, and confirmed by Henning.²⁶ Bickerman has rightly remarked that "the Arabs called the Seleucid reckoning the era of Alexander, though Biruni recognized this error".²⁷ Another victim of this error, in his *Moḍākarāt*, was Abu Ma'shar Bal'ki (787-886), the Bactrian astronomer who dated Zoroaster 240 years before the death of Dārā,²⁸ and Biruni's fundamental correction of this perplexed Herzfeld, Altheim and Stiehl,²⁹ and implicitly Shahbazi, who actually reached the unlikely conclusion that Biruni had not been wrong in his *Chronology*, but evidently in admitting his mistake.³⁰ But there can be no doubt that Biruni's initial error was the same as Abu Ma'shar's: the 18 years should not be subtracted from 258 ($258 - 18 = 240$), but from the 276 that Biruni gives in his *al-Qānun al-Mas'udi*, because this figure obviously refers to the period that elapsed be-

tween 330 and 312/1, since 330 B.C. was the epochal year that our sources indicate by the name 'Alexander'.

On the other hand, as we have said, the sources for the 300 years of the Good Religion before Alexander refer quite clearly to the end of the reign of Darius III, with their insistence on the cursed effects of the Macedonian conqueror's invasion. And so, in *Ardā Wirāz Nāmag* I, 1-7, we read that after 300 years had passed from the time when Zoroaster had propagated throughout the world the religion that he had received (*kū ēw-bār ahlaw Zarduxšt dēn ī padīrift andar gēhān rawāg be kard tā bowandagīh ī sē sad sāl*), the accursed Evil Spirit (*gizistag gannāg mēnōg*) roused up the accursed Alexander, the Greek who lived in Egypt, (*gizistag Aleksandar ī hrōmāyīg ī muzrāyīg mānišn*), who came to Ērānšahr, wielding heavy tyranny there, bringing fight and sickness (*pad garān sezd ud nibard ud yask*) killing the Iranian ruler and destroying the Court and the monarchy (*u-š ōy Ērān dahibed ōzad ud dar ud xwadāyīh wišuft ud awērān kard*). This Ahrimanian scourge carried off all the Avesta and the Zand (*hamāg abestāg ud zand*), in order to burn them (*abar āwurd ud be sōxt*), from the store of archives of Staxr-Pābagān, the fortress of the scriptures (*diz ī nibišt*) — the Ka'be-ye Zardošt, as Henning explained³¹ — he killed many *dastur*, judges, teacher priests, magi, worshippers, skilled and wise men of Ērānšahr, casting the seed of hatred and discord among the magnates and householders of Ērānšahr (*ud čand dastwarān ud dādwarān ud hērbedān ud mowbedān ud dēn-burdārān ud abzārōmandān ud dānagān ī Ērānšahr rāy be kušt ud mehān ud kadag-xwadāyān ī Ērānšahr ēk abāg did kēn ud anāštīh ō mayān abgand*).³² Likewise the *Wizīdagīhā ī Zādspram* XXV, 12 state that "in the three-hundredth year there will be night during the day, after which the religion will be disturbed and the monarchy shattered": *pad sē sad sālag andar rōz šabīh bawēd pas dēn ašōbīhēd ud xwadāyīh čandīhēd*.³³ Similarly, the second 'Olamā'-e *Eslām*, 33, says that for the followers of the Religion everything went well for three hundred years until the arrival of Alexander and the great confusion that stemmed therefrom.³⁴

On the other hand, there is no difference in the meaning that Alexander's coming had for the Zoroastrians in the Muslim sources either. There is a famous passage by Mas'udi in his *Ketāb al-tanbih wa'l-ešrāf*,³⁵ which has been translated and commented on several times.³⁶ In it Mas'udi, unlike what he says in *Moruj al-dahab* (see p. 134), reports that Zoroaster foresaw, in the Avesta, that at the end of 300 years the Persian empire would suffer a great upheaval which the religion would nevertheless survive, and a final catastrophe for the empire and the religion too at the end of 1000 years, revealing that between Zoroaster and Alexander there had elapsed 'about' (*naḥwa*) three hundred years. If the expression 'about 300 years' can be justified by the 258 years which Mas'udi also speaks about elsewhere, as Gershevitch has aptly pointed out,³⁷ the said passage clearly testifies that the coming of Alexander was in any case the fixed reference point of a great crisis, evidently also for those who placed it 300 years after Zoroaster. We shall come back later on to this different chronological calculation of the 300 years, but now we shall dwell still further on the epochal year of 'Alexander', that is, on the death of Darius III in the summer of 330 B.C.

That year was used by the Zoroastrian Magi as a starting point to date important events, going both backwards and forwards in time: it was the 258th year after Zoroaster and at the same time it was the year from which subsequent events were dated. And it is precisely this that emphasizes its epochal importance. We have, in this connection, an unmistakable piece of evidence. A passage from an 11th-century Arabian writer, Abu 'Abdallāh Moḥammad al-Qoṣṭā'i (d. 1062),³⁸ is highly significant as proof of the importance that the slaying of the last Achaemenian had in Persian chronology. It was quoted by Edward Pocock in his *Specimen historiae Arabum* (1649),³⁹ by Ludwig Ideler in his *Handbuch der mathematischen und technischen Chronologie*, by Édouard Drouin in his essay on the era of Yazdegard and the Persian calendar, by Terrien de Lacouperie, by F.K. Ginzel, and then by Taqizadeh,⁴⁰ but even so it has not attracted the attention that it deserves.

As a matter of fact, this passage gives us a valuable piece of information about the reckoning of time amongst the Magi: first starting from Adam, i.e. from Gayōmart, then from the slaying of Darius III and the coming of Alexander, then from the coming of Ardaxšīr, and lastly from king Yazdegard and the envoy of the Prophet. Taqizadeh, in the three places mentioned above, did not deduce all the possible implications, but confined himself to the statement that it is further proof of the fact that the Persians had used an era of Ardaxšīr or a Sassanian era. But the passage tells us much more than this: in the first place, that the Magi were used to the continuous calculation of time,⁴¹ secondly, that the calculation starting from Adam, or Gayōmart, was undoubtedly the one that conformed to the millenary doctrine, since Gayōmart was at the beginning of the 7th millennium, corresponding to the 1st millennium of the 'Mixed State'; thirdly, that the death of Darius III coincided with the coming of Alexander and consequently the year in which it happened could be used as an epochal year neither more nor less than the year of Yazdegard's accession (era of Yazdegard) or death (Magian or *pārsīg* era); fourth, that there had been an era of Ardaxšīr, of which at the time of Pocock, Ideler, Drouin, Terrien de Lacouperie or Ginzler, and even at the time of Taqizadeh's early works, there was not to be had the proof that emerged with the discovery of the inscription of Šābuhr I at Bīšābuhr, published by Roman Ghirshman in 1936;⁴² fifth, that the Magian or *pārsīg* era had had a very similar precedent in the above-mentioned case of a calculation of time starting from the end of the Achaemenian empire with the assassination of its last sovereign.

As for the era of Ardaxšīr, which seems to be attested in al-Qoṣṣā'i, it is very likely that it was the same as the one in the Bīšābuhr inscription, that was dated to the year 58 of an era that corresponded to the year 40 of the 'fire' of Ardaxšīr and to year 24 of the 'fire' of Šābuhr: that is to say, an era whose epochal year must have been 208/9,⁴³ or, perhaps more precisely, 205/6.⁴⁴ We cannot rule out that the epochal year of this Sassanian era was

linked not with Ardashīr but with one of his predecessors, such as Pābag himself. In any case, even if that date did not refer to an event in the career of Ardashīr before his ascent to the throne as 'King of kings', the era it had begun could well have taken the name of the founder of Sassanian power later on. The Bīšābuhr inscription has therefore confirmed the evidence given by al-Qoṣṣā'i: it was not for nothing that Ginzel, thirty years before the discovery of the inscription, included the era of Ardashīr amongst the other Persian eras, compared with the era of Yazdegard.⁴⁵

However that may be, as far as the continuous calculation of the years from the coming of Alexander and the coming of Ardashīr is concerned, we must make some clarifications. As for the epochal year of the death of Darius III, it will be useful to clear the field of a possible misunderstanding. When we state that 330 B.C. had been an epochal year for the Zoroastrians this does not mean to say that the Persians from the end of the 4th century onwards had adopted a real, true era beginning in that year. All it means is that the death of Darius was considered, at least by the Zoroastrian Magi, to be an event of capital importance for the monarchy and the religion, which were both affected, to a different extent, by the devastating fury of the Macedonian conqueror.⁴⁶ There would be nothing strange about it, then, if the disciples and the successors of the prophet, who were well aware of the passing of time that separated them from some important event or other in the life of Zoroaster — most probably the revelation that he had had at the age of thirty (see pp. 20, 156 f.) — were able to date the event that had put an end to the Achaemenian period starting from 'Zoroaster' too. The 258 years between Zoroaster and Alexander were therefore the result of a simple chronological reckoning, whose insertion in the chronology of a true era did not come about until the beginning of the Sassanian period, when the Seleucid era was interpreted as the era of Zoroaster (see p. 143). That a period of the religion was brought to a close with Alexander is something that is widely attested, even outside the Zoroastrian and Muslim sources, as can be seen by the above-quoted passage from

Diogenes Laertius (see p. 47), which ends with the phrase μέχρι τῆς τῶν Περσῶν ὑπ' Ἀλεξάνδρου καταλύσεως.

The year 330 B.C. did not become known as the epochal year of a real, true era, but only as a chronological reference-point, that was probably only used by a narrow circle of learned men and Magi out of religious piety. As Gershevitch has rightly written, "258 (330 B.C.), inextricably linked with the name of the detested Alexander, was never forgotten by the priests who up to then, i.e. until the year 330 B.C., had been counting the passage of years from Zoroaster".⁴⁷ It is not mere chance that al-Qoṣā'i also speaks of 'Magi' and not generically of Persians. After all, even Henning, when he maintained that by 'Alexander' we must understand 330 B.C., never mentioned an era of Alexander. Therefore the criticisms made by Nyberg and Altheim and Stiehl are unjust,⁴⁸ while Gershevitch has rightly criticised Werner Sundermann's recent view, when he follows the example of Nyberg and states that "The date of 330 B.C. as an epoch making year is not supported by any other tradition".⁴⁹ But even if 330 B.C. did not mark the beginning of an authentic era, it is still the date we must start from to calculate the years, 258 or 300, back to Zoroaster. What is more, it was such an important year that, according to al-Qoṣā'i, it was used by the Magi as a chronological reference-point not only for counting backwards but also forwards. If we do not have any other attestations of this latter usage, it is because it must have been confined to priestly circles and because it must have soon fallen into disuse in the presence of new chronological reckonings, such as the ones introduced by the Seleucid era and the Arsacid era. What Nyberg stated in the 'Begleitwort zum Neu-druck' of his *Die Religionen des alten Iran*, "Alexanders Thronantritt in Persien ist nie zum Ausgangspunkt irgendeiner Zeitrechnung genommen worden, weder nach vorne noch nach hinten"⁵⁰ is certainly wrong. We may therefore conclude on this point that, independently of the importance that they give to the date of 258 years before Alexander — i.e. whether its reliability as a historical date is accepted or not — we must reject all the reconstruc-

tions that are based on the interpretation of 'Alexander' as 'Seleucid era'. The views of Herzfeld, Altheim and Stiehl, Shahbazi, Wiesenhöfer cannot be of any use to us in solving our problem, except in some details or particular aspects.⁵¹

As for the epochal year of the coming of Ardaxšīr, we shall see how the Sassanian sovereign really did link his name with an important innovation in chronology, but that innovation was not the giving of his name to a new era. We must not forget that the Sassanian or Ardaxšīr's era was short-lived, as the epigraphical evidence tells us that the Sassanians went back to dating events in the traditional manner, by the regnal years of the single sovereigns. This is proved by two inscriptions from Persepolis of the reign of Šābuhr II (309-379) and, in particular, by numismatic evidence.⁵² And not only this — because it would not be enough to prove its episodic and transient nature — but also that we have no clear traces of such an era in Iranian documentation. On the contrary, the reform which Ardaxšīr entrusted to a council of sages appointed for this purpose (see below) had lasting effects and certainly did not consist in an "unreasonable revival of the Achaemenid system of dating by regnal years", as Shahbazi supposes most improbably.⁵³ Different calculations of the years, for example, according to the Seleucid era, the Arsacid era, and then the transient Sassanian era, or else according to the regnal years of the single kings, could easily co-exist next to one another under the Arsacids and the Sassanians, sometimes in one and the same document as we can see from the Bīšābuhr inscription, to say nothing of the synchronism between the year 117 of Persian rule and the 31st year of Šābuhr II in the *Acta sanctorum martyrum* I, 15, or in other Syriac sources.⁵⁴ On the other hand, if the epigraphical evidence of the Sassanian period shows a priority of the traditional system of dating by regnal years, the literary sources indicate the use of a continuous reckoning of the years, as part of the cosmological doctrine of millennia. And this is exactly what Ardaxšīr's reform consisted in. H. Lewy has devoted enlightening pages to it in her study on the Persian calendar,⁵⁵ though she

touches upon some arguments concerning the reform of the calendar that are still open to debate.⁵⁶

We must give credit to H. Lewy and Taqizadeh for having shown that Ardaxšīr's reform, as far as the method of reckoning years was concerned, consisted in the identification of the Seleucid era with the tenth millennium of the world era. Henning has given a clear description of what must have happened:

At the beginning of the Sassanian epoch there was current in Persia only one era by which events could be conveniently dated: the Seleucid era.⁵⁷ That it was widely used in that country is well established; thus the Parthian coins date by it. However, although the Seleucid era was used, its origin was not known; in particular, the Persians did not know that it was a foreign era. Wrongly believing it to be an indigenous way of counting years, they combined it recklessly with their world-year of twelve thousand years, which had been devised many centuries earlier, perhaps in the fifth century B.C.⁵⁸ This world-year had been a vague affair. The great events of world history as seen by the Persians were fixed in it: the creation of the world, the First Man, the coming of Zoroaster, the future Messiah, Judgement Day, &c.; but it had no precise relation to every-day life. This was changed now: by becoming combined with the Seleucid era the world-year ceased to be a nebulous speculation and gained practical importance. The years of the Seleucid era were identified with the corresponding years of the tenth millennium of the world-year; thus the Seleucid year 538, which was counted as the official beginning of Sassanian rule, became the year 9,538 of the world era [...]

When the Seleucid era was identified with the tenth millennium, its beginning necessarily coincided with the Coming of Zoroaster. Thus the Seleucid era became, so to speak, the 'era of Zoroaster'. The mistake that was made in determining the length of the Arsacid rule followed automatically. Ardashir, the first Sassanian king, ascended the throne in 538. Subtract from 538 the 258 years from the Coming of Zoroaster to Alexander and the 14 years of Alexander, then the remainder must be the period of Arsacid rule (which was wrongly believed to have begun with the death of Alexander). This remainder is precisely 266 years, the number of years actually allotted to the Arsacids in the Sassanian tradition.

The mistake thus proves to be a perfectly innocent one. It reveals not deliberate fraud, as Mas'ūdī thought, but singular ignorance of Iranian history. The point that concerns us here is that the mistake

presupposes acquaintance with the traditional date of Zoroaster, 258 *years before Alexander*. It became possible only because the traditional date was not merely known to exist, but respected as an immutable quantity.⁵⁹

Besides the aforementioned works by H. Lewy and especially Taqizadeh, to find a more detailed presentation of this thesis it will be of great benefit to consult Gershevitch's recent article, which is also devoted to a keen-sighted defence of Henning's viewpoint against the criticisms made by Shahbazi and the present author. In it Gershevitch has shown brilliantly that the objections that have so far been raised against Henning's conclusions are due to erroneous interpretations and misunderstandings or to superficial arguments. In reality, it is only the fact that Ardaxšīr was convinced a priori that 258 years had passed between Zoroaster and Alexander that can give a satisfactory explanation to the various problems arising out of the identification of the Seleucid era with the tenth millennium, taken as a sort of era of Zoroaster, to use Taqizadeh's happy definition. This means that the figure 258 in the date has a certain historical reliability and that it is an 'immutable quantity' (see p. 149).

It will be worth while, however, to dwell upon some of the main points of Henning's summing up. These are: a) that the Persians were unaware of the foreign origin of the Seleucid era; b) that to them the 258 years before Alexander represented an immutable quantity. The first point is clearly confirmed by the fact that no Iranian source which reflects a usage in vogue in the Sassanian period says that the Seleucid era was known as the era of the Greeks, or the Macedonians, or Alexander. These last denominations were in use, with some variants, in Syrian, Byzantine and Arab authors. In this connection we can consult Ginzell on the usage of the era by Babylonians, Arabs, Persians, Jews and Syrians,⁶⁰ and Taqizadeh, in various studies of his,⁶¹ and in particular in his article "The 'Era of Zoroaster'", from which we quote the following passage concerning the Persians:

they would not have put the date of Alexander's domination in Persia only 266 years before the foundation of the Sasanian dynasty if they had had knowledge of an 'era of Alexander' (beginning soon after Alexander's death), and when they could easily find by inquiry from their Syrian and Greek subjects that the year of the foundation of the Sasanian rule corresponded to the 538th year of the 'era of Alexander' (Seleucid). They (or at least some of them) may, however, have known this era under the name of the 'era of the astronomers of Babylon', as it must have been used under this name among the Chaldeans of the central region of the empire (Lower Mesopotamia). Mani used this era under this name in his 'Shāpūrakān', written in Persian for the benefit of the Persians in the middle of the third century.⁶²

Likewise Henning, who wrote, a propos of the Seleucid era, "how little it was associated with the name of Alexander is best seen by the early Sassanian construction of chronology which put Alexander in the 258th year of that era and not at its beginning".⁶³ This is a definite condemnation of Shahbazi's attempts to interpret the reference to Alexander in the Zoroastrian sources as a reference to the Seleucid era,⁶⁴ independently of the reasons we have already set out (see p. 136 f.). It is no chance that the sources on which he mainly bases his arguments are Arab or Byzantine or Syriac. We have no right to hold that "since the early Muslim authors drew heavily upon Sasanian sources, it is likely that in associating the Seleucid Era with Alexander they were following a Sasanian tradition".⁶⁵

As for the second point, unlike what I thought in 1980, I now think that the 258 years really were an 'immutable quantity'. Gershevitch, in the article I have already quoted several times⁶⁶ has dwelt upon this point with convincing arguments and with some remarks on the origins of an era, the invention of the Seleucid era and its significance.

If we consider that the figure 14 giving the years of Alexander's rule, theoretically referring either to the period after or to the period before 330 B.C., namely to the end of Darius III, must also have been an immutable quantity in a way, deriving from a foreign source,⁶⁷ it is surely the first of the other two addends of the total 538, 258 and 266, that is a fixed and immutable datum. Pre-

viously I had doubts about this, thinking that both the addends were to be placed on the same level.⁶⁸ But this is not so: of the two, the first is more stable, the second less so. A careful examination of the sources clearly shows that the duration of the Arsacid period was expressed in different figures (see below), so that we can affirm, for this reason too, that 258 was a primary datum and 266 a secondary datum. In fact, in respect of the alleged historical evidence represented by the 258 years between Zoroaster and Alexander, taking into account the 14 years attributed to Alexander's reign, the duration of the Arsacid period had necessarily to be reduced to 266 years: $538 - 258 - 14 = 266$.

We shall give here below the data concerning the duration of the Arsacid period that reflect the shortening it was subjected to in Sassanian chronology. We shall not include the evidence given by writers such as Mas'udi, Abu'l-Faraj Zanjāni, Ṭabari, who measured it as a period of more than 500 years, or Ta'ālebi, nor those such as Ḥamza Eṣfahāni (358 years including the 14 of Alexander's rule).⁶⁹ It is well known that the *Iranian* or *Greater Bundahišn* XXXVI, 9 and the *Indian Bundahišn* XXXIV, 9 give different accounts. In the first the duration of the Arsacid rule is fixed at '200 and odd years' (*200 ud and sāl*), whereas the second gives it as '284 years', as Shahbazi has emphasized.⁷⁰ The transliteration and translation into English by B.T. Anklesaria has the second figure, while the edition by T.D. Anklesaria gives the first figure.⁷¹ Shahbazi has corrected his previous inaccuracy in the quotation of the passage⁷² — now quoted by C.G. Cereti in his edition of the *Zand ī Wahman Yasn*⁷³ — thanks to the advice of Professor MacKenzie, pointing out that B.T. Anklesaria has adopted the version of the *Indian Bundahišn* (284 years) "in order to fill a lacuna"⁷⁴, while the figure attested in the Pahlavi codices TD1 103r 1-2, DH 230r 10-11, TD2 122v 4-5 is *200 ud and sāl*, '200 and odd years'.

A similar testimony is given by Ferdowsi in his *Šāh-nāme* (Moscow ed., VII, 1968, 115-16), which has "some two hundred years" (*sāli devist*),⁷⁵ a figure that cannot be due to a source such as the

Šāh-nāme-ye Abu Maṣṣuri, because in it, as we know from Biruni, Abu Maṣṣur b. ‘Abd al-Razzāq fixes the duration of Arsacid rule at 266 years,⁷⁶ as Shahbazi has remarked.⁷⁷

There are still further differences in the years attributed to the Arsacids in Agathias II, 26⁷⁸ and in Maṣ‘udi, in his *Ketāb al-tanbih wa’l-ešrāf*,⁷⁹ but they differ only slightly from the figure 266. The first has 270 years, which both Nöldeke and Averil Cameron rightly say derives from a Persian source, probably the lost *Xwadāy Nāmag*,⁸⁰ while the second has 260. Shahbazi (to whom the reader is referred for the bibliographical references), cites these testimonies as concerning the 266 years:⁸¹ the *Šāh-nāme-ye Abu Maṣṣuri* apud Biruni; Ṭabari; Maṣ‘udi; Bal‘ami; Maqdesi.⁸² Therefore Agathias and Maṣ‘udi give two figures that can be explained by rounding off the 266 years in the main calculation and that recall Biruni’s approximation in his *Chronology*: 260-270 years.⁸³

We still have to explain the ‘200 and odd years’ and the ‘284 years’ in the two versions of the *Bundahišn*. These figures are too different to be taken as two readings that can be traced to the same source. Shahbazi has attempted to explain the 284 in an unconvincing fashion: taking it for granted that the redactors of the *Indian Bundahišn* were influenced by the same figure given by Abu Maṣ‘ar (240 years) for the period between Zoroaster and Alexander — a figure due to an error as we have already said (see p. 136 f.) — they would have reported the figure 258 for that period, but at the same time they would have calculated the Arsacid period as 284 years, which is the result of the subtraction of 254 years (240 plus the 14 years of Alexander’s rule) from 538: $284 = 538 - 254$.⁸⁴ This is unlikely and, in any case, it is not confirmed by textual evidence. It is also contradictory: it is hard to see why the redactors of the *Indian Bundahišn*, who doubtless reckoned the period between Zoroaster and Alexander as being 258, should have had to keep the figure 240 in mind. Therefore it is pure conjecture to say that “they dated Zoroaster to 240 years before the accession of Alexander or 254 before his death (= $240 + 14$)” and that they were therefore obliged to allot 284 years to the Arsacids (538

- 254 = 284). Actually, we have already seen that the figure 240 which Abu Maʿṣar established as being the number of years between Zoroaster and Alexander, instead of 258, was due to the same error that Biruni made in the *Chronology* and later corrected. The error was to have taken 'till Alexander' as meaning 'till the Seleucid era'. Now it is very likely that the redactors of the *Indian Bundahišn* got their information concerning the Arsacid period from a source that had not made the same error but a similar one; that is to say, they had assigned the 18 years that had elapsed between the death of Darius in 330 and the epochal year of the Seleucid era (312/1) to the Arsacids, who were thought of as the immediate successors of Alexander:⁸⁵ $266 + 18 = 284$.

As for the *200 ud and sāl* in the *Greater Bundahišn*, Shahbazi has come close to what seems to be the only possible solution with his proposal that this figure has been counted from the epochal year of the Arsacid era (248/7 B.C.).⁸⁶ He thinks that the expressions *200 ud and sāl* and *sāli devist* originally stood for the figure 203 (see p. 172 f. n. 75) and, by adding this number to the 272 years ($258 + 14$) of the period between Zoroaster and the death of Alexander, he gets the sum of 475 years that takes him back to the 'Ctesiphon accession' of Ardaxšīr in 227 A.D. ($272 + 203 = 475$; likewise $248 + 227 = 475$).⁸⁷ Apart from the inadequacy of a solution of this type, which is unconvincing and debatable in some details, we must admit that only a reckoning that starts with the Arsacid era can give a reasonable explanation for the *200 ud and sāl* of the *Greater Bundahišn* and the *sāli devist* of the *Šāh-nāme*, if we take into account that the epochal year of this era corresponds to the year 65 of the Seleucid era: $266 - 65 = 200$ *ud and sāl*. According to the correspondences recorded by Ginzel, the 1st year of the Arsacid era is equal to the 65th year of the Seleucid era and to the year 247 B.C.⁸⁸

If it is true that the figures given in the two versions of the *Bundahišn*, *200 ud and sāl* and *284 sāl*, are both connected with the same reckoning that allotted 258 years to the period between Zoroaster and the coming of Alexander or 272 until his death

($258+14+266=538$, according to the Seleucid era, or $258+14+200$ *ud and sāl* = about 473, according to the Arsacid era), it is just as true that, of the two figures 258 and 266, the first one was constantly attested whereas the second one could vary, on account of either different calculations or of rough estimates that varied in their precision.⁸⁹ This, too, shows that the second figure was secondary compared with the first and that the first was “respected as an immutable quantity”, just as Henning maintained.

It is worth paying attention to the fact that a chronological calculation based on the epochal year of the Arsacid era existed in the late Sassanian period — and it is likely that the *Bundahišn* dates to the end of the Sassanian period, as Henning thinks, though he remarks that it “still remains to be proved”.⁹⁰ Shahbazi saw it both as proof of the long-lived importance of the Parthians, especially of their aristocracy, which amongst other things maintained a position of prominence in Armenia, and also as a re-interpretation of the Arsacid era with a religious meaning.⁹¹ There is some truth in this argument, but probably not as far as the subjects who re-interpreted the Arsacid era are concerned: they were possibly the Sassanians themselves, who as early as the beginning of the 3rd century found themselves having to deal with two different chronological calculations and one of these, namely the one based on the Arsacid era, was incompatible with their intention of identifying the current era with the era of Zoroaster, that is to say, with the beginning of the 10th millennium of the world era. In fact, as Gershevitch has rightly shown, they could not have allotted to the period between Zoroaster and Alexander any more than 51 years, as this would be the number of years left after the 14 years of Alexander’s rule had been subtracted if they had adopted an era that had its epochal year in the year 65 of the era of Zoroaster ($65-14 = 51$).⁹² But, as they knew from a well established and unalterable tradition that 258 years had elapsed between Zoroaster and Alexander, they were led to insert this figure in the reckoning of the era that was most commonly used at that time, viz. the era of the astronomers of Babylon, which they thought of as the era of

Zoroaster. Thus they were compelled to shorten somewhat the duration of the Arsacid period, reducing the 473 years from 247 B.C. to 226 A.D. to a mere 266 years.

The Arsacid era, however, that was deeply rooted in the Iranian world as a 'Royal reckoning',⁹³ as distinct from the 'former reckoning' (i.e. the Seleucid era), evidently did not vanish altogether and with the passing of time it must have appeared as another possible chronological reference point, having lost its original nature as a true era linked to the preceding dynasty whose beginning had always been thought to go right back to Alexander's death. Therefore it cannot have been so much the Parthians who kept it alive as the Persians themselves. The very fact that they saw it as an alternative reckoning to the main one in current use meant that it could be adopted as a different calculation which began with the 10th millennium. A calculation of this kind must have been without any religious significance that was valid only for the Parthians. On the other hand, as far as we know, the Arsacid era had never had any such significance, not even at its beginning: it had come into being as a dynastic era. The attestations of the *Greater Bundahišn* and the *Šāh-nāme*, according to the present interpretation, make it quite clear that the adoption of the Arsacid era left unchanged the 258 years between Zoroaster and Alexander and also the 14 years of Alexander's reign. It is not for nothing that Shahbazi by supposing that the "Zoroastrianization of the Arsacid era must have been the work of the Parthian families who resented the Sasanian re-interpretation of the Seleucid era as the 'era of Zoroaster'", had to imagine that the Parthians, with the claim that their era had been initiated by Zoroaster, "sanctified their dynastic symbol at the expense of sharply reducing the period of their rulership"⁹⁴ — an explanation which is far too tortuous indeed. Moreover, it is significant that the attestation of the *Bundahišn* is comparatively late and dates to a time when the memory of the Parthians must have been fairly hazy. It had lost the negative connotations that it must have had at the beginning of the Sassanian period, as is shown by the passage where it says

that the Arsacids were “renowned for righteous rule” (*pad ahlaw xwadāyīh nām barēnd*).⁹⁵ It should be remembered that book IV of the *Dēnkard* was likewise to consecrate the name of an Arsacid king, Walaxš, amongst those who, like Dārāy ī Dārāyān, Ardaxšīr ī Pābagān, Šābuhr ī Ardaxšīrān, Šābuhr ī *Hormizdān, Husraw ī Kawādān, had particularly distinguished themselves in the keeping and passing on of the religious tradition.⁹⁶

According to Mario Grignaschi, some evidence for the survival, in the late Sassanian period, of a chronological calculation based on the Arsacid era can be got from Pahlavi, Arabic and Persian sources that so far have not been given due attention.⁹⁷ Unfortunately Grignaschi did not take into account the evidence of the *Greater Bundahišn* concerning the duration of the Arsacid period. He made particular mention of a passage in the so-called second part of the *Mādayān ī Hazār Dādestān* XLVII, 42, basing himself on the English version done by S.J. Bulsara in 1937 (the works by Anahit G. Perikhanyan and Maria Macuch came out later, in 1973 and in 1981)⁹⁸ and on the information in the *Letter of Tansar*, according to which Ardaxšīr came on the scene four centuries after the devastation brought about by Alexander.⁹⁹ Both these attestations could, he thinks, be explained by taking into account a calculation based on the epochal year of the Arsacid era, if this is understood as being the end of Alexander’s rule. In that case one could, in his opinion, explain both the possible variations of the dates of a sovereign named Yazdegard (see below), as well as of other figures mentioned in the aforesaid passage of the *Mādayān ī Hazār Dādestān*, between the first and the second half of the same century or, as Macuch suggests, some fifty years before and after,¹⁰⁰ and also the advent of Ardaxšīr not 266 but 400 years after Alexander. In actual fact the first passage is not easy to interpret,¹⁰¹ while the testimony in the *Letter of Tansar* is not isolated and seems to fall in with the ones given by the *Tāriḳ-e Bal’ami*,¹⁰² the *Mojmal al-tawāriḳ wa’l-qeṣaṣ*,¹⁰³ and Maqdesi, *Ketāb al-bad’ wa’l-ta’riḳ*.¹⁰⁴ All these are quoted by Shahbazi, who explains them as the result of “a rough estimate by historians uncon-

vinced of the authenticity of the official reckoning".¹⁰⁵ And so, according to Grignaschi, the slowing down of time referred to in a subsequent passage of the *Letter of Tansar*,¹⁰⁶ that had drawn the attention of Darmesteter,¹⁰⁷ should not be attributed to Ardashīr's chronological stratagem, that is mentioned in Mas'udi's aetiological story (see p. 154), but to the adoption of the Arsacid reckoning.

I am not convinced by the explanations that Grignaschi gives for the passage in the *Mādayān ī Hazār Dādestān* about the first and second fifty-year period (*panjāhag ī pēš* and *panjāhag ī pas*) of the tenth century and for the passage in the *Letter of Tansar* about the 400 years of the period between Alexander and Ardashīr, but I do think that the reference to the Arsacid reckoning could be of some use all the same in solving some complex problems of the chronology concerning pre-Islamic Iran, which we cannot dwell upon at any greater length here. It is just worth while pointing out that the passage in the *Mādayān ī Hazār Dādestān* could be explained if we were to hypothesize the co-existence of two alternative reckonings, one according to the Seleucid era and the other according to the Arsacid era, whose respective epochal years, 312/1 and 247/6 B.C., by being re-interpreted both as the beginning of the era of Zoroaster, would lend themselves to the dating of persons and events that could be placed in a first or second half of the one century, or some fifty years before or after, since they are 65 years apart. It would be well to observe how Grignaschi came to a similar conclusion to ours as far as the importance of the date of 258 years is concerned, although with some inaccuracies.¹⁰⁸ Having already noted that millenarian anxieties in the *Testament of Ardashīr*¹⁰⁹ would have led to changes being made, towards the end of the Sassanian period, in the chronological order of the tenth millennium, he posed the following question:

What amazes us is that, lacking precise information on the reign of the Kayanians,¹¹⁰ it was not preferable to alter the time of Zoroaster's appearance. Did the date given by Biruni for Wištāsp's conversion (258 years before the Seleucid era) rest on some tradition that nobody dared touch, that was more solid than the calculations concerning the duration of the Kayanians?¹¹¹

Now that we have determined the historical importance of the date of 258 years before Alexander, let us look at the alternative date concerning the 300 years that elapsed between Zoroaster and the end of the Achaemenian empire, which we have already mentioned above.

We have insisted on the fact that these two figures are incompatible and, though they both date Zoroaster back to a period between the 7th and the 6th century B.C., they belong to different chronological calculations or, rather, to different traditions. This is important. It is the desire to reconcile these two figures at all costs that has given rise to considerable confusion, to which the present writer has also fallen a victim: either it was assumed that the original figure was 300, to which should be traced back the figures 258 and 272 ($258+14$), these being due to an error that was consecrated by the *Bundahišn* according to E.W. West,¹¹² or else it was observed that $258 + 42$ (the age at which Zoroaster was supposed to have converted Vištāspa) gives the sum of 300. This tendency can already be seen in Jackson, in Taqizadeh, and to some extent even in Henning.¹¹³ Although Henning did not question the historical value of the 258 years and rightly considered that the tenth millennium was “the one that opens with the Coming of Zoroaster”, he thought that “In the year 9,001 Zoroaster, then 42 years of age, converted King Vištāspa.” This led him to propose three alternative datings for Zoroaster, doubtless following in Taqizadeh’s footsteps, because in his view, once it had been established that the date of Zoroaster was 588 B.C. ($330 + 258$),

The one uncertain point is whether the year from which his adherents counted was the one in which he reached the age of thirty and had his first revelation, or the one when he was forty and had his first success,¹¹⁴ or the one when he was forty-two and converted King Vištāspa. The differences are not of much account. The tradition says that his age at death was seventy-seven. Accordingly, the three possible dates of Zoroaster are: 630-553, 628-551, 618-541.¹¹⁵

And, on the basis of the aforesaid remarks, Henning concluded that “This then is the ‘traditional date of Zoroaster’: either 258 years before Alexander or $258 + 14 = 272$ years before the death

of Alexander (the Coming of Zoroaster) or $258 + 42 = 300$ years before Alexander (the birth of Zoroaster)".¹¹⁶

We shall come back later on to the three datings that Henning proposed. For the moment it will be worth our while to note that the tendency to combine the two figures 258 and 300 actually goes back as far as Mas'udi and Biruni who were led to consider them as two figures that were apparently the result of the one reckoning, which would therefore have varied considerably. In his *Ketāb al-tanbih wa'l-ešrāf* Mas'udi stated that between Zoroaster and Alexander, according to the Persians, there elapsed "about three hundred years", after saying that Zardošt b. Boršāsb b. Esbimān had foreseen, in the Avesta, that the empire would be shattered after three hundred years but the religion would survive.¹¹⁷ This is the well-known story about the religious and political secret which was supposed to have distinguished the Persians' chronology of Alexander from the one used by other peoples.¹¹⁸ If we consider that Mas'udi himself gives 258 as being the number of years in the same period in his *Moruj al-ḡahab* according to the Zoroastrians (see p. 134), we can understand the meaning of the expression "about three hundred years" in this passage, in which we also have a reference to the three hundred years of the prophecy that the Persians attributed to the Avesta. Gershevitch has made this point clear¹¹⁹ and I think that the present writer, who tried to defend the reliability of Mas'udi's story about Ardashīr's chronological falsification, must now agree that it is, on the contrary, of an aetiological nature resulting from the overlapping of a historical tradition, the one of the 258 years, and a legendary tradition, the one of the 300 years, which had probably already come into being at the beginning of the Sassanian period. The upheaval that, according to a legendary tradition (see p. 157 f.), Zoroaster had prophesied would come about at the end of the first three hundred years of the tenth millennium was identified with the end of the Achaemenian empire, dated 258 years after Zoroaster in the official reckoning which had equated the current era (the Seleucid era) with the era of Zoroaster. As Gershevitch rightly says, such

an identification was permissible "because 258 is after all not so remote from 300 that one may not call it 'about 300'".¹²⁰ The theory of Ardashīr having deliberately falsified the chronology is not nearly so likely or reasonable as that of the chronographers of the Sassanian empire having abandoned the Arsacid time-reckoning in favour of the Seleucid time-reckoning, this being the current and more widely used era.

For his part Biruni, in the aforementioned passage from the *Chronology*,¹²¹ shows that he was aware of the existence of a different tradition from the one about the 258 years, a tradition that established the period between Zoroaster and Alexander as being 300 years. In fact, he says that the period can be calculated as 260-270 years "or something more, as 300 years", it is obvious that the expression 'something more' seems to have a similar meaning, in our context, as the expression 'about' has in the passage from Mas'udi. In fact the two traditions are compared with one another.

What has undoubtedly contributed to the overlapping of the two dates, 258 and 300 years, is the usual interpretation of the *Bundahišn* XXXVI, 7-9. From the comparison of the two versions of the work and the various manuscripts, this passage should be read as follows:

Kay Wištāsp tā madan ī dēn sīh sāl; mar ēk hazār sāl, pas hazārag xwadāyīh ō Wahīg mad; Zarduxšt ī Spitāmān pad paygāmbarīh ī az dādār Ohrmazd ō Wištāsp šāh āmad; Wištāsp šāh pas <az> padīrīftan ī dēn nawad sāl; āgenēn sad ud wīst sāl.

As we said at the beginning of the present work, Cereti has convincingly proved that the expression *pas <az> padīrīftan ī dēn* in this case does not refer to Wištāsp but to Zarduxšt. The reference to Wištāsp, which is theoretically possible and generally accepted, can be ruled out by a close comparison with parallel passages, especially from book VII of the *Dēnkard* and the *Wizīdagihā ī Zādspram*, so that the correct interpretation of the passage is the one restored by Cereti:

Kay Wištāsp <reigned> thirty years until the coming of the religion; the reckoning is one thousand years. Thereafter the rule of the millennium came to Capricorn; Zarduxšt the Spitāma came in prophethood from the Creator Ohrmazd to king Wištāsp; king Wištāsp, after the acceptance of the religion <by Zarduxšt, reigned> ninety years; altogether one hundred and twenty years.¹²²

This rules out the possibility that the 258 years before Alexander can be counted from the Conversion of Wištāsp, when Zoroaster was 42 years of age, as Nyberg or Humbach maintained.¹²³ We can be certain that the reckoning started from the Conference of Zoroaster with Ohrmazd, when the prophet was thirty years of age. On the other hand, as Gershevitch points out,¹²⁴ it is significant that in Zādspram's mini-calendar, in *Wizīdagihā ī Zādspram* XXV, the Conversion of Wištāsp, which *Dēnkard* VII, 5, 1 and *Pahlavi Revāyat* XLVII, 22 place in the 42nd year of the prophet's life (35 years before his death at the age of 77) is not even mentioned, which means that, for Zādspram at least, this was not such an epoch-making event as, for instance, Taqizadeh took it to be.¹²⁵

With Cereti's interpretation of *Bundahišn* XXXVI, 7-9 we are thus ensured of consistent textual support. When we find 'Zoroaster' as the starting-point for calculating the years up till Alexander, then we must take this to mean the year in which Zoroaster was thirty years old, i.e. the beginning of the tenth millennium or of the era of Zoroaster, or the Coming of the Religion, *madan ī dēn*, or the Acceptance of the Religion, *padīriftan ī dēn*, by Zoroaster. We have no grounds whatsoever for thinking that the years were counted from the Conversion of Wištāsp or from the conversion of Mēdyōmāh (the first apostolic success) or from the birth of the prophet — an idea of Herzfeld's that was taken up by Shahbazi.¹²⁶ All this met with the agreement of Wiesehöfer,¹²⁷ who based his argument on a study by J. Fück on the text of Biruni's *Chronology* in an Istanbul manuscript,¹²⁸ in a passage corresponding to a lacuna in Sachau's edition, to which attention had already been drawn by Taqizadeh himself.¹²⁹ Of the three alternative proposals made by Henning we can therefore take only the third one

as being valid, the one which identified 588 as the 30th year in the prophet's life. The traditional date of Zoroaster is therefore either 258 years before Alexander or $258 + 14 = 272$ years before the death of Alexander (the Coming of Zoroaster), as Henning proposed or, lastly, $258 + 30 = 288$ years before Alexander (the birth of Zoroaster). Quite rightly Gershevitch reaches the same conclusion, although he follows a different line of reasoning.¹³⁰

As I said before, at the beginning of this work, it was precisely the illusion of being able to explain the date of 258 years as $300 - 42$ that misled me when I stated that the original date would have been the one giving 300 years — an approximate figure of no historical value — while the 258 years would have been precise in appearance only.¹³¹ This view was shared before me by Molé, who as we know was certainly not prompted by the desire to find a place for Zoroaster in history.¹³² A similar attitude was shared by those who, like Humbach, argued that there was no historical value in either the 258 years or the 300 years, “a round number and, therefore, of limited historical value”.¹³³ In his opinion “as already pointed out by G. Gnoli,¹³⁴ Bīrūnī's figure 258, which Henning accepted, can only have been obtained by subtracting 42 years, Zaratustra's age at Vištāspa's conversion, from the 300 B.A. Inv. [= before Alexander's invasion] of his birth”.¹³⁵ These statements, however, are all outweighed by the fact that, as we have seen, the 42nd year of Zoroaster's life, in which Vištāsp was converted to the new faith, did not coincide with the epochal year from which the beginning of the period between Zoroaster and Alexander was reckoned.

We still have to explain the origin of the figure 300, once we have ascertained that it was unrelated to the figure 258. Gershevitch has given an excellent explanation, starting with the assumption that the figure 300 must be taken as intrinsic to the legend reported by Mas'udi concerning Zoroaster's prophecy, and supposing that the legend “was firmly hinged, in Sasanian folklore, on a combination of the figure 300 with the figure 1000”. Therefore it is the myth of Yima that provides a satisfactory solution to our

problem, with its “run of 1000 years in the course of which remediable hardships occurred, three times, in the years 300, 600, and 900”. Gershevitch rightly emphasizes that the likelihood that the story reported by Mas‘udi “was inspired by this pre-Zoroastrian myth is overwhelming”.¹³⁶ We shall certainly gain a lot from Gershevitch’s further considerations on the way in which the aetiological story about the religious and political secret concerning Alexander’s chronology among the Persians is presented in the *Ketāb al-tanbih wa’l-ešrāf*. As far as we are concerned, it will suffice us to acknowledge that the tradition of the 300 years between Zoroaster and Alexander, which became ‘about’ 300 in Mas‘udi (see p. 138), may in all likelihood have been modelled on the popular legend about Yima’s thousand-year reign, probably connected from comparatively early times with the chiliadic doctrine of the cosmic year, as Panaino maintains in a contribution, as yet unpublished, on the Avestan passage incorporated in the Pahlavi translation of *Vd.* 2, 19 (one of the two Avestan passages mentioning the millennium of Yima: the other one is *Yt.* 9, 8-10).¹³⁷

Modelled as it was on a theme inspired by a legend that was certainly widespread in the collective imagery of the Iranian nation, this date of 300 years before Alexander met with particular success, as is shown by its presence in Muslim and Christian sources as well, where the beliefs of the Magi and, more generally, of the Persians were recorded. This is probably the explanation for the account given by Theodore bar Kōnay,¹³⁸ an eighth-century Syrian writer who probably used the work against the religion of the Magi written by Theodore of Mopsuestia at the beginning of the fifth century. The author of the *Book of Scholia* probably did not calculate the date of Zoroaster by referring to the sum of the 258 years of the traditional date and the 330 years between the fall of the Persian empire and the birth of Jesus, and by counting back about 41 years, as was suggested by Taqizadeh,¹³⁹ but by referring to 330 B.C., to which he mechanically added 300 years: the result was 630, corresponding to the astronomical year 629 B.C.¹⁴⁰

In the previous lecture we paid special attention to the Zoroaster-Pythagoras connection (a teacher-pupil relationship) and to the Zoroaster-Ezekiel identification, which is implicit in the information that some people believed Ezekiel, and not Zoroaster, to have been Pythagoras' teacher. Both of these testimonies, one of which goes back to the 4th century B.C. and the other in any case to Hellenistic times, seem to provide significant evidence for a late chronology for Zoroaster, between the 7th and the 6th century B.C.

We also remarked that the Zoroaster-Pythagoras connection probably lay behind the story which told how the philosopher from Samos, having been taken prisoner by Cambyses in Egypt, had occasion to go to Babylon where he met with Chaldaeans and Magi. We then mentioned the fact that some Christian sources, Eutychius, Makin b. 'Amid and Bar Hebraeus, seem to contain an echo of the Pythagoras-Cambyses synchronism in their synchronizing of Cambyses (or Smerdis) and Zoroaster, though this latter connection should be interpreted more loosely as being between Zoroaster and the early Achaemenians (see p. 111).

In fact, this synchronism is attested by the Melchite patriarch of Alexandria, Sa'id b. Beṭriq (Eutychius), who lived between 877 and 940, an author whose works included a *Ketāb al-ta'riḵ al-majmu'* 'ala'l-taḥqiq wa'l-taṣdiq or *Naẓm al-jawhar* (a work which was continued at the beginning of the 11th century by Yahyā al-Anṭāqī),¹⁴¹ in which he drew on Ebn Moqaffa' for Sassanian history. It is also attested by Makin b. 'Amid, a Copt who lived between 1205 and 1273 and wrote an *al-Majmu' al-mobārak* in Arabic,¹⁴² and by Gregorius Abu'l-Faraj b. 'Ebri (Bar 'Ebrāyā or Bar Hebraeus), of Jewish origin on his father's side, who lived between 1225 and 1286 and whose various works in Arabic and Syriac included the *Moḵtaṣar ta'riḵ al-dowal* (*Historia compendiosa dynastiarum*).¹⁴³

Eutychius, to be precise, connected Zoroaster (Zarādašt) with Smerdis (Samardiuš) or the 'Magus'. The Arabic text is given by Michael Breydy with his German translation:

Quruš, der König von Persien, starb, und es herrschte sein Sohn und starb, und nach ihm herrschte Samardiuš der Magier, ein Jahr lang. Er wurde «Magier» genannt, weil zu seiner Zeit, ein Perser namens Zaradašt erschienen ist und die Religion der Magier verkündet hat und die Feuerhäuser eingeführt hat.¹⁴⁴

As for Makin b. ‘Amid, Thomas Hyde had already quoted the passage that concerns us, as Jackson pointed out.¹⁴⁵ It says that Zarādašt explained one of his teachings about the communion of his flesh and his blood “in the year XII (*sic*) of the reign of Smerdis”.

Bar Hebraeus, after speaking about Cyrus and Cambyses and relating them to people and events in Jewish history and then about Greek learning (Pythagoras is also mentioned),¹⁴⁶ writes that that was the time of Zarādašt “*Praeceptor Sectae Magorum, oriundus regione Aderbijan, vel (ut dicitur) regione Assyriae*”.¹⁴⁷

Eutychius’ testimony focuses on the epithet ‘the Magus’ (*al-majusi*). Since Smerdis was called in this way, the author evidently gives an explanation of this definition, mentioning by name the founder of the Magi school and thus establishing a Smerdis-Zoroaster or Cambyses-Smerdis-Zoroaster synchronism. For this reason Floigl concluded that, as Eutychius had made Zoroaster a contemporary of Cambyses and Smerdis, then the only year that could be taken into account was the one that was common to both of them, namely 522 B.C., and he even went so far as to determine, on other grounds, that that was the year of Zoroaster’s death.¹⁴⁸ A similar idea can also be found in Altheim and Stiehl,¹⁴⁹ though without any reference to Floigl’s argument: as we know, these authors also propose identifying Porphyry as the source of Eutychius and Bar Hebraeus.¹⁵⁰ In their opinion “Schwerlich kann dann Zarathustra’s Nennung unter dem falschen Smerdis etwas anderes meinen als dies, daß der Prophet in diesem Jahr vom Tod ereilt wurde. Zarathustra’s Ende wäre mit Smerdis’ Tötung, wäre mit Herodot’s μαγοφόνια zusammengefallen”.¹⁵¹ But this conclusion is obviously quite arbitrary and must of course be given up, in spite of the agreement expressed at first by Wiesehöfer.¹⁵² The testimonies of Eutychius, Makin b. ‘Amid and Bar Hebraeus, taken each in its own context, mean no more than Zoroaster was

considered to have been a contemporary of the early Achaemenians. On the other hand, it would hardly make sense to establish a synchronism that was confined to 522 B.C., the only year of Smerdis (since the information given by Makin b. 'Amid, where a twelfth year of the usurper is mentioned, is clearly due to an error), or even to the eight years of Cambyses' reign. There are no grounds whatsoever for such an interpretation and it would be very surprising indeed that writers such as Herodotus or Ctesias, who are our sources for the tragic adventure of Smerdis, make no mention of Zoroaster. Nevertheless, these testimonies of Christian writers are of some importance in that the Zoroaster-Pythagoras synchronism, which is already present in the Classical sources (see p. 102 f.), fits in with a date that, broadly speaking, confirms the current chronology of Zoroaster by placing him in the 6th century B.C.

And so the Zoroaster-Pythagoras and the Pythagoras-Cambyses connections can be explained in the context of a late chronology for the prophet and this is reflected in Christian authors who, like the Muslim writers, were more or less directly acquainted with the ideas that the Magi and the Persians had about Zoroaster and Iranian national history as it had been codified in the Sassanian *Xwadāy Nāmag*. The other connection, the Zoroaster-Ezekiel one, can be explained in the same way, as it reflects what was evidently known about Zoroaster's time amongst the Jews of the Hellenistic age. From a chronological viewpoint similar explanations can be given for the other identifications or associations of Zoroaster with other characters of the Old Testament in sources that present Jewish and Christian traditions in different ways (see p. 114 ff.).¹⁵³

And it is probably by going back to Jewish and Judaeo-Christian traditions that we shall find an explanation for what little we know of Zoroaster amongst the Manichaeans. That little consists in an item of information that is unfortunately not certain, though not altogether meaningless, that was put forward as an hypothesis by Henning in his article on the *Book of the Giants*.¹⁵⁴ Henning's interpretation was criticized by Sundermann,¹⁵⁵ and then backed

up once again by Gershevitch.¹⁵⁶ The information is also contained in a Persian work of the first half of the seventh century of the Hegira, attributed to Jamāl al-Din Sayyed Mortazā b. Dā'i Ḥasani Rāzi or to Jamāl al-Din Abu 'Abdallāh Moḥammad b. Ḥoseyn b. Ḥasan al-Rāzi,¹⁵⁷ which was studied by the present author in a contribution published in *East and West* 45 and followed up in another contribution, which was presented at the third European Conference of Iranian Studies held in Cambridge, September 1995, and made use of in part in the previous lecture.¹⁵⁸

As we know, Henning hypothesized that a fragment of the *Book of the Giants* could be taken as evidence for the date of 618 B.C. as the beginning of Vištāspa's reign (258 + 30 years before Alexander's conquest of Persia, 330 B.C.). This is obtained by filling in a missing figure, 328[?], which Henning sees as possibly indicating the number of years separating the Biblical Enoch and King Vištāspa (3288) according to the Jewish world-era, or the mundane era of Alexandria (beginning 5439 B.C.), or by counting backwards from the Deluge. Thus the second page of M291a should read "[...] three thousand two hundred and eighty-[eight] [...] the beginning of King Vištāsp [...]". As the present author and Gershevitch have explained,¹⁵⁹ Henning's interpretation is quite plausible, although not absolutely certain because of the lacuna in the text. And it is interesting to note that the suggested date, if it were certain, would be the result of an interpretation of the traditional date of Zoroaster in Jewish chronological terms. Which would mean that, amongst the Manichaeans a historiographic tradition of Jewish origin would have been the custom. This is proved by the other aforementioned testimony, which was wrongly interpreted by Hartman.¹⁶⁰ The Persian text runs: *mānaviyya guyand dar zamān-e Dārā Zardošt arvand zāher šod va majus enkār-e ān konand*, which Hartman translated "Les Manichéens disent: 'Au temps de Dārā apparut Sa Majesté Zardošt'. Mais les Mages nient cela". Hartman's error lies in the fact that he supposed the Magi objected to the idea that Zoroaster had lived more or less at the same time as Darius the son of Vištāspa and that therefore there

was the same difference of opinion between the Magi and the Manichaeans that has divided generations of modern scholars on the basis that some of them maintain that the Achaemenian Vištāspa and the Avestan Vištāspa were one and the same person. In actual fact this passage must be interpreted in another way, since the Magi, who were traditionally acquainted only with Dārā ī Čihrazādān and Dārā ī Dārāyān, could not accept that Zoroaster had lived only a few decades before Alexander, whereas the Manichaeans, on account of a different historiographical tradition, knew about Darius I and most likely about the problematical Darius the Mede¹⁶¹ as well. That is to say, the Manichaeans, who were probably no less aware than the Magi that Zoroaster had lived in the sixth century, asserted that the prophet was contemporary with a sovereign unknown to the tradition of the Magi: the two sides were not divided on the period of the prophet but, rather, by two quite distinct historiographical traditions, one Iranian and the other Western, which may be defined as either Graeco-Babylonian or, perhaps more rightly, Judaeo-Hellenistic.

On the other hand, the *successio apostolica* of Manichaeism also seems to be the result of a mixture between Biblical and what may be called Eastern traditions: it mentions, for instance, Sethel, Enoš, Enoch and Sem before the Buddha, Zoroaster and Jesus in the first Coptic *Kephalaion*. Moreover, suffice it to recall the other figures, such as Noah, appearing in the various formulations of the sequence of the prophets.¹⁶² And it is precisely the *successio apostolica* of Manichaeism that provides us with another clue in favour of the fact that Mani dated Zoroaster in the 6th century B.C. The two sequences Buddha-Zoroaster-Jesus and Zoroaster-Buddha-Jesus which, as Sundermann has rightly pointed out,¹⁶³ distinguish the *Šābuhragān* from the *Book of the Giants*, prove two things: first, that Zoroaster and Buddha, to appear in inverse order, must have been considered by Mani as being not very far apart in time, and secondly, that the correction placing Zoroaster before Buddha must have been made when Mani acquired a more direct knowledge of the date of the Buddha. The scanty evidence

that we can glean from the Manichaean sources¹⁶⁴ also seems to confirm the late chronology and perhaps even an awareness on Mani's part, if we accept Henning's hypothesis, of the same traditional date or 258 years before Alexander.

Now that we have come to the end of this last lecture, we can sum up the results obtained in the following way. The Classical sources converge on a late chronology for Zoroaster because even the ones that date the prophet to five millennia before the fall of Troy or six millennia before 480 or 347 B.C. are really a reflection of Iranian chronology referring to the formation of Zoroaster's *fravaši* 6000 years before his physical birth, while the sources that connect Zoroaster with Pythagoras confirm a date for Zoroaster in the 6th century or between the 7th and 6th century B.C. Some sources, that are not incompatible, point to a similar date having become accepted amongst the Jews, in the Hellenistic age, at least. Christian and Muslim sources, that also reflect beliefs and traditions of Sassanian Iran, confirm a similar dating too. Zoroastrian literature offers two versions, unrelated to each other, on the date of the prophet (or the Coming of Religion): a legendary one placing him 300 years before the end of the Achaemenian empire, that is probably modelled on the myth of Yima, and a historical one that fixes the 30th year of his life — the epochal year of the era of Zoroaster — in 588 B.C., that is to say, 258 years before Alexander (330 B.C.). There are echoes of both these versions in the Muslim sources and of the first one probably in Theodore bar Kōnay as well. In any case, both of them bear witness to a late chronology. The traditional date of 258 years before Alexander is not contradicted by any available evidence and cannot be the result of a late fabrication. It is based on a figure that appears coherently as an immutable quantity and cannot have any other meaning but that of a historical date¹⁶⁵. The so-called mini-calendar of Zādspram shows, beyond all shadow of doubt, that the Zoroastrian community kept an accurate record of the events that were important for the religion in the hundred years that followed Zoroaster's Conference with Ohrmazd down to the birth of Sēn,

who is then recorded as having died in the 200th year, leaving a community of one hundred disciples. The dates referring to Zoroaster's life in chapter XXV of the *Wizīdagīhā ī Zādspram* are borne out by other sources, such as the *Dēnkard* VII, 5, 1, and Mas'udi, *Moruj al-dahab*, or Ṭa'ālebi.¹⁶⁶ This shows that the prophet's disciples and his successors were particularly careful about keeping count of the years, as Gershevitch has rightly stressed,¹⁶⁷ and it is worth noting that, even if we take into account the unreliable duration of the reigns of the early rulers that are given in the various sources, the total sum of the years in the period between the 30th year of Vištāspa and Alexander is invariably 258 years.

The present work concludes, therefore, with the remark that the analysis which Jackson made of the sources a hundred years ago — for the sources which are not mentioned here the reader is referred to that excellent work — should leave no room for doubt as to the fact that Zoroaster lived between the end of the 7th and the middle of the 6th century B.C. We may also confirm that the discovery made by H. Lewy in 1944, which was perfected by Taqizadeh in 1947, then made use of by Henning in 1949 and more recently brought into favour again by Gershevitch in 1993, allows us to be even more precise and to acknowledge the historical value of the traditional date and, in the absence of new elements that contradict the results presented here, to state that the dates of Zoroaster are the ones that Henning gave as a third alternative in his masterly Ratanbai Katrak Lectures: 618-541 B.C.

Notes to lecture four

1. A.T. Olmstead, *History of the Persian Empire*, 3rd ed., Chicago, 1960, 147-48; J.M. Cook, *The Persian Empire*, London – Melbourne – Toronto, 1983, 131-33; Dandamaev, o. c. (see p. 85 n. 72), p. 109; Briant, o. c. (ib.), p. 154.

2. Bickerman, "Calendar", 203.

3. Hartner, art. cit. (see p. 93 n. 186), p. 761 n. 2.

4. For a review of the traditional chronology of the Nirvāṇa see H. Bechert, "Die Lebenszeit des Buddha", *Nachrichten der Akademie der Wissenschaften zu Göttingen*, hist. philolog. Kl., 1986, 129-84. For the date of the Buddha in general see volume four, in two parts, of the "Symposien zur Buddhismusforschung", edited by Bechert: *The Dating of the Historical Buddha / Die Datierung des historischen Buddha*, 2 vols, Göttingen, 1991-1992. For a critical review of the whole problem: Daffinà, "Senso del tempo", 50-70 (with an ample bibliography).

5. Daffinà, ib., p. 2: "un asse cronologico, lungo il quale ordinare tutto il passato fino a noi e mediante il quale raggiungere ogni punto di quel passato e renderlo presente".

6. Gnoli, art. cit.: see p. 13 n. 44, and "Presentazione della storia e identità nazionale nell'Iran antico" (in the press).

7. Van Seters, *In Search of History. Historiography in the ancient world and the origins of Biblical history*, New Haven – London, 1983. For Momigliano see p. 13 n. 43.

8. Gnoli, art. cit., p. 159.

9. Mazzarino, *PSC* II, 2, pp. 412-61.

10. Momigliano, "Time in ancient historiography", in *Essays*, 179-204, at p. 185.

11. A. von Premerstein, "Clavus annalis", *RE* IV, 1, 1900, 2-4; Mazzarino, *PSC* II, 2, pp. 352-53; Daffinà, "Senso del tempo", 25-28. The same thing was done by the Etruscans of Volsinii in the temple of the goddess Nortia, according to L. Cincius Alimentus.

12. Cf. Bickerman, *Chronology*, 77; Daffinà, "Senso del tempo", 27 f.

13. Bickerman, *Chronology*, 71, mentions, for example, that in the Julian calendar of Antioch the year began on 1 Dios (1 October). Before Bickerman:

Taqizadeh, "Various eras" [II], 125-26; H. Lewy, "Calendrier", 46. Even before them: Nöldeke, *Tabari*, 409. The Babylonians established that the beginning of the era was the 3rd day of April in the year 311, and not 1st October 312, as was decided by the Syrians. See Kugler, *Sternkunde* II, p. 461 and passim; J. Finegan, *Handbook of Biblical Chronology*, Princeton, N.J., 1964, 117-23.

14. H. Lewy, "Faulty Pers. chron.", 38; Taqizadeh, "Era of Z.", 36. Cf. Henning, *Zoroaster*, 37-38; Kennedy and van der Waerden, art. cit. (see p. 93 n. 183), p. 315; Bickerman, "Calendar", p. 206 n. 43. See also Shahbazi, "Date of Z.", 27; Gnoli, "Sassanidi", 234; *ZTH*, 170-71.

15. Mas'udi, *Moruj*, transl. Pellat, II, p. 551 (§ 1434).

16. Biruni, *Āṭār*, 14, 105, 213; transl. Sachau, *Chronology*, 17, 112, 196; and see also Jackson, "Date of Z.", 9 (= *Zoroaster*, 161).

17. *Mojmal*, pp. 51, 53-55. See J. Mohl, "Extraits du Modjmel al-Tewarikh relatifs à l'histoire de la Perse", *JA* 3^e série, 11, 1841, 136-78, 258-301, 320-61, at p. 142; 4^e série, 1, 1843, 385-432, at p. 408.

18. Cf. Jackson, "Date of Z.", 11 (= *Zoroaster*, p. 163), who referred to the translation by D. Shea and D. Troyer (Paris, 1843, vol. I, pp. 306-309). See, amongst others: E. Röth, *Geschichte unserer abendländischen Philosophie*, Mannheim, 1862, I, p. 350; V. Floigl, *Cyrus und Herodot nach den neugefundenen Keilinschriften*, Leipzig, 1881, 15, 18; G. Le Strange, *The Lands of the Eastern Caliphate*, London, 1905, 355 f.; J.V. Prášek, *Geschichte der Meder und Perser bis zur makedonischen Eroberung*, Gotha, 1906, I, p. 205; A. Houtum-Schindler, "Marco Polo's travels; new editions; his 'Arbre Sol' not 'Sun-tree', but Cypress of Zoroaster", *JRAS*, 1909, 154-62; Jackson, *Studies*, 255-66; C.F. Lehmann-Haupt, "Wann lebte Zarathustra?", in *Oriental Studies in honour of C.E. Pavry* (see p. 40 n. 76), 251-80, at p. 266; Taqizadeh, "Various eras" [II], p. 128 n. 2; Herzfeld, *Zoroaster*, 19-21; W. Hinz, *Zarathustra*, Stuttgart, 1961, 23 f.; B. Spuler, "Zoroasters Zeit nach einer islamischen Überlieferung des 12. Jh. n. Chr.", *AMI*, n. s. 4, 1971, 113-15; Wiesehöfer, *Aufstand*, 161. See also Nyberg, *RAI*, 434 (note to p. 33), who took a negative view, whereas others think the testimony is a genuinely historical one. There are traces of it in other Muslim sources, though it is interpreted, with an obvious twist in meaning, as being connected with epochal year of the Seleucid era, and not with the year 330 B.C.

19. Spuler, art. cit. Cf. H. Halm, "Bayhaqī, Abu'l-Ḥasan Moḥammad", *Elr*: III, 1989, 894-95.

20. Nöldeke, *Tabari*, 1.

21. For details see Taqizadeh, "Various eras" [II], p. 129; "Era of Z.", 37; Cameron, "AS", 106, 136-7; Shahbazi, "X^wadāy-nāmag", 218 ff. (with some implications that cannot be accepted: see p. 145). See also H. Lewy,

"Calendrier", 60; "Faulty Pers. chron.", 208; Henning, *Zoroaster*, 38; Yarshater, "Iranian national history", *CHIr.* III, 1, 1983, 359-477, at p. 387.

22. Although his interpretation of the 6000 years in Diogenes Laertius must, I think, be rejected (see p. 54 f.).

23. Herzfeld, "Zarathustra, Teil IV: Zarathustra und seine Gemeinde", *AMI*, 2, 1930, 1-48, at pp. 43-44; "The traditional date of Zoroaster", in *Oriental Studies in honour of C.E. Pavry* (see p. 40 n. 76), 132-36, at p. 135; *Zoroaster*, 23-24; Altheim and Stiehl, *SA*, 26-30; *GMA*, 15; Shahbazi, "Date of Z.", 27-30; "X^wadāy-nāmag, 218-24; Gnoli, "Sassanidi", 233-38; *ZTH*, 168.

24. I do not think the position held by Rudolph, art. cit. (see p. 12 n. 19), pp. 274-76, is justified: not only does he consider the date of 258 years to be historically unreliable, but he puts the two explanations of 'before Alexander', 312/1 and 330 B.C., on the same plane. On the contrary C.F. Whitley ("The date and teaching of Zarathustra", *Numen*, 4, 1957, 215-27, at p. 220) and Hinz, o. c. (see n. 18), p. 24, follow in Henning's footsteps. The former has proposed the following dates for Zoroaster: 618-541 B.C. (like Gershevitch and like us: see p. 156 f.); the latter 630-553 B.C. (cf. Henning, *Zoroaster*, 41). It is worth while noting, though, that the solution 312/1 B.C. has been appropriated by Boyce (*HZ* II, p. 69; *HZ* III, p. 370), who based her arguments on Shahbazi ("Date of Z."), and by Sundermann ("Manichaean traditions on the date of the historical Buddha", in *The Date of the Historical Buddha* [see n. 4], I, pp. 426-38, at pp. 432-33), whose reasoning is based not only on Shahbazi, but also on the present author (Gnoli, *ZTH*, 166-75) and on the criticism that Nyberg, in his "Begleitwort zum Neudruck" of *RAI* (Osnabrück, 1966, pp. XII-XIII), made of Henning's theory. With regard to Sundermann's position see Gershevitch, "Approaches", p. 28 n. 24.

25. Entitled: "On the mistake I made regarding the era of Alexander". See Sachau in the introduction to the edition of Biruni's *Āṭār* (p. xxxiii) and see also, for the *Qānūn al-Mas'ūdi*, book 1, treatise 1, chap. 3 of the *Canon Masudicus* in the Hyderabad-Deccan edition (3 vols, 1954-1956), pp. 127 ff.

26. Taqizadeh, "Various eras" [II], pp. 129-30; Henning, *Zoroaster*, 41.

27. Bickerman, *Chronology*, 72.

28. Cf. Taqizadeh, "Various eras" [II], p. 130 with n. 2, who writes: "It is curious that even Abū Ma'shar Balkhī, the famous astronomer, apparently knowing that the conquest of Persia by Alexander was eighteen years earlier than the so-called era of Alexander, was still under the impression that the 258 years interval between Zoroaster and Alexander referred to the said era and not to the reign of the Macedonian conqueror in Persia and therefore put Zoroaster 240 years before Alexander". On Biruni's error see also,

correctly, Humbach, *Gāthās* I, p. 28 with n. 38. On Abu Ma'shar and his *Moḏakarār*, by his pupil Abu Sa'id Šādān, see Pingree, "Abū Ma'shar Balḡī", *Elr.* I, 1985, 337-40.

29. Herzfeld, *Zoroaster*, 9; Altheim and Stiehl, *SA*, 29; *GMA*, p. 10 with n. 3.

30. Shahbazi, "Date of Z.", 28.

31. Cf. Gignoux, *Le livre d'Ardā Vīrāz* (Bibliothèque Iranienne, 30), Paris, 1984, p. 145 n. 5; F. Vahman, *Ardā Wirāz Nāmag. The Iranian 'Divina Commedia'*, London – Malmö, 1986, 225-26. For an exhaustive bibliography, up to the end of the seventies, on the problem of the identification of the 'fortress of the archives' — according to Henning (*The Inscription of Naqš-i Rostam*, CII, Part III, Portfolio II, London, 1957, p. [I]) the Ka'be-ye Zardošt, in the Sassanian period, defined as 'foundation house', *bun xānag* in *KKZ* 3 — see K. Schippmann, *Die iranischen Feuerheiligtümer*, Berlin – New York, 1971, 186-99. The proposal identifying the Ka'be-ye Zardošt of the Achaemenian period as "the initiation tower where the royal fire was kept and the regalia were preserved" (H.W.A.M. Sancisi-Weerdenburg, "The Zendan and the Ka'bah", in *Kunst, Kultur und Geschichte...* [see p. 40 n. 77], 145-51, at p. 151) is grounded on elements of a too imponderable and hypothetical nature.

32. For these passages from chap. I of the *Ardā Wirāz Nāmag* see three recent editions, with translations and annotations: W. Belardi, *The Pahlavi Book of the Righteous Viraz*, I: *Chapters I-II*, Rome, 1979, 75-77, 89, 95-103, 127-28, 135; Gignoux, o. c., pp. 36-37, 145-46; Vahman, o. c., pp. 19-20, 76-79, 191, 223-27. Here I am basically following Gignoux's edition, of which we also have a Persian version edited by Jaleh Amouzegar: *Ardā Vīrāf nāme*, Tehran 1372 Š./1993.

33. Cf. Gignoux and Tafazzoli, *Anthologie de Zādspram (Štlr – Cahier 13)*, Paris, 1933, 86-87, 249.

34. Cf. Zaehner, *Zurvan*, 413, also for the bibliographical references (on p. 409) to earlier works and translations, from J. Olshausen and J. Mohl to J.A. Vullers, E. Blochet and E.B.N. Dhabhar.

35. Mas'udi, *Tanbih*, 97-98.

36. See, amongst others, S. de Sacy, *Notices et extraits des manuscrits de la Bibliothèque impériale*, VIII, Paris, 1810, 161; Gottheil, "References", 34-35; B. Carra de Vaux, *Maḡoudi, Le livre de l'avertissement et de la revision*, Paris, 1896, 140-41; Jackson, "Date of Z.", 10 (= *Zoroaster*, 162-63); Messina, *Magi a Betlemme*, 51-53; Klíma, art. cit. (see p. 124 n. 80), p. 560 with n. 19; Gnoli, *ZTH*, 171; Shahbazi, "X^wadāy-nāmag", 219-20.

37. Gershevitch, "Approaches", 12-13.

38. On which see Brockelmann, *GAL* I, p. 343; *GAL-Suppl. I*, p. 584 f.

39. See the 1806 edition published at Oxford: E. Pocock, *Specimen historiae Arabum*, ed. M. White, Oxford, 1806, 177-78.

40. L. Ideler, *Handbuch der mathematischen und technischen Chronologie*, II, Berlin, 1826, 499-500; É. Drouin, "L'ère de Yazdegerd et le calendrier perse", *Revue archéologique*, 12, 1888, 333-43, at p. 333; Terrien de Lacouperie, "Sur deux ères inconnues de l'Asie antérieure 330 et 251 av. J.-C. d'après un document chinois", *Le Muséon*, 10, 1891, 549-55, at p. 551; F.K. Ginzel, *Handbuch der mathematischen und technischen Chronologie. Das Zeitrechnungswesen der Völker*, I, Leipzig, 1906, 305; Taqizadeh, *Gāh-šomāri dar Irān-e qadim*, Tehran, 1316 Š./1937, 217; "Zur Chronologie der Sassaniden", *ZDMG*, 9, 1937, 673-79, at p. 673; "Early Sasanians", p. 32 n. 3.

41. On this argument see above p. 131 f.

42. For the text of the inscription see: R. Ghirshman, "Inscription du monument de Châpour I^{er} à Châpour", *Revue des arts asiatiques*, 10, 1936, 123-29, pl. XLIV; O. Hansen, "Epigraphische Studien", *ZDMG*, 92, 1938, 441-51; J.M. Unvala, *The Ancient Persian Inscriptions of Darius I and Other Achaemenian Sovereigns Found at Susa and the Sassanian Pahlavi (Pārsik) Inscriptions of Šāpūr I from Bīšāpūr and Hājīābād in Fārs*, Bombay, 1952, 22-25; Nyberg, *A Manual of Pahlavi*, Part I: *Texts*, Wiesbaden, 1964, 124-25; M. Back, *Die sassanidischen Staatsinschriften* (ActIr 18), Téhéran-Liège, 1978, 378-83.

43. Cf. Christensen apud Ghirshman, art. cit., pp. 126-28; Taqizadeh, "Early Sasanians", 34; Widengren, "The establishment of the Sasanian dynasty in the light of new evidence", in *Persia nel Medioevo*, 711-82, at p. 756.

44. Cf. R. Altheim-Stiehl, "Das früheste Datum der sasanidischen Geschichte, vermittelt durch die Zeitangabe der mittelpersisch-parthischen Inschrift aus Bīšāpūr", *AMI*, n. s. 11, 1978, 113-16; "Die Zeitangabe der mittelpersischen Dipinti in der einstigen Synagoge zu Dura-Europos", *Boreas*, 5, 1982, 152-59, at p. 157; R.N. Frye, "The political history of Iran under the Sasanians", *CHIr*. III, 1, 1983, 116-80, at pp. 117-18; *The History of Ancient Iran* (Handbuch der Altertumswissenschaft, III. VII), München, 1984, 292; Wiesehöfer, "Ardašīr I", *Elr*. II, 1987, 371-76, at p. 372; Schippmann, *Grundzüge der Geschichte des sasanidischen Reiches*, Darmstadt, 1990, 13-14; Sundermann, "Shapur's coronation: the evidence of the Cologne Mani Codex reconsidered and compared with other texts", *BAI*, 4, 1990, 295-99, at p. 296, with reference, for the synchronisms of the Bīšābuhr dates, to the 'provisional' calculation proposed by Henning "as early as 1952": 1st year of Ardašīr beginning September 27, 223; 1st year of Šābuhr September 23, 239; G. Haloun and Henning, "The compendium of the doctrines and styles of the teaching of Mani, the Buddha of Light", *AM*, 3,

1952, 184-212, at p. 199 n. 4. See also: H. Lewy, "Calendrier", 46-50; Loukonin, "Monnaie d'Ardachir I et l'art officiel sassanide", *IrAnt*, 8, 1968, 106-17, at pp. 106-107; M.-L. Chaumont, "Corégence et avènement de Shāhpur 1^{er}", in *Mémorial Jean de Menasce*, ed. Gignoux and Tafazzoli, Louvain, 1974, 133-46, at p. 138 with n. 36; Wiesehöfer, *Das antike Persien. Von 550 v. Chr. bis 650 n. Chr.*, München – Zürich, 1994, 222.

45. See Ginzel, loc. cit. in n. 40.

46. On the demonization of Alexander as a 'topos' of Sassanian propaganda cf. Gnoli, *Idea of Iran*, p. 124 with n. 27; "La demonizzazione di Alessandro nell'Iran sassanide (III-VII secolo d.C.) e nella tradizione zoroastriana", in *Alessandro Magno. Storia e mito* (catalogue of an exhibition held in Rome, December 21st 1995 – May 21st 1996), Roma, 1995, pp. 175 and 384 (for the bibliography).

47. Gershevitch, "Approaches", 8.

48. Nyberg, loc. cit. in n. 24; "Stand der Forschung zum Zoroastrismus", *AMI*, n. s. 1, 1968, 40-48, at p. 46; Altheim and Stiehl, *SA*, 28.

49. Sundermann, art. cit. (see n. 24), p. 433 with n. 43; cf. Gershevitch, loc. cit. in n. 24.

50. Nyberg, loc. cit. (see n. 24), p. XIII.

51. Herzfeld, *Zoroaster*, 10; Altheim, o. c. (see p. 124 n. 76), pp. 101, 107; Altheim and Stiehl, *SA*, 26-27; *GMA*, 15; Shahbazi, "Date of Z.", 26-30; "X^wadāy-nāmag", 218-19; Wiesehöfer, *Aufstand*, 156-60. See also Rudolph, art. cit. (see p. 12 n. 19), p. 85; Kingsley, "Greek origin", 257; Boyce, *HZ* II, pp. 68-69; Hartner, art. cit. (see p. 93 n. 186), p. 749 n. 3; Boyce, *HZ* III, p. 370. Cf. Altheim and Stiehl, *SA*, p. 21 n. 1, for further bibliographical references.

52. On the Persepolis inscriptions see Back, o. c. (see n. 42), pp. 492-97, 518-19, and Gignoux, *Glossaire des inscriptions pehlevies et parthes* (CII, Suppl. Series I), London, 1972, 13, for the bibliography. For the numismatic evidence see R. Göbl, *Sasanian Numismatics*, Braunschweig, 1971, 23-24.

53. Shahbazi, "X^wadāy-nāmag", 220.

54. Cf. Nöldeke, *Tabari*, 410-11; P. Peeters, "La date du martyre de S. Siméon, archevêque de Séleucie-Ctésiphon", *Analecta Bollandiana*, 56, 1938, 118-43, at pp. 122-23; Taqizadeh, art. cit. (see n. 40), p. 673; H. Lewy, "Calendrier", 45; R. Altheim-Stiehl apud P. Kawerau, *Die Chronik von Arbela* (CSCO 467-468/Syr. 199-200), Leuven, 1985, 14; Chaumont, *La christianisation de l'empire iranien des origines aux grandes persécutions du VI^e siècle* (CSCO – Subsidia 80), Lovanii, 1988, p. 160 with n. 3. In more general terms, on the synchronisms calculated by Syrian or later Christian writers: Taqizadeh, "Era of Z.", p. 33 n. 1; Bickerman, "Time-reckoning", *CHIr*, III, 2, 1983, 778-91, at p. 783.

55. H. Lewy, "Calendrier", 22-45.

56. See above p. 93 n. 186, and in particular de Blois, art. cit. (ib.). The article "Calendars (Pre-Islamic calendars)" by Panaino (see above, in the same note) has a copious bibliography on the subject, regarding also the calendars derived from the Zoroastrian calendar.

57. Henning, *Zoroaster*, p. 37 n. 4, explains at this point that "Occasionally the 'Arsacid' era was used; thus in the inscription of Artaban V, dated in the year 462 (erroneously read as 532 by Ghirshman, *Monuments Piot*, 97 sqq.)." The reference is to Ghirshman, "Un bas-relief d'Artaban V avec une inscription en pehlevi arsacide", *Monuments Piot*, 44, 1950, 97-107.

58. What we maintained in the lecture two (see above pp. 74 ff.) is a clear confirmation of the exactness of this hypothesis of Henning's: the world-year of twelve thousand years was very probably devised in the fifth century B.C.

59. Henning, *Zoroaster*, 37-38.

60. Ginzel, o. c. (see n. 40), I (1906), pp. 136, 236, 305; II (1911), p. 59; III (1914), pp. 40-43.

61. Taqizadeh, "Various eras" [II], pp. 124-30; "Early Sasanians", 7, 9-10.

62. Taqizadeh, "Era of Z.", 34-35.

63. Henning, *Zoroaster*, 41.

64. Shahbazi, "Date of Z.", 27-30; "X^wadāy-nāmag", 218-19.

65. Shahbazi, "Date of Z.", 29.

66. Gershevitch, "Approaches", 8-9.

67. The 14 years would correspond to the whole period of Alexander's rule (336-323 B.C.), inclusive of his year of accession and the year of his death: H. Lewy, "Calendrier", 61; "Faulty Pers. chron.", 197; Taqizadeh, "Era of Z.", 39; Shahbazi, "Date of Z.", p. 32 with n. 61, with reference to R.A. Parker and W.H. Dubberstein, *Babylonian Chronology 626 B.C. – A.D. 75*, Providence, Rhode Island, 1956, 36.

68. This view is also expressed by Daffinà, "Senso del tempo", 25.

69. For the testimony given by Mas'udi, Abu'l-Faraj Zanjāni (apud Biruni), Ṭabari, Bal'ami, Ta'ālebi, Ḥamza Eṣfahāni, see H. Lewy, "Faulty Pers. chron."; Grignaschi, "Ḥosrō I", 145; Shahbazi, "Arsacids, vi: Arsacid chronology in traditional history", *Elr*: II, 1987, 542-43.

70. Shahbazi, "Date of Z.", pp. 26 and 27 n. 19; "X^wadāy-nāmag", 222.

71. *GBd.* – BTA, 306-307; *GBd.* – TDA, 240. 5.

72. Shahbazi, "Date of Z.", p. 26 with n. 6.

73. Cereti, *The Zand ī Wahman Yasn. A Zoroastrian apocalypse* (SOR 75), Roma, 1995, 180-81.

74. Shahbazi, "X^wadāy-nāmag", p. 228 n. 129.

75. The two expressions 200 ud and sāl in the *Bundahišn* and *sāli devist*

in the *Šāh-nāme* are explained by Shahbazi as the result of an extension of the Sassanian period at the expense of the Arsacid period on account of a slight alteration, similar to the one between the 457 and the 460 years assigned to the Sassanian period respectively in Ḥamza (456 years plus 1 month and 22 days) or in the tradition that attributes 457 to the Sassanians (427 plus the 30-year period preceding the overthrow of the Parthians: Shahbazi, "Date of Z.", p. 26 n. 9, with bibliographical references), and in the *Bundahišn* (ib., p. 27). This, according to him, is how we ought to explain the '200 and odd years' which would have become 'some two hundred years': and in the same way the figure given by Mas'udi (see p. 147). He supposes – by mere conjecture – that the 'odd years' would originally have been three (ib., p. 27 n. 19; "X^wadāy-nāmag", pp. 222 and 228 n. 128). This, however, does not explain the 270 years of the Arsacids in Agathias II, 26, because in this case the extension would be if anything in favour of the Parthians, nor does it explain the figure given by the *Greater Bundahišn* for the Sassanians, which is not 460 but 403: *čahār sad ud *sē sāl* (TD1 103r. 2-3; DH 230r. 11-12; TD2 122v. 4-5). On the other hand the very fact that the number 403 years occurs in the same text as the expression *200 ud and sāl* makes it extremely unlikely that the latter expression must be understood as '203 years' as Shahbazi supposes. Regarding the number 460 years for the Sassanians – a reading which poses some problems – see the *Indian Bundahišn* (F. Justi, *Der Bundehešh zum ersten Male herausgegeben, transkribirt, übersetzt und mit Glossar versehen*, Leipzig, 1868, p. 82 line 1 in the text, p. 46 in the translation). It has had a great deal of influence: see, e.g., Spiegel, *Erânische Alterthumskunde*, III: *Geschichte, Staats- und Familienleben, Wissenschaft und Kunst*, Leipzig, 1878, 192; Klíma, art. cit. (see p. 124 n. 80), p. 563. The problem is a complex one, but in any case Shahbazi's explanation is unconvincing, whereas it is more likely that by *200 ud and sāl* and *sāli devist* a period of just a little more than 'two hundred years' was meant, viz. between 200 and 201 years, as is explained on p. 148.

76. Biruni, *Āfār*, 116-17.

77. Shahbazi, "Date of Z.", p. 26 n. 7.

78. See Cameron, "AS", 86-87 (text and translation), 105-106 (commentary).

79. Mas'udi, *Tanbih*, 98.

80. Nöldeke, *Tabari*, p. XVI with n. 3; Cameron, "AS", 106.

81. Shahbazi, art. cit. (see n. 69), p. 542.

82. The quotation of Maqdesi given by Shahbazi as Moqaddasi is misleading: see the short references and abbreviations of books and periodicals of the *Encyclopædia Iranica*: Maqdesi, *Bad*¹.

83. Actually, Biruni, *Āṭār*, 119, shows that he was aware of the existence of another tradition that established that period as 300 years (see p. 155).

84. Shahbazi, "Date of Z.", 30.

85. Cf. H. Lewy, "Faulty Pers. chron.", 213-14; Taqizadeh, "Era of Z.", 36, 39. In order to lend support to the number of 240 years as proof of the existence of a calculation that took the epochal year as being 312/1 and not 330 B.C., Shahbazi also makes reference to the testimony of Ebn Nawbakṭ (Abu Sahl b. Nawbakṭ), a famous Persian astrologer and author of the eighth century (see Pingree, "Abū Sahl b. Nawbakṭ", *Elr.* I, 1985, 369), and of Biruni in his *Qānun al-Mas'ūdi* (vol. III, pp. 1473-74 of the Hyderabad-Deccan edition, 1956) on the synchronism between the 25th year of Husraw I, i. e. A.D. 556, and the 867th year of the tenth millennium according to Ebn Nawbakṭ or the 851th year of the fourth millennium according to Biruni. As we know, Biruni stated that the reform of the astronomical tables came about in the year 3851 of what we call the era of Gayōmart, corresponding to the year 851 of the so-called era of Zoroaster (= Seleucid era) and to the 25th year of Husraw, though this is reckoned as being the year 867 of the tenth millennium by Ebn Nawbakṭ (see Taqizadeh, art. cit., p. 35). The problem is a complex one, as can be seen from the different solutions proposed by Taqizadeh (ib., and "Some chronological data relating to the Sasanian period", *BSOS*, 9, 1937, 125-39, at pp. 134-35, 139), Herzfeld (*Zoroaster*, 14-15), Shahbazi ("Date of Z.", 29-30; "X"adāy-nāmag", 223). A careful examination of Biruni's testimony has been made by Pingree and Kennedy in the commentary to *al-Hāshimī*, 'Alī ibn Sulaymān, *The Book of the Reasons behind Astronomical Tables – Kitāb fī 'īlāl al-zījāt*, A facsimile reproduction of the unique Arabic text contained in the Bodleian Ms. Arch. Seld. A. 11 with a translation by F.I. Haddad and E.S. Kennedy and a commentary by D. Pingree and E.S. Kennedy, New York, 1981, 212 f., and recently by Panaino, o. c. (see p. 87 n. 98), pp. 31-34.

86. Shahbazi, art. cit. (see n. 69), p. 543; "X"adāy-nāmag", 222.

87. With regard to the 'Ctesiphon accession' of Ardaxšīr and the chronology of the first Sassanians in connection with the problem of the dates of Mani's lifetime, see Sundermann, "Mani's revelation in the Cologne Mani Codex and in other sources", in *Codex Manichaicus Coloniensis – Atti del Simposio internazionale (Rende-Amantea 3-7 ottobre 1984)*, ed. L. Cirillo, Cosenza, 1986, 205-14, and the debate between Taqizadeh and Henning: Taqizadeh, *Māni va din-e u*, Tehran, 1335Š./1956, pp. I-XIII; Taqizadeh and Henning, "The dates of Mani's life", *AM*, 6, 1957, 106-21, at pp. 106-15 and 115-21. See also A. Maricq, "Les débuts de la prédication de Mani et l'avènement de Šāhpuhr I^{er}", *Annuaire de l'Institut de Philologie et d'Histoire Orientales et Slaves*, 11, 1951, 245-68 (cf. E. Honigsmann and Maricq,

Recherches sur les Res Gestae divi Saporis, Bruxelles, 1953, 21-38; Maricq, "Res Gestae divi Saporis", *Syria*, 35, 1958, 295-360, at pp. 344-48 = *Classica et Orientalia*, Paris, 1965, 86-90); Widengren, art. cit. (see n. 43), pp. 756, 782. I take 226 as being the date of Ardashīr's accession, following the example of Gershevitch, "Approaches", p. 28 n. 19, "because this is the date usually assumed in discussions of Zoroaster's traditional date".

88. Ginzel, o. c. (see n. 40), vol. I, p. 138.

89. The figure of the 266 years for the duration of Arsacid rule, remained in the work of Musā b. 'Isā Kesravi on the Sassanians. The importance of this work is confirmed by the 'Older Preface' of the *Šāh-nāme*, which mentions a *Nāme-ye Sāsāniyān* by Musā b. 'Isā Kosravi: cf. D. Monchi-Zadeh, *Topographisch-historische Studien zum iranischen Nationalepos* (ADMG 41, 2), Wiesbaden, 1975, 9. See also V. Minorsky, "The Older Preface to the *Shāh-nāma*", in *Studi orientalistici in onore di Giorgio Levi della Vida*, II, Roma, 1956, 159-79, at p. 173. The importance of Kesravi's work is confirmed also by the use that Ḥamza Eṣfahāni made of it: cf. Grignaschi, "La Nihāyatu-l-'arab fī aḥbāri-l-Furs wa-l-'Arab (Première partie)", *BEO*, 22, 1969, 15-67, at p. 35. In his *Chronology* Biruni did not fail to remark: "I should like to know why he [sc. Kesravi] refers it [the chronological confusion] to the period of the Sāsānian, not to that of the Ashghānian rule. For there was much more opportunity for mistakes creeping into the chronology of the Ashghānians (than into that of the Sāsānians)" (Biruni, *Āṭār*, 129; transl. Sachau, *Chronology*, 127). After listing the names of the Sassanian rulers as reported by Ḥamza according to the emendation of Kesravi, he gives the total figure of the 696 years that the latter allotted to the Sassanians (Biruni, *Āṭār*, 130-31), after having pointed out not long before that this author "has increased the durations of their reigns and their number" (Biruni, *Āṭār*, 119; transl. Sachau, *Chronology*, 122).

90. Henning, "An astronomical chapter of the Bundahishn", *JRAS*, 1942, 229-48, at p. 229 with n. 1; MacKenzie, "Bundahišn", *Elr*. IV, 1990, 547-51, at p. 548, who writes that most scholars subscribe the view expressed by Henning, "and that the final chapters (XXXI-XXXVI) are a later addition".

91. Shahbazi, loc. cit. in n. 86; "X"adāy-nāmag", 221-22.

92. Gershevitch, "Approaches", 7-8.

93. On the Arsacid era see: Lehmann-Haupt, "Zur Arsakiden-Ära", *Klio*, 5, 1905, 128-30; Ginzel, o. c. (see n. 40), vol. I, pp. 136-68; E.H. Minns, "Parchments of the Parthian period from Avroman in Kurdistan", *JHS*, 35, 1915, 22-65, at pp. 31-36; Kugler, *Sternkunde* II, pp. 443-63; Henning, *Zoroaster*, p. 37 n. 4; "The monuments and inscriptions of Tang-i Sarvak", *AM*, 2, 1952, 151-78, at p. 176; Shahbazi, "Arsacids, v: The 'Arsacid' era", *Elr*. II, 1987, 541-42. For the problem of the meaning that the date of the

beginning of the Arsacid era had for the Parthians (vernal equinox of 247 B.C.) see: Schippmann, *Grundzüge der parthischen Geschichte*, Darmstadt, 1980, 17; A.D.H. Bivar, "The political history of Iran under the Arsacids", *CHIr.* III, 1, 1983, 21-99, at pp. 28-29; Frye, o. c. (see n. 44), p. 209; J. Wolski, *L'empire des Arsacides* (ActIr 32), Louvain, 1993, p. 49 n. 36. For the diffusion of the reckoning based on the same era see also MacKenzie, "Dates and dating (in Old and Middle Iranian)", *EIr.* VII, 1996, 124-26, at p. 124.

94. Shahbazi, art. cit. (see n. 69), p. 543.

95. See the passage referred to above, p. 134, on which see now Cereti, loc. cit. in n. 73.

96. Cf. Bailey, *ZP*, 81, 218-19; S. Wikander, *Feuerpriester in Kleinasien und Iran*, Lund, 1946, 134-36; Zaehner, *Zurvan*, 7-9, 31-34; M. Shaki, "The Dēnkart account of the history of the Zoroastrian scriptures", *ArOr*, 49, 1981, 114-25; Cereti, o. c. (see n. 73), pp. 181-83.

97. Grignaschi, "Ḥosrō I", 143-46.

98. Bulsara, *The Laws of the Ancient Persians as found in the 'Mâtikân ê hazâr Dâtastân' or 'the Digest of a thousand Points of Law'*, Bombay, 1937, chap. XLII, 42; cf. Grignaschi, "Ḥosrō I", 144. See also Perikhanyan, *Sasanidskii sudebnik 'Kniga tysyachi sudebnykh reshenii' (Mâtakdân ī hazâr dâtastân)*, Erevan, 1973, 420-21 (= *The Book of a Thousand Judgments, A Sasanian Law-Book*, transl. N. Garsoïan, Costa Mesa, California – New York, 1997, 316-17) (A 38, 6-12); Macuch, *Das sasanidische Rechtsbuch 'Mâtakdân ī Hazâr Dâtistân' (Teil II)* (ADMG 45, 1), Wiesbaden, 1981, 221-22 (MHDA 38).

99. Cf. M. Minovi and M.E. Rezvāni, *Nāme-ye Tansar be Gošnasp*, 2nd ed., Tehran, 1354Š./1975, 93; English transl.: Boyce, *The Letter of Tansar* (SOR 38), Roma, 1968, 67 (a translation which follows the page-numbers of Minovi's first edition: Tehran, 1311Š./1932). See also the edition and the French translation by Darmesteter in *JA*, 1894, March-April, pp. 185-250, at p. 245, and May-June, pp. 502-55, at p. 551.

100. Macuch, o. c. (see n. 98), pp. 221-22 and 232-33 n. 51.

101. Grignaschi, "Ḥosrō I", 144, and Macuch, loc. cit., think of Yazdegard I (399-421), whereas Perikhanyan, o. c. (see n. 98), p. 421, thinks of Yazdegard II (439-457).

102. Bal'ami, ed. Bahār, p. 874.

103. *Mojmal*, p. 59.

104. Maqdesi, *Bad'* III, p. 155.

105. Shahbazi, art. cit. (see n. 69), p. 542 (and see above n. 82).

106. Minovi and Rezvāni, o. c. (see n. 99), p. 94.

107. Darmesteter, art. cit. (see n. 99), p. 552 n. 1.

108. Grignaschi, "Ḥosrō I", 146.

109 Cf. Grignaschi, "Quelques spécimens de la littérature sassanide conservés dans les bibliothèques d'Istanbul", *JA*, 254, 1966, 1-142, at pp. 89-90 n. 62. On this text see also C.-H. de Fouchécour, *Moralia. Les notions morales dans la littérature persane du 3^e/9^e au 7^e/13^e siècle* (Bibliothèque Iranienne, 32), Paris, 1986, 87-89.

110. See Grignaschi, "Hosrō I", p. 146 with n. 232.

111. "Sorprende solo che, nell'assenza di notizie precise sui regni dei Kayān, non si sia preferito modificare piuttosto l'epoca dell'apparizione di Zoroastro. Riposerebbe la data di Al-Bīrūnī sulla conversione di Vištāsp (258 anni prima dell'era seleucide) su qualche tradizione che non si osava toccare, più solida dei calcoli sulla durata dei Kayān?." This is where the inaccuracy in Grignaschi's calculation lies: the tenth millennium does not begin with the conversion of Vištāsp but with the thirtieth year of Zoroaster's lifetime, which corresponds to the thirtieth year of Vištāsp's reign (see p. 155 f.), and Biruni does not make the statement that Grignaschi seems to attribute to him about Vištāsp's conversion. As for the 258 years before the Seleucid era, instead of before the death of Darius III, see above p. 141 f.

112. According to E.W. West, *Pahlavi Texts*, V (see p. 37 n. 19), p. xxviii, this error lay in an omission of thirty-five years in the reckoning of the *Bundahišn*: "We cannot place Alexander's invasion of Irān itself at a later date than the battle of Gaugamela (B.C. 331); and if this were the 300th year of the religion, the death of Alexander (B.C. 323) must have occurred in its 308th, instead of its 273rd year, and the coming of the religion would have to be put back thirty-five years. This may be done with some plausibility by assuming an omission of thirty-five years between the reigns of Hūmāi and Dārāi, where the *Bundahis* passes from traditional to historical personages". In his opinion, then, the beginning of the tenth millennium should be placed 300 years before 331 B.C., and thirty years before this should be placed the birth of Zoroaster (660-583 B.C.).

113. Jackson, "Date of Z.", 8 (= *Zoroaster*, 159); Taqizadeh, "Various eras" [II], pp. 127-28; Henning, *Zoroaster*, 38.

114. The reference, in this case, is to the conversion of Mēdyōmāh, which the *Wizīdagīhā ī Zādspram* XXIV, 1 and XXV, 1 date in the tenth year after the advent of the prophet at the age of thirty: cf. Gignoux and Tafazzoli, o. c. (see n. 33), pp. 84-85, 86-87, and pp. 76-77 (chap. XX: *Abar *madan ī-š ō sīh sālag*).

115. Henning, *Zoroaster*, 41, and see also ib., p. 38.

116. Ib., p. 38.

117. Mas'udi, loc. cit. in n. 79.

118. See above p. 138 and n. 36 for the bibliographical references. A

part from the present writer (Gnoli, "Sassanidi", 235-37; *ZTH*, 171-72; *De Z. à M.*, 37), there have been others who believed Mas'udi's account, one of these being Christensen, "Quelques notices sur les plus anciennes périodes du Zoroastrisme", *Acta Orientalia*, 4, 1925, 81-115, at p. 87.

119. Gershevitch, "Approaches", 12.

120. *Ib.*

121. Biruni, *loc. cit.* in n. 83.

122. Cereti, *art. cit.* (see p. 37 n. 20), pp. 321-22 and 326. See also Cereti, *o. c.* (see n. 73), pp. 180-82.

123. Nyberg, *RAI*, 31-32; Humbach, *Gāthās* I, p. 28.

124. Gershevitch, "Approaches", 14.

125. Taqizadeh, "Various eras" [II], p. 128.

126. Herzfeld, *art. cit.* (see n. 23), p. 135; *Zoroaster*, 26-27; Shahbazi, "Date of Z.", 26-27.

127. Wiesehöfer, *o. c.* (see n. 18), pp. 158-59.

128. Fück, "Sechs Ergänzungen zu Sachaus Ausgabe von al-Bīrūnī's 'Chronologie Orientalischer Völker'", in *Documenta Islamica Inedita*, Berlin, 1952, 69-98, at pp. 75-76.

129. Taqizadeh, "A new contribution to the materials concerning the life of Zoroaster", *BSOS*, 7, 1937, 947-54. Altheim and Stiehl, *GMA*, 16, like Wiesehöfer at the time (though later he changed his mind in favour of the early chronology: Wiesehöfer, *o. c.* [see n. 44], p. 354), came to the conclusion, however, that the dates of Zoroaster were 599/8-522/1, since their calculation was based on the Seleucid era.

130. Gershevitch, "Approaches", 15, answers in the negative the question if 588 (330 + 258) could have been the year of Zoroaster's death, on the ground of the synchronism of Pythagoras, because "the latter's birth was in antiquity thought to have fallen in the year 570 B.C." (see also his note 27 at p. 28). For this reason, and also on the grounds of Zādspram's minicalendar in chap. XXV of the *Wizīdagīhā* (see his note 25 at p. 28), he concludes that: "We may therefore feel confident that 588 B.C. was not the year of the prophet's death but may very well have been, as we saw above in n. 25, the thirtieth year of his life". The same conclusion, on the ground of the fact that the 'conference', or revelation, "is regarded as being the decisive event in the prophet's ministry", was also reached by Whitley, *art. cit.* (see n. 24), pp. 219-20, whereas Boyce in an article published in 1970 thought that 588 B.C. was the year of the prophet's death according to the evidence given by some calendrical observances: see above, p. 37 n. 33.

131. Gnoli, "Sassanidi", 233; *ZTH*, 167; *De Z. à M.*, 38.

132. Molé, *CMC*, 531.

133. Humbach, *Gāthās* I, p. 30.

134. A printing error in Humbach, *ib.*, p. 29 n. 43, places at this point the same note on the following page (p. 30 n. 44). The original reference in n. 43 will certainly have been to my *ZTH*.

135. Humbach, *o. c.*, p. 29.

136. Gershevitch, "Approaches", 13.

137. Panaino, "The *Widēwdād* fragments on the millennium of Yima" (paper presented to the conference hosted by the World Zoroastrian Organisation, London, 16th-17th November 1996).

138. Cf. H. Pognon, *Inscriptions mandaïtes des coupes de Khouabir*, II, Paris, 1898, 111-13; A. Scher, *Theodorus bar Kōnī, Liber Scholiorum* (CSCO, 69, syr. 26), II, Louvain, 1912, 295-98; A. Yohannan, "Another Old Syriac reference to Zoroaster", *JAOS*, 43, 1923, 239-42; Jackson, *Studies*, 249-51; Benveniste, "Le témoignage de Théodore bar Kōnay sur le zoroastrisme", *Le monde oriental*, 26, 1933, 170-215. For other bibliographical references: J.P. Asmussen, "Theodore bar Kōnay", *Elr.* III, 1989, 737-39; M. Albert, "Langue et littérature syriaques", in M. Albert, R. Beylot, R.-G. Coquin, B. Outtier, C. Renoux, *Christianismes orientaux. Introduction à l'étude des langues et des littératures* (with an introduction by A. Guillaumont), Paris, 1993, 297-375, at p. 324.

139. Taqizadeh, "Various eras" [II], p. 128.

140. As we know, Theodore bar Kōnay put Zoroaster 628 years and seven months before Christ. The reckoning of the seven months poses some problems: see, for example, the different solutions proposed by Jackson, *Studies*, 250, and Shahbazi, "X^wadāy-nāmag", p. 229 n. 144. Darius III died mid-330 B.C. (see E. Badian, "Darius. v: Darius III", *Elr.* VII, 1996, 51-54). On the problem of Zoroaster's date in Theodore bar Kōnay see, in any case, in addition to the reference given above: Bidez and Cumont, *MH* II, p. 107 n. 3; Herzfeld, *Zoroaster*, 19; Henning, *Zoroaster*, 41-42; Altheim and Stiehl, *SA*, 29; *GMA*, p. 10 n. 3; Humbach, *Gāthās* I, p. 30 n. 44 (with various and sometimes conflicting points of view).

141. Cf. Brockelmann, *GAL* I, pp. 148-49; *GAL-Suppl. I*, p. 228; F. Micheau, "Sa'īd b. al-Bīṭrīk" *EP* VIII, 1995, 853-56, and also, on the sources that he used, M. Breydy, *Études sur Sa'īd Ibn Bāṭriq et ses sources* (CSCO – Subsidia 69), Louvain, 1983, 12-38. For the text, after Pocock's edition (*Contextio Gemmarum sive Eutychiei Patriarchae Alexandrini Annales*, 2 vols, Oxford, 1658-1659), and his Latin translation republished by Migne (*P.G.* 111, Paris, 1863, cols 889-1231), as well as by Bidez and Cumont, *MH* II, p. 61 (for the passage that concerns us here), see L. Cheikho (with B. Carra de Vaux and H. Zayyat), *Eutychiei Patriarchae Alexandrini Annales*, 2 vols, Louvain, 1906-1909 (repr.: CSCO 50-51, arab. 6-7, Louvain, 1954), on which the Italian translation by B. Pirone, *Eutichio, Gli Annali* (Studia

Orientalia Christiana, Monographiae 1), Cairo, 1987, is based, and see also the edition and translation into German by Breydy, *Das Annalenwerk des Eutychios von Alexandrien. Ausgewählte Geschichten und Legenden kompiliert von Saʿīd ibn Baṭrīq um 935 A.D.* (CSCO 471-472, arab. 44-45), Louvain, 1985, based on the Ms. Sinaiticus Arabicus 582.

142. Cf. Brockelmann, *GAL I*, p. 348; *GAL-Suppl. I*, p. 590; C. Cahen and R.-G. Coquin, "al-Makīn b. al-ʿAmīd, *Djirdjis*", *EF* VI, 1991, 143-44, with bibliography. The passage that concerns us is given in Hyde, o. c. (see p. 80 n. 5), p. 559, with the text in Arabic and a Latin translation.

143. Cf. Brockelmann, *GAL I*, p. 349; G. Graf, *Geschichte der christlichen arabischen Literatur*, II, Vatican City, 1947, 272-81; H.G.B. Teule, "Ebn al-ʿEbrī", *EIr* VIII, 1998, 13-15. For the editions of the *Moḳtaṣar* see, after Pocock's edition (*Historia compendiosa dynastiarum auctore Gregorio Abul-Farajio*, Oxford, 1663), A. Šāleḥāni, *Moḳtaṣar taʾrīḳ al-dowal*, Beirut, 1890 (repr. 1958). On Bar Hebraeus see also J.B. Segal, "Ibn al-ʿIbrī", *EF* III, 1971, 804-805, and, as my colleague Riccardo Contini, of the Oriental Institute of Naples, very kindly pointed out to me, J.-M. Fiey, "Esquisse d'une bibliographie de Bar Hebraeus († 1286)", *Parole de l'Orient*, 13, 1986, 279-312; S.R. Todt, "Die syrische und die arabische Weltgeschichte des Bar Hebraeus – ein Vergleich", *Der Islam*, 65, 1988, 60-80. On the passage that we are concerned with cf. Gottheil, "References", 32; Jackson, *Zoroaster*, 201; Bidez and Cumont, *MH I*, p. 134. Professor Yarshater has paid particular attention to the comparison between the lists of the Achaemenian sovereigns given in Biruni and in Bar Hebraeus in an important paper presented to the "Biruni Symposium" held in December 1973: "Lists of the Achaemenid kings in Biruni and Bar Hebraeus", in *Biruni Symposium*, ed. Yarshater and D. Bishop (Persian Studies Series, 7), New York, 1976, 49-65, see in particular p. 60.

144. Breydy, *Das Annalenwerk des Eutychios* ... (see n. 141), pp. 29 and 31. See the corresponding passage in the edition by Cheikho, o. c. (see n. 141), I, p. 76, and the relevant translation in Pirone, o. c. in the same note, p. 131: it tells of Kuroš and his son Qamisus, and of Samardius the Magus, who reigned for one year.

145. See n. 142 and Jackson, "Date of Z.", 14 (= *Zoroaster*, p. 168 n. 5).

146. Pocock, o. c. (see n. 143), p. 84 (Arabic text) and p. 55 (Latin translation); Šāleḥāni, o. c. in the same note, p. 74. It should be noted, in this connection, that Bar Hebraeus (Šāleḥāni, ib., p. 81) mentions Pherecydes, Pythagoras' teacher, in the same period as Zoroaster, and that Biruni, *Āṭār*, 28, states that, according to a possible reckoning, Zoroaster could have lived in roughly the same time as Thales of Miletus, whose ἀκμή, according to Apollodorus' system, should be placed in 585/4 B.C.: Mosshammer, o. c.

(see p. 125 n. 95), p. 121. On Zoroaster and Thales see also Jackson, "Date of Z.", 10 (= *Zoroaster*, 161-62) and *Zoroaster*, p. 169 n. 3.

147. Pocock, o. c. (see n. 143), p. 54 and p. 83 for the Arabic text; Šālehāni, o. c., pp. 82-83.

148. Floigl, o. c. (see n. 18), p. 18, who refers back to Rōth (see the same note), cited also in this context by Jackson, "Date of Z.", 12 (= *Zoroaster*, 164) n. 1, by Herzfeld, *Zoroaster*, p. 20 n. 23, who makes Rōth depend on Floigl, and by Wiesehöfer, *Aufstand*, p. 160 n. 1.

149. Altheim and Stiehl, *SA*, 52; *GMA*, 44.

150. Altheim and Stiehl, *SA*, 45-53; *GMA*, 39-45.

151. Altheim and Stiehl, *GMA*, 44.

152. Wiesehöfer, *Aufstand*, 162. Wiesehöfer later changed his mind, having given up the idea of the 'Spätdatierung Zarathustras': see above n. 129.

153. The Jewish tradition is probably the source of the association of Nebuchadnezzar, the conqueror of Jerusalem, with Lohrāsp, the father of Zoroaster's protector Wištāsp; plenty of evidence for it can be found, as well as in Muslim sources, also in Pahlavi literature: see above pp. 118, 128 with n. 153, and now also Skjærvø, "Zarathustra in the Avesta and in Manichaeism. Irano-Manichaica IV", in *La Persia e l'Asia Centrale da Alessandro al X secolo* (Atti dei Convegni Lincei, 127 - Roma, 9-12 novembre 1994), Roma, 1996, 597-628, at p. 624 n. 90. It should be noted that this association, according to which the Babylonian king was one of Lohrāsp's lieutenants, confirms the late chronology for Zoroaster, between the 7th and the 6th century B.C. In fact it cannot be explained by the theory which de Menasce ("Jews and Judaism in the third book of the Dēnkart", in *K.R. Cama Oriental Institute Golden Jubilee Volume*, Bombay, 1969, 45-48) upholds, though not without good arguments concerning some aspects of it: namely that in Pahlavi literature Judaism was a code-word for Islam — on which see Russell, art. cit. (see p. 127 n. 141), pp. 61-62 — that the Zoroastrians would not have been able to attack openly without running a serious risk. The traditional themes which the Jews of the Diaspora had elaborated over the centuries were made acceptable, or more acceptable, to the Iranian conscience by Islam, most likely with alterations or additions, thus providing an encounter with Iranian culture in which Israel was not the only active protagonist. On the other hand, the researches done by J. Lewy ("The late Assyro-Babylonian cult of the Moon and its culmination at the time of Nabonidus", *HUCA*, 19, 1946, 405-89) and H. Lewy ("The Babylonian background of the Kay Kâûs legend", *ArOr*, 17, 1949, 28-109; "Points of comparison between Zoroastrianism and the moon-cult of Ḥarrân", in *A Locust's Leg. Studies in honour of S.H. Taqizadeh*, London, 1962, 139-61) have illustrated in an exemplary fashion the complex nature of the inter-

mingling of Mesopotamian, Jewish and Iranian traditions that went back to the pre-Islamic period and certainly had nothing to do with any sort of Greek mediation. On these problems, see above at the end of the third lecture. See also on Zoroaster in Babylon in the Classical sources and in the Pahlavi texts some recent remarks by Skjærvø, loc. cit. pp. 607-11.

154. Henning, "The Book of the Giants", *BSOAS*, 11, 1943, 52-74, at p. 73 n. 3; *Zoroaster*, 37.

155. Sundermann, art. cit. (see n. 24), p. 433. Now see also Skjærvø, art. cit., p. 616.

156. Gershevitch, loc. cit. in n. 24.

157. See G. Monnot, "Les écrits musulmans sur les religions non-bibliques", *Mélanges de l'Institut dominicain d'études orientales*, 11, 1972, 5-48 (= *Islam et religions*, Paris, 1986, 39-77, at p. 72). Cf. A. Afšār-e Širāzi, *Motun-e 'arabi va fārsi dar bare-ye Māni va Mānaviyyat ...*, Tehran, 1335Š./1956, 50-4; and see Gnoli, art. cit. (see p. 13 n. 38), p. 316.

158. Gnoli, art. cit. (see p. 13 n. 37), p. 13 with n. 2.

159. Gnoli, art. cit. (see p. 13 n. 38), pp. 314-15; Gershevitch, loc. cit. in n. 24.

160. Hartman, loc. cit. (see p. 124 n. 89).

161. On Darius the Mede see now Yamauchi, o. c. (see p. 127 n. 133), pp. 58-59; Frye, "Darius, ii: Darius the Mede", *EI* VII, 1996, 40-41; Gnoli, art. cit. (see p. 13 n. 38), p. 319 n. 34, with bibliographical references. See as well the succession of the Medo-Persian sovereigns "in the writings of all the authors of the Old Testament literature, canonical or uncanonical" in C.C. Torrey, "Medes and Persians", *JAOS*, 66, 1946, 1-15, at p. 3. It begins precisely with Darius the Mede.

162. Cf. Sundermann, art. cit. (see n. 24), pp. 430-31. See C. Colpe, *Der Manichäismus in der arabischen Überlieferung*, Diss., Göttingen, 1954, 81-82, and now see also E.B. Smagina, "Die Reihe der manichäischen Apostel in den koptischen Texte", in *Studia Manichaica. II. Internationaler Kongress zum Manichäismus (6.-10. August 1989, St. Augustin/Bonn)*, ed. G. Wiessner and H.-J. Klimkeit, Wiesbaden, 1992, 356-66.

163. Sundermann, art. cit., p. 432, has apparently corrected an ingenious idea proposed by M. Tardieu ("La diffusion du Bouddhisme dans l'Empire kouchan, l'Iran et la Chine, d'après un kephalaion manichéen inédit", *StIr*, 17, 1988, 153-82, at p. 165), according to which the sequence Buddha – Zoroaster – Jesus was a "correction ultérieure imposée par apologétique missionnaire en direction des milieux bouddhistes de l'Iran du Nord-Est". Sundermann's article represents a definite step forward, both as regards the problem of the different sequences of the apostolic succession of Manichaeism, with reference to the three major forerunners of Mani, and also regard-

ing our ascertainment of the actual knowledge that Mani and the Manichaeans had of the Buddha and his historical date.

164. For a more detailed discussion the reader is referred to my articles cited in the notes 37 and 38 at p. 13.

165. The possibility that the number of the 258 years may originally have an astrological meaning based on the doctrine of the Saturn-Jupiter conjunctions (on their importance see now what Y. Stoyanov, *The Hidden Tradition in Europe. The secret history of medieval Christian heresy*, London, 1994, 124, has to say about the Qarmatian commemoration of Zoroaster with reference to the conjunction of 928 and to Zoroaster's anniversary in 930 A.D.) in signs of the same triplicity (every 240 or 260 years), does not explain its origin, if we consider the fairly late attestations of the speculations about 'astrological history', whose chief exponents were Māšā'allāh (died 815 circa) and Abu Ma'shar (787-886): on their works see F. Sezgin, *Geschichte des arabischen Schrifttums*, VII: *Astrologie – Meteorologie und Verwandtes bis ca. 430 H.*, Leiden, 1979, 102-108, 139-51. The most noteworthy of all the writings on the conjunctions, in this context, is the *Book of Jāmāsp the Wise* (Paris BN MS Arabe 2487, 39r-55v), cited by Kennedy, art. cit. (see p. 93 n. 183), pp. 34-5, and Pingree, *From Astral Omens to Astrology. From Babylon to Bīkāner* (SOR 78), Roma, 1997, 43, which dates Zoroaster 1300 years after the Flood, that is, according to his calculations, "in about 2800 B.C." It will be very useful, in any case, to refer to Kennedy and Pingree, o. c. in the same note, and to the articles in the *Encyclopædia Iranica*, by Brunner (see p. 87 n. 98) and Pingree ("Astrology and astronomy in Iran, iii: Astrology in Islamic times", *Elr.* II, 1987, 868-71) for the bibliography as well. I owe a great deal to the courtesy and erudition of my colleague Antonio Panaino, of the University of Bologna, for the close study of astrological arguments connected with problems of the chronology and historiography of ancient Iran. On the Qarmatian commemoration of Zoroaster see in particular W. Madelung, "Ḳarmaṭī", *Elr.* IV, 1978, 660-65, at p. 662; *Religious Trends in Early Islamic Iran* (Columbia Lectures on Iranian Studies, 4), Albany, N.Y., 1988, 97.

166. Mas'udi, *Moruj*, transl. Pellat, I, p. 203; Ta'ālebi, *Ġorar*, 262.

167. Gershevitch, "Approaches", pp. 8-9 and 28 n. 25. For the sources of the traditional dates referring to Zoroaster's life see now Ž. Āmuzegār and A. Tafāzzoli, *Ošture-ye zendegi-ye Zardošt*, Tehran, 1372Š./1993, 29-33.



Addenda

SINCE I GAVE THE EHSAN YARSHATER LECTURES in April 1997 I have come across some other works which have to do, more or less directly, with the main problems I dealt with in these lectures. I think it appropriate to point out here that, in spite of everything, the arguments I put forward and the conclusions I come to in the above do not lose their validity. And so we shall have a look at some recent works by Kellens and Pirart, Skjærvø, Albert de Jong, and Clarisse Herrenschmidt, insofar as they concern us.

1. In an important article,¹ in which they deal with the problem of Zoroastrian dualism on the basis of the controversial interpretation of Y. 30, 3, Kellens and Pirart make only a brief mention of the chronological problem in a note.² They point out that Gershevitch, in the article that I quote on several occasions,

ne peut rejeter l'antiquité relative de la langue de Gâthâs par rapport à celle du reste de l'Avesta qu'en se situant sur le plan des principes et non sur celui des faits. L'argument de la vitesse variable de l'évolution linguistique, si juste soit-il théoriquement, veut seulement dire que tout est possible, y compris que le gâthique est encore plus vieux qu'on dit et le récent plus récent. La question est de savoir si des traits précis comme la présence d'hiatus dus aux anciennes laryngales, la préservation d'un système pronominal enclytique complexe et l'opposition distinctive vivante, en quantité statistique égale, du présent et de l'aoriste sont compatibles avec une datation basse de l'avestique des Gâthâs et du Yasna Haptahâti.

And so there is nothing new (see pp. 23 ff.): the evidence in favour of an early chronology is still, in their opinion, of a linguistic nature, evidently because they are convinced that there could not be any valid extra-textual evidence against their argument. But this is precisely the question: in order to refute Gershevitch's argument, the two authors ought rather to contest its validity on historical grounds by dealing with the subject of the so-called traditional date of Zoroaster. It is on these very grounds that Gershevitch has drawn our attention to the solution that Henning gave to the problem of Zoroaster's date, debating the arguments against it. In this connection I must confess that I can in no way see why the form of his reasoning should be thought "inutilement polémique", as Pierre Briant describes it in a recent work of his, in which the reader is referred "pour une appréciation plus sereine de ces travaux"³[i. e. Kellens' numerous studies] to an article by Skjærvø, to which we shall now turn our attention.

2. In a review article of the second and third volume of *Les textes vieil-avestiques* by Kellens and Pirart and of *Le panthéon de l'Avesta ancien* by Kellens, Skjærvø writes of the chronological problem, expressing his agreement with Kellens' views both on the early chronology of the 'Old Avestan' texts and against the historicity of Zoroaster.⁴ What he says about Henning's argument is important:

These and other attempts at establishing Zarathustra's date on the basis of the traditional dates of the Zoroastrians and the Greek authors, can only lead to the establishment of the traditional date. The jump from this to the assumption that the traditional date was a real date of the life of a real person is, of course, imaginary.⁵

This, of course, would make sense only if it had already been proved, beyond any shadow of doubt, that Zoroaster was not a historical character.

In point of fact, this is the method that should be followed: it is the historicity of Zoroaster, that is generally assumed to be obvious and natural both in antiquity and, apart from rare exceptions, in our studies too, that would have to be proved false, and not the

contrary. Now, neither Molé⁶ nor Kellens have succeeded in proving the non-historicity of Zoroaster as a reasonably certain fact, even though they have contributed no small amount towards a better understanding of the Zoroastrian tradition in the first case, and of the text of the *Gāthās* as far as language and structure are concerned in the second case. Actually, “the fact that the Zoroastrian tradition, sometimes cited by Classical authors, places the prophet in time and space” is external evidence of some account, while the statement that “the Zoroastrian tradition about Zarathustra is highly legendary, in places even mythical”,⁷ proves nothing against the historicity of Zoroaster since, as Alessandro Bausani once wisely pointed out in this connection, history abounds in examples of founders of religions who, with the passing of time, in the natural veneration of their disciples, were transformed into figures of a divine character.⁸

3. In a slightly revised version of a doctoral thesis submitted by Albert de Jong to the Faculty of Theology of the University of Utrecht, published as volume 133 of the series ‘Religions of the Graeco-Roman World’,⁹ the author deals, albeit rather fleetingly, with the problem of the date of Zoroaster, in contexts that concern us closely in many ways, especially as regards the subject dealt with in our second lecture. De Jong’s work centres on the main evidence on the Magi and the Persians in Greek authors — Herodotus, Strabo, Plutarch, Diogenes Laertius, Agathias¹⁰ — and includes a thematic inventory of the Greek and Latin texts.¹¹ Although it is unfortunately impossible to discuss several points of this work here (as the author’s painstaking effort and the very size of the work would demand), we would do well to look specifically at what is said about the problem of Zoroaster’s date.

After stating that “There appears to be virtual agreement on the date of Zoroaster (around 1,000 BCE)”,¹² with a mere mention of Gershevitch’s arguments to the contrary in defense of the sixth-century dating being given in a note without further comment, and that “Zarathustra’s existence cannot be proved and cannot be disproved. It is, moreover, for the greater part of our discipline,

irrelevant. Zarathustra exists within the Zoroastrian tradition ...",¹³ de Jong devotes no more than a page and a half to our problem.¹⁴ We may remark that the exiguous space devoted to the date of Zoroaster in a book of over 450 pages dealing with a subject of the Magi in Greek and Latin sources is in itself significant: it goes without saying that the author thinks the problem of Zoroaster's existence is actually an 'irrelevant' one, naturally as far as his subject is concerned.

With regard to the dating of 6000 years before Xerxes' crossing or Plato's death and the one of 5000 years before the fall of Troy, de Jong is inclined to attribute the origin of these dates to some particular version of the millenary speculations that is otherwise unknown to us, whereas he expresses no opinion about Kingsley's suggestion (see p. 63 ff.), according to which the dating of 6000 years before the Persian army's διόβασις of the Hellespont was a piece of priestly propaganda, except to say that it is an attractive suggestion but one that cannot be proved.¹⁵ As for the reading 600 instead of 6000 in Diogenes Laertius' Proem (see p. 47 ff.), for which he only quotes Humbach, he rejects this on the grounds of the "massive evidence for millenary datings of Zarathustra" and the fact that "one could not possibly imagine how this would have been remembered".¹⁶ Furthermore, as regards the "unsupported reading of 60" — which he erroneously considers an 'emendation' proposed by Gershevitch: the same error, then, as made by Kingsley (see p. 55) — he rejects the theory of the late chronology because it "brings about the familiar problems of the total silence on Zarathustra in all other sources pertaining to that time".¹⁷ Oddly enough, with this statement de Jong contradicts what he says straight afterwards, about the Greek connection Zoroaster-Pythagoras and the Jewish identification of Zoroaster with Ezekiel.

In conclusion we may say that the author does not attach any great importance to the problem of the date of Zoroaster, and in his study of the Greek sources he makes no new contribution towards its solution. He does not go into the matter because he considers the problem substantially solved by the argument for the

early chronology, as he confirms shortly afterwards: "The sixth-century date of Zoroaster was once commonly adopted by most scholars in Zoroastrian studies, but it has been abandoned almost completely in favour of a much earlier date".¹⁸ We might say that de Jong has fallen victim to the same oversight that led Kingsley, himself influenced by the early chronology, into error, so much so that the latter was led to believe that the sixth-century dating of Zoroaster was not of Iranian but of Greek origin.

4. In a recent article on Democritus and Mazdaism, Clarisse Herrenschildt has dealt briefly in a note with the problem of the Greek dates for Zoroaster in the terms of 6000 years before Xerxes' crossing or Plato's death, or else 5000 years before the fall of Troy.¹⁹ The article, which was read as a paper at the third international conference on the subject "La Transeuphratène à l'époque perse" (Paris, 19th to 21st April 1994), was already known to me in broad outline before I gave the Ehsan Yarshater Lectures, as the author had kindly sent me a provisional version of the unpublished text, but I was not acquainted with its final form until after the summer of 1997. Since the aforesaid note appears in this latter version, I think it useful to pay due attention to it.

In this note²⁰ the following explanation is given for the dating of Zoroaster 6000 years before Xerxes' expedition:

la fravaši, âme céleste, de Zarathustra, existant au moment de la création du monde par Ahura Mazdâ, aurait «vécu» les deux premiers trimillénaires et se serait actualisée au bout de ces six mille ans de «vie» anhistorique. Pareille interprétation pose le problème suivant: Zoroastre serait le contemporain de Xerxès ou de Platon, ce qui n'est point vrai ...

Apart from the last phrase, which reflects her own personal opinion in favour of an early chronology for Zoroaster or 'Old Avestan' literature, in accordance with Kellens' thesis, the author has come to the same conclusion as ours, though without making any effort to prove the validity of the reading ἐξακισχίλια in Diogenes Laertius' text, in spite of the various disputes over it, or to place the 6000 years dating in the context of previous studies on the subject. In fact, there is no mention of Jackson's explanation (an

echo of which may be found in Humbach, though the latter did not apply it to the evidence contained in Xanthus). Jackson's argument was accepted straight away by E.W. West and later by Duchesne-Guillemin, M.L. West and, more recently, by P'yankov as well as by the present writer in a lecture given on 22nd March 1995 at the University of Urbino, in which the publication of an article dealing with this problem was announced, though the article itself did not appear until 1997.²¹

But the aforesaid note also deals with the other chronology, namely the one which would have Zoroaster as having lived 5000 years before the fall of Troy. In this connection the author writes:

Zoroastre vivant cinq mille ans avant la guerre de Troie, nous met sur la bonne piste, car elle fait implicitement reculer la date de naissance de Zoroastre sous sa forme d'âme céleste comme le relate la légende iranienne (M. Molé, *La légende de Zoroastre*, Paris 1967, p. 123) et sous sa forme humaine; on devrait trouver soit six mille ans avant la guerre de Troie, soit sept mille ans avant Xerxès.

Quite frankly, I cannot see where this 'bonne piste' lies, even if one does accept the author's viewpoint: unless she is inferring that one should calculate — for some reason that escapes me — 6000 and not 5000 years before the fall of Troy, the calculation she proposes is not convincing. While 6000 years before Xerxes' crossing or Plato's death would give us respectively 6480 and 6347 B.C.,²² 5000 years before the end of the Trojan war, even if we do use an early chronology for this epochal event (see p. 49), would not take us any further back in time. For what reason, then, could it implicitly make the date of Zoroaster's birth any earlier?

Notes to Addenda

1. Kellens and Pirart, "La strophe des jumeaux: stagnation, extravagance et autres méthodes d'approche", *JA*, 285, 1997, 31-72.

2. *Ib.*, p. 45 n. 24.

3. Briant, "Bulletin d'histoire achéménide (I)", *Topoi*, Supplément 1, 1997, 5-127, at p. 71 n. 166.

4. Skjærvø, "The state of Old Avestan scholarship", *JAOS*, 117, 1997, 103-14.

5. *Ib.*, p. 105. Skjærvø then goes on to say: "Similarly, the attempts at establishing Zarathustra's homeland can only establish the 'homeland' of the Avestan texts".

6. Nor, as a consequence, the 'young Gherardo Gnoli', (*ib.*, p. 106), who had not yet been converted to the 'common opinion'. The reference is to my article "Problems and prospects of the studies on Persian religion", in *Problems and Methods of the History of Religions*, ed. U. Bianchi, C.J. Bleeker and A. Bausani (Supplements to *Numen*, XIX), Leiden, 1972, 67-101; I have long considered this article to be obsolete, especially as far as its historical implications are concerned.

7. Skjærvø, *art. cit.*, p. 104.

8. Bausani, *Persia religiosa da Zaratustra a Bahâ'u'llâh*, Milano, 1959, 35 (repr. Cosenza, 1999, p. 54).

9. de Jong, *Traditions of the Magi. Zoroastrianism in Greek and Latin literature* (Religions in the Graeco-Roman World, 133), Leiden – New York – Köln, 1997.

10. *Ib.*, pp. 76-250.

11. *Ib.*, pp. 251-451.

12. *Ib.*, p. 39.

13. *Ib.*, p. 58.

14. *Ib.*, pp. 319-20.

15. *Ib.*, p. 319.

16. *Ib.*, p. 319 f.

17. *Ib.*, p. 320.

18. *Ib.*, p. 320 with n. 19, where he refers to Shahbazi, "Date of Z.", though in this case, too, he does not neglect to quote Gershevitch, "Approaches", for "a recent defence of the traditional date" (still without any further comment).

19. Herrenschildt, "Entre Perses et Grecs, I. Démocrite et le mazdéisme. Religion, philosophie, science", *Transeuphratène*, 11, 1996, 115-43. We must give credit to this article for bringing up a particular aspect of the old, complex problem concerning intellectual exchange between Greeks and Persians in the Achaemenian period, though here we have only taken into consideration the part of it which concerns the main subject of our lectures.

20. *Ib.*, p. 126 n. 37.

21. Cf. Gnoli, *art. cit.* (see p. 120 n. 28), pp. 292-95 with n. 32, where I refer to my "Data di Z."

22. In the note before the one we are discussing here (*art. cit.*, p. 126 n. 36), the author puts (the death of) Plato in brackets "car il semble bien qu'Eudoxe soit mort avant son maître". On this point, see above on p. 83 n. 32, where I refer to F. Lasserre and P. Kingsley. The latter ("Meetings", p. 183 n. 64) also quotes the views of G. de Santillana (*Reflections on Men and Ideas*, Cambridge, Mass., 1968, 219-30) and of Jaeger, who changed his opinion on the matter (in fact, as Kingsley points out, we owe to Jaeger, *Aristotle*, p. 136 with n. 2, "the influential, and often-repeated, claim that the dating of Zoroaster to 6,000 years before Plato's death cannot go back to Eudoxus because Eudoxus died 'long before' Plato").



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For some anonymous or collective works see also the Abbreviations

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